

FOOL'S STAGE

Go Home...

Written by Alias Lupus

FOOL'S STAGE | Go Home

Copyright © 2026 Portal Master Of Games All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, transmitted, stored in a retrieval system, or translated into any language in any form or by any means without prior written permission from the author, except for brief quotations used in reviews or educational discussion. Recommended Reading Age: 16+ This story contains themes of identity, memory, friendship, regret, personal growth, and philosophical questions that may be best appreciated by older teen and adult readers. First Edition Beta Reader Version 1.0 Author: Portal Master Of Games Genre: Philosophical Fantasy Adventure Fantasy Mystery Fantasy For everyone who has ever followed a road without knowing where it would lead. And for those who discovered that the journey mattered more than the destination.

Before the Road Continues

Fool's Stage | Go Home...

A work of fiction

Draft manuscript • Book Three in The Road Trilogy

This story is the final volume of The Road Trilogy. It can be read after The Flip Side of Knowledge and Burned Memories and Made-Up Apologies, where the roads began to ask more from their travellers than courage alone.

Names, places, records, and memories have been kept as faithfully as roads allow.

A Letter from M

Reader,

You have come far enough that I will not pretend this road begins here.

Roads rarely begin where people think they do. They begin in small decisions that are easy to overlook: a door left open, a question not asked, a hand not taken, a promise made because someone was afraid of being forgotten. By the time a traveller looks down and realizes they are walking, the road has usually been carrying them for a while.

You may be expecting answers. That is understandable. Answers are useful things. They fit neatly in pockets. They can be copied into journals, repeated at tables, and carried through difficult weather. But be careful with them. An answer can tell you where something happened. It cannot always tell you why someone stayed, why someone left, or why they came back when they had every reason to keep running.

This record concerns people who have already learned that the road is not gentle simply because it has a destination. They have found things. They have lost things. They have returned home and discovered that home does not always make the past smaller.

Still, I have known worse beginnings.

Keep this close: a road is allowed to change its mind. So are you.

Do not rush ahead merely because you are nervous about what comes next. Do not stop merely because the last chapter hurt. Walk carefully. Listen when someone calls your name. And when you reach a door you cannot open alone, perhaps try asking before you decide it is locked forever.

The journey has been recorded. That does not make it less real. Sometimes a page is only proof that someone was there.

With a lantern left near the next turn,

M

Table of Contents

Chapter 1: The Morning After Tomorrow	1
Chapter 2: Things We Carried Home	9
Chapter 3: North, Then East.....	17
Chapter 4: Borrowed Without Asking.....	28
Chapter 5: The Sound Beyond Camp	43
Chapter 6: A Town in Snow	55
Chapter 7: What We Give.....	64
Chapter 8: Six Against Snow.....	78
Chapter 9: The Year We Chose.....	93
Chapter 10: The Thing He Forgot.....	103
Chapter 11: The Wolf Who Ran	116
Chapter 12: Nobody Disappears Alone.....	125
Chapter 13: The Promise Beside the Fire	137
Chapter 14: Moonlight Rules	148
Chapter 15: The Page That Was Missing.....	163
Chapter 16: A House Without Legends.....	175
Chapter 17: The Gate Where I Waited	186
Chapter 18: What Love Could Not Fix.....	196
Chapter 19: A Day With Nothing to Solve.....	205
Chapter 20: A Guide Written by M.....	215
Chapter 21: Rooms Made for Returning	226
Chapter 22: What M Could Not Fix.....	237
Chapter 23: The Journal of Varux.....	249
Chapter 24: Before the Grey Cloak	257
Chapter 25: The Book That Hit Me	266
Chapter 26: The Last Direction	277
Chapter 27: The Doors We Chose	286
Chapter 28: The Note Still Being Written	297
Chapter 29: The Farewell That Was Not a Flight.....	304
Chapter 30: The Library Again.....	313
Chapter 31: Gerhardt's Door.....	320
Chapter 32: I Received Your Gifts	328

Chapter 33: Four Stones Under Moonlight	337
Chapter 34: The Sky Was Always Bright.....	344
Chapter 35: The Dream of Those Who Stayed	351
Chapter 36: Recorded by M	364

What Happened Before

The group made it home. There was a birthday, a crowded tavern table, gifts, too much food, and the relief of being in the same room again after a road that had tried very hard to scatter them.

Before that return, Alias, Rowan, Maris, Corvin, and Eldric had travelled through Structures gathered around memory and unfinished choices. They had followed old records signed only M, argued with Paper, and learned that a road could offer an answer without making that answer easy to live with.

Somewhere along those roads, Alias met Future Alias - Varux: a version of himself from farther down another path. Future Alias carried grief, regret, and the habits of someone who had spent too long believing that being alone was safer than being loved. He was given a chance to walk beside the people he had lost before his own road became empty.

The warmth at home is real, but it has not answered everything. The group now carries six unexplained keys, a compass that refuses to behave, coins that still want to lead them somewhere, and a question no one can ignore: how can Future Alias return to his own road without walking it alone?

The Travellers

Alias — A traveller trying to understand the road in front of him without losing the person he was before it began. He notices more than he says, carries questions carefully, and has learned that being afraid does not always mean standing still.

Future Alias / Varux — A version of Alias from farther along another path. He carries his own journal, old regrets, and the difficult knowledge of what loneliness can turn into when it is allowed to grow unchecked.

Rowan — Loud, quick, and often impossible to ignore. Rowan brings energy into rooms that would otherwise become too serious, though he is more observant than his jokes first suggest.

Maris — A careful writer and watcher of small moments. Maris keeps memories from slipping away, especially the ones everyone else might think are too ordinary to matter.

Corvin — Practical, organised, and likely to be thinking about supplies when everyone else is busy arguing about fate. Corvin believes a good plan is not the enemy of an adventure.

Eldric — Quiet, patient, and wiser than he claims to be. Eldric knows that people need room to make their own choices, but he refuses to let them mistake loneliness for strength.

M — A name found in old records, towers, routes, and notes left for travellers who have not yet learned what they are searching for.

Paper — A strange piece of writing that has opinions, answers only some questions, and appears to have no interest in being polite about any of them.

Bizo — A name connected to earlier mysteries. Not every name has finished meaning something just because it has been spoken once.

Places Worth Remembering

Home — The place the group returned to at the end of Book Two. It is warm, familiar, and important—but not an answer to every question waiting beyond its door.

The Roads — Routes that do not always behave like ordinary paths. They can lead travellers through places shaped by memory, unfinished choices, and the need to return or continue.

The Tower — A place of books, records, and difficult doors. It is connected to answers that never arrive in the clean, simple form people hope for.

The Structures — Strange places gathered around abandoned choices, unfinished grief, and paths people could not bring themselves to complete. They offer possibilities; they do not make decisions for anyone.

Old Routes — Traces of earlier travellers: storage rooms, shelters, archives, notes, markers, and places that may look unimportant until someone realizes what was left behind there.

The Taverns — Places of food, rest, stories, arguments, and the rare chance for travellers to remember that survival is not the same as living.

Objects and Terms

Coins — Small guides that respond to direction in ways the group does not fully understand. They are helpful, stubborn, and not remotely good at explaining themselves.

The Six Keys — A set of keys received after the previous journey. Each member of the group carries one. Their purpose remains uncertain, but they clearly belong to a road that has not ended yet.

The Compass — A practical object with an impractical history. It points, but not always toward the answer someone expects.

The Shared Journal — A record carried by the group. It holds notes, memories, questions, arguments, and the kind of truth that becomes easier to say when placed on paper first.

Future Alias's Journal — A more private record belonging to Future Alias. Its pages contain a road the others have only begun to understand.

Paper — Not merely paper. It writes when it wishes to write, answers when it wishes to answer, and has demonstrated a worrying confidence in its own sense of humour.

Pathstriders — Travellers who continue walking even when the road has become more complicated than the map.

— *The road continues in Chapter 1: The Morning After Tomorrow* —

PART I
THE ROAD AFTER HOME

Chapter 1: The Morning After Tomorrow

Some roads only begin after you have finally come home.

The morning after a long journey never feels like the end of anything.

It feels strange to wake up somewhere familiar after spending so long sleeping beneath trees, inside ruined towers, beside roads that did not exist on any map. The ceiling was too still. The window was too square. Even the pale line of sunlight on the floor seemed as though it had been placed there on purpose.

Alias lay awake for a while, listening.

There was no wind dragging through broken stone. No distant howl. No low hum from a Structure waiting for someone foolish enough to touch it. There was only the ordinary sound of the house waking around him: a pipe knocking once in the wall, wood settling in the cold, someone downstairs dropping a spoon and saying a word that was definitely not polite.

Rowan, then.

Alias smiled into his blanket before he could stop himself.

Yesterday had been loud. There had been food in uneven piles, too many mugs on the tavern table, a birthday that had somehow become everyone talking at once, and gifts that kept appearing from pockets, bags, sleeves, and one very suspicious loaf of bread. They had stayed until the lamps burned low. For one evening, nobody had needed to solve anything. Nobody had needed to run. Nobody had needed to explain a terrible thing that had happened on a road.

They had simply been there.

It had felt almost dangerous, how good that was.

Alias pushed himself upright. His pack sat beside the bed where he had left it, still dusty from the last journey. The sight of it should have bothered him. He was home. He should have unpacked it, washed the dirt from his clothes, placed the strange things from the road in a safe drawer and promised never to look at them again.

Instead, he looked at the pack as though it might already know where they were going next.

On the small table beside it lay the compass.

It was not pointing north.

It had not pointed north for a long time.

Alias reached for it, then stopped. The needle trembled once, lazily, and settled toward the window. Not directly east. Not directly anywhere useful. Just far enough away to be annoying.

'You could at least pretend to be a normal compass,' Alias muttered.

The compass did not answer.

From downstairs came a second crash, followed by Corvin's tired voice. 'That was the third spoon this morning.'

'It slipped,' Rowan called back.

'Spoons do not normally fly across rooms.'

'This one did.'

Alias laughed, got dressed, and went downstairs.

The kitchen was already warm with the smell of bread, tea, and something frying in a pan. Morning light spilled across the table in wide gold strips. Rowan stood near the stove with one hand held behind his back, looking innocent in the way only someone who had very obviously done something could look innocent.

Corvin sat at the table with a stack of paper, a pencil, and the expression of a person trying to bring order to a world that had personally offended him.

Maris was beside him, writing in the shared journal. Her hair was still half tied back, and there was a little ink on the side of her hand. She did not look up when Alias entered.

'He is awake,' she said.

'I can see that,' Corvin replied.

'No, I meant he has that face.'

Alias paused in the doorway. 'What face?'

Maris finally looked up. 'The one you make when you are thinking about a road before breakfast.'

'I do not have a road face.'

Rowan turned from the stove. 'You absolutely have a road face. It is like your normal face, but less sensible.'

'My normal face is sensible.'

Rowan said, 'That is not the part I disagreed with.'

Eldric sat at the far end of the table, both hands around a cup of tea. He did not join the argument immediately. He watched it with the quiet, patient look he had when he was enjoying himself too much to interrupt.

'Good morning, Alias,' he said.

'Morning.' Alias took the empty chair between Rowan and Maris. 'What happened to the spoons?'

'They made a brave attempt to escape,' Rowan said.

Corvin did not look up from his papers. 'Rowan tried to flip one into the pan.'

'And it almost worked.'

'The pan was behind you.'

'Details.'

For a while, that was enough. Bread was passed around. Rowan complained that there was not enough honey. Corvin said there was plenty of honey and that Rowan had simply put most of it on one piece of bread. Maris wrote down a line, crossed it out, then wrote another. Eldric poured tea for Alias without being asked.

It was ordinary.

Alias kept noticing it because it was ordinary.

Then he noticed the empty chair.

It was beside the window, turned slightly toward the light. A cup stood in front of it. Steam still lifted from the tea.

Future Alias was standing at the window with his back to the room.

He had been there when Alias entered. Somehow, Alias had simply not seen him at first.

The older version of him wore the same grey cloak from yesterday, though he had removed the gloves. One hand rested against the frame. Outside, the street was beginning to fill with people: a woman carrying vegetables, two children chasing each other around a cart, an old man trying to keep his hat from blowing away.

Future Alias watched them as though he had been asked to remember every face.

'Your tea is getting cold,' Rowan said, more gently than usual.

Future Alias turned. For a second, he looked startled, as if he had forgotten there were other people in the room. Then the expression passed.

'I know,' he said.

His voice was quiet. Not sad exactly. Just far away.

Alias knew that look. He had seen it before, usually when Future Alias thought nobody was watching. It was the look of someone standing in a warm room and still expecting the door to close behind him.

Future Alias crossed back to the table and sat down. His movements were careful. He picked up the cup, held it between both hands, and did not drink.

'Did you sleep?' Maris asked.

'Enough.'

'That is not an answer,' Corvin said.

'It is the answer I have.'

Rowan pushed the honey toward him. 'You look like someone who needs sugar.'

Future Alias stared at the jar. 'Is that medical advice?'

'Yes.'

'From you?'

'I have a lot of experience with sugar.'

That got a small smile from Future Alias. It appeared only for a moment, but everyone noticed it. Rowan pretended not to. Maris returned to the journal before the smile could become embarrassing. Eldric took a sip of tea, looking pleased in the quiet way he did when nobody was looking at him.

Corvin tapped his pencil against the table.

'Since everyone is awake,' he said, 'we should decide what we are doing.'

Rowan looked offended. 'We are eating breakfast.'

'After breakfast.'

'That is very different.'

'It is not.'

Alias looked at the papers in front of Corvin. Most were lists. Corvin liked lists. There were lists for food, lists for money, lists for supplies that needed repairing, and one list titled THINGS WE HAVE NOT BEEN ABLE TO EXPLAIN, which was much longer than Alias expected.

At the top of it, in Corvin's neat writing, were three words:

THE SIX KEYS.

Beside the papers, laid carefully on a folded cloth, were the things that had followed them home from the road: the six keys, the strange coins, the compass, and the shared journal. The keys were different sizes and different metals. One was old brass, one dark iron, one silvered almost black with age. They did not look as though they belonged together.

But they had come together.

Alias felt the same uncomfortable pull in his chest that he felt whenever he looked at them too long.

'We know they are important,' Corvin said. 'We know M intended us to have them. We know the coins have been... less restless since we returned. And we know the compass is still refusing to act like a compass.'

'It is doing its best,' Rowan said.

'It is an object.'

'That is exactly what an object would want you to think.'

Maris looked toward the journal. 'Paper wrote something this morning.'

Alias leaned closer. The book lay open to a blank page. A line of dark letters sat in the middle, sharp and narrow, as though someone had pressed a pen into the paper from the other side.

GOING HOME IS NOT THE SAME AS STOPPING.

No one spoke for a moment.

Rowan looked at the words. 'That is annoyingly wise for a piece of paper.'

The letters changed.

I AM NOT PAPER.

'You are literally paper,' Rowan said.

I AM ALSO RIGHT.

Eldric smiled into his cup.

Future Alias had gone still.

Alias noticed the way his fingers tightened around the tea cup. It was not much. Someone who did not know him might not have seen it. But Alias did know him, in the strange incomplete way a person could know someone who carried his own face years ahead of him.

'What does it mean?' Alias asked.

The journal remained silent.

'Probably that we should not pretend the road is finished because we got to sleep in beds for one night,' Corvin said. 'There are still questions. Important ones.'

'Such as?' Rowan asked.

Corvin looked at Future Alias, then looked away again. 'Such as how he returns safely.'

The kitchen became very quiet.

Outside, someone laughed in the street. A cart rolled over uneven stone. The pan on the stove hissed once, loudly, as though it had been waiting for the worst possible moment to do it.

Future Alias lowered his eyes.

'You do not have to make your lives about that,' he said.

Alias frowned. 'About what?'

Future Alias said, 'About me getting back. You have already done enough.'

'Enough for what?' Rowan asked.

Future Alias did not answer.

Rowan's face changed. The joke disappeared from it. 'No. Seriously. Enough for what?'

Future Alias looked at the keys instead of any of them. 'You came through things that were not yours. You went places you did not need to go. You could have stayed home after the first road. You could have left me in the Tower. You could have said I was someone else's problem.'

'You are not someone else's problem,' Alias said.

The words came out faster than he meant them to.

Future Alias finally looked at him.

For a second, they were too similar. Same eyes. Same way of holding still when something hurt. Same instinct to say nothing until silence became heavier than the truth.

'I know that is what you think now,' Future Alias said softly.

Alias felt something sharp move through him. 'That sounds like you think I will stop.'

'I think people get tired.'

'People do,' Eldric said.

Future Alias glanced toward him.

Eldric set down his cup. 'But being tired is not the same as being abandoned. It is important not to confuse the two.'

No one made a joke after that.

Maris closed the shared journal, carefully, as though she were giving the words inside it privacy. 'We are not deciding this because we have to rescue you,' she said. 'We are deciding because there is something unfinished. That is different.'

'And because I hate unfinished notes,' Corvin added. 'They make bad routes.'

Rowan nodded. 'Also, you are very bad at accepting help. Someone needs to supervise that.'

Future Alias almost smiled again. 'You would call this supervision?'

'The best kind.'

Alias looked down at the compass. Its needle had begun to move. Slowly, it turned away from the window, past the door, and pointed toward the back wall.

Then it stopped.

The wall led nowhere but toward the old road beyond the town.

'There,' Alias said.

Corvin leaned over. 'It could be reacting to the keys.'

'Or the coins,' Maris said.

'Or it is hungry,' Rowan offered.

'It is not hungry,' Corvin said.

'You do not know that.'

Alias held the compass up. The needle trembled once against the glass, then steadied. It was not a command. It was not a warning. It was only a direction.

He thought of every road that had brought them here. The first road had felt like falling. The second had felt like trying to hold onto something that was already burning away. This one did not have to be either.

'We should go,' he said.

Future Alias shook his head immediately. 'Alias.'

'Not today,' Alias said. 'Not without packing. Not without a plan. But soon.'

'You just came home.'

'Yes.'

Future Alias said, 'Then stay home,' and there was something almost desperate in the words. 'You have people here. A room. A life. You do not have to follow every strange thing that points somewhere.'

Alias looked around the kitchen.

At Rowan, standing with a spoon in one hand and a burned piece of bread in the other. At Corvin, who had already started adding headings to his lists. At Maris, who was watching the

compass more closely than anyone else. At Eldric, who somehow seemed to have understood every part of the conversation before anyone had said it.

Then he looked back at Future Alias.

'I am not leaving home,' Alias said. 'I am taking it with me.'

Rowan blinked.

'That was annoyingly good,' he said.

'Do not ruin it,' Maris told him.

'I was praising him.'

'You were being loud about praising him.'

'That is how praise works.'

Corvin made a small line on one of his papers. 'For the record, I agree with Alias. We should travel. But we do it properly. We make a route, we bring supplies, and nobody vanishes into a ruin without telling the rest of us first.'

Future Alias looked as if he wanted to argue again. Instead, he said, 'You do not know where it leads.'

'Neither do you,' Alias replied.

'No,' Future Alias admitted.

'Then we find out together.'

The room held still around that sentence.

It was not a promise that everything would be safe. Alias did not think any of them were foolish enough to make promises like that anymore. Roads could still be cruel. People could still make mistakes. A door could still open somewhere it should not.

But together was something they could choose.

Eldric reached into the middle of the table and rested two fingers on the folded cloth beside the keys.

'There is a difference,' he said, 'between running because you are afraid of what waits behind you, and walking because you are ready to understand what waits ahead.'

Future Alias listened without moving.

'Which is this?' he asked.

Eldric looked around the table. 'That depends on what we do when the road becomes difficult.'

Rowan lifted the burned bread. 'Eat first?'

Corvin sighed. 'Yes, Rowan. Eat first.'

'Then I say we are ready.'

This time, Future Alias did smile. It was not the small, careful smile from before. It was tired and uncertain, but real enough to stay for a few breaths.

'All right,' he said.

Alias did not know whether he meant all right, they could travel, or all right, he would let them try. Maybe it was both.

Maris opened the journal again. After a moment, she wrote in it herself.

We returned home. We rested. We are leaving again, not because home failed us, but because something still needs to be understood.

She looked at the others. 'Too serious?'

'A little,' Rowan said. 'Add that breakfast was good.'

'Breakfast was not good,' Corvin said.

'It was brave,' Rowan corrected.

Maris wrote a second line underneath.

Rowan says breakfast was brave.

Future Alias let out a quiet laugh.

The sound made Alias look at him.

He was holding the cup normally now. The cold tea had finally been forgotten. Sunlight reached the edge of his cloak, making the grey look less like ash and more like silver.

For a moment, he did not look like someone waiting to disappear.

He looked like part of the room.

The compass needle pointed toward the road.

Alias set it down beside the keys.

Tomorrow, they would pack. Soon after, they would leave. There would be maps, arguments, too many supplies, not enough supplies, and Rowan trying to fit something useless into someone else's bag. There would be questions waiting at the end of the road, and probably questions waiting before they even reached it.

But this morning belonged to them.

The morning after tomorrow, Alias thought, was not something a person could own yet.

Still, for the first time, he wanted to meet it.

PART I

THE ROAD AFTER HOME

Chapter 2: Things We Carried Home

A direction is not the same as a destination.

Packing made a journey feel more real than deciding on one ever did.

A decision could stay safely inside a warm kitchen, between cups of tea and unfinished bread. A decision could sound brave while everyone was sitting down. But a bedroll on the floor, a half-filled pack, and Corvin arguing with Rowan about the reasonable number of socks a person needed made the road feel very close.

'You do not need seven pairs,' Corvin said for what was probably the fourth time.

Rowan held up two mismatched socks. 'These are not pairs. These are options.'

'You have one left sock with a hole in it.'

'A useful hole.'

'For what?'

Rowan looked down at it. 'Air.'

The common room had become a small disaster before noon. Packs leaned against chairs. A blanket was folded on the windowsill because Maris had decided it would dry faster there. Corvin had made three separate piles on the table: food, tools, and things Rowan had tried to pack without a reason.

The third pile was the largest.

Alias sat on the floor near the hearth with his own pack open in front of him. He had put in a spare shirt, a cloak, a waterskin, a little pouch of coins, and a small knife that had been sharpened so often the edge looked almost too bright. Beside him lay the strange compass, wrapped in cloth so that it would not scratch against anything else.

He had packed and unpacked it twice already.

It was strange how quickly a person could become afraid of taking too much, or not enough.

'That goes in the middle,' Maris said from the table.

Alias looked up. 'What does?'

She pointed to the compass. 'Not at the bottom. If we need it quickly, we should not have to pull out a shirt and three pieces of bread first.'

'Two pieces of bread,' Alias said.

Maris glanced at his pack. 'You packed a third piece after I looked.'

Alias put the compass in the middle.

At the other end of the room, Future Alias stood beside the long table with his personal journal in his hands. Its cover was worn at the corners. The leather was darker near the spine, where his thumb had rested against it so often that the material had changed shape.

He had not put it in his pack yet.

For a while, he only looked at it.

Alias almost asked what he was thinking. Then he remembered how much he hated being asked that question when he did not yet have an answer. He looked back down at his own bag instead.

Eldric was checking the straps on a travel lantern. He did everything calmly, including deciding whether a lantern had a good enough strap. Corvin had given him a list. Eldric had read it, nodded once, and then quietly improved it.

'We leave after lunch,' Corvin said. 'That gives us time to make sure everyone has what they need.'

'I need a better sock,' Rowan announced.

'You need to stop packing nonsense,' Corvin replied.

'That is not a thing I can carry.'

'It would make the pack lighter.'

Maris covered a smile with the back of her hand.

On the table beside her, the six keys waited on a folded cloth.

They had been there since breakfast. Nobody had said they were avoiding them, but nobody had touched them either. The keys did not shine or hum or do anything that would make a normal person understand them. They were simply different: different metals, different teeth, different shapes, each carrying the quiet, uncomfortable feeling that it belonged to this journey more than any of them did.

Six keys. Six people.

The answer seemed too obvious to be trusted.

Corvin noticed Alias looking. 'We should settle this now.'

Rowan turned away from his socks. 'Settle what?'

Corvin pointed at the keys. 'Who carries what.'

'I vote that I carry two,' Rowan said immediately.

'You cannot even carry two socks that match,' Maris said.

'That is because socks are trying to limit me.'

Eldric set the lantern down. 'One key each seems sensible.'

'There are six of us,' Alias said.

Future Alias finally moved. He set his journal down beside his pack, then came closer to the table. 'That does not mean they are made for us.'

'No,' Eldric said. 'But it may mean we are meant to decide what to do with them together.'

Future Alias looked at him, uncertain.

Eldric did not add anything else. He never pushed a sentence further than it needed to go.

For a moment, nobody reached for a key.

Then Maris chose the narrow silver one. She did not make a speech. She only picked it up, tested its weight in her palm, and slipped it into the inner pocket of her coat beside her pencil case.

'I will write down anything it does,' she said.

'Very comforting,' Rowan said.

'It is more comforting than guessing.'

Corvin picked up the old brass key with the square head. He inspected it as though it had been handed to him for repair, then tucked it into a small pouch on his belt.

'I will keep it somewhere it cannot fall out,' he said.

'That was aimed at me,' Rowan said.

'Everything I say about securing objects is aimed at you.'

Rowan chose next, mostly so nobody could choose for him. He picked the key with the round handle and held it up to the light.

'This one looks like it has a story,' he said.

'They all have stories,' Maris replied.

'Yes, but this one looks like it knows a song.'

No one knew what that meant, including Rowan. He tied it carefully inside his coat instead of tossing it into his pack, which was probably the closest he came to admitting it mattered.

Eldric selected a dark iron key. He examined it briefly, then placed it in the quietest pocket of his cloak.

Alias took the small key with a worn black edge. It was colder than he expected. The cold stayed in his palm even after he slipped it into the same inner pocket as his compass.

That left one key on the cloth.

Future Alias stared at it for long enough that Rowan stopped smiling.

'You do not have to carry it,' Alias said.

Future Alias looked at him. 'It is not that.'

'Then what is it?'

He looked down again. 'I am trying to remember whether I have held it before.'

The room quieted.

'Do you remember?' Maris asked.

Future Alias shook his head. 'Not clearly. There were too many things near the end that felt like this. Something important. Something I was meant to understand. I cannot tell if it is memory or fear pretending to be memory.'

Eldric rested one hand on the table. 'Then you do not need to know today.'

Future Alias breathed out slowly. He picked up the last key and closed his fingers around it.

Nothing happened.

No door opened. No light spilled across the room. The floor did not shake. The keys simply disappeared into six different pockets, and somehow that felt more serious than any kind of magic would have.

Maris opened the shared journal and wrote a line beneath the note from breakfast.

Six keys. Six hands. No idea what they open.

Rowan leaned over her shoulder. 'Add that we are optimistic.'

'Are we?' Corvin asked.

'No, but it sounds better than worried.'

The journal waited for a few seconds.

Then fresh letters appeared beneath Maris's writing.

SOME THINGS ARE EASIER TO CARRY THAN TO LEAVE.

Rowan read it twice. 'That is either very meaningful or Paper wants us to stop complaining about packs.'

The letters changed at once.

BOTH.

'Helpful,' Corvin said flatly.

Future Alias had not laughed. He was looking at the words with the careful stillness Alias had started to recognize. It was the stillness he wore when something had reached him before he had time to guard against it.

Then Future Alias closed the shared journal and handed it to Maris.

'Keep that one with you,' he said.

Maris blinked. 'I was planning to.'

'Good.'

He picked up his own journal, slid it into the inside of his grey cloak, and fastened the clasp over it. Not in his pack. Not where anyone could take it by accident. Against his chest, where he could feel it while he walked.

Alias noticed. He said nothing.

There were some things a person carried because they were useful. Water. Food. A knife. A compass that refused to be normal.

There were other things a person carried because leaving them behind felt impossible.

By the time the food had been packed, the light outside had moved from pale gold to clear afternoon. Corvin checked his list one last time. He did it with the seriousness of someone preparing for a small war against bad planning.

'Bread?'

'Packed,' Maris said.

'Water?'

'Packed,' Eldric said.

'Bandages?'

'Packed,' Alias said.

'The shared journal?'

Maris held it up.

'The coins?'

Future Alias reached into his coat and brought out the small leather pouch. He opened it carefully over the table.

The coins inside were old and uneven, as though they had travelled farther than any money had a right to travel. They had spent too long spinning, pulling, and leading people toward places nobody could explain. Now, when Future Alias tipped them into his palm, they did something quieter.

They settled together against the base of his fingers.

Not pointing like an arrow. Not giving him a map. Just leaning, all of them, in the same direction.

He turned his hand slightly toward the northern road beyond town. The coins shifted together, then grew still.

'North first,' he said.

Corvin looked at the compass on Alias's pack. 'And then?'

Alias opened the cloth and held the compass flat. Its needle wavered, then settled a little to the east of north.

'East, eventually,' he said.

'North, then east,' Maris repeated, writing it down.

Rowan peered at the coins. 'That is all we get?'

Future Alias closed his hand around them. 'The coins are not maps.'

'And the compass is still only a compass,' Eldric added.

Rowan looked personally betrayed by both objects. 'Then why do they act so mysterious?'

'Because you keep asking them questions they cannot answer,' Corvin said.

'That has never stopped you before.'

'I ask people. People can be corrected.'

Rowan nodded thoughtfully. 'The compass should be grateful.'

They ate lunch standing around the table because nobody had remembered to make room to sit. It was bread, cheese, apple slices, and the last of the honey that Rowan had defended from Corvin as if it had been a family inheritance.

For a little while, the road waited outside and the room felt almost normal again. Then Rowan bent over his pack to tie one of the straps. A thin red thread slipped loose from the knot around his rolled blanket and drifted to the floor.

'There,' Rowan said, without noticing. 'That is why I do not like tying things properly. They escape.'

Corvin made a sound that was almost a groan.

Rowan tried to retie the blanket. Maris helped him before he could make it worse. Eldric was checking the doorway for draughts, which Alias suspected was just his quiet way of making sure everyone had actually finished packing.

No one noticed Future Alias bend down.

Alias only saw it because he was already watching him.

Future Alias picked up the red thread from the floor. It was nothing much. A loose strand, bright against his gloved fingers. He looked at it for one second too long, then folded it once and slipped it into the small pocket inside his sleeve.

Alias thought he might be saving it so Rowan would not lose it again.

He did not ask.

When everyone was ready, the room felt suddenly too full of the things they were leaving behind.

The blanket folded over the chair. The bread crumbs still on the table. Rowan's abandoned bad sock under the window. The cup Future Alias had used that morning, washed and drying beside the sink. Ordinary proof that they had been here.

Future Alias stood near the door with one hand on the strap of his pack. He looked back once, quickly, as though he did not want anyone to see him do it.

Alias did see.

'We are coming back,' he said.

Future Alias looked at him.

'I know,' he replied.

But he said it like a person testing whether the words could hold his weight. Eldric locked the door behind them. Corvin checked it twice. Rowan insisted he had never seen anyone lock a door with such disappointment.

'I am not disappointed,' Corvin said.

'You are making your disappointed face.'

'That is my careful face.'

'It looks disappointed.'

Maris walked between them with the shared journal tucked safely beneath her arm. 'Both of you can be quiet for one minute,' she said.

They were quiet for nearly twenty seconds.

The road out of town began past the last row of shops, where the stone gave way to packed earth and grass pressed close to either side. The day was cool but clear. Clouds moved slowly across a wide blue sky. A cart passed them heading the other way, full of vegetables and one very loud child who waved at Rowan until Rowan waved back like they were old friends.

At the north gate, the town guard barely looked at them. Six travellers with packs were not unusual. A man in a grey cloak with an old journal might have been unusual, but the guard only yawned and told them to keep to the road if rain came.

'We will,' Corvin promised.

Rowan waited until they were out of earshot. 'That sounded exactly like the kind of thing someone says before absolutely not keeping to the road.'

'We will keep to the road,' Corvin said.

'Until the road becomes impossible and then we go through a forest or a cave or a wall.'

'That has happened twice.'

'It has happened more than twice.'

'It has happened twice in ways that were our decision.'

Eldric looked toward the road ahead. 'Let us try for a third decision that is better planned.'

That ended the argument, mostly because none of them could think of a good answer to it.

Beyond the gate, the world opened around them.

The northern road ran between fields faded by the season. Far ahead, it curved behind a low hill and disappeared. It did not look like a road to a Tower, or a Structure, or an answer. It looked like any other road. Dusty. Narrow. Patient.

Alias felt the compass shift lightly against his chest.

Future Alias loosened his grip on the pouch of coins. They were quiet in his pocket now.

Maris opened the shared journal while she walked and wrote the first line of the new journey.

We left with six keys, a broken direction, and enough bread for four days if Rowan does not find it first.

'I can hear you writing that,' Rowan said.

'Good,' Maris replied.

Alias looked once over his shoulder at the town, at the roofs and chimneys and the little square window of the room they had just left. Then he turned back to the road.

Home did not vanish when they walked away from it.

It travelled with them in the sound of Rowan arguing, in Corvin's careful lists, in Maris's handwriting, in Eldric's steady steps, and in the strange fact that Future Alias was still beside him.

They walked north first.

East could wait.

PART I

THE ROAD AFTER HOME

Chapter 3: North, Then East

A road can look ordinary and still lead somewhere impossible.

By the third morning, the north road had stopped feeling like the beginning of anything.

It had become a road.

It ran through low fields and past crooked fences. It climbed shallow hills only to come down again. It gave them dust when the weather was dry, mud when it rained, and one long patch of loose stones that made Rowan complain for nearly half an hour.

"They keep moving," Rowan said, looking down at the road as though it had betrayed him personally.

Corvin did not look up from the map in his hands. "That is what loose stones do."

"They move when I step on them."

"That is also what loose stones do."

"I think they have chosen me."

Maris, walking beside Alias, made a note in the shared journal.

Alias tried to read it upside down.

"Do not," Maris said.

"What did you write?"

"Rowan has discovered gravel."

Rowan pointed at her without slowing down. "That is not respectful documentation."

"It is exact documentation."

Eldric smiled into the collar of his cloak. Ahead of them, Future Alias walked a little apart from the others. Not far. Never far enough that a person could accuse him of leaving. But far enough that he could see the whole road before it bent behind the next hill.

His grey cloak moved softly in the breeze. One hand rested near the pouch of coins beneath it. The other stayed loose at his side, as though he had taught himself not to reach for anything unless there was a reason.

Alias watched him for a while.

Future Alias looked behind them.

Then at the hedge to their left. Then at the slope to their right. Then ahead again.

He did it so quickly that nobody else seemed to notice.

Alias noticed because he had started noticing everything Future Alias did when he thought nobody was looking.

They had been walking for three days. The first morning, Future Alias had been awake before the sun rose. The second, he had checked the water skins twice before anyone had asked him to. Yesterday, when a cart passed them on the road, he had moved slightly in front of Maris without seeming to realize he had done it.

None of it was wrong.

That was what made it difficult to talk about.

The road crested another low hill. Beyond it sat a cluster of houses with red roofs and whitewashed walls. A little stream curled around one side of the village, and smoke rose from at least four chimneys.

Rowan stopped complaining about stones immediately.

"Food," he said.

Corvin folded the map. "A village."

"Food village."

"There may be food in it."

"That is what I said."

Maris glanced at the sun. "We could stop for an hour. We are ahead of the distance Corvin planned for today."

"Because Rowan walked quickly once he thought there might be a bakery," Corvin said.

"Motivation is an important travel skill."

Eldric looked toward Future Alias. "What do the coins say?"

Future Alias had already taken the pouch from his coat. He loosened its drawstring and tipped the old coins into his palm.

For a moment, they made no sound at all.

Then one turned. Another followed. They shifted against one another like a small group deciding where to stand.

All of them leaned north.

Future Alias looked toward the village, then down at the coins again.

"They do not object," he said.

Rowan grinned. "Even the coins want food village."

The village was called Nettlebridge, though Alias did not see a bridge until they were nearly inside it. The name had been painted above a wooden gate in faded blue letters. Someone had added a small drawing of a nettle leaf beneath it, perhaps so strangers would not forget which village they had reached.

The bridge itself crossed the narrow stream at the far end of the main street. It was made of grey stone, old enough that moss had grown in its cracks. A woman with a basket of onions was crossing it at the same time as a goat that seemed to have no interest in sharing the space.

The goat won.

"It has the right idea," Rowan said quietly. "Walk like you own the road."

"Please do not learn confidence from a goat," Corvin replied.

"Too late."

They found a small bakery near the stream. Its windows were fogged with warmth, and the sign above the door showed a loaf of bread with a very serious face drawn on it. Rowan stared at it for a full second.

"That bread looks worried," he said.

"It has seen you coming," Maris said.

Inside, the smell was enough to make Alias realize how hungry he was. Warm bread. Apples. Butter. Something sweet with cinnamon. The room was crowded with villagers eating late breakfast and a pair of traders arguing gently about wheels.

The baker looked at the six packs, the tired faces, and Rowan staring at the shelves as though he had reached a holy place.

"Travellers?" she asked.

"Temporarily hungry travellers," Rowan said.

Corvin placed two coins on the counter before Rowan could say anything worse. "Six rolls, two loaves for the road, and whatever hot drink is easiest."

The baker nodded. "Going north?"

"For now," Eldric said.

"Then keep to the eastern side after the old mill," she told them. "The western bank turns to mud if rain comes."

"Thank you," Corvin said.

The baker began gathering bread. "You are not headed for Rellin, are you?"

Corvin looked at the map again. "We might be. Why?"

She shrugged, but not quite carelessly. "Nothing wrong with it. Just odd. Most people going north take the larger road through Bramblecross. Rellin has old records, old houses, old people who want to tell you about both."

"It has food?" Rowan asked.

The baker looked at him. "It has an inn."

"Then it sounds perfect."

Maris leaned forward slightly. "What kind of old records?"

The baker took longer than necessary to cut a loaf. "Route records, mostly. From before the road was redone. Old storage ledgers. Letters. Things no one has wanted for years, except the people who suddenly want them very badly."

Future Alias went still beside the door.

Alias saw him look toward the northern window. His fingers closed around the pouch of coins in his pocket.

"Is there an archive?" Maris asked.

"A routehouse," the baker said. "Old stone thing near the east gate. Locked up now. The town lets a collector mind the papers. Says it is safer that way."

"Safer from what?" Rowan asked.

The baker gave him the look adults gave children when the truth was not dangerous enough to hide but too annoying to explain. "From damp. From fire. From people who do not know what they are touching. And from anyone who does not have the right money."

Corvin's mouth tightened just a little.

Maris quietly wrote Rellin in the shared journal.

Future Alias did not say anything.

The baker handed them their food. Her eyes settled on the grey cloak for a moment, perhaps noticing how pale Future Alias had become.

"You all right, lad?" she asked.

Future Alias blinked once. "Yes."

It was not a convincing answer, but she did not press him.

Outside, they ate on the low stone wall beside the stream. Rowan ate two rolls so quickly that Corvin looked at him with a mixture of concern and surrender.

"You know we bought bread for later too," Corvin said.

"I am preserving the later bread by not eating it now."

"That is not how preservation works."

"It is if you believe hard enough."

Maris spread the map between them. The paper kept trying to curl in the breeze, so Eldric held two corners while Alias held the other two.

"Rellin is here," Corvin said, tapping the map. "Two days if the weather holds. The main road bends northeast before it reaches it."

Alias held the compass above the map. The needle wavered, then pointed just east of north.

"That fits," he said.

Future Alias stood at the end of the wall. He was not looking at the map. He was looking at the road leaving the village.

"I remember the name," he said at last.

Everyone looked at him.

"Rellin?" Maris asked.

He nodded once. "Not clearly. I think I passed through it. Or meant to. There was a building with a bell over the door. I remember the sound when the wind moved it."

"That is something," Eldric said.

"It might be nothing," Future Alias replied.

"Nothing can still be useful," Eldric said. "It tells us where to look."

Future Alias looked down at the coins again. "They feel calmer when we go this way."

Rowan paused halfway through the last bite of his roll. "Calmer?"

Future Alias nodded. "Usually they are restless. They move. They pull. I do not know how else to say it. When we are close to a direction that matters, they stop fighting each other."

Alias thought of the coins in Future Alias's palm. Not pointing. Not pulling. Leaning together.

"So they are not telling us where the end is," Maris said slowly.

"No," Future Alias replied. "Only that this road is not wrong."

For some reason, that answer made the road feel larger.

They left Nettlebridge before the clouds decided what they wanted to do. The first rain began as a soft tapping against their cloaks, almost polite. By the time they reached the old mill, it had become a steady grey curtain that swallowed the fields on either side of the road.

Rowan pulled his hood over his hair and stared into the rain. "The sky is leaking."

"That is rain," Corvin said.

"It is still a design flaw."

The eastern bank did not turn to mud, exactly. It turned to something less honest: ground that looked firm until a boot sank into it without warning.

Rowan found this out first.

His foot disappeared nearly to the ankle. He threw both arms out, caught nothing, and somehow remained standing.

"I am fine," he announced immediately.

"Nobody asked," Maris said.

"You were about to."

Eldric offered him a hand anyway. Rowan accepted it with dignity that survived only until he looked down at his muddy boot.

"The road is still choosing me," he said.

The rain did not let them reach the next town before dark. They found shelter under the roof of an abandoned cart shed at the edge of a field, where three walls remained and the fourth had apparently been taken by time, weather, or a very determined cow.

Corvin inspected it with suspicion.

"It is dry enough," Eldric said.

"Mostly dry," Corvin corrected.

"That is a generous description," Rowan said, wringing water from one sleeve.

Still, they made it work. Eldric coaxed a small fire into life inside an old iron pan. Maris hung the wettest pieces of cloth near the warmth. Corvin checked their food supply, then checked it again because Rowan had been left alone near the bread for nearly ten minutes.

Alias sat with his knees drawn close beneath his cloak, watching steam rise from the little pot of water.

Future Alias sat opposite him.

He had taken the outer layer of his grey cloak off and spread it near the fire, but he kept his boots on. His pack rested against the wall beside him. The pouch of coins lay inside it. His personal journal was not.

It was tucked under his arm, protected from the damp.

There were two openings in the shed: the missing fourth wall, and a broken doorway at the far side. Future Alias had positioned himself where he could see both.

Alias noticed that too.

He tried not to make it feel like a question. "Do you always sit where you can see the exits?"

Future Alias looked up.

For one second, something guarded crossed his face. Then it softened into embarrassment.

"Usually," he said.

"Why?"

Future Alias considered that longer than Alias expected. Outside, rain moved across the broken roof in a soft, constant sound.

"Because it is easier," he said finally. "If I know where I would go."

"Go where?"

Future Alias stared past him, toward the dark field. "Anywhere that is not where the danger is."

Alias looked at the doorway too. It was just a doorway. A wet, crooked rectangle that led to grass and rain.

"Does it help?" he asked.

Future Alias gave a small shrug. "Sometimes."

Rowan had gone unusually quiet near the fire. He was holding his mug of hot water in both hands, listening without pretending not to.

Eldric spoke before the silence became too heavy.

"It is sensible to know the way out," he said. "It is only a problem when the way out becomes the only thing you can see."

Future Alias looked at him.

Eldric did not sound accusing. He rarely did. He sounded as though he was saying something he had learned from walking his own bad roads.

"I know," Future Alias said.

Corvin passed him a piece of bread. "Then also look at the food. You have barely eaten since Nettlebridge."

Future Alias blinked, as though he had forgotten food existed.

"I ate," he said.

"One bite does not count as a meal," Corvin replied.

"It was a large bite."

"It was not."

Rowan raised his mug. "I saw it. It was emotionally large."

Maris pressed her lips together, trying not to smile.

Future Alias looked at the bread in Corvin's hand. At last, he took it.

"Thank you," he said.

They ate in the soft light of the small fire. The rain held them in place. There was nowhere else to go for the night, which was strange enough to make the shed feel almost safe.

After a while, Maris opened the shared journal.

"We should write down what we know," she said.

"That will be short," Rowan said.

"It will be clearer than what we do not know."

She placed the journal on an overturned crate. "Six keys. A compass that points northeast. Coins that are less restless when we walk the correct way. Rellin. An archive. A memory of a bell."

"And rain," Rowan added.

"The rain is not a clue."

"It might be."

Corvin rubbed a hand over his face. "Please do not make weather mysterious just because we already have enough mysterious things."

Maris wrote the first list anyway.

Then she looked at the six of them around the fire.

"We also know each of us has a key," she said. "That has to mean something."

"It could mean the keys are badly organized," Rowan said.

"That is not how keys work," Corvin replied.

"You do not know. Maybe they are trying to become a key-ring."

Alias touched the key in his inner pocket through the cloth of his coat. It had been cold on the first day. Now it felt no different from anything else he carried.

"Maybe it does not mean one person has the answer," he said.

The others looked at him.

"Maybe it means the answer needs all of us."

Maris turned that over in her mind. "A door that needs six keys."

"Or six people," Eldric said.

Future Alias's fingers tightened once around the edge of his journal.

"That sounds like a lot to put on people," he said.

"Only if they did not choose it," Eldric replied.

No one spoke for a while after that.

The fire snapped softly. Rain tapped against the roof. Somewhere beyond the field, an animal called once, then went quiet.

Alias looked at Future Alias. "Do you think we are walking the right way?"

Future Alias did not answer immediately.

"I think," he said, choosing each word, "that I spent a long time believing there was one correct road. One place I should have gone. One thing I should have done before everything became impossible."

He looked down at the little fire. "The coins do not feel like that. They do not promise an answer. They only stop feeling angry when we are not lying to ourselves about where we are going."

"Coins can feel angry?" Rowan asked.

"Not literally."

"That is less useful than I hoped."

Future Alias almost smiled. "They are calmer when I am not trying to force them."

Alias thought he understood.

A direction was not the same as a destination. They had learned that before leaving home. But maybe it was not nothing. Maybe knowing that a road was not wrong was enough to keep walking until the next choice came.

By the time the rain softened, Corvin had made them take turns sleeping. It was not really necessary. The road was empty, the field quiet, and no one expected danger from a broken cart shed.

Future Alias took the last watch without asking.

Alias woke once in the dark. The fire had become a small bed of red coals. Everyone else was still. Rowan snored softly through his hood. Corvin had somehow managed to sleep with one hand resting on his map case. Maris had the shared journal tucked against her chest. Eldric slept with his cloak folded neatly beneath his head.

Future Alias sat near the doorway.

He was awake, of course.

He was counting something beneath his breath.

At first, Alias thought it was the seconds between drops of rain. Then he saw Future Alias touch the edge of each pack with his eyes: one, two, three, four, five, six.

Then the water skins.

Then the shapes of the sleeping people.

Alias did not say anything. He closed his eyes again before Future Alias could notice he was awake.

In the morning, the rain was gone. The road shone dark beneath a pale, washed sky. They followed it northeast through fields that smelled clean and cold after the storm.

They passed an old milestone just after midday. Its carved letters had been worn almost smooth, but a small symbol remained visible beneath the moss: a lantern above a thin curved line.

Future Alias stopped so quickly that Alias nearly walked into him.

"What is it?"

Future Alias crouched beside the stone. He brushed moss away with the side of his thumb.

The lantern symbol appeared more clearly.

Maris came close, journal already open. "Do you know it?"

"I have seen it in the Tower," Future Alias said. "In some of the records."

Eldric studied the mark. "M?"

Future Alias nodded slowly. "Or someone who used the same route marks. M used a lantern beside paths that were safe enough to return from."

"Safe enough?" Rowan repeated.

"That was usually the closest thing to a promise."

Corvin looked north along the road. "Then Rellin matters."

No one argued.

They reached the town shortly before sunset.

Rellin sat where two old roads met. Its buildings leaned close together, as if they had spent years listening to travellers pass between them. The east gate was a tall stone arch patched with newer bricks. A small bronze bell hung above it, green with age.

When the wind moved, it gave one quiet, uneven note.

Future Alias stopped beneath it.

Alias saw his face change. Not with fear exactly. With recognition trying to become memory.

"The bell," he said.

Maris looked up at the arch. "You remembered."

"A piece of it."

Inside the gate, the town was preparing for evening. Lamps were being lit in shop windows. A man dragged shutters across a stall full of ribbons. Somewhere nearby, someone was playing a fiddle badly but with great confidence.

Rowan looked delighted. "This place has everything."

"It has one bell and a bad fiddle," Corvin said.

"Exactly."

The old routehouse stood at the end of a narrow street beside the east gate.

It was taller than the surrounding buildings, though not grand. Grey stone. Narrow windows. A roof darkened by years of rain. Above its heavy wooden door, almost hidden beneath a rusted iron sign, was the same lantern-and-road mark from the milestone.

The sign read:

RELLIN ROUTEHOUSE AND ARCHIVE.

A little lamp burned in the window of the office across the street. Its painted board, leaning beneath the glass, read VALE COLLECTION OFFICE in careful gold letters. Below that, smaller letters had been added:

ARCHIVE VISITS: BY APPOINTMENT ONLY.

As they watched, an older man came out of the office carrying a narrow box of papers under one arm. He saw them looking at the routehouse and stopped.

"Closed," he said, not unkindly. "You will need to ask inside tomorrow."

"Is that the office that keeps the records?" Maris asked.

"It manages them," the man said. "The owner manages the valuable things. That is what he calls it, anyway."

Corvin looked at the notice, then at the locked door. "And what does an appointment cost?"

The man gave a short laugh without much amusement. "Too much if all you want is a page. Four silver just to enter. Extra for copies. Extra for old route ledgers. Extra if Master Vale decides the file is troublesome."

"Files can be troublesome?" Rowan asked.

"Only when they are interesting."

Future Alias had not moved. His eyes were fixed on the door.

The man followed his gaze. "You know the place?"

"I think I did," Future Alias said quietly.

The man studied him for a moment, then seemed to decide not to ask. "Then you know it used to be open to travellers. That was before my time."

He walked away before anyone could answer, his papers held close beneath his coat.

For a little while, all six of them stood in the narrow street with the locked routehouse in front of them and the Vale office watching from across the road.

The routehouse door was locked tight.

It was not merely closed for the day. A thick new padlock held an old iron latch shut.

A notice had been pinned crookedly beside it.

RECORDS AVAILABLE BY APPOINTMENT.
ENQUIRIES TO THE VALE COLLECTION OFFICE.
FEES APPLY.

Rowan read it over Maris's shoulder. "Fees apply is a very unfriendly sentence."

Corvin's expression said he agreed.

Maris touched the edge of the notice without pulling it loose. "Vale Collection Office. Do we know it?"

Future Alias stared at the padlock.

"No," he said. "But I know this building."

Alias looked from the locked door to the lantern mark above it. The compass shifted against his chest. Beneath Future Alias's cloak, the coins made the faintest, almost eager sound.

North had brought them here.

East, it seemed, was waiting behind a locked door.

PART I

THE ROAD AFTER HOME

Chapter 4: Borrowed Without Asking

Some doors are locked because someone wants you to forget they exist.

When the group returned to the inn, Rowan announced that he had found the only room in Rellin with a chair that looked capable of beginning an argument.

The chair was brown, narrow, and old enough that one leg had been repaired with a strip of metal.

"It has a face," Rowan said, pointing at a knot in the wood.

"It has a knot," Corvin corrected.

"It is judging me."

"It is a chair."

"Exactly. It has seen things."

The innkeeper did not react. She had probably heard worse from travellers who had been wet for three days and hungry for four. She set six bowls of stew on the long table by the fire, added a basket of bread, and said, "No boots on the benches."

Rowan looked down at the bench.

The innkeeper looked at Rowan.

"I was not going to," he said.

"You were thinking about it loudly."

Then she left them alone.

For a while, the food gave them something simple to do. Rain ticked against the windows. The room smelled of onions, woodsmoke, and wet wool. A man near the hearth was losing a game of cards with the slow patience of someone who had been losing for years. Someone upstairs was dragging a trunk across the floor.

It was an ordinary inn.

Alias had missed ordinary places more than he had realised.

Across from him, Future Alias had not taken off his cloak. He sat with one hand near the inside pocket where he kept his journal and the other wrapped around a mug of tea. His eyes kept returning to the wet street beyond the window.

Corvin broke a piece of bread in half. "Four silver to enter a public archive."

"Eight," Maris said. "Four to enter. Three for the route ledger. One because Master Vale has decided old paper is apparently dangerous."

"He did not say dangerous," Eldric said.

"He said troublesome," Maris replied. "Which is worse. Dangerous things usually have the decency to admit it."

Rowan leaned over the table. "Maybe we could offer him a different payment."

"What?" Corvin asked.

Rowan thought for a moment. "A very convincing speech."

"No."

"A song?"

"No."

"A chair that judges people?"

"Especially no."

Alias looked at the shared journal between Maris and Eldric. Paper had been quiet since they arrived. Its blank pages lay open beside a small spill of candlelight. He wondered whether it was sleeping. Paper did not sleep, exactly. It merely became more annoying when ignored.

As though it had heard him think that, thin dark words appeared across the page.

PUBLIC RECORDS SHOULD NOT REQUIRE A SMALL FORTUNE.

Rowan nodded solemnly. "Finally. Someone sensible."

Corvin looked at the message. "Paper is agreeing with you. That should concern all of us."

Another line appeared beneath the first.

THIS IS NOT PERMISSION TO DO SOMETHING STUPID.

Rowan pointed at it. "It is staring directly at me."

"It often is," Maris said.

Future Alias had still not looked at the journal. "The routehouse was not always like that," he said.

The table grew quiet.

Alias watched him. "You went there before."

"I think so." Future Alias looked at the flame in the small lamp on their table instead of at any of them. "Not in the way you mean. I remember coming through Rellin. I remember the roadhouse being open. People left messages there. Warnings. Maps, sometimes. The sort of things travellers did not want to lose."

"And Vale?" Corvin asked.

"I do not remember him."

"Maybe he came after," Eldric said.

"Maybe."

Future Alias said it quietly, but Alias heard the word underneath it.

Or maybe I forgot.

They had all learned not to force every memory out of him when it appeared. Some came like frightened birds: visible for only a moment, then gone if anyone moved too quickly.

Maris opened the journal to a fresh page. "Tomorrow, we ask properly one more time. We find out exactly which record we need, who owns the routehouse, and whether Vale is allowed to charge that much."

Corvin nodded. "That is sensible."

Rowan looked disappointed. "We are doing sensible first?"

"We are doing sensible always," Corvin said.

"That has never happened once."

"It can begin tomorrow."

Eldric lifted his cup. "A brave dream."

Alias smiled despite himself. He reached for the bread basket at the same time as Future Alias. Their hands stopped, almost touching.

Future Alias pulled his back first.

Alias took the last piece and broke it in half. He offered one half across the table.

For a second, Future Alias only stared at it.

Then he accepted it.

"Thank you," he said.

It was a small thing. Just bread.

But Future Alias said it as if he was still learning how to receive something that had not been earned, traded for, or taken.

* * *

Morning in Rellin arrived grey and sharp.

The rain had stopped, but the sky remained low over the rooftops. Water ran down the gutters in thin silver lines. The cobbles shone. Shopkeepers lifted shutters one by one, and the town woke with the unwilling sound of people who had work to do.

The Vale Collection Office looked warmer from inside than it had the night before.

That did not make it friendly.

Shelves filled the walls from floor to ceiling. Some held books. Others held boxes, jars of sealing wax, rolled maps tied with string, and tiny labelled bundles of paper. A brass clock ticked loudly on the mantelpiece. Behind a wide desk sat Master Vale.

He was not old, exactly. His hair was dark except for silver at the temples, and his coat was cleaner than anyone else's in town. He had the sort of smile that looked polite until you noticed it never reached his eyes.

"Travellers," he said as they entered. "I was expecting you."

Rowan looked around. "You were?"

"No," Vale said. "But you were standing outside my office for a very long time last night."

"Ah," Rowan said. "That is fair."

Corvin stepped forward before Rowan could improve the conversation. "We are looking for an old route record. Possibly associated with the lantern-and-road mark on the routehouse."

"Many records are associated with that building."

"A specific one," Maris said. She set the shared journal on the desk but did not open it. "We have reason to believe it concerns a continuing route."

Vale's eyes flicked toward the journal, then to the six of them. "A continuing route."

The way he repeated it made Alias's shoulders tighten.

"Do you have it?" Eldric asked.

"I have many things," Vale said. "That is rather why people visit."

"Can we see the list?" Corvin asked.

"For a consultation fee."

Rowan made a small choking noise.

Vale ignored him. "The routehouse archives are delicate. Maintaining them costs money. Organising old documents costs money. Keeping careless travellers from scattering centuries of records across the floor costs money."

"Were they scattered before?" Alias asked.

"Not yet today."

Future Alias stood by the door. He had gone very still.

Vale noticed him then.

It was only a glance. A quick, curious pause.

"Have we met?" Vale asked.

Future Alias's face did not change, but Alias saw his fingers curl once at his side.

"No," Future Alias said.

Vale held his gaze for another breath. "No. Of course not. I remember faces well."

Alias did not believe that either.

Maris spoke before the silence could grow. "What would it cost to see the record?"

"That depends on the record." Vale took a small notebook from his desk and opened it. "If it is one of the old open-route ledgers, four silver to enter the archive and three silver to inspect the book. Copies are extra. If the material is restricted, the fee rises."

"And if it is a record that used to be available to travellers?" Eldric asked.

Vale smiled again. "Everything used to be available to someone."

Corvin's expression turned flat.

"We have enough for food and rooms," he said. "Not for seven silver to look at a page."

"Then perhaps you will enjoy the town," Vale replied. "It has a lovely bell."

Rowan straightened. "It is a very good bell."

Corvin closed his eyes for a moment.

Vale turned back to his notebook. "If you leave your names, I can arrange an appointment in several days."

"The road may not wait several days," Maris said.

"Then that sounds like a problem the road should have considered."

No one answered immediately.

Alias felt the small, angry pressure of the compass against his chest. It was not moving. It was only there, heavy and sure.

Future Alias finally spoke.

"Could we at least know the name of the ledger?"

Vale looked up. "Why?"

"So we know whether we are waiting for the right thing."

For the first time, Vale seemed almost amused. "The North-Eastern Traveller Register. One of the older books. Routes, weather notes, shelter records, that sort of thing. It has been incomplete for decades, so I would not expect miracles."

The name changed Future Alias's face.

Only slightly.

But Alias saw it.

"The one with the blue binding," Future Alias said.

Vale's smile disappeared.

"You have been here," he said.

Future Alias did not answer.

The brass clock ticked once. Twice.

Then Eldric placed one calm hand on the edge of the desk. "We will return if we need to.

Thank you for your time."

Vale looked from Eldric to Future Alias, then back to the notebook. "Of course."

They left without the ledger.

The door shut behind them with a neat little bell sound.

Rowan waited until they were halfway down the street. "I dislike him."

"That was very clear," Corvin said.

"He charges people to breathe his office air."

"He did not charge us for that."

"Only because we left quickly."

Maris looked at Future Alias. "Blue binding?"

Future Alias nodded. "I remember it on a shelf behind the desk in the routehouse. The pages were thin. There was a stain on the corner from tea."

"You remember all that?" Alias asked.

"I remember pieces."

"Then maybe the pieces are enough," Eldric said.

Future Alias looked toward the routehouse. "Maybe."

But he said it in the same way he had said it the night before.

Like maybe was a door he did not trust himself to open.

* * *

The group spent the rest of the morning doing sensible things.

This was Corvin's description.

Rowan's description was that they spent the morning "walking around until a better plan found them."

They asked the baker whether the routehouse had always been private. They asked the woman who ran the ribbon stall whether anyone remembered the town council owning it. They asked a man repairing a window frame whether Master Vale had bought the building.

No one had the complete answer.

But by midday, Maris had filled three pages with pieces.

The routehouse had once been open to anyone travelling the old roads.

The town council still owned the building, technically.

Master Vale had been hired years ago to protect the records after a leak damaged part of the roof.

Then he had begun "organising" them.

Then he had begun charging fees.

Then the town had grown used to it.

"He is not the owner," Maris said, standing beneath the awning outside a closed cloth shop.

"He is just the keeper."

"He has the keys," Corvin said.

"He has the keys because no one stopped him," Rowan replied.

"That is still having the keys."

Eldric folded his hands over the top of his walking stick. "The question is not whether Vale is behaving fairly. The question is what we will do about it without becoming exactly the sort of travellers he expects."

Alias watched a drop of water slide from the awning above them and land on the street.

No one said anything for a moment.

Then Future Alias said, "There is a window at the back of the routehouse."

Everyone looked at him.

Future Alias stared at the street.

"It used to stick in wet weather," he added.

Corvin blinked. "How do you know that?"

Future Alias looked up at last. "I was here."

"You said you remembered pieces," Alias said.

"I do."

"Those are very specific pieces," Maris said.

Future Alias's mouth tightened. "I used to notice doors."

Rowan gave him a cheerful grin. "That is useful. I notice snacks."

"That is also specific," Eldric said.

Alias said nothing.

But later, after they returned to the inn and the others went upstairs to dry their cloaks and sort their packs, he found himself standing alone in the stable yard behind the building.

The rain had started again, light this time. It softened the sound of the town. A horse shifted in one of the stalls. Somewhere beyond the rooftops, the bell rang noon, slow and round.

Alias should have gone upstairs.

Instead, he walked toward the narrow lane behind the inn.

He told himself he only wanted to look.

Looking was not stealing.

Looking was not even a plan.

The lane curved behind the routhouse. Its back wall was covered in rain-dark stone. A small upper window sat above a lean-to roof. The glass was old and uneven. One shutter hung crookedly open.

It looked exactly like the sort of window someone would not notice unless they were looking for it.

Alias stopped beneath it.

"You lean too far to the right when you are pretending you do not have an idea."

He spun around.

Future Alias stood at the end of the lane, hood down, rain catching in his dark hair.

Alias tried to look normal.

"I am looking at a wall."

"Yes."

"That is all."

Future Alias glanced at the upper window. "A very interesting wall."

Alias folded his arms. "You followed me."

"I noticed you leave."

"That is different."

"Not really."

For a while, neither of them moved.

The lane was too narrow to feel comfortable. Too quiet. Alias could hear water slipping from the roof tiles and the faint noise of people talking somewhere beyond the wall.

Future Alias looked at the window again.

"It was easier before," he said.

"Before what?"

"Before I knew everyone would be worried if I disappeared."

Alias looked at him.

Future Alias gave a small, humourless smile. "That was supposed to sound less sad."

"It did not."

"I know."

Alias turned back toward the routehouse. "We should not do anything stupid."

"No."

"But Vale is keeping a traveller record locked away because he can."

"Yes."

"And the town says it is not even his."

"Yes."

"And we only need to read it."

Future Alias was silent.

Alias glanced sideways. "You are not telling me no."

"I am trying to."

"You are doing badly."

"I know."

A little of the tension left Alias's shoulders. "You have done this before."

Future Alias's face went still again.

"Borrowed something without asking?" Alias added.

Future Alias looked at him for a long moment.

Then, very quietly, he said, "Yes."

It was not pride. It was not even really an answer.

It was a fact he had been carrying for a long time.

Alias nodded once. "Me too."

Future Alias blinked.

"You?"

Alias looked away. "Not important things."

"That does not answer the question."

"I did not say it did."

A sound came from the other side of the routehouse wall. A door opening. A man's voice.

Then quiet again.

Future Alias stepped closer to the stone wall, listening.

"The office door," he said. "Vale is locking up for his meal."

Alias stared at him. "You can tell that from here?"

Future Alias's expression changed by the smallest amount.

He had said too much.

"I remember the sound," he replied.

The answer was not enough.

But Alias knew that feeling: wanting to ask, and knowing the other person would only close up if you pushed too hard.

So he did not ask.

Instead, he said, "We read it. We copy what we need. Then we put it back."

Future Alias looked up at the window.

"We do not take anything else," Alias continued.

"No."

"We do not break anything."

"No."

"We do not let Rowan know until after."

That earned the first real smile Future Alias had shown all day.

"No," he said. "We definitely do not let Rowan know until after."

* * *

The archive did not feel like a place that wanted strangers.

It smelled of damp paper, old ink, and stone that had spent too many winters holding cold. The narrow rooms behind the routehouse were darker than the office, their shelves crowded with boxes and books. Thin strips of afternoon light fell through the dusty windows.

Alias stood still just inside, listening.

His heart was beating too quickly.

Not because he was afraid of the room.

Because he was afraid of being good at this.

Future Alias was beside him, almost silent.

"You know where it is?" Alias whispered.

"Second room. Back shelf. Blue binding."

"From memory?"

"From pieces."

They moved deeper into the archive.

Alias did not know who started it, but they fell into the same rhythm without speaking. One watched the hall while the other checked the shelves. One paused when the floorboards creaked; the other paused too. It was not planned. It was simply easy.

That was the part that made Alias uncomfortable.

It should not have been easy.

But it was.

The second room held old ledgers behind a wire-fronted cabinet. A small lock hung from the latch. The blue book sat on the middle shelf, its spine cracked, its cover faded by time.

Future Alias exhaled slowly.

"There," he said.

Alias looked at the lock.

Future Alias looked at Alias looking at the lock.

"You have something?" he asked.

Alias raised an eyebrow. "You have something?"

For one second, Future Alias seemed offended.

Then he reached into his sleeve and produced a slim little tool wrapped in cloth.

Alias stared.

Future Alias stared back.

"What?" he whispered.

"You have that with you?"

"It is useful."

"You brought it on a journey to find out how to go home."

"I brought it on a journey with Rowan."

That was difficult to argue with.

Alias watched the cabinet while Future Alias worked carefully, quietly, and with the calm focus of someone doing a task he had done too many times to count. No loud clicks. No dramatic movements. Just patience.

A moment later, the latch lifted.

Alias looked at him.

Future Alias folded the cloth back around the tool. "What?"

"That was fast."

"You were counting the hallway steps," Future Alias replied. "That was fast too."

Alias did not have an answer.

The blue ledger was heavier than it looked. When Future Alias lifted it free, a faint line of cleaner dust marked the shelf beneath it.

They carried it to a small reading table near the window.

The title on the cover had almost vanished, but they could still make out the words:

NORTH-EASTERN TRAVELLER REGISTER.

Future Alias touched the cover with two fingers.

"I remember this," he said.

This time, he sounded certain.

Alias opened the book.

Most of the pages were lists. Supply notes. Storm warnings. Names of travellers who had passed through one shelter or another. Some had left short messages in the margins.

Do not sleep beneath the western bridge in spring. The river rises faster than it looks.

Good water at Halden's farm, if you help with the fence first.

A red-haired woman in Bellcross cheats at dice. Do not let her deal.

Rowan would have liked that one.

Then, almost halfway through the ledger, Alias found a page where the handwriting changed.

The ink was darker. More careful.

At the top was the lantern-and-road mark.

Future Alias leaned close.

Below it, someone had written:

For travellers carrying questions they cannot yet name:

Do not mistake a delayed road for a broken one.

North will bring you to rain. East will bring you to snow.

When the weather asks you to stop, stop.

Do not enter the old shelter alone.

And do not give one person the weight meant for six.

There was no signature.

Only a single letter beneath the final line.

M.

Alias read it twice.

Future Alias's hand had gone still on the table.

"East will bring you to snow," Alias said softly.

"It knew," Future Alias replied.

"Who knew?"

Future Alias looked at the mark at the top of the page.

"I do not know."

But he did not sound like someone who knew nothing.

A floorboard creaked in the hallway.

Both of them froze.

A shadow crossed the crack beneath the door.

Vale's voice came from somewhere nearby, speaking to someone in the office. "No, leave the invoices there. I will deal with them after supper."

The shadow moved away.

Alias felt his breath return all at once.

Future Alias closed the book carefully.

"We need to copy it," Alias whispered.

"We do not have time."

"We need the exact words."

Future Alias looked at the page, then at Alias.

"I can remember it."

"Can you?"

Future Alias did not answer immediately.

Then he nodded.

"Yes."

They put the ledger back where it had been. Future Alias locked the cabinet again. Alias watched the hall. The whole thing took only a few minutes.

When they reached the back window, Alias looked at Future Alias.

"Are you ready?"

Future Alias nodded.

They slipped out into the rain.

They nearly made it to the lane before someone said, "I would like to know why both of you are wet in places where the rain did not reach."

Alias stopped.

Future Alias stopped.

Maris stood at the end of the lane beneath a borrowed umbrella. Corvin was beside her, arms crossed. Rowan leaned out from behind them with the delighted expression of someone who had just discovered that sensible plans had failed.

Eldric stood a little apart, holding two cups of tea.

He looked more disappointed in the rain than in them.

"You followed us," Alias said.

Maris looked at him. "You both vanished within three minutes of each other."

"Not vanished," Future Alias said.

Corvin lifted one eyebrow. "No?"

"We were nearby," Alias said.

"Behind the locked routehouse," Maris replied.

Rowan's mouth fell open. "You went inside?"

Alias said nothing.

Future Alias said nothing.

Maris looked between them.

Then she looked at the streak of archive dust on Alias's sleeve, the rain on Future Alias's boots, and the small cloth-wrapped tool that Future Alias had not quite managed to hide before they escaped.

"Wait," she said.

Her eyes widened.

"Both of you are thieves?"

"Resourceful," Alias said.

"Resourceful," Future Alias said at exactly the same time.

There was a short silence.

Then Rowan made a sound somewhere between a laugh and a shout.

"I knew it!"

"You did not," Corvin said.

"I absolutely did."

"You accused a goat of stealing your scarf last week."

"It had a suspicious face."

Maris was still staring at the two Aliases. "You both said the same word."

"Unfortunate timing," Alias muttered.

"Very unfortunate," Future Alias agreed.

Corvin looked at Future Alias. "You stole my spoon."

Future Alias blinked. "What?"

"The small travel spoon. It went missing on the second night out of Nettlebridge."

Future Alias looked genuinely confused for a moment.

Then he looked down.

Slowly, he reached into the inside pocket of his cloak.

Along with his journal, a length of red thread, and the cloth-wrapped tool, he pulled out a small metal spoon.

It had Corvin's initials scratched into the handle.

No one spoke.

Future Alias looked at it.

Then at Corvin.

"You were not using it," he said.

Rowan doubled over laughing.

Corvin closed his eyes.

Maris put one hand over her mouth, but Alias could see she was trying not to smile.

Even Eldric's expression softened.

"That," Corvin said after a moment, "is not how spoons work."

Future Alias held it out to him. "You can have it back."

"I am glad."

Alias could not stop laughing now. It came out before he could catch it, sharp and surprised. Future Alias looked at him, then started laughing too, though he seemed less certain why.

For one minute, standing in a wet alley behind a locked archive, they were not future selves and present selves and people with too many questions.

They were just six travellers, one stolen spoon, and a very bad plan that had happened to work.

Then Eldric held out one of the tea cups.

"Before anyone explains how they entered a locked public building," he said, "I would like to hear whether the risk achieved anything useful."

Alias's laughter faded.

He looked at Future Alias.

Future Alias looked at the others.

Then he repeated the words from the ledger exactly.

He did not miss one.

When he finished, no one laughed.

East will bring you to snow.

When the weather asks you to stop, stop.

Do not enter the old shelter alone.

And do not give one person the weight meant for six.

Maris opened the shared journal beneath the umbrella and wrote every word down.

Corvin looked toward the routehouse, then to the road beyond the town.

"So," he said. "We go east."

"We return the book first," Eldric said.

Future Alias nodded immediately. "It is already back."

Eldric looked at him for a moment.

“Good.”

Rowan accepted the second cup of tea and took a careful sip. “So the official plan is that we are following a mysterious message toward snow?”

“The official plan,” Corvin said, “is that no one borrows anything else without asking.”

Alias glanced at Future Alias.

Future Alias glanced back.

Neither of them said a word.

That, more than anything, made Maris sigh.

Above them, the rain began to ease.

By evening, the road east would still be there.

And now, at least, they knew where it was asking them to go.

PART I

THE ROAD AFTER HOME

Chapter 5: The Sound Beyond Camp

Some secrets are loudest when no one is listening.

The cold began quietly.

It waited until Rellin was a low grey shape behind them and the eastern road had narrowed between bare fields. Then it climbed into the wind and found every gap in their cloaks.

"This is not snow," Rowan said, walking backward for three steps so he could look at the sky.

"This is weather practising to become snow."

"Walk forward," Corvin said.

"I am observing."

"You are about to walk into a ditch."

Rowan turned around just in time. The ditch passed beside him with the patient disappointment of something that had almost been useful.

Maris pulled the shared journal closer beneath her cloak. "For the record, the east is colder than the north."

"A brave discovery," Rowan said.

"Write it down anyway," Corvin replied.

They had left Rellin after breakfast, with their packs tied properly and the borrowed ledger safely back behind the routehouse door. The road that led east did not look special. It ran between fields gone brown for the year, then climbed slowly toward a dark line of trees. A few old boundary stones leaned beside it, their painted marks faded by rain and time.

But the coins in Future Alias's pocket had stopped pulling in every direction.

That was enough to make all of them watch the road more carefully.

Future Alias walked near the front beside Eldric. He had said very little since the alley behind the archive. His grey cloak moved in the wind. Once in a while, his hand went to the pocket holding the coins, as if he needed to make sure they were still there.

Alias noticed something else too.

Every time they passed a side path, Future Alias looked down it.

Every time the wind changed, he lifted his head a little.

Every time a bird moved in the distant trees, his attention snapped toward the sound and did not leave until the bird had flown away.

Alias had seen that look before. It was the look Future Alias wore when he was trying to be ready for everything at once.

At midday, they stopped beneath a crooked stone marker where the road split around a shallow stream. Corvin unpacked bread, cheese, and dried apples. Rowan unpacked two extra apples from a place nobody had seen him put them.

"You said we had enough food for four days," Maris said.

"We do," Rowan said. "I simply also have emergency apples."

"Where did they come from?"

"An emergency."

Corvin looked at the apples. "Are those from the inn?"

"They were left near a window."

"That is still a place."

"Then I borrowed them from the place."

Future Alias looked at Rowan's hands. "You should return them."

Rowan stared at him. "You took Corvin's spoon."

"That was different."

"How?"

Future Alias considered this.

"The spoon was smaller," he said.

Eldric made a sound into his tea that might have been a laugh.

For a while, the group ate in the thin sunlight. The stream ran over black stones. Somewhere beyond the nearest field, a dog barked twice and fell quiet. It was not a bad place to stop. It was not a dangerous place. It was only a road with cold water beside it and a day that had not decided whether it wanted to rain.

Still, Future Alias did not relax.

His eyes kept moving over the tree line.

Alias nudged one of the dried apples toward him. "You have not eaten much."

"I ate this morning."

"That is not an answer."

Future Alias looked at the apple as if it had personally offended him. Then he took it.

"Thank you," he said.

It was such a careful answer that Alias wished he had not made it sound like an order.

After lunch, the road climbed. By late afternoon, the fields had disappeared behind them. Pine trees closed around the road in uneven rows, their dark branches holding the last wetness from yesterday's rain. The ground was softer there. Needles covered the path. Their steps became quieter.

The compass pointed ahead.

At one point it turned sharply toward a narrow trail that entered the trees.

Corvin stopped. "That is not a road."

"It is a direction," Maris said.

"It is a bad direction."

The trail led only a short distance before ending at the remains of an old hunter's shelter. The roof had partly fallen in. Moss grew between the boards. One wall leaned outward so far that it looked as though the building had grown tired of standing.

Future Alias stopped so suddenly that Alias almost walked into him.

The coins in his pocket made no sound.

The compass needle trembled once, then returned to the road.

"We should not camp there," Future Alias said.

Nobody had suggested it yet.

Corvin looked from the shelter to Future Alias. "I was not planning to."

"Good."

The answer came too quickly.

Eldric watched Future Alias for a moment, then looked at the broken shelter again. "The message said not to enter an old shelter alone."

"It did," Maris said.

"We are six," Rowan said. "Very difficult to be alone when there are this many of us."

Future Alias did not smile.

"We keep walking," he said.

So they did.

No one argued. Not because the shelter was frightening, exactly. It was only broken wood and dark windows. But the cold around it felt sharper than the rest of the road, and Alias was glad when the trees hid it behind them.

They made camp before sunset in a small clearing where a ring of old stones showed that travellers had stopped there before. Corvin checked the ground for roots. Eldric gathered dry branches from beneath the lower pines. Maris wrote down the warning from the ledger again, adding a small note beneath it: Old shelter passed. Did not enter.

Rowan announced that he was in charge of firewood, then brought back three damp sticks, a feather, and something that might once have been part of a boot.

"This is not firewood," Corvin said.

"It has the spirit of firewood."

"It has the spirit of rubbish."

"That is still a spirit."

Alias helped Eldric arrange the better branches. Soon a small fire took hold, first uncertain, then steady. The light made the trees look farther away. Steam rose from the pot hanging over the flames. The smell of soup slowly replaced the smell of wet earth.

Future Alias sat just beyond the strongest part of the firelight.

He was close enough to be with them. Far enough that the shadows touched his boots.

Alias looked at him once, then twice.

On the third time, Future Alias noticed.

"What?" he asked.

"Nothing."

"You are looking at me like there is something."

"You are sitting too far away."

Future Alias glanced at the space between himself and the fire. "I can hear you from here."

"That was not the problem."

Rowan lifted the soup pot carefully. "Maybe he likes the dramatic lighting."

"I do not," Future Alias said.

"That is exactly what someone who likes dramatic lighting would say."

Maris accepted a bowl from Rowan. "The fire is too warm for him. That is all."

Future Alias looked at her. She had said it simply, without asking him to defend it.

"Maybe," he said.

Alias did not think that was all. But he let the conversation go.

Dinner was quiet in the comfortable way that came after a long day. Corvin complained about the soup being too thin, even though he ate two bowls. Rowan complained that the soup had too many vegetables, even though he had put some of them in himself. Eldric listened to both complaints with the calm expression of someone who had accepted that travel meals would never satisfy everyone.

Maris asked Future Alias whether the coins had changed.

He took them out and laid them on his palm.

They were dull in the firelight. Six old coins, each marked differently, each heavier-looking than a thing that small had any right to be.

"They are quieter," he said.

"That is good?" Alias asked.

"I think so."

"You think?" Rowan said.

Future Alias closed his fingers around them. "They do not explain themselves."

"Rude coins," Rowan said.

"Very," Maris agreed.

For a moment, Future Alias looked almost amused. Then the wind moved through the trees,
low and long.

His expression changed.

Not into fear.

Into attention.

Alias saw his shoulders tighten. Saw his eyes go toward the dark forest beyond the fire. Saw
the hand with the coins close harder.

Then the wind passed.

Future Alias set the coins away.

Later, when the bowls had been cleaned and the fire had lowered, they divided the watches.
Corvin took first watch. Eldric took second. Future Alias said he would take the last before dawn.

"You took last watch yesterday," Corvin said.

"I am awake early anyway."

"That does not mean you should always take it."

Future Alias looked at the sleeping rolls being spread around the fire. "I do not mind."

Eldric's eyes rested on him for a quiet second.

"All right," he said. "But wake someone if you need to."

Future Alias nodded.

Alias lay down with his cloak folded beneath his head. The fire was low enough that it no
longer hurt his eyes. Around him, the others settled into sleep one by one. Rowan muttered
something about apples. Corvin told him, while already half asleep, to stop talking about apples.
Maris turned one page in the journal, then another, before closing it carefully beside her pack.

Future Alias sat awake at the edge of the clearing.

He was only a dark shape beyond the fire.

Alias watched him until his own eyes became too heavy to stay open.

Then sleep found him.

It was not kind.

In the dream, he was running down a road that had no end.

The sky was white. The ground was black. Trees leaned over him from both sides, but their
branches were made of hands, and every hand pointed in a different direction.

Go back, one hand said.

Go forward, said another.

Do not stop, said a third.

Alias tried to answer, but his voice would not come out.

Far away, something called to him.

It was not a word. It was not even a proper sound at first. It was low and thin and stretched across the distance, like a note carried through a storm.

Then it became clearer.

A howl.

Alias woke with his hand pressed over his mouth.

The fire was nearly out.

For a few seconds, he could not tell where he was. The dream still clung to him. The trees were only trees now, black shapes against a sky scattered with weak stars. The ground was cold through his blanket. Corvin was asleep on the other side of the fire, breathing slowly. Maris had curled close to her pack. Rowan had somehow lost half his blanket and was using a folded coat instead.

Everything was normal.

Except Future Alias was gone.

Alias sat up.

He listened.

At first there was only the night. A small insect clicking somewhere near the stones. Water moving far off. Wind caught high in the branches.

Then there it was again.

Not a howl this time.

A low sound, almost too quiet to be real.

It came from far beyond the clearing.

Too far for anyone to hear, Alias thought.

But he could hear it.

He did not know why.

The sound pulled at something under his ribs. Not like the compass. Not like the coins. More like recognition. Like hearing a song you had never learned and somehow knowing the next note.

Alias stood carefully.

He left his blanket where it was. He did not wake the others. He only took his cloak and the small knife from beside his pack, then stepped between the trees.

The forest swallowed the campfire behind him.

At first, he followed the path Future Alias had made without needing to search for it. A bent fern. A scuff in the needles. A branch pushed aside and not quite returned. The trail was quiet, but it was there.

Future Alias had walked this way before.

That thought made Alias slow down.

Not once, then.

Not only tonight.

The farther he went, the colder the night became. The ground rose beneath the trees. Pale moonlight slipped through gaps in the branches. Somewhere ahead, the low sound came again.

Alias stopped behind a wide pine trunk.

A grey wolf stood in the clearing beyond it.

For one breath, Alias did not understand what he was seeing.

The wolf was larger than any animal he had expected to find so close to the road. Its coat was dark grey along the back and silver near its throat. Moonlight touched the fur on its shoulders. Its head was lowered, nose close to the ground, but not hunting exactly. It moved in a restless circle around the clearing, stopping to scent the air, then moving again.

There was no rabbit. No deer. No prey at all.

Only the wolf.

Only the night.

Alias held still.

The wolf froze.

Its ears lifted.

It turned its head toward the tree.

Its eyes caught the moonlight.

Alias knew those eyes.

He stepped out from behind the trunk.

The wolf backed away at once.

"Future Alias," Alias said quietly.

The wolf's ears went flat.

For a moment, it looked ready to run.

Alias raised both hands. "I am not going to hurt you."

The wolf gave a short, unhappy sound in its throat.

"You left camp."

Another sound. Softer this time.

"You have done this before."

The wolf looked away.

That was answer enough.

Alias took one step closer. "You should not be out here alone."

The wolf's head snapped back toward him. Its eyes narrowed.

Alias felt the words land badly.

Not angry, exactly.

Wounded.

He swallowed.

"I mean," he said, "you should not have to be out here alone."

The wolf stood very still.

Then it turned away from him and moved to the far side of the clearing, where a small pile of folded clothes rested beneath a low branch. Grey cloak. Boots. Journal.

Alias looked away before the change began.

He heard fur shift against leaves. A sharp breath. The soft sound of a person sitting down too quickly.

"You can look now," Future Alias said.

His voice was rough.

Alias turned.

Future Alias sat with his back against the tree, wrapped in his cloak. His hair was damp with cold. He looked exhausted in a way Alias had only seen when someone had been awake for too long and pretending it did not matter.

Alias did not sit right beside him. He chose a patch of ground a few steps away.

For a while, neither of them spoke.

The forest did not care about their silence. Wind moved through the pines. A distant bird called once, then once again.

Future Alias pulled one knee closer to his chest.

"You should go back," he said.

"No."

"Alias."

"You should have woken someone."

Future Alias stared at the ground.

"I did not want to wake anyone."

"That is not the same thing."

"It is at night. People are asleep."

"That is still not the same thing."

Future Alias let out a tired breath through his nose. "You are difficult."

"You said that in the archive alley."

"You were difficult there too."

"I learned from you."

For the smallest moment, Future Alias almost smiled.

Then it disappeared.

Alias looked at the clearing. The tracks around them were everywhere now: deep marks in the needles, circles and sudden turns, long lines where paws had pushed off hard. This was not a peaceful place for Future Alias.

It was a place where he had been trying to wear something out.

"Why do you do it?" Alias asked.

Future Alias did not answer immediately.

"Because it is easier," he said at last.

"Easier than what?"

"Than being human sometimes."

Alias waited.

Future Alias rubbed one hand over his face. "In wolf form, things are simple. Not good. Not always safe. Simple." He looked toward the trees. "There are smells. Movement. Hunger. Cold. A trail. Something far away that matters or does not matter. I do not have to make every thought into words before it hurts."

Alias listened without moving.

"When I stay around people too long," Future Alias continued, "I notice everything. Someone shifting in a chair. A change in their voice. The way they look at me when they think I am not watching. The food. Smoke. Fear. A door closing two rooms away." His mouth tightened. "It builds. The noise builds. The instincts build with it."

"So you run."

"Sometimes I hunt. Sometimes I only run until I can hear myself think again." He looked down at his hands. "Sometimes I circle the same place for an hour because I cannot decide whether going back is worse than staying away."

The words were quiet. The truth inside them was not.

Alias remembered Future Alias at the fire, sitting just outside the warmest light. He remembered him watching every exit, every side road, every moving branch.

"Does it hurt?" Alias asked.

Future Alias looked surprised by the question.

"Not like a wound," he said. "It takes energy. More than people think. Changing is easier than changing back. Running is easier than stopping. And when I am angry, or afraid, or too tired..." He paused. "The wolf does not make those things disappear. It only makes them louder in a different way."

"Could you get stuck?"

Future Alias did not answer.

Alias felt cold move through him that had nothing to do with the night.

"Could you?" he asked again.

"Not forever," Future Alias said. "But long enough to make a bad decision. Long enough to forget that people are waiting."

His voice had become very small.

"That happened before?"

Future Alias looked up at the stars through the branches.

"Yes."

Alias wanted to ask when. He wanted to ask how long. He wanted to ask whether that was why Future Alias had watched everyone laugh at breakfast like he was trying to save the moment somewhere inside himself.

Instead, he said, "You do not have to tell me all of it tonight."

Future Alias looked at him then.

There was something almost careful in his expression. As if he had expected Alias to pull harder at the answer.

"You should tell the others," Alias said.

The careful look closed.

"No."

"They would understand."

"They might."

"They would."

"You do not know that."

Alias thought of Rowan giving people space when they needed it, even if he complained while doing it. Maris writing down what mattered and never forcing a page open. Corvin pretending not to care while checking everyone's packs twice. Eldric offering tea when there were no useful words left.

"I know them," Alias said.

Future Alias looked away.

"They will look at me differently," he said.

"Maybe at first."

"Exactly."

"Different does not always mean worse."

Future Alias said nothing.

Alias did not know how to make that truth easier. He did not know how to explain that people could be afraid and still stay. That they could need time and still choose someone. He only knew that he had seen the group do it before.

"I will not tell them," he said finally.

Future Alias's head turned quickly.

"Not yet," Alias added. "It is your secret. You should be the one to tell it."

The silence that followed was different.

Not solved.

But less sharp.

"Thank you," Future Alias said.

"But you cannot do this again without telling me."

Future Alias frowned. "Alias-"

"No. Listen." Alias leaned forward, elbows on his knees. "You do not get to disappear in the night and call it fine because everyone is asleep. You do not get to make one person carry all your secrets either." He thought of the message in the stolen ledger. The weight meant for six. "Tell me before you leave. If it gets worse, we tell the others together."

Future Alias watched him for a long time.

"You will not like what I might say," he said.

"Probably not."

"You might be scared."

"I am already scared."

That seemed to stop him.

Alias looked down at the tracks in the clearing.

"I am not scared of you," he said. "I am scared that you think you have to do everything like this. Alone."

Future Alias's face changed.

Not much.

But enough.

He pressed his lips together and looked away again. This time, though, he did not tell Alias to go back to camp.

After a while, he said, "All right."

"All right what?"

"I will tell you before I leave."

"And?"

Future Alias sighed.

"And if I cannot come back, or if I think I might lose control, you wake the others."

Alias nodded. "Good."

"Do not look pleased."

"I am pleased."

"That is annoying."

"You taught me that too."

This time, Future Alias did smile.

It was tired. It was small.

But it stayed.

They returned to camp together.

Future Alias walked with his cloak pulled close around him, carrying his journal under one arm. Alias did not ask whether he wanted to be seen. He did not try to make him walk closer to the fire. He only kept beside him as the trees opened and the faint orange light of the coals appeared ahead.

No one had woken.

Corvin still slept with one hand on the edge of his pack. Maris's journal lay safely beneath her cloak. Rowan had found his blanket again somehow and was wrapped in it so tightly that only his hair showed.

Future Alias paused at the edge of the clearing.

"You should sleep," Alias whispered.

"I have last watch."

"You have been running in the woods."

"I am still awake."

"That is not the same as being able to watch."

Future Alias gave him a look.

Alias held it.

After a moment, Future Alias looked toward Eldric's sleeping roll.

Then toward the fire.

"Wake Eldric in an hour," he said.

Alias blinked.

"You are actually doing it?"

"I said I would tell you. I did not say I would enjoy you being right."

Alias smiled despite himself. "That is fair."

Future Alias settled near the coals, closer than he had sat earlier. Not close enough to be warm. Close enough not to be outside the circle.

Alias lay down again.

This time, when the wind moved through the trees, he still heard it.

But it did not sound like a warning.

It sounded like the forest breathing around a camp where, for tonight at least, no one had vanished alone.

PART II
TURN OF THE YEAR

Chapter 6: A Town in Snow

Sometimes the road closes so that people can learn how to stay.

By morning, the world had forgotten its edges.

Snow came down in slow, determined sheets. It covered the road, the roots beside it, the dark needles beneath the pines, and the clearing where they had slept. The fire had gone out hours earlier. Their camp looked less like a place people had made and more like six uneven mounds of blankets and bad decisions.

Rowan was the first one to complain.

"I cannot feel my nose," he announced from inside his cloak.

"That is because you are lying on it," Corvin said.

There was a pause.

Then Rowan shifted beneath the blanket. "I can feel it a little now. This is worse."
Maris pushed snow from the entrance of her shelter with the side of her boot. "The road will be hard to follow."

"The road was hard to follow yesterday," Corvin said. "Now it has been hidden under weather."

Eldric crouched near the ashes and looked up through the white trees. Snow caught in his silver hair and did not melt. "We need warmth, a roof, and a place that serves something with more effort than our soup."

"The soup had effort," Rowan said.

"The soup had vegetables," Corvin corrected.

Alias pulled his cloak around his shoulders and looked toward the edge of the clearing.

Future Alias was already awake.

He stood beneath the trees with his hood down, one hand resting against the trunk of a pine. Snow had gathered on his dark hair and shoulders. He looked tired in the way people did after a night with too little sleep, but there was something else there too. He was listening.

Alias knew why.

The night before, beyond the firelight and the sleeping camp, he had found out what Future Alias had been carrying alone. He had promised not to tell the others. Not yet. It was not a secret that belonged only to him.

But it changed how Alias saw him.

Every distant sound had a direction now. Every gust of wind made Future Alias lift his head. Even in the snow, even while he was exhausted, he was still trying to notice everything before it could surprise them.

Alias walked over, boots sinking deep into the fresh snow.

"You should have woken someone," he said quietly.

Future Alias looked at him. His eyes were pale in the morning light.

"For what?"

"For watch. For anything."

"Nothing happened."

"That is not the point."

For a moment, Future Alias almost smiled. It was small and tired.

"You sound like Eldric."

"Good. Someone has to."

"There are already too many people trying to be sensible in this group."

"That is not true. Corvin is only one person."

A faint sound escaped Future Alias then. Not quite a laugh, but close enough that Alias kept the moment safe in his mind.

Behind them, Corvin began tying the packs more tightly. "We are moving in ten minutes. If the snow gets deeper, we will be moving in a straight line until we find a village, a barn, or a wall that looks like it belongs to a building."

"Very specific plan," Rowan said.

"You are welcome to suggest a less specific one."

"I suggest a warm town with bread."

"Excellent," Corvin said. "We will follow the bread."

The compass had stopped pretending it knew more than the weather. Its needle pointed east, then shook, then pointed east again. The coins in Future Alias's pocket stayed quiet.

They packed with cold fingers and damp sleeves. The firewood was too wet to save. Maris wrapped the shared journal inside two layers of cloth. Eldric checked that everyone had enough food for a day, then looked at the grey sky and quietly doubled the amount he placed in the side pockets.

When they finally left the clearing, the road had disappeared beneath a smooth white slope.

For a while, they could only follow the shape of the trees.

The snow reached Rowan's ankles first. Then his shins. Then, after he stepped into a hidden hollow and vanished almost to his knees, he announced that the road had become personally unfriendly.

"It is not personal," Maris said, taking his offered hand and helping him out.

"It swallowed me."

"It is snow."

"That is exactly what it wants you to think."

Corvin walked ahead with a branch, testing the ground. Eldric stayed near the middle of the group. Alias moved beside Future Alias without making a point of it. The forest was muffled by the snowfall. No birds called. No branches creaked. The only sounds were their breathing, their boots, and the quiet scrape of packs against cloaks.

After an hour, they found the road again only because of a half-buried stone marker. It leaned out of the snow at an angle, a small black shape with one word carved into it.

WRENFALL - 2 MILES.

Rowan stared at it as if it were a message from the sky.

"There is a town," he said.

"That is what the sign says," Corvin replied.

"A town with a name. Named towns usually have food."

"That is not how names work."

"It is how hope works."

Eldric studied the snow on the marker. "Two miles would be easy on a clear road."

"That sounded like the beginning of bad news," Maris said.

"It may take longer today."

Rowan sighed. "Hope has rules now."

They kept going.

The road began to slope down. The trees thinned, first enough to show a pale white field beyond them, then enough to reveal the faint suggestion of smoke rising into the storm.

Future Alias stopped.

Everyone else stopped too.

"What is it?" Corvin asked.

Future Alias listened for a moment.

Then he pointed through the snow.

"Bells," he said.

Alias heard nothing at first. Only wind.

Then, far away and softened by the falling snow, a bell rang once.

A second answer came from somewhere farther down the hill.

Wrenfall appeared slowly.

First there were roofs, low and steep beneath the snow. Then chimneys. Then narrow streets where people were shovelling paths between homes. Lanterns hung under eaves, still unlit in the grey afternoon. A small river ran dark under a wooden bridge at the town's edge, its banks thick with ice.

It was not a large town. It did not need to be.

After the forest, it looked like a promise.

"Bread," Rowan whispered.

"Roof," Maris said.

"Dry socks," Corvin added.

Eldric's expression softened. "All very worthy goals."

They crossed the bridge together.

A woman in a heavy blue coat was clearing snow from the railing. She looked up as they approached, took in their wet cloaks and tired faces, and set down her shovel.

"You came in from the eastern road?" she asked.

Corvin nodded. "We did. Is there an inn?"

The woman looked past them at the road. Her face changed slightly.

"The eastern road is closing. Snowfall like this fills the lower pass first. You should not try to leave again today. Maybe not tomorrow either."

Rowan made a small, deeply emotional sound.

"There is an inn," the woman continued. "The Lantern and Lark. Yellow door, two streets up. Tell Lysa that Bera sent you. She will make space."

"Thank you," Eldric said.

Bera glanced at their packs, then at Future Alias, who had gone very still while the bells rang again across town.

"Festival week," she said, as though that explained everything. "You picked a good time to get stuck."

"Festival?" Maris asked.

"New Year is in four days." Bera brushed snow from one glove. "We put lanterns out, share food, try not to make too many promises we cannot keep. The usual things."

Rowan looked at Corvin. "We have accidentally arrived at a celebration."

"That sounds exactly like something you would call an accident," Corvin said.

Bera laughed once. "Go on. Get warm before you turn into decorations."

The Lantern and Lark had, as promised, a yellow door.

It also had warm windows, a wooden sign painted with a bird carrying a lantern, and the smell of stew drifting through every crack in the walls. Alias nearly walked into the door before Eldric opened it.

Warmth met them all at once.

It was loud warmth. Firelight and voices and clattering bowls. Wet coats hung near the entrance. A dog slept beneath one of the tables, too comfortable to care about strangers. At the far wall, three children stood on stools and tied paper stars to a line of string while an older man pretended not to notice that they were dropping scraps everywhere.

Future Alias stopped in the doorway.

Only for a second.

But Alias saw it.

He was not looking at the fire.

He was looking at the people.

At the children arguing over a crooked paper star. At the woman carrying bowls to a table where two tired workers were laughing. At the dog opening one eye and deciding that the world could wait until after its nap.

It was all ordinary.

Maybe that was why it seemed to catch him off guard.

A woman behind the counter looked up. Her hair was tied back with a yellow ribbon, and she had the kind of expression that suggested she had already solved three problems before anyone else noticed them.

"You must be Bera's travellers," she said. "I am Lysa. You look frozen."

"We are," Rowan said immediately.

"Speak for yourself," Corvin said through chattering teeth.

Lysa looked at them for two seconds longer.

"Six beds in the loft. Dinner in half an hour. Boots by the stove, not on it. And if anyone brings a live goat upstairs, they clean the floor themselves."

Rowan blinked. "Why would anyone bring a goat upstairs?"

"Because someone did last year."

"Fair enough."

The loft was low-ceilinged and plain, with six narrow beds, a small window looking over the snow-covered street, and enough blankets to make Rowan look at them as if he had found treasure.

They changed out of the wettest layers. Corvin lined boots near the stove downstairs with the strictness of a military operation. Maris carefully dried the edge of the shared journal with a cloth. Eldric gave everyone tea in chipped cups. Future Alias sat near the window, his hands wrapped around the warmth without drinking.

Alias took the place beside him.

Outside, snow drifted past the glass in thick white lines. Across the street, someone was hanging little paper lanterns beneath the roof of a shop.

"You all right?" Alias asked.

Future Alias looked at the town below. "Yes."

Alias waited.

Future Alias took a breath.

"I did not expect this."

"The snow?"

"No." He nodded toward the street. "This."

A child ran through the snow below, carrying something bright red. Another child chased him, shouting that it was not fair. Their voices reached the window only as a blurred sound, softened by the glass.

"It is just a town," Alias said.

"I know."

"That sounded like it is not just a town."

Future Alias did not answer immediately.

"It is normal," he said at last. "People are getting ready for something. They are not afraid of the road. They are not waiting for a door to open. They are just... getting ready."

Alias looked at him.

Future Alias's expression made him seem older than he was supposed to be.

"You are allowed to like normal things," Alias said.

"I know."

"You keep saying that."

"Knowing something and believing it are different."

Before Alias could answer, Rowan burst into the room wearing two blankets over his shoulders like a king who had lost a war with fabric.

"Dinner," he announced. "There is stew. Real stew. With actual meat. I checked."

"How did you check?" Corvin asked from the doorway.

"I asked."

"That is not checking."

"Then I checked with words."

Dinner filled the inn with steam and noise.

They were given a long table near the fire. Lysa brought bowls of thick vegetable stew, dark bread, butter, and a plate of fried onions that Rowan treated as though they were a religious offering. The dog from earlier moved beneath their table and placed its head on Eldric's boot.

"You have been chosen," Rowan said.

"I am honoured," Eldric replied, scratching behind the dog's ear.

"Do not feed him too much," Lysa warned as she passed. "His name is Porridge, and he already believes the kitchen exists for him."

Porridge looked up at her without shame.

Maris smiled into her bowl. "He has confidence."

"He has a history of stealing sausages," Lysa said.

Future Alias looked down at the dog.

Porridge looked back.

For a strange second, the two of them seemed to understand each other perfectly.

Then Porridge yawned and put his head back on Eldric's boot.

Corvin noticed Future Alias watching. "Do not take that as encouragement."

"I was not going to steal the dog," Future Alias said.

"You stole a spoon."

"I returned it."

"Eventually," Corvin said.

"That is almost responsible," Rowan added.

Future Alias looked offended, which made Maris laugh so suddenly she had to cover her mouth.

It was not a large laugh. It was not a dramatic moment.

But Future Alias looked at her as if he had forgotten laughter could sound like that.

Later, when the bowls had been cleared, the innkeeper set a small basket of coloured paper on the end of the counter. The three children from earlier came running over with more string and a pile of uneven stars.

"More lanterns?" Rowan asked.

"More lanterns," Lysa confirmed. "New Year needs light. Especially when the snow tries to eat the streets."

The children began folding paper with serious, important faces. One of them held up a bright blue star.

"This one is crooked," she said.

"It is trying its best," Eldric told her.

"That is not how stars work."

"You would be surprised."

Future Alias stayed at the table at first.

Then he stood and wandered toward the window without explanation.

Alias saw him stop near a little display that had been placed beside the door. It held cheap winter things: knitted wristbands, small carved birds, paper stars, bits of coloured ribbon, and tiny wooden charms painted like lanterns.

Nothing valuable.

Nothing anyone would travel across a dangerous road for.

A length of red ribbon had been wound around a wooden spool. Another was blue. A third was silver, catching firelight when people passed.

Future Alias looked at them for too long.

Not the way a thief looked at something useful.

The way a person looked at an answer they were not yet brave enough to ask for.

Then a child dropped a paper star near his boots.

Future Alias picked it up and held it out.

"You dropped this," he said.

The child took it carefully. "Thank you."

He nodded once, then returned to the table.

Alias did not mention the ribbons.

The night grew later. Snow kept falling beyond the windows. More travellers arrived at the inn, each one shaking white from their cloaks and being told, with increasing patience, to leave their boots by the stove. Someone began playing a soft tune on a small wooden flute near the fire.

At one point, Paper appeared from the shared journal.

The page lifted by itself, turned once, and stayed open between Maris and Corvin.

Words appeared in dark ink.

SNOW IS WATER HAVING A DRAMATIC DAY.

Rowan read it aloud.

"Paper has been listening to me," he said.

Corvin looked at the page. "Paper is encouraging you. That is worse."

More words appeared.

THE ROAD WILL NOT BE USEFUL UNTIL THE STORM PASSES.

Everyone at the table went quieter.

Maris touched the edge of the page. "How long?"

The ink waited.

Then wrote:

LONG ENOUGH TO STOP PRETENDING YOU HAVE TO LEAVE IMMEDIATELY.

Rowan leaned back. "That is almost kind."

DO NOT GET USED TO IT.

Eldric smiled into his tea.

Future Alias had not said anything.

Alias looked across the table. Future Alias's fingers rested near the pocket that held the coins. The coins had been quiet all day. Still, he looked like he was waiting for them to pull him away from the inn at any moment.

Eldric seemed to notice too.

"We will stay," he said simply.

Future Alias looked at him.

"The road is closed," Corvin added. "Even you cannot argue with weather."

"I could," Rowan said. "But it would probably snow harder out of spite."

"We will stay," Eldric repeated. "For however long we need."

Future Alias lowered his eyes.

"All right," he said.

The word was quiet.

But it was not a fight.

That night, they climbed back to the loft while the inn below slowly settled into sleep. Rowan claimed the bed nearest the stove pipe. Corvin told him he had not earned it. Rowan said survival was its own kind of earning. Maris set the shared journal beside her pillow. Eldric checked the window latch twice because the wind had started pushing snow through the smallest gap.

Alias lay awake for a little while.

The room was dark except for the pale blue light coming through the window. Snow covered the town below. The lanterns beneath the eaves were still glowing, small warm dots against all that white.

Across the room, Future Alias stood by the glass.

He was not leaving.

He was only looking.

At the streets. At the lanterns. At a town preparing to welcome a new year without knowing what it would bring.

Alias almost asked whether he was all right.

Then he remembered what Future Alias had said earlier.

Knowing something and believing it are different.

So Alias said nothing.

He stayed awake long enough to see Future Alias place one hand against the window frame, as though he needed to make sure the warmth behind him was real.

Then Future Alias returned to his bed.

Outside, Wrenfall disappeared beneath fresh snow.

PART II
TURN OF THE YEAR

Chapter 7: What We Give

A gift is not a debt. It is proof that someone saw you here.

The next morning, the snow had stopped trying to swallow Wrenfall.

It had not disappeared. It still lay in heavy white heaps along the streets and pressed against every roof. But the sky above the town had opened into a pale, cold blue, and sunlight caught on the drifts until the whole world seemed brighter than it had any right to be.

From the loft window, Alias could see people moving below with shovels, baskets, armfuls of wood, and the strange determined energy of a town that had been snowed in but had decided not to let weather make the decisions for it.

Rowan was already dressed, though he had wrapped a blanket around his shoulders over his coat.

"Why are you wearing that inside?" Corvin asked.

"Because I have learned from yesterday," Rowan said. "The cold is clever. It waits until you think you are safe."

"The cold is outside."

"That is exactly the kind of thing it wants you to believe."

Maris sat on the edge of her bed with the shared journal open on her knees. She had been writing since dawn. Her hair was still untidy from sleep, and the end of her quill had a small blue ink stain.

"The storm is clearing," she said. "But Lysa says the pass will need another day before carts can use it."

"Another day," Rowan said, almost respectfully. "I think I can survive another day of stew."

"You said that as if it were difficult," Corvin replied.

"I am a complicated person."

Eldric came up the stairs carrying six cups of tea on a tray. "Then drink something before you become a complicated person with frostbite."

Future Alias was awake, but he had not joined the conversation. He stood at the window with one hand resting on the frame. In the daylight he looked less tired than he had the night before, though Alias knew that did not always mean much. Some people became very good at looking all right when they had not slept properly.

The red thread was still tied around his wrist.

Alias noticed it because he had started noticing small things about Future Alias without meaning to. The way he listened before answering. The way he checked a door before sitting with his back to it. The way he woke early enough to make it look accidental.

Future Alias caught him looking and lowered his sleeve over the thread.

Alias pretended he had been watching the snow.

A bell rang somewhere in the town below.

Then another.

Rowan went still. "Is that breakfast?"

"That is probably the town bell," Maris said.

"It could be both."

Eldric placed a cup beside Future Alias. "New Year is tonight. Lysa told me the market is open again. The streets will be busy."

Future Alias looked down at the tea. "Tonight?"

"Tonight," Eldric repeated.

Corvin lifted one of the six keys from the small pouch at his belt. "The road is still closed. We have no reason to leave before tomorrow."

For a moment, Future Alias looked as though he wanted to argue.

Then he looked out at the town. A little girl in a red cap was dragging a wooden sled behind her. An older man was hanging lanterns beneath the eaves of a shop. Two people were laughing while trying to pull a cart through the snow.

"All right," Future Alias said.

It was a simple answer.

Alias heard how much effort it cost anyway.

* * *

Downstairs, the Lantern and Lark had become even louder than it had been the night before.

The breakfast tables were crowded. Someone had brought in a box of oranges from a cellar and was selling slices for far too much money. The children were still making paper stars, though there were now enough stars hanging from the rafters that the inn looked as though a small piece of the night sky had been caught indoors.

Porridge the dog was asleep directly in front of the stove.

Rowan stopped beside him. "He has taken the best spot again."

Porridge opened one eye.

"I respect it," Rowan said.

Lysa appeared from the kitchen carrying a tray of bread, eggs, and something that smelled strongly of cinnamon. "There you are. Sit down before Corvin begins arranging the chairs by height."

"I was not," Corvin said.

"You were considering it."

Corvin sat down.

Breakfast did not solve anything. The six keys were still in their separate pouches. The compass still pointed east whenever it remembered how. The coins still rested in Future Alias's pocket as if they had no opinion about being trapped by snow.

But for half an hour, none of that mattered.

They ate warm bread. Rowan burned his tongue on cinnamon apple and blamed the apple. Maris wrote down a line Lysa said about winter roads and refused to explain why it was important. Corvin found out exactly how much food they had left and seemed personally pleased that they had enough for three more days. Eldric gave Porridge one small piece of bacon after looking around to make sure Lysa was not watching.

Future Alias did not say much.

Still, he ate everything on his plate.

Alias counted that as good.

When the meal was nearly finished, Lysa leaned on the end of their table with her hands on her hips.

"Are you all staying for the lantern walk?" she asked.

"The what?" Rowan said.

"The town walks to the bridge after dark. We hang lights, we say goodbye to the old year, then we make promises we hope we are sensible enough to keep." Lysa looked at the group. "It is nothing grand. Do not worry. We are a small town. We cannot afford grand."

"We can afford promises," Maris said softly.

Lysa nodded. "That is usually the expensive part."

She turned to leave, then looked back at them. "Oh. And people give small gifts today. Nothing that makes anyone uncomfortable. A sweet. A warm pair of gloves. A note. Something that says, I noticed you were here."

Rowan immediately looked at the others.

Corvin narrowed his eyes. "No."

"You do not even know what I was going to say."

"I know your face when you have an idea."

"We should give each other gifts," Rowan said. "Small ones. Like the town does."

Corvin looked at Eldric for help.

Eldric smiled into his tea.

"That is not help," Corvin said.

"No," Eldric agreed. "But it may be a good idea."

Maris glanced around the table. "We have never really done that."

"Then it is time," Rowan said. "We are stuck in a snow town. We have bread, too many paper stars, and nothing dangerous to do until the road opens. This is exactly the kind of situation where people make gifts."

"You make it sound like a disease," Corvin said.

"A joyful disease."

Future Alias had gone very quiet.

Alias watched him carefully. "Only if everyone wants to."

"I do," Maris said.

"I suppose I can manage something useful," Corvin said, which was as close to enthusiasm as Corvin usually came.

Eldric nodded. "A small thing, then. No one needs to spend much."

Rowan looked at Future Alias.

Future Alias's hand tightened around the edge of the table.

"You do not have to," Alias said quickly. "It is not a test."

Future Alias looked at him. Then at the people around the table.

"I do not know what to get anyone," he admitted.

"Good," Rowan said. "Neither do I. That is why it is exciting."

"That is not reassuring."

"It was not supposed to be."

For the first time that morning, Future Alias smiled properly.

It was small. It did not stay long.

But it was there.

* * *

Wrenfall's market filled the main street from the bridge to the small square near the bell tower.

The snow had been cleared into tall uneven walls on either side of the road. Between them, people had set out tables beneath patched awnings and hung little lanterns from poles. There were baskets of dried fruit, wool socks, carved toys, buttons, candles, tea, ribbons, wooden cups, wrapped sweets, and enough paper decorations to make Rowan stop every few steps.

"Do not buy a paper star," Corvin warned him.

"I was looking at the stars."

"You already have three in your pockets."

"They chose me."

Maris pushed one of the stars back into Rowan's coat. "This one chose the ground."

They agreed to split up for an hour.

"Meet by the bridge before the lantern walk," Eldric said. "And do not buy anything that needs feeding."

Rowan looked offended. "I learned from the goat rule."

"You learned that someone else once brought a goat upstairs," Corvin corrected.

"That is almost the same thing."

Alias stayed near the market stalls at first, pretending he did not know exactly what he wanted to find.

He had not brought much money. None of them had, not after the earlier roads and the way they had spent what they could on food and supplies. But the town had cheap things made by people who cared about them. That seemed more fitting anyway.

At the far end of the street, an old woman sat behind a narrow table covered in leather scraps, thread, tiny brass buttons, and notebook covers. She had one eye that looked sharper than the other and the calm expression of someone who had watched generations of people make poor decisions near sharp objects.

Alias stopped in front of a simple strip of dark brown leather. It had a small brass loop at one end.

"For a journal?" the woman asked.

Alias nodded.

"You made the book?"

"No. It belongs to someone else."

"Then do not carve their name into it. People think that makes a gift personal. Usually it makes it difficult to give away later."

Alias looked at her.

The woman shrugged. "I make book covers. I learn things."

He bought the leather strip, a small needle, and dark blue thread.

The woman gave him a look when he reached for the needle.

"Do you know how to sew?"

"A little."

"That means no."

"It means enough."

"That also means no."

She took the leather back, punched two neat holes near the edge, and showed him how to make a simple loop that would hold a worn journal shut without damaging it.

"There," she said when he had copied the stitch twice without stabbing himself. "Ugly, but sturdy. The best kind of useful."

Alias paid her and slipped the little journal strap into his pocket.

When he turned around, he saw Future Alias across the street.

He stood before a stall selling small carved wooden charms. There were animals, stars, leaves, birds, lanterns, and little boats hanging from strings. The stall owner, a thin man with a white beard, was trying to keep the charms from twisting in the wind.

Future Alias was holding a tiny wooden lantern in his palm.

It was painted yellow, though the paint had chipped at one corner.

Alias did not go over.

Future Alias looked at the charm for a long time. Then he put it back very carefully and walked away without buying it.

Alias watched him disappear into the crowd.

Something in his chest ached, though he could not have said exactly why.

* * *

They met again near the bridge as the light began to fade.

Rowan arrived first, carrying a small paper bag like it contained a secret important enough to explode.

Maris came next with six folded squares of paper tied with different colours of thread.

Corvin had a bundle of waxed cords tucked beneath one arm and a flat packet that looked suspiciously like a map case.

Eldric had a cloth pouch that smelled faintly of mint and something warmer.

Alias kept one hand inside his coat pocket, touching the leather strap to make sure it was still there.

Future Alias was last.

He had nothing visible in his hands.

His expression was guarded enough that nobody asked right away.

Lysa spotted them from the inn door and pointed upstairs. "Loft. Before the bells. You have twenty minutes. And do not start a fire up there, unless it is a very small and apologetic fire."

"We never start fires inside," Rowan said.

Lysa stared at him.

"On purpose," Rowan added.

* * *

The loft was quiet in the way it only became quiet when all six of them were trying not to ruin a moment by caring too loudly.

Outside, the town was beginning to glow. Lanterns appeared one by one along the street.

Gold behind blue glass. Warm dots beneath the snow-heavy roofs.

Rowan sat on the floor first, because he said chairs were too serious for gifts.

Everyone else followed, though Corvin took a long time deciding whether sitting on the floor would somehow make him less organised.

Maris placed the folded papers in the middle of their small circle.

"Who starts?" Alias asked.

"Me," Rowan said immediately. "I have no patience, and everyone knows it."

"That is one thing you understand about yourself," Corvin said.

Rowan ignored him. He pulled six small wooden shapes from his paper bag.

They were terrible.

Not terrible in the way something broken was terrible. Terrible in the way they had clearly been carved by someone who had argued with a knife and lost several times. One looked like a bird. One might have been a horse. One was so uncertain of its identity that it had somehow become a small round creature with wings, ears, and a tail.

"They are road guardians," Rowan announced.

Maris picked up the bird. "This one has one wing."

"It is a very fast bird."

"This one has three legs," Corvin said.

"That means it can run away from danger better."

Eldric turned over a little wooden cup with a crooked handle. "And this one?"

"That is yours. It is tea."

Eldric's eyes softened. "Of course it is."

Rowan gave each person one.

Maris received a tiny book with too many pages. Corvin received what was meant to be a compass but looked more like a confused potato with an arrow scratched into it. Alias received a small grey wolf with one ear larger than the other.

Rowan held out the final charm to Future Alias.

It was a lantern.

Not the same lantern Alias had seen at the stall. This one was carved from pale wood and had a piece of yellow paper tucked into its middle. It was rough around the edges, but it was clearly made to hold light.

"For when you forget where the fire is," Rowan said, suddenly less loud.

Future Alias did not take it at first.

Rowan's hand stayed out.

Then Future Alias reached forward and accepted the little lantern.

"Thank you," he said.

His voice was so quiet that nobody spoke for a moment.

Rowan looked down at his hands. "You are welcome. It is not a big thing."

"It is," Future Alias said.

Rowan blinked hard and immediately pointed at Corvin. "Your turn. Before I become emotional and ruin everything."

Corvin sighed as though he had been asked to carry a mountain upstairs.

Then he opened the packet in his lap.

Inside were six small lengths of waxed cord, each with a different wooden bead threaded onto it. The beads were marked with simple symbols: a flame, a page, a compass, a feather, a small star, and a wolf.

"They are pack ties," Corvin said. "For coats, bedrolls, journals, whatever you need. The cords will not rot quickly in rain. The beads are so you can tell them apart."

Rowan held up the star. "This one is mine."

"It is because you cannot be trusted to keep track of your own things."

"That is the same as love."

"No, it is organisation."

Corvin gave the compass-marked cord to Future Alias.

"For your journal or your pack," he said. "You can use it as a return marker too. Tie it somewhere you want to find again."

Future Alias looked at the small compass bead.

"A return marker," he repeated.

Corvin seemed to realise too late that the words had landed more heavily than expected. His expression changed, becoming less certain.

"Only if you want to," he added. "It does not mean you have to return to a place you hate. It just means... you should have the option."

Future Alias closed his hand around the cord.

"I understand," he said.

Maris went next.

Her gifts were the folded papers in the centre of the floor. Each had a person's name written on the outside. She passed them out one at a time.

"They are not poems," she said before anyone could open them. "They are just things I wanted to remember."

Alias unfolded his.

It said:

You never walk at the front for long. You keep moving back to make sure everyone is still there. I do not think you notice that you do it. I do.

Alias read it twice.

Across from him, Rowan was reading his and trying not to smile. Corvin stared down at his paper for so long that Maris began to look worried.

Then he folded it very carefully and placed it inside his coat.

"Thank you," he said.

Maris nodded.

Future Alias had not opened his yet.

"You do not have to read it now," Maris told him.

He looked at the little square of paper in his hand. "I want to."

He unfolded it.

Alias could not see every word from where he sat, but later Maris would tell him it said:

You came back to breakfast. You sat near the fire. You laughed when Rowan was ridiculous. These are small things, but they are real things. I want to remember them.

Future Alias read the note once.

Then he folded it again along the exact same lines.

"Thank you," he said.

Maris smiled. "You are welcome."

Eldric opened his pouch last.

Inside were six small bundles of dried tea leaves, each tied with a narrow strip of cloth. There was also a little carved charm for each person. The charms were simple leaves, smooth from being rubbed with oil. Eldric had painted the veins on them in different colours.

"For tea when the road is unpleasant," he said. "Or when the road is pleasant. There is no reason to wait for trouble before making something warm."

He gave Rowan a bright red leaf. Maris received one painted blue. Corvin's was dark green. Alias's was grey and silver. Eldric kept a soft brown one for himself.

The last charm was pale green, with a thin blue cord tied through it.

He placed it in Future Alias's hands.

"For you," Eldric said. "It is a tea leaf. Nothing magical."

Future Alias looked at it.

"It does not have to be magical," Eldric continued. "It only has to remind you that you are welcome at a fire."

Future Alias swallowed.

"Thank you," he said again.

This time, he had to look down before he could say it.

* * *

Alias had planned to give his present quietly after everyone else.

But once the other gifts were in the room, once the air felt too full of kindness and nobody seemed to know where to put their hands, he realised there probably would not be a better moment.

He took the leather strap from his pocket.

"This is for you," he told Future Alias.

Future Alias looked up.

Alias held out the journal band. It was not perfect. The stitches were uneven. One of the holes sat slightly too close to the edge. But the dark blue thread looked good against the brown leather, and the little brass loop was strong.

"Your journal keeps opening," Alias said. "When you carry it. I thought this could keep it closed."

Future Alias did not move.

Alias felt heat rise into his face. "It is not much. The woman at the stall helped me. Mostly. I did some of it."

"It is good," Future Alias said.

He reached for it slowly.

Alias watched him run his thumb over the blue thread. Future Alias had carried that journal through roads, years, fear, and places where he had apparently trusted paper more than people.

Alias did not know everything inside it. He knew he was not supposed to.

But he knew it mattered.

"You made this?" Future Alias asked.

"I tried."

"No," Future Alias said. His voice broke very slightly on the word. "You made it."

Alias did not know what to say to that.

So he said, "You are welcome."

Future Alias stared at the strap for a moment longer.

Then he put it around his journal carefully, testing the loop. It fit.

Not perfectly.

But well enough.

"Thank you," he said.

It was the same sentence he had said all evening.

Yet this time it sounded like he was learning the words for the first time.

Everyone turned toward him after that.

Future Alias went still.

Rowan hurriedly lifted both hands. "You do not have to give us anything back."

"I know," Future Alias said.

He looked down at the small wooden lantern, the compass cord, Maris's note, the tea charm, and the leather strap now around his journal.

"I did not know we were doing this," he said. "And I do not... I do not have anything that belongs to me enough to give away."

There was no self-pity in his voice.

That made it worse.

Eldric leaned forward slightly. "You gave us time," he said. "That is enough for tonight."

Future Alias shook his head. "That is not a gift."

"It can be," Eldric said.

Corvin cleared his throat. "Also, you helped us get the route record. Even if you insisted on calling it borrowing."

"And you stole my spoon," Rowan said.

Corvin looked at him.

"I am trying to make him feel included."

Maris covered a smile with her hand.

Future Alias looked around the circle.

Then, unexpectedly, he laughed.

It was quiet. Tired. A little disbelieving.

But it was a laugh.

Alias hoped Maris wrote it down later.

* * *

The town bells began just after dark.

Wrenfall gathered near the bridge, wrapped in coats and scarves and blankets. Lanterns moved through the snowy streets in yellow and blue and red. Children carried paper stars on sticks. Old people held hands. Someone passed around a tray of sweet bread. Porridge the dog trotted importantly beside Lysa, wearing a red scarf that made him look like he had an official job.

The six of them walked together.

No one said they had decided to do that.

They just did.

At the bridge, the river moved black and slow beneath the ice. The town lined the railing with lanterns until their reflections shivered in the water below.

A man from the bell tower stood on a small crate and spoke for less than a minute. He did not say anything grand. He thanked the people who had cleared snow from the roofs. He thanked the people who had shared food. He thanked the people who had made room at their tables.

Then he said, "We made it through another year. That does not mean the next one will be easy. It means we begin it together."

Somebody began clapping.

Then everyone did.

Alias looked toward Future Alias.

Future Alias had his hood down despite the cold. Snow had caught in his hair. In one hand, nearly hidden by his sleeve, he held the little wooden lantern Rowan had made.

The other gifts were safe inside his coat.

Alias could tell because Future Alias checked them twice.

When the clapping faded, Lysa stepped forward with a lantern in each hand.

"One promise," she called. "Not a perfect one. Just a promise you can carry."

People began speaking in small groups. Some made promises so quietly that nobody else could hear them. A mother promised to visit her sister more. A baker promised to stop burning bread when he was tired. One child promised not to throw snow at the mayor, then added that he would try.

Rowan leaned close to the group.

"We should do one," he whispered.

"Not another gift," Corvin murmured.

"It is not a gift. It is a group promise. Completely different danger."

Maris looked at the river, then at the people beside her. "What should it be?"

No one answered at first.

The old year was almost gone. The road ahead was still unknown. There were six keys with no locks, a compass that had led them into snow, coins that pointed toward questions, and a future version of Alias who kept looking like happiness might vanish if he blinked.

Then Eldric said, "No one walks into the next year alone."

The words settled among them.

Rowan nodded immediately. "Yes. That one."

Corvin looked away toward the bridge railing. "It is practical," he said, which meant yes.

Maris put her hand over her heart. "No one walks into the next year alone."

Alias repeated it.

Then all of them looked at Future Alias.

Future Alias's face had gone pale in the lantern light.

For one terrifying second, Alias thought he would leave.

Not run. Not make a scene. Just take one small step back, then another, and disappear into the darkness before anyone could stop him.

Instead, Future Alias tightened his fingers around Rowan's lantern.

"No one walks into the next year alone," he said.

His voice was barely more than breath.

But he said it.

The bells rang twelve times.
On the first bell, the town cheered.
On the second, someone began crying and laughing at the same time.
On the third, Rowan hugged Corvin so suddenly that Corvin nearly dropped his lantern.
"Rowan," Corvin said, horrified.
"It is New Year. You have to let me."
"I absolutely do not."
But Corvin did not push him away.
Maris hugged Eldric. Eldric hugged her back. Porridge barked because everyone else was making noise and he had decided to participate.
Then Alias felt a hand catch the edge of his sleeve.
Future Alias was standing beside him.
He did not say anything.
He did not have to.
Alias moved closer until their shoulders touched through their coats.
They watched the lanterns glow against the snow.
They watched the first moments of the new year arrive without fire, without a door opening, without anyone being left behind.

* * *

Later, back in the loft, the inn was finally quiet.
Rowan fell asleep holding his ridiculous road guardian. Corvin placed his compass cord beside his bed with more care than he would ever admit to. Maris's blue paper star hung from the window latch. Eldric's tea leaves made the room smell faintly warm even before they had been steeped.
Alias lay awake for a while.
Across the room, Future Alias sat on his bed with his journal open in his lap.
The new leather strap lay beside it.
The small gifts were arranged on the blanket in front of him: Rowan's lantern, Corvin's compass cord, Maris's note, Eldric's tea leaf charm.
Future Alias touched each one as though he was counting them.
Or making sure they were real.
Alias almost spoke.
Then Future Alias looked up.
"Did you mean it?" he asked.
Alias did not need to ask what he meant.

"Yes," he said. "No one walks into the next year alone."

Future Alias looked back at the gifts.

"I do not know how to be good at that," he admitted.

"Neither do I."

That made him look up again.

Alias shrugged beneath his blanket. "We can be bad at it together."

For a moment, Future Alias just stared.

Then he smiled.

Not because everything was fixed.

Not because he suddenly believed he deserved every kind thing placed in his hands.

But because the room was warm. Because there were people sleeping nearby. Because the road had closed, and he had stayed.

"All right," he said.

He placed the gifts inside the back pocket of his journal, one by one. The lantern. The cord.

The note. The tea charm.

Then he wrapped the new leather strap around the journal and closed it.

Outside, Wrenfall slept beneath the snow.

Inside, for the first night of the new year, Future Alias did not keep watch alone.

PART II
TURN OF THE YEAR

Chapter 8: Six Against Snow

Some battles matter because nobody has to lose.

The morning after New Year arrived bright enough to hurt the eyes.

Wrenfall had turned silver in the night. Snow lay smooth across the roofs and piled high against the streets, but the storm clouds were gone. The sky above the town was a clear, impossible blue. Smoke rose straight from chimneys. Somewhere below the loft window, someone was already singing badly while shovelling a path.

Alias woke because Rowan dropped a boot on Corvin.

"Why," Corvin said from beneath his blanket, very calmly, "is there a boot on my face?"

"It escaped," Rowan said.

"Boots do not escape."

"You have not met this one."

Maris made a tired sound from the bed near the window. "It is too early for this."

"It is nearly ten," Eldric said from downstairs.

Rowan froze. "Then it is not too early. It is a reasonable hour for victory."

"What victory?" Alias asked.

Rowan was already sitting up. His hair went in every direction, and one of the paper stars from the night before had somehow become stuck to his sleeve.

"Snowball fight," he said.

Corvin lowered the boot from his face. "No."

"You do not even know the rules."

"I know you made them."

"I did not make them. I am making them now. There is a difference."

Future Alias sat against the far wall with his back to the window. He had been awake already. Alias could tell by the way he had packed his blanket neatly beside him and by the quietness in his face.

But when Rowan said, "Six people. Snow. No road to travel yet. It is the law," Future Alias looked up.

"Is it?" he asked.

"Probably," Rowan said. "I have never checked."

Eldric appeared at the top of the stairs with six mugs of tea balanced on a tray. "I asked Lysa whether there is somewhere you can play without breaking anyone's window."

Rowan blinked. "You asked already?"

"I suspected the morning would become loud."

"You know us too well."

"That is one of the advantages of age," Eldric said.

He set the tray down on the small table. The steam smelled of mint and orange peel. Outside, a bell rang once, then twice, then stopped.

"The old mill field beyond the east bridge is clear," Eldric continued. "The children of Wrenfall use it after storms. Lysa says the snow there is deep enough that nobody will hurt themselves if they fall."

"Nobody will fall," Corvin said.

Rowan stared at him.

Corvin looked back. "I am capable of standing."

"That is what makes this so exciting."

Maris rubbed sleep from her eyes. "Teams?"

"Obviously," Rowan said.

He pointed around the room before anyone could object.

"Alias, Maris, and me. Future Alias, Corvin, and Eldric."

"Why those teams?" Alias asked.

"Because I chose them."

"That is not a reason."

"It is the best reason."

Corvin sat up and reached for his tea. "It is not entirely unfair. Maris notices everything. Rowan is impossible to predict. Alias is quick."

Rowan looked pleased. "You think I am quick?"

"I think you change directions without warning."

"That is nearly the same thing."

Corvin glanced toward his own team. "Eldric is accurate. Future Alias is also quick. I am organized."

"You are organized?" Rowan asked.

"Yes."

"In a snowball fight?"

"Especially in a snowball fight."

Alias expected Future Alias to refuse. He had been quiet since the lantern walk. Quiet in the way he became when something had mattered too much.

Instead, Future Alias looked between them all. Then he said, carefully, "All right."

Rowan leaned closer. "You are not allowed to be too good at it."

Future Alias raised an eyebrow. "You are making rules before we even leave?"

"That is what rules are for."

"I thought rules were for stopping people from doing things."

"That too."

A small smile appeared at the corner of Future Alias's mouth.

It stayed there long enough for Alias to see it.

* * *

By the time they reached the mill field, the whole town seemed awake.

Wrenfall's children had already claimed the lower end of the open ground. They were building a fort made from snow blocks and shouting at one another with the serious focus of people defending something that had never been in danger.

The group took the upper end near the old mill wall, where a line of bare trees marked the edge of the field. The mill itself had not turned in years. Its wheel was frozen still beneath a thick white crust, and its stones leaned together like old shoulders.

Lysa had given them one warning as they left the inn.

"No throwing ice," she had said.

"We would never," Rowan had replied.

Lysa had looked directly at him.

"No hiding rocks in the snow."

"I would never."

"No climbing onto roofs."

"I did not even think of that."

"Now you have."

Eldric had placed one hand on Rowan's shoulder and gently turned him toward the field.

Now Rowan stood in the snow with both hands on his hips, studying the ground as if he had been asked to lead an army.

"The rules are simple," he announced. "No ice. No throwing at faces. No leaving the field. No attacks before both teams say they are ready. No magic that melts snow, makes snow, throws snow farther, or turns someone into a snowman."

Maris lifted her hand. "Can I keep score?"

"Yes."

"Can I decide what counts as a point?"

"No."

Maris smiled. "Then I will keep the score in secret."

Corvin was already kneeling beside a low drift, testing the snow with one gloved hand. "We should also agree that a hit on the coat counts, but a hit on a backpack does not."

"Why?" Rowan asked.

"Because backpacks are equipment, not people."

"That is the least fun sentence anyone has said today."

"It is still true."

Eldric rested his walking stick in the snow. "I believe a good rule is one everyone understands."

"Thank you," Corvin said.

"And one nobody uses as a weapon when they are losing."

Corvin looked at Rowan.

Rowan looked innocent.

Future Alias had not said anything. He stood a little apart from the others, looking over the field. His coat was dark against the snow. A few pale flakes clung to his hair even though the sky had cleared.

Alias watched him look at the trees, the mill wall, the open path back to town.

He was counting exits again.

Then Future Alias noticed Alias looking.

For a second, neither of them spoke.

Alias did not say, You are allowed to have fun.

Future Alias did not say, I know.

Instead, Future Alias bent down, scooped up snow, and tested it in his hand.

"Too dry," he said.

Corvin nodded immediately. "It needs to be packed harder."

Rowan pointed accusingly. "You two are not allowed to make this into a lesson."

"Snow behaves differently at different temperatures," Corvin said.

"No."

"It does."

"I refuse to learn that."

Maris opened the shared journal and made a small note.

Rowan turned to her. "What are you writing?"

"That you lost your first argument before the fight began."

"That is not a real point."

"Secret score," Maris said.

Alias laughed.

Future Alias looked at him, then down at the snow in his hands.

The corner of his mouth moved again.

* * *

They split into teams and moved to opposite sides of the field.

Rowan insisted that his team needed a name.

"We are the North Wind," he said.

Maris looked at the bright blue sky. "There is no wind."

"It is a name, Maris. Names are allowed to be dramatic."

Alias looked across the field. Corvin was drawing a line in the snow with the toe of his boot while Eldric listened patiently. Future Alias was gathering snow behind a low drift, making quiet, even spheres with both hands.

"What is their team called?" Alias asked.

Rowan squinted. "The Boring Ones."

"We can hear you," Corvin called.

"Then choose a better name!"

Eldric raised his voice just enough to carry. "The Snow Owls."

Rowan stopped.

"That is actually good," he admitted.

"Thank you."

"I still dislike you."

"Of course."

Maris tucked the journal safely inside her coat. "What is our plan?"

Rowan's face lit up with the dangerous joy of someone who had been asked exactly the wrong question.

"We build a fort."

"That is not a plan."

"We build two forts."

"That is more fort. Not more plan."

"Then you make the plan."

Maris looked at Alias. "Alias?"

He glanced at the shallow hill behind them, the clump of trees to their left, and the narrow dip that ran toward the mill wall.

"We do not need a big fort," he said. "Just enough cover. Rowan distracts them. Maris stays where she can see the field. I go around the side."

Rowan nodded as if this had been his idea all along. "Perfect."

"You are the distraction," Maris said.

"I am the heart of the operation."

"The loud heart."

"The loudest."

They started packing snow.

The work was colder than Alias expected. Snow pushed through the seams of his gloves. His fingers went numb at the ends. But after a few minutes, he found the rhythm of it: gather, press, turn, stack. Their low wall rose slowly, uneven but strong enough to hide behind.

Rowan built the front of it higher than the rest and carved a crooked shape into the top.

"What is that?" Alias asked.

"A wolf."

Alias stared at the lump of snow.

"It looks like a very worried potato."

"It is a wolf in winter."

"It has ears in the wrong places."

"You are both hurting its feelings."

Maris added two sticks for eyes.

"There," she said. "Now it knows exactly who betrayed it."

Rowan looked pleased again.

Across the field, the Snow Owls were doing something that looked far too organized.

Corvin had built their wall in clean layers, each block pressed flat on top. Eldric had made a small stack of snowballs beside him, all nearly identical. Future Alias moved between the wall and the trees, setting another pile where it would be hard to see.

"They are preparing," Rowan said in a low voice.

"So are we," Alias said.

Rowan looked at their worried potato wolf.

"Are we?"

"No," Maris said.

* * *

When both teams were ready, they walked to the middle of the field.

The children at the lower end had noticed them by now. A few had climbed onto the snowbank along the road to watch. One small boy in a green scarf called out, "Get him!" and pointed at Rowan for no reason anybody could understand.

"I have supporters," Rowan said.

"You have enemies," Corvin replied.

"They are the same thing."

Eldric held up one hand. "First clear hit wins a point. First team to five wins. If anyone becomes cold or upset, we stop."

"No one will become upset," Rowan said.

Maris looked at him.

"Fine. I will become upset. But only in a fair way."

Future Alias's gaze moved from Corvin to Eldric to Alias.

"Ready?" he asked.

Alias nodded.

For a strange second, the field was silent.

Then Rowan shouted, "NORTH WIND!" and ran back toward their fort before anyone had started.

Corvin turned to watch him go.

Maris threw the first snowball.

It hit Corvin directly in the shoulder.

"One point!" Rowan yelled from behind the wall.

"That was before we started," Corvin called.

"You said ready!"

"I meant ready to begin."

"We began!"

Eldric looked at Maris. "Does it count?"

Maris opened the journal, pretending to check something.

"It counts," she said.

Corvin stared at her.

"Secret score," Maris added.

The children on the bank cheered.

That was when the snowballs began properly.

* * *

The Snow Owls recovered faster than Alias expected.

A white blur flew over the top of their wall. Alias ducked. It struck Rowan's worried potato wolf and knocked off one of its stick eyes.

"That was cruel!" Rowan shouted.

"It was an accident," Eldric called.

"It knew what it did!"

Another snowball came from the right.

Alias heard it before he saw it.

There was a faint rush in the air, a sound barely different from the wind moving past a branch. His body moved before he thought about it. He stepped left, and the snowball passed beside his shoulder and hit the drift behind him.

Rowan stared.

"How did you do that?"

"Lucky," Alias said.

Maris looked at him for one moment too long, then calmly packed another snowball.

From the other side of the field, Future Alias had gone still.

His eyes met Alias's across the snow wall.

Alias could not read the expression there.

Then Corvin called, "Future Alias, left side," and the moment broke.

Future Alias disappeared behind the trees.

"That is bad," Rowan said.

"Probably," Maris agreed.

"Probably?"

"He is very quiet."

"That is definitely bad."

Alias looked toward the trees. There was no sound except distant shouts, boots in snow, and the soft scrape of snowballs being packed.

Too quiet.

He crouched lower.

Then Rowan jumped up above the wall and waved both arms.

"COME OUT, SNOW OWLS!" he shouted. "YOUR FORT LOOKS LIKE A VERY SAD CAKE!"

"Rowan," Alias said.

A snowball hit Rowan in the chest.

He fell backward into the snow with a dramatic cry.

"I have been struck!"

"One point to us," Corvin called.

"You are supposed to say something kinder when a person is injured!"

"You are not injured."

"You cannot know that from there."

"You shouted immediately."

Rowan sat up with snow in his hair. "I am incredibly brave."

Maris patted his shoulder once. "Try being brave behind the wall."

"No. They expect that now."

He crawled away through the snow instead.

Alias watched him go. "What are you doing?"

"Something heroic."

"That is never a useful answer."

"It is a very useful answer. It stops people from asking more questions."

A snowball struck the top of their wall and burst across Maris's shoulder.

"One-one," Eldric called.

Maris wiped snow from her sleeve. "That was from the trees."

Future Alias.

He had gone around the side exactly the way Alias had planned to.

Alias felt a quick, almost unwilling thrill of recognition. Of course Future Alias had seen it too. Of course he had noticed the dip in the ground and the thin gap between the trees.

"Stay here," Alias told Maris.

"That sounds like a line someone says just before doing something foolish."

"I am going around the other side."

"That is still foolish."

"It might work."

Rowan lifted his head from the snow. "It is definitely foolish. I support it."

Alias moved before anyone could stop him.

He kept low and slipped down behind the shallow rise where the snow lay deeper. The cold climbed into his boots. Branches caught at his coat. Somewhere on the other side of the trees,

Future Alias stepped lightly over packed snow.

Alias could hear him.

Not clearly. Not like words.

Just the small changes: a breath held, a glove brushing bark, snow shifting under a careful boot.

Future Alias was moving toward their fort again.

Alias circled wider.

For a few seconds, they hunted each other through the bare trees with snowballs in their hands.

Then Future Alias stopped.

Alias stopped too.

There was a pause in the world. A bird called from the far side of the mill. The children shouted somewhere below. A small clump of snow fell from a branch and broke softly beside

Alias's boot.

Future Alias turned his head.

Alias knew, before he saw him, that he had been found.

He jumped sideways just as a snowball struck the tree where his shoulder had been. Future Alias stepped out from behind a trunk, holding another snowball. His eyes were bright in a way Alias had not seen often.

"You heard me," Future Alias said.

Alias packed snow quickly in both hands. "You heard me too."

"Maybe."

"That is not an answer."

"Neither is yours."

Alias threw.

Future Alias ducked.

Future Alias threw.

Alias ducked.

For one ridiculous moment, they stood in the snow with their shoulders tense and their eyes narrowed, each waiting for the other to move.

Then Rowan burst from behind a drift and threw a snowball at both of them.

It hit Alias in the side of the head and Future Alias in the upper arm.

Rowan froze.

"Did I get both?" he asked.

"No," Corvin called from the fort. "One throw cannot be two points."

"It absolutely can!"

"It cannot."

"Maris?"

Maris stood on top of the North Wind wall, looking down at the field with the journal open in her hand.

"One point each," she announced.

"That is not how points work," Corvin said.

"Secret score."

The children on the bank began chanting, "SECRET SCORE! SECRET SCORE!"

Rowan raised both hands in victory.

Corvin looked genuinely tired.

Future Alias was laughing.

Not smiling. Not pretending to be amused because somebody else was.

Laughing.

It came out quiet at first, almost surprised. Then he bent forward a little, one hand pressed against his coat as if he had forgotten the sound belonged to him.

Alias forgot about the snowball fight for a second.

Future Alias looked younger when he laughed.
Not younger exactly. Less like someone who had spent too long carrying a heavy thing alone.
Then Eldric's snowball struck Future Alias on the shoulder.

Future Alias straightened in shock.
Eldric lowered his throwing hand. "My apologies. I thought you were distracted."

"You did that on purpose," Future Alias said.

"I did."

"Two points for the Snow Owls," Corvin said.

"Traitor!" Rowan shouted at Eldric.

"I am on their team."

"That is exactly what a traitor would say."

* * *

The battle became less organized after that.
Corvin's careful snow wall began to collapse under repeated attacks from Rowan, who had discovered that running in zigzags made it difficult for anyone to predict where he would fall.

Maris kept appearing in places nobody expected, throwing one perfect snowball and disappearing again behind cover. Every time Corvin tried to challenge a point, she wrote something in the journal and said, "I have checked."

Alias moved between the trees and the field, taking quick chances whenever Future Alias was busy protecting Corvin's side.

Eldric was somehow the most dangerous person there.

He did not run. He did not shout. He simply stood behind the Snow Owls' wall with a calm expression, waited until someone thought they were safe, and hit them with a snowball exactly where it would ruin their plan.

"How are you doing that?" Rowan yelled after the third time.

"Practice," Eldric said.

"Practice at what?"

Eldric considered this. "Life."

"That is a terrible answer!"

"I know."

At some point, Porridge the dog appeared at the edge of the field wearing a tiny knitted scarf. Lysa stood behind him with her arms crossed, watching as if she had expected this outcome from the beginning.

Porridge barked once when Rowan fell into a drift.

"Even the dog is against me," Rowan said.

Porridge wagged his tail.

"No, do not act friendly now."

The score became impossible to follow.

Maris claimed North Wind had four points.

Corvin claimed Snow Owls had four points.

Rowan claimed North Wind had at least twelve points, not including moral victories.

Eldric said he believed everyone had been sufficiently victorious.

No one accepted that answer.

So they agreed on one thing only: the next clear hit would decide it.

The field went quiet again.

Everyone found cover.

Alias crouched behind a low drift near the frozen mill wheel. He could see Rowan's boots sticking out from behind the worried potato wolf. Maris had disappeared completely, which was usually a good sign for Maris and a bad sign for everyone else.

Across the field, Corvin was behind the broken remains of the Snow Owls' wall. Eldric stood near the trees. Future Alias had vanished.

Alias listened.

The snow was full of sounds when people stopped talking. The distant scrape of a shovel in town. A crow calling from a roof. The soft hiss of snow sliding from a branch.

And underneath it all, a breath.

Not beside him.

Above.

Alias looked up.

Future Alias stood on the low old mill wall, balanced carefully on the snowy stones. He had a snowball in one hand. His coat lifted a little in the cold air. For a second, he looked like he might throw and disappear before anyone knew where he had been.

Then Rowan shouted from the fort.

"THERE!"

Future Alias turned.

At the same instant, Alias stood and threw.

Future Alias threw too.

The two snowballs crossed the field in opposite directions.

Alias felt the cold burst against the centre of his chest.

A heartbeat later, Future Alias rocked backward as Alias's snowball struck him in the shoulder.

For one second, nobody spoke.

Then everyone did.

"I hit him!" Alias said.

"You were hit too!" Corvin said.

"That means we won," Rowan yelled.

"It means nobody won," Maris called from somewhere behind the wall.

"It means both teams won," Eldric said.

"That is worse," Rowan said.

Future Alias climbed down from the mill wall. Snow clung to his hair and coat. He looked at the wet mark on his shoulder, then at Alias.

"A tie," he said.

Alias brushed snow from the front of his coat. "A tie."

Future Alias shook his head, but he was still smiling.

"You moved too quickly."

"You did too."

"Maybe we are both resourceful," Future Alias said.

Rowan threw another snowball at them both.

It missed completely.

"Stop talking like thieves and accept that I won," he said.

"You did not win," Corvin replied.

"I won the spirit of it."

"There is no point for spirit."

Maris closed the journal. "There is now."

Corvin looked at her. "You cannot keep adding rules."

"I am not adding them. I am discovering them."

Eldric laughed into his glove.

* * *

They returned to the Lantern and Lark wet, cold, and covered in snow.

Lysa took one look at them and did not ask who won.

"Outside clothes off," she said. "Boots by the stove. No snow upstairs. And Rowan, if I find a snowball in my kitchen, you will be peeling potatoes until spring."

Rowan held up both hands. "I would never."

A small ball of snow dropped from his sleeve and landed at his feet.

Lysa stared at it.

Rowan stared at it too.

"It escaped," he said.

Corvin made a sound that was almost a laugh.

They crowded around the big table near the fire with dry blankets over their shoulders and mugs of hot cider warming their hands. The children from the field passed the inn windows a few times, waving when they saw them. Porridge lay beside the stove again, very pleased with the amount of attention he had received for doing nothing.

Maris put the shared journal on the table and opened it.

"Final score," she said.

Everyone leaned closer.

Corvin looked suspicious. "You did keep an actual count?"

"Of course."

Rowan grinned. "North Wind won."

Maris read the page.

"North Wind: four points, one damaged snow wolf, three moral victories, one good distraction, and one accidental head full of snow."

"That is a lot of victories."

"Snow Owls: four points, one very organized wall, one betrayal by a peaceful old man, one dog witness, and one excellent final shot."

Corvin frowned. "What is an excellent final shot?"

"The tie."

"That is not a point."

"It is in the journal now," Maris said.

Eldric took a sip of cider. "Then I believe it is settled."

Rowan leaned back in his chair. "A tie is fine. I did not want to embarrass you all on the first day of the year."

"That is very generous," Future Alias said.

Rowan looked at him.

There was no joke in Future Alias's voice. Just warmth.

Rowan's expression softened for half a second before he quickly covered it with a dramatic nod.

"I am a generous person."

"We know," Maris said.

The fire cracked.

Outside, snow slid from a roof in a soft rush. Inside, the room was gold with lamplight. The road would open soon. The keys would still need answers. The compass would still point east.

There would be harder things ahead, and they all knew it.

But not yet.

Future Alias sat with one hand around his mug and looked at the five people around the table.

He was not watching the door.

He was not counting their supplies.

He was not looking toward the road.

He was simply there.

Alias saw him notice it too.

Future Alias looked down at the red thread tied around his wrist. Then he looked back at the table.

"I think," he said slowly, "I will remember this."

Nobody laughed at him.

Eldric's face became quiet and kind.

Maris closed the journal carefully.

Corvin looked down into his cider, pretending he had not heard something important.

Rowan reached across the table and stole one of Future Alias's biscuits.

"Good," he said around the bite. "Because I am not doing all that again until next year."

Future Alias looked at the empty space where the biscuit had been.

Then he laughed.

This time, he did not seem surprised by the sound.

Alias smiled into his own mug.

Outside, Wrenfall shone beneath the winter sun.

And for one day, at least, the road could wait.

PART II
TURN OF THE YEAR

Chapter 9: The Year We Chose

Happiness is not a trap. Stop staring at it like it will bite.

The road out of Wrenfall opened on a morning so bright it looked almost unreal. For three days, snow had filled the pass east of town. The wind had buried the road markers, packed drifts against the low stone walls, and made the world beyond the inn windows disappear into white. Then, slowly, the weather changed. The clouds loosened. The wind quieted. The people of Wrenfall went outside with shovels, ropes, hot tea, and the determined expression of people who had survived enough winters to take bad weather personally.

By dawn, a narrow path had been cleared through the pass.

By breakfast, Rowan had packed twice, unpacked once, and packed again because he had decided the first arrangement was emotionally wrong.

"You are putting the food at the bottom again," Corvin said.

"I am putting the food somewhere safe."

"At the bottom of every other object you own."

"Exactly. Very safe."

Maris sat at the long inn table with the shared journal open beside her porridge. She had drawn a small snowball beside the last page, then written beneath it: Wrenfall: no winner, everyone wet.

"That is not accurate," Rowan said, leaning over her shoulder. "I was clearly the winner."

"You were clearly damp," Maris replied.

"The two are not separate."

Eldric folded a map near the fire. "The pass is open for travellers, not for arguments. We should thank Lysa and leave before the next storm changes its mind."

"I have already thanked her," Rowan said.

Corvin looked at the pile beside Rowan's chair. "With what?"

"A very thoughtful speech."

"You gave her a snowball shaped like a potato."

"It was symbolic."

"Of what?"

"Appreciation."

Across the table, Future Alias had gone quiet.

He had been quieter all morning, though not in the old way. He was not staring at the door. He was not checking the window every few minutes. His journal sat safely inside his pack. The red thread was still tied around his wrist. A little wooden lantern, Rowan's gift, hung from the strap near his shoulder where it tapped softly whenever he moved.

He looked almost peaceful.

Almost.

Alias watched him fold the blanket from the loft with too much care, smoothing every edge before he put it away. When Lysa brought out a small paper packet of travel bread, Future Alias thanked her twice. When Porridge came over and rested his large head on Future Alias's knee, Future Alias stayed very still for a moment before scratching behind the dog's ears.

"You can visit again," Lysa said from behind the counter.

Future Alias looked up.

She was holding a basket of clean cups in one hand. Her sleeves were rolled to her elbows. A little flour marked one cheek, probably from the bread she had been baking since before sunrise.

"Wrenfall is not difficult to find," she continued. "Take the east road until you reach the birch fence. Turn left at the broken shrine. Do not ask Rowan for directions."

"That is unfair," Rowan said.

"It is based on evidence," Lysa replied.

A few people in the inn laughed.

Future Alias looked at the cleared road beyond the window. Then he looked back at Lysa.

"Thank you," he said.

His voice was careful, as if the words had to pass through something narrow before they could leave him.

Lysa only nodded. "Keep warm."

No grand farewell. No promise that they would all meet again. Just a townkeeper telling travellers to keep warm.

Alias thought that might be why Future Alias looked at her for so long.

* * *

Outside, the cold caught them immediately.

The road had been cut through snowbanks taller than Rowan's shoulders. Wooden poles rose from the drifts every few steps, each one wrapped with blue cloth so travellers could see the path when the sky turned white again. Wrenfall sat behind them beneath its chimneys and lanterns, small and gold against all the snow.

Porridge followed them as far as the east bridge.

"You cannot come," Rowan told him, kneeling in the snow. "You are brave, loyal, and suspiciously good at making people feel bad for leaving. But you are also a dog."

Porridge wagged his tail.

"That was not permission."

The dog licked Rowan's glove.

"You are using emotional methods."

Lysa called from the bridge, "Porridge!"

Porridge looked toward her. Then back at the group. Then at Future Alias.

Future Alias bent down and held out one hand.

Porridge pressed his nose into it.

For a second, Future Alias closed his eyes.

Then he stood.

"Go home," he told the dog quietly.

Porridge gave one offended bark, turned around, and trotted back toward Lysa.

No one said anything as they began walking again.

The snow made every sound smaller. Boots crunched. Packs shifted. The wooden lantern on Future Alias's strap tapped once, twice, once again. Ahead, the road climbed into a narrow line of dark pines.

After a while, Rowan said, "I think I am going to miss the inn."

"You said the beds were too small," Corvin replied.

"They were. I can miss something and still have standards."

"You also said the soup was too thin."

"The soup was emotionally thin."

Maris looked up from the journal. "What does that mean?"

"It means it needed more bread."

"That is not an emotion."

"It is if you are hungry enough."

Eldric smiled. "A useful discovery for the next time we need to negotiate with you."

Rowan looked pleased. "I am very easy to negotiate with."

"You are easy to feed," Corvin said.

That started another argument, a harmless one. It moved beside them as they walked, warming the road more than their coats did.

Alias let the others talk. He stayed near Future Alias, close enough that their shoulders sometimes brushed when the path narrowed.

Future Alias was looking ahead.

Not at exits this time.

At the mountains beyond the trees.

The coins were in the pocket of his coat. Every so often, he touched them through the fabric. Not checking whether they were there. Checking whether they had changed their minds.

"Are they pulling?" Alias asked.

Future Alias glanced at him. "A little. East."

"That is useful."

"Not really. East is large."

"It is smaller than everywhere."

That made Future Alias smile.

The smile faded quickly, but it had been real.

They walked another few steps.

Then Future Alias said, "I did not expect to miss it already."

Alias knew he did not mean the road.

"Wrenfall?"

Future Alias nodded.

"We were there for less than a week."

"I know."

"You can still miss it."

"That is the problem."

Alias looked at him. "Missing something means it mattered."

Future Alias's hand closed around the coins in his pocket.

"It also means it is behind you."

For a while, they walked without speaking.

The snowbank on their right glittered in the sun. A branch cracked somewhere high in the trees. Ahead, Rowan had started telling Maris that he could definitely teach Porridge to carry messages between towns. Maris was explaining that dogs did not usually enjoy being turned into postal workers.

Alias wanted to say that Wrenfall was not gone forever. That roads could be travelled twice. That Lysa would probably still be there next winter, still warning Rowan away from kitchens and roofs.

But he knew words like that could be dangerous when someone had already watched too many places vanish.

So he only said, "We are still here."

Future Alias looked at him.

Then, after a moment, he nodded.

"Yes," he said. "You are."

* * *

They stopped at midday beside a low stone wall where the snow had melted enough to reveal brown grass beneath it.

Corvin declared the place acceptable because the wall blocked most of the wind. Rowan declared it unacceptable because there was nowhere dramatic to sit. Eldric declared it a lunch stop before either of them could begin a longer debate.

They ate bread, cheese, dried apples, and the remains of Lysa's warm rolls. The food had become cold in their packs, but nobody complained much. Even Rowan only complained once, which everyone agreed was a sign that he was tired.

Maris sat with her back against the wall and copied a few notes from the route ledger they had borrowed in Rellin. The ink had to be warmed between her hands before it would write properly.

"The map says there is an old hunters' shelter two days east of here," she said. "Or there was. The record is old."

Corvin leaned over to look. "Does it say who used it?"

"Travellers. Traders. A few forest wardens. There is a mark beside it."

Alias looked at the page.

It was the same small sign they had seen cut into stone near Rellin: three lines meeting at a point, like a road splitting and returning.

M's mark.

Future Alias went still.

Not so still that the others noticed immediately.

Alias did.

"What is it?" he asked.

Future Alias's eyes stayed on the map. "Nothing."

Rowan swallowed a piece of bread. "That is usually the least convincing word in the world."

"It is an old shelter," Future Alias said. "That is all."

"You know it?" Maris asked.

Future Alias looked away from the page. "I know of it."

Eldric did not push.

He only folded the map when Corvin handed it back and said, "Then it may be worth seeing. Not because we need to force an answer from it. Because it is on the road we are already walking."

Future Alias said nothing.

The little wooden lantern tapped against his pack as he shifted.

Alias noticed his fingers move toward the back pocket of his journal, where the gifts were kept.

For half a second, Alias thought Future Alias might say he wanted to turn back.

Instead, he asked, "How far did you say?"

"Two days," Maris replied.

Future Alias nodded once.
"Then we will know soon enough."
It sounded like an answer.
It did not sound like relief.

* * *

By evening, the road had changed.
The snow became thinner as they travelled east. The land rose and fell beneath their feet. Dark pines gave way to bare birches, their white trunks clustered close together like quiet people. The sky turned pale gold, then grey, then the deep blue of early night.
They made camp beside a small stream that was mostly hidden under ice.
Rowan volunteered to gather firewood and came back with three sticks, a pinecone, and a feather he insisted might be important.
"You were gone for twenty minutes," Corvin said.
"I was studying the environment."
"The environment gave you three sticks."
"Four," Rowan corrected. "One is very small."
Eldric handed him a bundle of dry branches he had collected in half the time. "You may study the environment closer to the fire."
Rowan took the bundle with dignity. "I was going to find those next."
Maris set the shared journal near the fire and placed a flat stone on its corners to keep the pages from curling in the cold. Corvin checked the route by lantern light. Eldric made tea from the leaves Lysa had given them, adding a little dried orange peel from his own pouch.
Future Alias moved around camp quietly, helping where he could.
He set up his bedroll before anyone asked. He fetched water. He tied the horses' lead ropes with neat, reliable knots. He found a safer place for the packs, away from the edge of the stream.
Each small thing was useful. Each small thing gave his hands something to do.
Alias watched him for a while.
Then Alias walked over and held out a mug of tea.
Future Alias accepted it. "Thank you."
"You are doing that thing again."
Future Alias looked down at the mug. "What thing?"
"Trying to be useful so nobody notices you are worried."
For once, Future Alias did not deny it.
They stood near the edge of camp, where the firelight faded into the trees. The others' voices carried behind them. Rowan was arguing that the pinecone should be allowed to sit near the fire

because it had made the journey with them. Corvin was explaining why pinecones did not become group members simply by being found.

Future Alias looked toward the sound.

"I am not worried about the shelter," he said.

Alias waited.

Future Alias sighed softly. "Not only about the shelter."

"Then what?"

He touched the red thread at his wrist.

"I had a good week," he said. "A real one. Not something I had to survive. Not something I had to explain afterward. Just... a week. An inn. Snow. A stupid fight. Gifts."

"The snowball fight was not stupid."

Future Alias looked at him.

Alias folded his arms. "It was a serious battle."

A short laugh escaped Future Alias.

Then he became quiet again.

"I keep thinking about how easily it could have been different," he said. "If the storm had not come. If we had gone another way. If we had not stopped. If I had said no to staying."

"But you did stay."

"Yes."

"And it happened."

"Yes."

"Then why are you looking at it like it was a mistake?"

Future Alias's jaw tightened.

"Because good things make me careless," he said.

Alias frowned. "How?"

"They make me believe I can have them. And when they leave, I have something else to lose."

The answer sat between them, colder than the air.

Alias thought about the way Future Alias had held every gift before putting it away. The way he had watched people in Wrenfall light lanterns. The way he had told Porridge to go home as if the words belonged to someone else.

"You cannot stop things from leaving by never letting them matter," Alias said.

Future Alias gave a small, humourless smile. "I know that."

"Do you?"

Future Alias looked at him.

Alias did not look away.

For a moment, the older version of him seemed tired enough to disappear into the dark trees. Then he lowered his eyes.

"I am trying," Future Alias said.

Alias nodded. "Good."

That was all.

No speech. No promise that trying would fix everything.

Just good.

Behind them, Paper woke.

The journal pages lifted in the windless air.

Maris stopped speaking. Corvin leaned closer. Rowan held the pinecone against his chest as if it might need protection from magical writing.

Ink spread across the open page.

HAPPINESS IS NOT A TRAP.

A second line appeared beneath it.

STOP STARING AT IT LIKE IT WILL BITE.

For a moment, nobody said anything.

Then Rowan whispered, "Paper can see us?"

"Paper has always been able to see us," Corvin said.

"That is deeply rude."

Maris looked from the page to Future Alias. Her expression softened, but she did not say his name.

Eldric poured another cup of tea.

Future Alias stared at the words for a long time.

Then he looked toward Alias.

"I hate when it is right," he said.

Alias smiled a little. "That is one of its talents."

Paper added a third line.

I HAVE MANY.

Rowan pointed at the journal. "See? Rude."

The tension broke just enough for everyone to breathe again.

Future Alias stepped closer to the fire and sat down with the group.

He did not move away when Rowan tried to put the pinecone beside his mug.

* * *

The next morning, the coins woke before anyone else.

Alias knew because he heard them shift inside Future Alias's coat pocket: a soft, restless click. Future Alias was already awake, sitting near the dying fire with his hood up and his knees drawn close.

The coins had been quiet since Wrenfall.

Now they pulled toward the east.

Not hard. Not like a hand dragging them forward.

More like a heartbeat that had finally found its rhythm.

By the time the others were packed, the road had narrowed into an old trail between birches. The snow here was thin enough that they could see old wheel marks beneath it. Moss covered the stones. A narrow creek ran beside the path, dark and fast under a skin of ice.

At midday, they found a signpost half-buried in snow.

One arm pointed west toward Wrenfall.

One pointed north toward a town none of them knew.

The last arm had cracked almost completely away. Only a few words remained carved into the wood.

HUNTERS' ...

And below it, nearly hidden by lichen, was M's mark.

Future Alias stopped walking.

The others stopped with him.

No one asked what was wrong at first.

The forest was very quiet.

Then Future Alias reached out and brushed snow from the broken sign with one gloved hand.

"I came here once," he said.

Alias felt something tighten in his chest.

"In your path?" Maris asked gently.

Future Alias nodded.

"Was it bad?" Rowan asked.

Corvin gave him a look.

Rowan raised both hands. "I am asking carefully."

Future Alias did not seem offended. He kept looking at the sign.

"It was not anything," he said at last. "That was the point."

Nobody understood.

Future Alias swallowed.

"It was a place where I went when I did not want anyone to ask questions. There was a shelter. A broken stove. A roof that leaked on one side. Nothing magical. Nothing important." He paused. "I thought that made it safe."

Eldric stepped closer, but not too close. "And now?"

Future Alias looked down the narrow trail leading east into the birches.

The coins clicked once in his pocket.

"Now I do not know what it is."

The little wooden lantern at his pack strap tapped against his coat in the cold wind.

Alias moved to stand beside him.

Not in front. Not behind.

Beside.

"Then we find out together," Alias said.

Future Alias closed his eyes for a second.

When he opened them, he looked frightened.

But he did not step away from the road.

He nodded.

The group turned east.

Behind them, Wrenfall was hidden by trees and distance. Ahead, the old trail disappeared beneath the bare branches, leading toward a shelter Future Alias had once chosen because nobody else was there.

This time, six sets of footprints pressed into the snow.

PART III

THE WOLF WHO RAN

Chapter 10: The Thing He Forgot

Some places are not dangerous because of what waits inside them. Some are dangerous because of what they remember.

By morning, the old trail had stopped pretending it was a road.

The snow was thinner beneath the birches, but the path was worse for it. Mud showed through in dark strips. Roots pushed out of the ground like knuckles. Every few steps, someone found an old wagon mark and lost it again beneath fallen leaves.

The group travelled in a loose line. Eldric walked near the front with the map. Corvin kept looking from the map to the trail as if one of them might finally begin behaving properly. Maris wrote whenever they stopped long enough for her ink not to freeze. Rowan had tied a strip of red cloth to the back of his pack and was claiming it made him easier to find.

"It makes you easier to hear," Corvin said.

"That is because I am an excellent traveller."

"That is not connected."

"It is connected emotionally."

Ahead of them, Future Alias did not join the argument.

He had walked close to the coins all morning, one hand in the pocket of his coat. The small wooden lantern Rowan had given him tapped against his pack strap. The red thread was still around his wrist, half hidden beneath his sleeve.

Alias watched him stop at every broken trail mark.

Not because he was lost.

Because he was remembering.

The old hunters' shelter was somewhere east of them. They had known that since the signpost. Still, every time the path bent between the trees, Future Alias looked ahead as if he expected the roof to appear immediately.

Or as if he hoped it would not.

At midday, the trail opened beside a narrow creek. The water ran dark beneath thin ice, carrying leaves and small pieces of broken branch downstream. A low ridge rose on the other side, thick with pine trees. The wind did not reach the hollow as sharply here.

Eldric stopped.

"This is a good place to rest," he said.

"Rest?" Rowan asked. "It is barely afternoon."

"We have been walking since dawn."

"That is not the same as being tired."

Corvin dropped his pack beside a flat stone. "It is exactly the same thing if you are carrying three spare scarves for reasons no one understands."

"They are for emergencies."

"What emergency needs three scarves?"

"A very cold emergency."

Maris hid a smile behind the shared journal.

The others began making camp with the easy teamwork they had learned from too many roads. Corvin gathered dry wood from under the pines. Rowan took far more than he could carry and immediately regretted it. Maris found a level place for the packs. Eldric checked the creek bank and pointed out where the ground was too soft to sleep near.

Alias set down his own bag, then looked toward Future Alias.

The older version of him had not moved.

He stood at the edge of the clearing, staring east through the trees.

The coins clicked once inside his pocket.

Alias walked over.

"You are doing that thing again," he said.

Future Alias looked at him. "What thing?"

"The thing where you stand completely still and somehow look like you are trying to run."

For a moment, Future Alias almost smiled.

Then the smile disappeared.

"I need to go to the shelter," he said.

Alias waited for the rest of it.

Future Alias looked past him toward the camp. Rowan was trying to balance three sticks on his shoulder. Corvin had taken two away already. Maris was writing a note in the margin of the shared journal. Eldric was kneeling beside the fire ring, arranging stones with the patient attention he gave to everything.

"I forgot something there," Future Alias said.

Alias blinked.

"At a shelter you visited years ago?"

Future Alias's mouth tightened.

"Yes."

"What did you forget?"

"A thing."

"That is not an answer."

"It is an answer."

"It is the kind of answer Rowan gives when he has broken something."

Across the clearing, Rowan looked up. "I heard that."

"You were meant to," Corvin called.

Future Alias rubbed one hand over his face. His fingers paused over the red thread at his wrist.

"I left something there," he said more quietly. "Not valuable. Not magical. But I should have taken it before."

Alias studied him.

The words were still not the whole truth. He could tell. Future Alias had become better at lying than he was at pretending he did not know how. But the fear in his face was real enough that Alias did not push immediately.

"How far?" Alias asked.

"A few hours. Maybe less if the trail is still there."

"And you want to go alone?"

Future Alias did not answer.

That was answer enough.

Alias folded his arms. "No."

"I can manage a few hours."

"I did not say you cannot."

"Then—"

"I said no."

Future Alias looked frustrated. "Alias."

"You made a promise."

The words landed between them.

Future Alias's expression changed. Not angry. Not exactly. More like someone had been reminded that the road beneath his feet was real.

"I said I would tell someone," he replied.

"You did. Good. Now I am coming with you."

Future Alias looked toward the shelter again.

"It is not important," he said.

"Then it will be easy."

"It might be difficult."

"Then you should not go alone."

For a while, the creek moved beside them. Somewhere above, a bird called once and then fell silent.

Future Alias exhaled slowly.

"You do not have to follow me everywhere," he said.

"No," Alias agreed. "But I am allowed to choose to walk beside you."

That made Future Alias go quiet.

Behind them, Eldric called, "Do either of you intend to help with the fire, or are you becoming scenery?"

Rowan added, "If they become scenery, I vote that Alias is a statue and Future Alias is a haunted tree."

"I am not haunted," Future Alias said automatically.

Rowan pointed at him. "That is exactly what a haunted tree would say."

The moment loosened. Not much, but enough.

Future Alias looked at Alias again.

"Fine," he said. "You can come."

"I was going to anyway."

"I know."

* * *

The rest of the group did not agree immediately.

Corvin was the first to object.

"No," he said, before Future Alias had even finished explaining. "We have all been following this trail together. We do not split up because someone remembered an old object at an abandoned shelter."

"I did not remember it," Future Alias said. "I have been trying not to."

That made Corvin pause.

The fire had not fully caught yet. Smoke rose in uneven curls through the cold air. The group stood around it with their packs still half open, everyone listening now.

Maris held the shared journal against her chest. "Is it dangerous there?"

"I do not know," Future Alias said.

"That is not comforting," Rowan said.

"I know."

Eldric sat on a fallen log, his hands folded over the top of his walking stick. He looked at Future Alias for a long moment.

"Why today?" he asked.

Future Alias looked down.

"The coins pulled toward it," he said. "I thought maybe they wanted us to go there. But when I saw the sign..." He swallowed. "I remembered something I left behind. I do not know if it is still there. I only know I have been thinking about it since Wrenfall."

"What is it?" Maris asked gently.

Future Alias did not answer right away.

Then he said, "A note."

Alias turned toward him.

Future Alias continued before anyone could ask more.

"Not an important one. Something I wrote to myself when I was there before. I was not... well. I thought writing it down would make it easier to leave. It did not."

Rowan's face lost its usual joke for a moment.

"You want to go back for a note?" he asked.

Future Alias nodded.

Corvin's voice was quieter when he spoke again. "Why not let all of us go?"

"Because I do not want all of you to see it," Future Alias said.

Nobody replied.

He looked embarrassed the second the words were out.

"I know that sounds selfish."

"It sounds private," Maris said.

Future Alias looked at her.

Maris shrugged one shoulder. "Those are not the same thing."

The fire crackled. A small spark jumped up and died in the smoke.

Eldric looked from Future Alias to Alias.

"Two people," he said. "No farther than the shelter. You return before night."

Corvin frowned. "Eldric."

"We are not sending them into a storm," Eldric said. "We are sending them along a trail we already know exists. And Future Alias has told us where he is going."

"That does not make it safe."

"No. But it makes it different."

Future Alias did not look relieved. He looked almost guilty.

Eldric turned to him. "You will return before night."

"Yes."

"You will not decide halfway there that the shelter is too difficult to face and disappear into the forest."

Future Alias looked down at the ground.

"No," he said.

"And if anything feels wrong?"

"We come back," Alias answered before Future Alias could.

Eldric nodded once.

Corvin still looked unhappy. But after a moment, he opened his pack and pulled out a small whistle on a leather cord.

"Take this," he told Alias. "Three sharp blows if you need us. We will hear it from the ridge if the wind is not too bad."

Rowan looked toward the dark trees. "And if the wind is bad?"

"Then we run toward the sound anyway," Corvin said.

Rowan nodded as if that was the correct answer.

Maris stepped forward and handed Alias a folded scrap of paper.

"What is this?" he asked.

"The route sketch," she said. "I copied the part from the old ledger. It is not perfect. But it may help."

Alias put it inside his coat.

Then Rowan reached into his own pack and held out a small, unevenly wrapped piece of bread.

"For the journey," he said.

Alias stared at it. "We are going for a few hours."

"Exactly. A dangerous amount of time to be hungry."

Future Alias accepted it before Alias could refuse.

"Thank you," he said.

Rowan blinked.

Then he looked away quickly. "Do not make it weird."

"I am not."

"You are making it a little weird."

Corvin sighed. "Go before he gives you another scarf."

Rowan pointed at him. "That was a possibility."

Alias fastened the whistle cord around his neck. Future Alias adjusted the strap of his pack, though he was not taking much with him. The red thread flashed once at his wrist when he moved.

Eldric stood.

"Before night," he repeated.

Before night, Alias thought.

It sounded simple.

So did most promises when people made them in daylight.

* * *

The trail east of camp was narrower than it had looked from the clearing.

At first, it followed the creek. Then it climbed away from the water between pines so close together that their branches touched overhead. The sky became a thin pale line above them. Old snow dropped from the needles whenever the wind moved, soft white pieces landing on their shoulders and hair.

They walked mostly in silence.

Alias could hear Future Alias breathing differently.

Not tired. Not frightened exactly.

Bracing.

After the first hill, Alias took out Maris's route sketch. The paper showed a crooked line, a small square for the shelter, and M's mark beside it. Someone had added an old note in faded ink:

KEEP FIREWOOD DRY. ROOF LEAKS ON EAST SIDE.

Alias held it out to Future Alias.

"You remembered the roof," he said.

Future Alias gave a short laugh. "It leaked directly onto the only part of the floor that stayed warm."

"That seems badly designed."

"It was not designed. It was repaired by people who had already stopped caring."

"Did you repair it?"

Future Alias looked ahead.

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because I did not plan to stay."

The answer came quickly. Too quickly.

Alias waited.

Future Alias's boots sank into a patch of old snow. He pulled them free and kept walking.

"I stayed for twelve days," he said.

Alias said nothing.

"I told myself it was temporary. I told myself I would leave when I had slept enough. When I had food enough. When I knew what to do next." His mouth twisted. "Then I began thinking I could stay forever, because forever did not require making another choice."

The trees creaked above them.

"Did anyone look for you?" Alias asked.

Future Alias did not answer for several steps.

"Maybe," he said at last. "I did not make it easy to be found."

Alias's hand closed around the whistle cord.

"You said you were not going to disappear alone anymore."

"I know."

"So why are you telling me this like you are defending it?"

Future Alias stopped.

They stood in the middle of the trail. Snow rested on the branches above them. The air smelled of pine resin, cold earth, and something old beneath the leaves.

"I am not defending it," Future Alias said.

"Then what are you doing?"

For once, Future Alias had no quick answer.

Finally, he said, "Trying to explain why the shelter scares me."

Alias looked at him.

The older version of him seemed smaller in that moment. Not weak. Just tired in a way that had nothing to do with walking.

"You do not have to explain it perfectly," Alias said.

Future Alias's shoulders lowered a little.

"Good," he said. "Because I cannot."

They started walking again.

A little later, Alias said, "You know, you could have repaired the roof."

Future Alias glanced at him.

"I know."

"You are good at fixing things."

"I know."

"You were probably just too dramatic."

Future Alias made an offended sound. "I was exhausted."

"Both can be true."

That time, Future Alias laughed properly.

The sound vanished quickly among the trees, but it had been there.

* * *

They found the shelter near the end of the afternoon.

It stood beneath a sloping hill where the forest opened into a small clearing. At first, Alias thought it was only another fallen shape among the trees. Then he saw the roofline.

The building was small. One room, perhaps two if the rear wall had not partly collapsed. The roof leaned sharply on the east side exactly as the note had warned. Moss covered the boards. Snow sat in the broken gutters. A rusted chimney rose above the roof, crooked but still standing.

Nothing magical.

Nothing grand.

Just a place someone had made so people would have somewhere dry to sleep.

Future Alias stopped at the edge of the clearing.

"This is it," he said.

Alias looked at him. "You do not have to go in first."

Future Alias gave him a tired look. "It is my shelter."

"It was your shelter."

Future Alias's expression changed slightly.

Then he nodded.

"It was," he said.

They crossed the clearing together.

The door was not locked. It hung half open, moving with a faint scrape whenever the wind pushed it. Inside, dust lay over everything. A broken stove stood against the far wall. One bench had collapsed. Someone had built a crude shelf from uneven wood, but it was empty now.

The east side of the roof had leaked exactly where Future Alias said it would. A dark stain ran down the wall and across part of the floor.

Alias stepped carefully over loose boards.

"It smells terrible," he said.

Future Alias looked around.

"It smelled worse before."

"That is not comforting."

"No."

Future Alias moved toward the back corner, where a square of stone had been set into the floor beside the stove. He knelt and ran his fingers over the edge.

Alias watched.

After a moment, Future Alias lifted the stone.

Beneath it was a narrow hollow.

Empty.

Future Alias did not move.

Alias crouched beside him. "The note?"

Future Alias nodded once.

"It was here."

"Maybe the wind took it."

"It was under a stone."

"Maybe an animal took it."

Future Alias looked at him.

"An animal moved the stone?"

"An unusually determined animal."

Despite everything, Future Alias almost smiled.

Then he reached into the hollow and pulled out something that had been caught between two loose boards.

Not a note.

A strip of dark cloth.

At first, Alias thought it was old packing material. Then he saw the cut edge. The cloth had been torn from a sleeve or a bag.

It was newer than the shelter.

And beneath it, pressed into the dust, were boot prints.

Several pairs.

Future Alias's face changed.

"Someone has been here," Alias said.

Future Alias did not answer.

He stood quickly and crossed to the doorway. His hand went into his coat pocket, closing around the coins.

"They are quiet," he said.

"The coins?"

"Yes."

"That is good, right?"

"No."

He looked out into the clearing.

"They were pulling here. They should be restless."

Alias felt the cold settle lower in his chest.

Outside, the forest had become very still.

No birds.

No wind.

Then voices reached them from beyond the hill.

Human voices.

Future Alias grabbed Alias's sleeve and pulled him down behind the broken wall before he could speak.

They waited.

The voices came closer, not toward the shelter exactly, but along the trail behind it. Alias could make out words only when the speakers raised their voices.

"... told you the coins brought them this way."

"Then why are we standing around a rotten shed?"

"Because this is where one of them used to hide."

Alias looked at Future Alias.

Future Alias's eyes were wide.

A third voice said, "You sure there are six?"

"Six. The young one, the older one, the loud one, the woman with the book, the man with the maps, and the old mage."

Alias stopped breathing for a second.

They knew them.

The first voice spoke again. "Tomas said the other four made camp near the creek. He is taking the east side with the rest. We take these two if they come here."

Alias's fingers closed around the whistle.

Future Alias leaned close enough that his whisper barely moved the air.

"They have been following the coins."

"How long?"

"I do not know."

"Who are they?"

Future Alias shook his head.

Outside, the people stopped near the shelter.

Boots pressed into snow. A man coughed. Someone said, "We do not need to hurt anyone if they hand over the coins and keys."

Another voice answered, bitter and tired, "People with keys do not hand them over."

"They will if they understand."

"They are children."

"They are travellers with magic objects."

"And we are hungry."

The words were not shouted. That made them worse.

Alias saw Future Alias close his eyes.

Not because he agreed.

Because he understood what it meant to be hungry enough that other people's things began looking like answers.

A fourth voice spoke softly. "No killing unless there is no choice. We need the objects. We need enough to get through winter. That is all."

No killing unless there is no choice.

Alias had heard enough stories to know how quickly people decided there was no choice.

The boot steps moved closer to the door.

Future Alias's hand found Alias's wrist.

"We have to get back," he whispered.

"What about the whistle?"

"Not yet. If they hear it, they will know where camp is exactly."

"They already know."

"Not the path we took. Not where the others are standing."

The door scraped open another inch.

A shadow crossed the floor.

Future Alias looked toward the rear wall, where a gap had opened beneath a broken board.

"You can fit through there," he whispered.

"You first."

"No."

"Future Alias."

For one second, the older version of him looked ready to argue.

Then he stopped.

He nodded.

Together, they crawled toward the gap.

The wood caught on Alias's coat. Cold mud soaked through one knee. Behind them, a voice said, "There is someone inside."

Future Alias slipped through first. Alias followed, pulling the broken board back into place just as a boot struck the shelter floor.

They ran.

Not east.

Not down the trail.

West, through the trees, toward the creek and the four people waiting at camp.

Branches tore at their sleeves. Snow slid beneath their boots. Alias heard someone shout behind them. Then another shout, farther away, answering.

Future Alias ran beside him with the coins clutched tight in one hand.

"They split us on purpose," he said between breaths.

"We are not split," Alias answered.

"No. But they think we are."

A whistle sounded behind them.

One sharp note.

Then two more.

Future Alias's face went pale.

"They are calling the others," he said.

Alias grabbed the whistle at his neck.

"Then we call ours."

He blew three times.

The sound cut through the forest: sharp, high, desperate.

For one second, nothing answered.

Then, far ahead, through the trees, there came a crash of breaking branches.

And smoke rose above the ridge.

PART III

THE WOLF WHO RAN

Chapter 11: The Wolf Who Ran

Sometimes a secret only becomes visible when someone else is in danger.

The smoke was wrong.

It did not rise like a campfire. It clung low between the pines, black at its centre and thin at the edges, as though the forest itself had taken a breath and forgotten how to let it go.

Alias reached the ridge first. He caught a tree trunk to stop himself from sliding down the wet snow, then looked into the clearing below.

For one second, he did not understand what he was seeing.

Their camp had become pieces.

One tent had been pulled half from its pegs. The fire stones were scattered across the snow. Corvin's neat stack of wood lay everywhere. Someone had kicked over the cooking pot. Steam rose from the spilled broth and vanished before it could become a smell.

Maris was backed against a pine tree, the shared journal held beneath one arm. Corvin stood in front of her with his walking staff in both hands. Rowan had somehow tied one attacker's ankle to a fallen branch with rope and was trying to pull the branch away while the man shouted at him. Eldric stood near the ruined fire ring, one hand raised. Pale light trembled in a curved line before him, blocking a knife that kept striking against it.

There were five strangers in the clearing.

And more tracks at the edge of it.

Future Alias made a sound beside him. It was not a word. It was the sound someone made when fear had reached him before thought did.

Then he was running downhill.

Alias followed.

"Coins!" one of the strangers shouted as they came into view. He wore a patched brown coat too thin for the cold. "They have the coins!"

"Get away from them!" Corvin shouted.

The man tied to the branch twisted hard enough to scrape snow into his sleeves. "Untie me, you little—"

Rowan yanked the rope again. "I have heard worse from goats!"

"Rowan," Maris said, breathless.

"Right. Less talking."

Future Alias reached the clearing and moved before anyone could stop him. He caught the nearest attacker's wrist just as the man lunged toward Maris. The knife turned away. Future Alias shoved the man back, stepped between him and the others, and said, "Leave."

The attacker stared at him.

For a moment, nobody moved.

Future Alias was breathing too fast. Snow had caught in his dark hair. The coins were clenched in one hand, so tightly that his knuckles had gone pale.

"We do not want a fight," he said. "You can still walk away."

A woman near the torn tent gave a short, broken laugh.

"Walk where?" she asked. "Back to empty cupboards?"

Her voice shook, but the knife in her hand did not.

Alias saw a small leather cord around her neck. On it hung a little wooden bead shaped like a bird. It looked like something a child would make.

Future Alias saw it too. His expression changed for half a second.

Then a man behind the woman lifted a crossbow.

"Drop the objects," he said. "The coins. The keys. All of it."

Eldric's pale barrier brightened as another blade struck it. "The objects will not solve hunger," he called, his voice calm even now.

"You do not know what will solve hunger," the man with the crossbow snapped.

"I know that taking from frightened people does not make frightened people safe."

"Safe?" the woman said. "We are past safe."

The tied man finally ripped free of Rowan's rope. He stumbled, caught himself, and swung his arm toward Rowan's face.

Alias reached him first.

He did not have time to think. He caught the man's elbow, stepped aside, and used the attacker's own movement to throw him into the snow. It was one of the old tricks Future Alias had shown him without calling it a lesson. The man hit the ground hard. Alias kicked the knife away before he could grab it.

"Stay down," Alias said.

The man looked up at him with mud on his cheek and hatred in his eyes.

Then he reached for the knife anyway.

Future Alias crossed the space in two steps. He stamped on the man's wrist—not hard enough to break it, but hard enough to make him cry out—and kicked the knife farther into the brush.

"Stay down," Future Alias repeated.

The man did.

For half a breath, Alias thought it might end there.

Then the crossbow fired.

The bolt struck Eldric's barrier with a sharp crack. Pale light burst across the clearing like broken glass. Eldric staggered backward.

The barrier vanished.

Everything began moving at once.

Corvin shoved Maris behind the tree and raised his staff to block a blade. Rowan grabbed the cooking pot by its handle and swung it at the man who had been tied up. The pot hit with a loud, hollow bang.

"I knew soup was useful!" Rowan shouted.

"That is not what useful means!" Corvin called.

The attacker with the crossbow reloaded with shaking hands.

Future Alias lunged toward him. The man dropped the crossbow and drew a short axe instead. Future Alias caught his arm. They struggled in the snow, slipping and striking at each other with elbows and shoulders. Future Alias kept turning the axe away. He could have taken it. Alias saw the openings. Saw the places where the older version of him could have hit harder, broken something, ended the fight quickly.

He did not.

The woman with the bird charm moved toward Maris.

Maris backed away until the tree pressed into her shoulders. She held the journal tighter.

"You do not need that," the woman said. "Give it to me."

"It is a journal," Maris replied.

"Then give it to me."

"No."

The woman raised her knife.

Corvin stepped between them. The blade cut across his sleeve before he knocked it aside with the staff. The woman stumbled. Corvin did not hit her again. He only put himself in front of Maris and said, "Go."

Her face twisted.

"You all keep saying that," she said. "Go where?"

A shout came from the trees.

"Tomas!" someone called. "The east side is ready!"

The woman looked toward the sound.

So did Future Alias.

Alias felt the meaning of it before he understood the words.

The people in the clearing were not the whole attack.

They had been holding the camp.

Waiting for the others.

Future Alias got free of the man with the axe and ran toward the edge of the clearing.

"Everyone together!" he shouted. "Now!"

Eldric lifted both hands.

The fire stones rose from the snow.

Not high. Not fast. But they moved, pulling themselves into a rough circle between the camp and the trees. A low wall of pale blue light climbed between them. It was thinner than the first barrier. It flickered almost as soon as it appeared.

Eldric's face had gone grey.

"Behind it," he said.

Rowan looked at the wall. "That is your plan?"

"It is the plan I have."

"That is fair."

They moved.

Maris ran first. Corvin stayed beside her. Rowan grabbed the fallen cooking pot and a pack at the same time, then dropped the pot when it clanged against his knee. Alias picked up the shared journal from the snow where it had slipped from Maris's arm and shoved it back into her hands.

"Do not lose that," he said.

"I was not planning to."

Future Alias pushed the man with the axe away from the light wall and came after them. The man stumbled, fell to one knee, then rose again with the axe still in his hand.

"Stop!" Future Alias said.

The man did not.

He charged.

Future Alias met him just before the wall. He twisted aside, caught the man's wrist, and drove his shoulder into the man's chest. The axe fell. The man struck the ground hard enough to lose his breath.

Future Alias stood over him.

"Do not make me hurt you," he said.

The man coughed, looked up, and smiled without humour.

"You already did."

Then he pulled a second knife from inside his boot.

Alias shouted a warning.

Future Alias turned too late.

The blade cut along the side of his coat. Not deep, but close enough that Alias saw red through the torn cloth.

Something inside him went cold.

Future Alias shoved the man away. This time he hit harder. The man rolled through the snow and did not get up immediately.

The others had reached the barrier.

On the far side, Maris was kneeling beside Eldric. Her hands were pressed against the old mage's sleeve where a thin line of blood had appeared beneath the fabric. Corvin stood between them and the light wall with his staff raised. Rowan had found a broken tent pole and was holding it like a spear, though the way his hands shook gave him away.

Alias ran toward them.

Then the blue wall broke.

Not all at once.

A crack of light opened near the edge. A second. A third.

Three more figures came through the trees.

The first was broad shouldered and carrying a woodcutter's axe. The second held a bow. The third looked barely older than Alias, with no weapon in his hands until he pulled a knife from his belt.

Tomas, Alias thought.

The one they had heard at the shelter.

The broad man saw the keys hanging from Corvin's pack.

"There," he said. "Take them."

"No," Future Alias answered.

The man looked at him. "You would rather we starve?"

"I would rather you stop pretending this will save you."

"It is magic."

"It is metal."

"Then why are you guarding it?"

Future Alias did not answer.

Because it belonged to them, Alias thought.

Because it was the only direction they had.

Because sometimes people guarded things not because they believed they could eat them, but because they did not know who they would be if they let every frightened hand take them away.

The young man with the knife rushed forward.

Rowan met him first.

He swung the tent pole. The young man ducked, grabbed it, and pulled. Rowan lost his grip. He fell backward into the snow.

The knife came down.
Corvin moved, but he was too far away.
Eldric raised one hand, but the magic around his fingers only sparked and faded.
Alias saw all of it at once.
Rowan's eyes wide beneath his wet hair.
The young man's arm falling.
The white snow beneath them.
There was no space between one thought and the next.
He ran behind the torn tent.
No one looked at him. They were all looking at Rowan.
Alias hit the ground on his hands and knees.
The world pulled apart.
Pain tore through him, fast and bright. His fingers pressed into the snow and became something else. His breath caught in a throat that no longer shaped the same sounds. Fur rushed over his skin. The smells of smoke, blood, cold metal, fear, and wet wool struck him all at once.
The noise became too much.
Every heartbeat in the clearing.
Every foot pressing into snow.
Every breath that could become a scream.
Then there was only Rowan.
The grey wolf burst from behind the torn tent.
It hit the young man before the knife could fall.
The sound the man made was short.
The wolf drove him into the snow. The knife spun away. For one second the man fought beneath heavy paws, his hands striking at fur, trying to reach for something at his belt.
The wolf saw the movement.
It bit.
Then the man stopped moving.
The clearing went silent around that stillness.
Rowan scrambled backward until his shoulder hit the fire stones.
The wolf stood over the fallen man, chest heaving. Blood darkened the fur around its mouth.
It did not understand what it had done until it saw the blood on the snow.
Until it smelled the person beneath its paws.
Not a creature from a story.
Not a shadow in the woods.
A person.

Someone who had been frightened. Someone who had been hungry. Someone who had raised a knife anyway.

The wolf's stomach turned.

A bowstring snapped tight.

The archer had raised his weapon.

Future Alias saw him first. "Down!"

The arrow flew.

The wolf moved before it could think. The arrow scraped across its shoulder instead of sinking into Rowan, who was still on the ground behind it. Pain flashed hot beneath the fur.

The wolf turned.

The archer reached for another arrow.

Future Alias ran toward him, but the broad man with the axe caught Future Alias from the side. They crashed into the snow. The axe came down once. Future Alias rolled away. It struck the earth close enough to spray snow across his face.

The broad man raised it again.

Future Alias was still trying to get up.

The wolf ran.

The broad man swung toward it.

The wolf felt the wind of the blade pass above its head. It leapt. Its weight carried both of them down. The axe fell somewhere beyond the fire stones.

The man fought hard. He was stronger than the first. He drove an elbow into the wolf's side. He shoved a hand against its throat. His face was close enough that the wolf could smell smoke in his beard.

"Get off!" he shouted.

Then he found a knife at his belt.

The wolf saw the blade.

It saw Future Alias on the ground beyond him.

It saw the man's hand draw back.

The wolf bit again.

The man made one rough sound.

Then he went still.

For a second, the wolf could not move.

Its paws were red now.

The snow was red too.

They were people.

The thought did not become smaller because they had tried to hurt his friends.

They were people.
A hand caught the wolf's fur from behind.
It twisted, teeth bared.
Future Alias was kneeling there, one hand gripping the wolf's shoulder, blood soaking through the side of his coat. His eyes were wide, not with fear exactly, but with something worse.
Recognition.
"Alias," he said.
The name cut through everything.
Corvin stopped moving.
Maris's hand went to her mouth.
Rowan stared at the wolf as though the whole forest had suddenly begun speaking.
Eldric, pale and unsteady, looked from Future Alias to the wolf.
"Alias?" Corvin repeated.
The wolf froze.
Future Alias had not meant to say it. Alias knew that before he knew anything else. He could smell the shock on him. Could hear the sudden change in his heartbeat.
But the word was already in the air.
The remaining attackers looked at the dead men in the snow.
The woman with the bird charm had gone white. Her knife hung uselessly at her side.
"Tomas," she whispered.
The archer backed away.
The woman looked at the wolf once more. Then she ran.
The archer followed her. The man with the cut wrist stumbled after them, one hand pressed against his injured arm. None of them looked back.
No one stopped them.
The forest swallowed their footsteps.
The wolf stayed where it was.
Future Alias's hand was still on its shoulder.
Alias could feel every place the older version of him was hurt. The blood. The cold. The tiredness beneath the fear.
He could also feel everyone else looking.
Corvin's careful silence.
Maris's frightened breath.
Rowan, who had almost died and was now staring at his friend through the face of a monster.
Eldric's sorrow.

Alias wanted to say something.

He wanted to say it was him.

He wanted to say he had not meant to kill them.

He wanted to say he had been afraid too.

But his throat could only make a low, broken sound.

The sound frightened him.

Future Alias moved closer.

"Alias," he said again, quieter this time. "Wait."

The wolf pulled away from his hand.

Future Alias's face changed.

"No," he said.

It was only one word.

But Alias heard the fear inside it. Not fear of the wolf. Fear that he knew exactly what would happen next.

Alias turned toward the trees.

"Alias, do not—"

He ran.

He ran past the broken tent. Past the place where the cooking pot lay on its side in the snow. Past the scattered fire stones and the steam from the spilled broth. He ran until the camp smells thinned behind him, until the voices became nothing but pieces of sound between the branches.

Behind him, someone called his name.

Then Future Alias did.

The wolf ran faster.

It did not stop when the blood on its paws began to freeze.

It did not stop when its injured shoulder burned.

It did not stop until the camp was gone behind the trees and there was only snow, dark trunks, and the terrible sound of its own breathing.

PART III

THE WOLF WHO RAN

Chapter 12: Nobody Disappears Alone

Sometimes finding someone begins with refusing to stop looking.

For a few seconds after Alias disappeared, no one moved.

The forest kept the sound of him running for longer than it should have. Snow broke beneath his paws. Branches struck together. Then even that was gone.

Only the camp remained.

The torn tent. The scattered fire stones. The wounded strangers who had run away, leaving the dead and the frightened behind them. Smoke pressed low between the pines. It smelled of wet cloth, burnt broth, iron, and fear.

Future Alias stood at the edge of the trees, staring at the place where the grey wolf had vanished.

"Alias," he said.

He did not shout it.

That made it worse.

Rowan was still sitting in the snow where he had fallen. The broken tent pole lay beside him. He looked from the trees to Future Alias and then to the dark blood frozen along the wolf's earlier tracks.

"That was him," Rowan said.

No one answered.

"That was Alias," he repeated, quieter.

Corvin lowered his staff. His sleeve was cut at the shoulder, and the wool beneath it had gone red. He did not seem to notice. "You knew," he said.

Future Alias did not turn around.

Maris had both hands around the shared journal as though it might keep the world from changing again. Her face was pale beneath the snow caught in her hair.

"You knew," Corvin said again.

Future Alias drew in a breath that did not become an answer.

Eldric stepped away from the broken ring of stones. He moved carefully, one hand pressed against his side. The pale light around his fingers had almost vanished.

"First," he said, "we see who is hurt. Then we speak."

Corvin looked at him.

"Eldric-

"First," Eldric repeated.

There was no sharpness in his voice. There did not need to be.

Corvin's shoulders dropped a fraction. He looked down at his own arm as though noticing it for the first time.

Maris moved immediately. "Sit down," she told him.

"I am fine."

"That is not an answer to the instruction."

Rowan stood slowly, brushing snow from his knees. He looked as if he wanted to argue too. Instead, he picked up the fallen cooking pot, stared at the dent in its side, and said, "I am putting this somewhere safe before it decides to save another person."

It was not funny.

Not really.

But Maris made a small sound that might have been the beginning of a laugh, and the sound gave everyone something ordinary to hold for half a breath.

Future Alias still had not moved.

Eldric looked at him. "He is injured."

Future Alias's head snapped around.

"You saw the shoulder," Eldric continued. "And he ran hard after changing. He will be frightened. He will not know what to do with the pain."

Future Alias's jaw tightened.

"I know."

"Then help us find him."

The words seemed to reach through everything else.

Future Alias glanced once toward the trees. Then at the broken camp. Then at the people around him.

"We cannot leave everyone here," Corvin said.

"We cannot leave him alone," Future Alias replied.

The two statements hit each other and stayed there.

One of the fallen attackers groaned near the ruined fire ring.

Future Alias flinched.

Eldric looked at Corvin. "Can you make the camp safe enough for an hour?"

Corvin looked over the clearing. He counted without seeming to mean to: the living strangers, the wounded, the scattered packs, the thin line of trees where more danger might be waiting.

"With Rowan and Maris," he said. "Yes. If no one returns."

"No one is returning tonight," Future Alias said.

His voice was low.

It sounded less like confidence than a promise he was afraid to make.

Maris looked at him. "How do you know?"

Future Alias looked away.

That was answer enough for Corvin.

"No," he said.

Future Alias's eyes lifted.

"No what?"

"No more half answers. Not after this."

The words were not loud. Corvin did not need them to be. He had always had a way of making a quiet sentence feel like a closed door.

Rowan stepped closer to Maris, not quite hiding behind her but clearly deciding that was a good location to be near.

"You knew he could do that?" he asked. "Become a wolf?"

Future Alias swallowed.

"I knew he might be able to," he said.

Maris looked at the trees. "Might?"

"I did not know for certain." Future Alias rubbed one hand over the cut in his coat. Blood had darkened the cloth beneath it. He did not look at the wound. "But he heard things no one else heard. He reacted to scents before he understood he had smelled them. He had the same restlessness I did when he was frightened. And he..." He stopped.

"And he is you," Rowan said.

Future Alias gave a small, unhappy laugh. "Not exactly."

"Close enough for wolf problems," Rowan muttered.

Eldric watched Future Alias carefully. "Did you tell him to hide it?"

For the first time, Future Alias looked ashamed.

"Yes," he said.

The word settled over the clearing.

Maris's fingers tightened around the journal.

"Why?" she asked.

Future Alias did not answer right away.

He seemed to be listening to something none of them could hear: distant footsteps, the cold in the trees, the part of himself that wanted to run after Alias and never come back to this conversation.

"Because I was afraid," he said at last.

Corvin's face changed, but not enough to become softer.

"Of him?"

"Of what people do when they are afraid of something they do not understand." Future Alias looked at the blood in the snow. "Of what he might do if he shifted in the wrong moment. Of what I might do if I was the one who taught him how to become like me."

"You did not teach him," Maris said.

"No." Future Alias's voice went quieter. "But I told him he should keep it from you. I told him there were things people would not accept."

Rowan's mouth opened.

Then closed again.

He looked toward the tree line where Alias had disappeared.

"That was a terrible thing to tell him," he said.

Future Alias nodded once.

"Yes."

The answer was so immediate that no one knew what to do with it.

Corvin looked down at the snow. "He killed people."

"They were trying to kill Rowan," Future Alias said.

"I know."

"He did not choose it because he wanted to."

"I know," Corvin said again, sharper this time. "That does not mean he is not going to think he did."

Future Alias went still.

The sentence found its target.

Eldric stepped between them before anything else could be said.

"We can speak about trust after we find him," he said. "Right now, he is frightened, exhausted, and alone."

He looked at Future Alias.

"And whether you made a mistake or not, you are the person who knows how to reach him."

Future Alias's expression tightened.

"I do not know if he will let me."

"Then you will try."

Eldric turned to Corvin. "Keep the fire alive. Give the wounded water. Bind what you can. Do not question anyone tonight."

Corvin nodded slowly.

"Maris, stay with him. Rowan, help Corvin with the packs and the barrier stones."

"What about you?" Rowan asked.

Eldric looked down at his shaking hand.

"I am coming."

Future Alias shook his head. "You are hurt."

"So is Alias."

"Eldric-"

"I am not asking permission." The old mage's voice was mild. "I am old enough to know when a cold walk will be unpleasant and when it will be necessary. This is the second one."

For a moment, Future Alias almost smiled.

Almost.

Then he took one step toward the trees.

"Stay behind me," he said.

Eldric raised an eyebrow.

"I will try."

Future Alias closed his eyes.

The snow around him was marked with too many tracks. Boots, dragged feet, scattered running steps, the deep places where people had fallen. There was blood. Smoke. Fear. The heavy smell of strangers.

He breathed it in anyway.

Then he pulled his cloak from his shoulders and let it fall into the snow.

Rowan stared.

"Oh," he said.

Future Alias's hands curled at his sides.

The change did not happen with a flash of light.

It happened like a breath taken backward.

His shoulders lowered. His body folded and shifted beneath the torn coat. Fur moved through the shape of him, dark grey at first, then silvered along his throat and sides. The air filled with the quick, strange sound of bone and muscle becoming something else. It was not loud. It was not violent.

But it was impossible to look away from.

Where Future Alias had stood, a large grey wolf stood in the snow.

He was bigger than Alias had been.

Older somehow, even as an animal.

The wolf lifted his head and scented the night.

Rowan took one step backward.

Then another.

Corvin caught his sleeve before he could retreat too far.

"You are all right," Corvin said quietly.

"I know," Rowan whispered. "I am just... I knew there was a suspicious wolf."

Maris stared at him.

"You also accused three goats, a raven, and moss."

"The moss had a look about it."

Future Alias's ears flicked.

For one second, the wolf looked as though he might have laughed.

Then he lowered his nose to the snow.

He moved through the ruined camp without hurrying. Once, he stopped near the place where Alias had shifted. Once, near the broken wall of pale light. He followed the blood scent to the tree line, then circled back, sorting through it again.

Eldric stood beside him in silence.

At last, the wolf lifted his head and looked north-east.

"You found him?" Eldric asked.

Future Alias gave one sharp nod.

Then he ran.

* * *

The forest was darker away from the camp.

The moon had risen, but clouds kept dragging across it, leaving the snow grey one moment and black the next. Future Alias moved ahead in long, silent strides. Eldric followed as quickly as the old injury in his side allowed, using one hand to catch branches before they snapped back at him.

The wolf kept stopping.

Not because the trail was hard.

Because it was too easy.

Blood marked the snow in thin drops. Not much. Enough.

There were pawprints, deep where Alias had leapt over roots and shallow where he had begun to tire. Twice the tracks veered away from the open path and toward thicker trees, as though he had been trying to hide without understanding that the blood would tell the truth for him.

Eldric saw each time Future Alias found another mark.

The older wolf's body would stiffen. His ears would flatten. He would move faster.

"Slowly," Eldric called after the third time.

Future Alias did not stop.

Eldric's voice changed.

"Slowly. If you chase a frightened animal, it only learns to run farther."

The wolf halted.

He looked back.

For a moment, in the moonlight, he looked less like an animal than a person forced into a shape that did not know what to do with grief.

Then he lowered his head.

His pace changed.

Still quick.

But no longer desperate.

They climbed toward an old road that had not been used in years. The stones beneath the snow were broken and uneven. Dead grass rose along the edges. A wooden sign leaned sideways beside the path, its painted letters worn away by weather.

Past it stood the remains of an old watchtower.

Only half of it was still standing.

The lower walls were made of dark stone. The upper floor had collapsed long ago, leaving a crooked circle of broken beams open to the sky. Snow had gathered inside the ruin. Vines climbed one side of it, dead and brittle against the mortar.

Future Alias stopped at the foot of the hill.

He scented the air.

Then he made a low sound in his throat.

Eldric heard it too.

Not a growl.

A whine.

Alias was inside.

"Do not rush him," Eldric said.

Future Alias looked at him.

"I know."

But he did not move.

Eldric came to stand beside him. The old mage rested one hand on the wolf's shoulder. Fur was cold beneath his palm.

"You cannot make him stop being afraid," Eldric said. "You can only make sure he sees that he has somewhere safe to stop."

Future Alias shut his eyes.

Then he walked up the hill.

* * *

Inside the watchtower, the wind had found every broken place.

It moved through the cracks in the stone and made a thin, mournful sound. Snow lay in uneven patches across the floor. In the far corner, beneath what remained of a fallen stair, the grey wolf was pressed against the wall.

Alias saw them before they crossed the entrance.

His head lifted.

His ears went flat.

One forepaw was tucked tight against his chest. The fur at his shoulder was dark where blood had frozen into it. His sides rose and fell too quickly.

Future Alias stopped just inside the doorway.

He did not bare his teeth. He did not move closer.

He only lowered his head.

"Alias," he said.

The name sounded different through the wolf's throat. Rougher. Smaller.

Alias growled.

It was not a warning growl.

It was a frightened sound pretending to be one.

Eldric stayed near the doorway. He did not enter farther. He looked at Future Alias once, then lowered himself slowly to sit on a fallen beam.

"Hello, Alias," he said.

The wolf's eyes flashed toward him.

"I am sorry we had to find you," Eldric continued. "But I am glad we did."

Alias's lip lifted.

Future Alias took one slow step forward.

Alias moved first.

He lunged.

The injured shoulder made the movement uneven, but fear gave him speed. He struck Future Alias hard enough to knock him sideways into a broken wall. Teeth caught fur at the older wolf's neck. Snow scattered beneath them.

Eldric did not move.

Future Alias did not fight back.

He twisted only enough to keep Alias from driving him into the sharp edge of a fallen beam. He let the younger wolf push him. Let him snap and claw and make the small, wounded sounds that came when anger could not hold itself together.

"It is all right," Future Alias said.

Alias growled again.

"It is all right."

The words did not stop him.

Nothing could have stopped him quickly.

He shoved Future Alias into the snow once more, then stumbled as the pain in his shoulder caught up with him. His breath came out in a sharp cry. He backed away at once, limping toward the corner.

Future Alias stayed where he was.

His fur was torn at the neck. A thin line of red showed beneath it.

He did not look angry.

He looked as though the hurt had reached somewhere deeper than skin.

"You were scared," he said quietly.

Alias stared at him.

"You did not want to hurt them," Future Alias continued. "You did not want to hurt anyone."

Alias's ears flattened harder.

"But you did," Future Alias said.

The words were not cruel.

That was what made them hard.

Alias made a broken sound and turned his face toward the wall.

Future Alias lowered himself to the floor. He lay down in the snow, leaving space between them.

"I know," he said.

The watchtower was quiet except for the wind.

Eldric looked down at his hands. He did not interrupt.

Future Alias breathed in slowly.

Then he let the air out through his nose. A long, low sound. Not a word. Not exactly.

A wolf sound.

The sound of one animal telling another that it was not alone in the dark.

Alias did not answer.

Future Alias did it again.

After a while, Alias's breathing changed.

Not calm.

Less wild.

Future Alias moved one paw forward, only a little.

Alias watched him.

Then looked away.

It was permission.

Future Alias crossed the space slowly. When he reached him, he did not touch the wound. He pressed his nose gently against Alias's cheek, then beneath his jaw, breathing in the familiar scent of snow, blood, smoke, and the person he had once been.

Alias shook.

Future Alias stayed.

"You came back," he whispered.

Alias's eyes closed.

The words broke something open in him.

His body shuddered once.

Then again.

The wolf shape could not hold.

Fur pulled inward. Paws became hands. The grey shape folded into itself against the cold stone, and a moment later Alias lay on the floor of the watchtower, human again, pale beneath the blood and snow.

Future Alias shifted beside him so quickly that the change looked like a shadow moving.

He caught Alias before his head struck the ground.

"Alias."

There was no answer.

Eldric was beside them now.

He pressed two fingers to Alias's neck, then to the wound at his shoulder. A soft light gathered in his palm.

"He is exhausted," Eldric said. "And cold. The shoulder needs cleaning, but it is not deep."

Future Alias bowed his head over Alias's chest.

"He is breathing."

"Yes," Eldric said. "He is breathing."

Future Alias closed his eyes.

For several seconds, he did not move at all.

Then he gathered Alias carefully into his arms.

"We should go back," Eldric said.

Future Alias looked toward the open entrance. Snow was blowing through it in thin lines.

"Not yet."

"The camp needs us too."

"I know." Future Alias pulled his cloak around Alias's shoulders. "But he cannot walk. I can carry him."

Eldric watched him.

"You can."

Future Alias stood, Alias held close against him.

At the doorway, he paused.

Then he looked down at Eldric.

"Will they hate him?"

Eldric's face went very still.

"They are frightened," he said. "And they are hurt. But fear is not the same as hatred. Do not decide their answer before they have had the chance to give it."

Future Alias did not say that he already had.

He only nodded.

* * *

By the time they returned to camp, the worst of the smoke had cleared.

The fire was burning again, smaller but steady. Corvin had rebuilt a low wall of stones around it. Maris sat beside him with the journal closed on her lap. Rowan stood watch at the edge of the clearing, holding the repaired tent pole in both hands.

When he saw Future Alias carrying Alias, Rowan went completely still.

Then he ran forward.

"Is he-"

"Alive," Future Alias said.

Rowan's breath left him all at once.

Corvin rose from the fire. His sleeve was bandaged now. He looked at Alias's pale face, at the blood on Future Alias's coat, and then away.

"Put him near the fire," he said.

It was not forgiveness.

It was not an answer.

But it was room.

Future Alias carried Alias to the warmest place in the clearing. Maris helped pull blankets around him. Eldric cleaned the shoulder wound while Corvin heated water. Rowan brought every spare cloak he could find, including two that did not belong to anyone in the group.

"Where did you get those?" Maris asked.

Rowan looked at the nearest abandoned pack.

"Borrowed them," he said. "We have precedent now."

Corvin made a sound that might have been a laugh. It surprised all of them.

The sound faded quickly.

Alias did not wake.

Night deepened around the camp. The wounded attackers had been given water and their injuries bound as best as Corvin could manage. At dawn, they would decide what to do. Tonight, no one wanted to speak to them.

Future Alias sat beside Alias's blankets long after everyone else had settled into uneasy silence.

The firelight touched his face. It made him look younger for a moment.

Or older.

Maybe both.

At last, he stood.

Maris looked up from where she sat with her back against a tree.

"Where are you going?" she asked.

Future Alias looked toward the darkness beyond the fire.

Then back at Alias.

"Nowhere," he said.

He stepped behind the blankets, pulled off his torn coat, and shifted.

The large grey wolf curled around Alias with careful distance at first, then closer when the cold wind moved through the clearing. His body made a wall against the night. His head rested near Alias's feet. One ear stayed turned toward the forest.

Alias slept between the wolf's forelegs, warm beneath blankets and fur.

For the first time since the attack, his breathing became slow.

Eldric watched from the other side of the fire.

After a while, he rose quietly and walked toward the wolf.

Future Alias lifted his head.

Eldric stopped beside him.

Neither spoke.

The fire cracked once between them.

Then Eldric sat down in the snow beside the blankets.

The wolf looked at him.

"Tomorrow," Eldric said softly. "We will have the conversation we need to have."

Future Alias's eyes lowered.

Eldric looked at the sleeping boy between them.

"Tonight," he added, "we keep him warm."

The wolf did not answer.

But he lowered his head again, closer to Alias's hand.

And he stayed there until morning.

PART III

THE WOLF WHO RAN

Chapter 13: The Promise Beside the Fire

Protection is not teaching someone never to fall. It is helping them believe they can come back.

The camp had grown quiet in the way only a camp after danger could.

Not peaceful.

Quiet.

The fire had been built up again, but it was smaller than it had been before the attack. Its flames stayed low between the stones, careful with the wood Corvin had managed to save.

Beyond the ring of light, the pines stood black against the snow. Every so often, a branch dropped its weight with a soft crash. Every time it happened, someone in the camp woke a little.

Alias slept closest to the fire.

Maris had spread blankets over him until only his face and one hand could be seen. The wound at his shoulder was clean now, wrapped in white cloth. His hair was still damp at the edges where snow had melted into it. He looked younger while he slept.

That was the part Future Alias could not stop seeing.

Not the wolf.

Not the blood in the snow.

Not the way Alias had run.

The boy beneath the blankets.

The version of himself who had fallen asleep because his body had finally run out of ways to keep moving.

Future Alias lay curled around the outside of the blankets in wolf form. He had left enough space that he would not crush or trap Alias if he woke frightened. Still, his body blocked the wind. His tail was tucked over his own paws. One ear was turned toward the forest. The other stayed angled toward Alias's breathing.

In.

Out.

In.

Out.

He counted every breath without meaning to.

Across the fire, Rowan had finally fallen asleep with his boots still on. One hand was wrapped around the repaired tent pole as though it was an important weapon rather than a

piece of wood that had been broken twice in one evening. Maris leaned against a tree with the shared journal closed beside her. Her eyes were shut, but Future Alias could tell from the tightness in her shoulders that she was not truly asleep.

Corvin sat farther from the fire, awake and still. He had a map on his knees, though he had not looked at it in a long time.

Eldric was the only one who moved.

He rose from his blanket slowly, careful not to wake the others, and came around the fire. The old mage's coat was wrapped close at his throat. One side of it was dark where the earlier injury had bled through, though he had cleaned it as best as he could.

Future Alias lifted his head.

Eldric stopped a few steps away.

"May I?" he asked.

The question was so simple that Future Alias did not understand it at first.

Then he looked at the strip of snow beside Alias's blankets.

The wolf shifted one paw aside.

Eldric nodded and sat down.

For a while, neither of them spoke.

The fire made small clicking sounds as a log settled. Snow whispered across the surface of the camp. Somewhere far off, an owl called once and then was silent.

Eldric looked at Alias.

"How is he?"

Future Alias breathed out through his nose.

"Tired. Cold. Hurt." He paused. "Alive."

"Yes," Eldric said. "Alive."

Future Alias watched Alias's chest rise beneath the blankets.

"That is not enough," he said.

Eldric did not answer immediately.

"No," he said at last. "It is not enough for everything. But it is enough for tonight."

Future Alias's ears lowered.

He wanted to reject that answer. He wanted to say that tonight had already proved how little alive could mean. People could be alive and afraid. Alive and bleeding. Alive after doing something they could not understand how to forgive.

Alive and alone even when people stood around them.

Eldric's hand rested on his own knee.

"Do you hate him for it?" he asked quietly.

Future Alias looked up.

The question felt wrong.

"No."

"I did not think you did."

"Then why ask?"

"Because he may wake believing that you do." Eldric's voice stayed low. "And because sometimes we carry anger toward someone who reminds us of a part of ourselves we would rather not meet again."

Future Alias turned his head away.

The firelight made the snow look gold. His shadow stretched across it, wolf-shaped and too large.

"I do not hate him," he said again.

This time, the words came out rougher.

"I am afraid for him."

Eldric nodded once.

"That is different."

"Is it?"

"Very. Fear can make people cruel too. But it does not have to."

Future Alias let out a small, bitter sound.

"You make that sound simple."

"I have had many years to make difficult things sound like short sentences." Eldric glanced toward the fire. "It is one of the few benefits of becoming old."

Despite himself, Future Alias's ears shifted forward a little.

Eldric saw it and allowed the smallest smile.

Then his expression became serious again.

"You told him to hide."

The wolf went still.

"Yes."

"Why?"

Future Alias stared at the sleeping face beside him.

He had answered this already, near the broken campfire. He had said fear. The word had been true, but it had not been all of it.

"Because I knew what it was like," he said. "The first time it happened to me, I was alone. I did not understand what I was becoming. I thought something had gone wrong inside me."

Eldric listened without interrupting.

"Later, I learned I could use it. I could run farther. Hear danger sooner. Hunt when there was nothing else. I could become something that did not have to explain itself." Future Alias's claws pressed into the snow. "It was useful. Until it was not."

"Until being alone became easier than being seen," Eldric said.

Future Alias closed his eyes.

"Yes."

The word barely moved the air.

"I did not want that for him."

"Then why did you send him toward it?"

Future Alias flinched.

Eldric did not say it cruelly.

That was worse.

"I thought secrecy would protect him," Future Alias said. "I thought if no one knew, no one could look at him differently. No one could decide what he was before he got the chance to decide it himself."

"And perhaps that was part of it."

Future Alias looked at him.

"Part of it?"

"You wanted to keep him safe from other people." Eldric's gaze stayed steady. "But you also wanted to keep him safe from becoming you."

The words found the place Future Alias had been guarding most carefully.

He lowered his head beside Alias's hand.

For several breaths, he said nothing.

At last, he spoke.

"I did become someone I did not recognize."

Eldric's face softened, but he did not look away.

"You became someone who was hurt," he said. "Those are not the same thing."

Future Alias gave a quiet, humourless laugh.

"You did not see me."

"No," Eldric agreed. "I did not."

The honesty made Future Alias look up again.

"I did not see every road you walked after you left," Eldric continued. "I did not see every decision you made. I did not see the days you survived because you had no one else. But I know this much: a person can do terrible things, or frightened things, or lonely things, and still not become only the worst thing they have done."

Future Alias looked toward the darkness at the edge of camp.

"That is easy to say when it is not your hands."

"No," Eldric said. "It is not."

The answer came too quickly to be kind words prepared for someone else.

Future Alias studied him.

Eldric looked older in the firelight than he had that morning. Not weak. Just tired in a way that had been earned over many years.

"When I was young," Eldric said, "I thought wisdom meant having the answer before anyone else asked the question. I believed that if I learned enough, planned enough, watched closely enough, I could keep the people around me from making mistakes."

He reached down and picked up a small piece of bark from the snow. He turned it between two fingers.

"I gave advice when people needed company. I made plans when people needed to be heard. I tried to hold every map so tightly that no one else had room to choose a road."

Future Alias listened.

"Did it work?" he asked.

Eldric's mouth moved in a sad almost-smile.

"No."

The bark broke cleanly between his fingers.

"People still made mistakes. People still left. People I loved still got hurt. Some of them chose paths I would not have chosen. Some of them never came back."

He dropped the broken pieces into the snow.

"For a long time, I thought that meant I had failed them. Then, for another long time, I thought the answer was to stop caring so much. Both ideas were wrong."

The wolf watched him closely.

"What was the right one?"

Eldric looked at Alias.

"Wisdom is not controlling someone's life," he said. "It is staying close enough that they do not have to face it alone."

The words settled into the quiet camp.

Future Alias thought of every night he had spent alone because he had been certain he had to. Every road he had taken because turning back would mean admitting he wanted someone to meet him there. Every time he had heard a door close and told himself he had chosen the silence.

He pressed his nose against Alias's knuckles.

"He should not have had to do that," he said.

"No," Eldric said. "He should not."

"He killed people."

"Yes."

Future Alias's head lifted sharply.

Eldric did not soften the word.

"They were attacking you," Future Alias said. "They were going to hurt Rowan. They had weapons."

"I know."

"Then why say it like that?"

"Because pretending it did not happen will not help him." Eldric's voice was quiet, but it did not bend. "He deserves better than being lied to in the name of comfort. Those people were trying to hurt us. Alias acted in fear, in defense, and in a form he did not understand. All of that is true. It is also true that people died. He will need help holding both truths without letting either one destroy him."

Future Alias's breathing became uneven.

"How?"

Eldric looked at the sleeping boy.

"First, we do not ask him to become fine before he is ready. We do not tell him he is a monster. We do not tell him he is innocent in a way that makes his memory feel false. We listen. We keep him warm. We make sure he eats when he wakes."

"That sounds too small."

"Small things keep people here." Eldric shifted carefully, one hand pressing against his side. "A fire. A meal. Someone saying your name gently. A person sitting beside you long enough for you to believe they are not leaving."

Future Alias looked down at Alias.

"I will keep him safe," he said.

Eldric was quiet for a moment.

Then he shook his head.

"Not from becoming you," he said.

Future Alias froze.

Eldric's eyes stayed on his.

"From becoming alone."

The fire crackled.

No one else stirred.

Future Alias felt the sentence move through him like cold water.

Not from becoming you.

From becoming alone.

He had spent so long thinking those were the same thing.

He had thought the wolf, the silence, the stealing, the running, the grief, the hunger, the terrible choices - all of it had made him something separate from everyone else. Something Alias needed to escape.

But Eldric was not asking him to erase himself from Alias's future.

He was asking him not to teach Alias that isolation was the only way to survive it.

"What if he does become like me?" Future Alias asked.

Eldric's expression changed only slightly.

"He already is like you in some ways. You have both noticed that." The old mage rested a hand against the snow. "He may be clever. He may be guarded. He may learn faster than you want him to. He may make choices you do not understand. He may even make some of the same mistakes."

Future Alias's throat tightened.

"Then what am I supposed to do?"

"Tell him the truth when the truth can help him. Let him keep what is private when privacy is what he needs. Ask him questions instead of deciding his answers. And when he starts to believe that leaving is the only way not to hurt people... remind him that he can stay."

Future Alias stared at the fire.

"I will not always be here."

He had not meant to say it.

But once the words existed, he could not take them back.

Eldric looked at him for a long time.

"No," he said gently. "I do not think you will."

Future Alias's ears flattened.

The coin rested in a pocket of the torn coat folded nearby. Even through cloth and snow, he could feel its strange pull. Not hard. Not yet. But present.

A road with an ending.

A door that would not stay open forever.

"When I go," he said, "he will think I left him too."

Eldric's gaze moved to Alias.

"Perhaps. At first."

"That is not good enough."

"No," Eldric agreed. "It is not. So do not leave him only with silence."

Future Alias did not understand.

"How?"

"By telling him, before the moment comes, that returning is not the same as running away. By giving him the truth he needs, even when it hurts. By leaving him with memories that do not

end at the point of goodbye. By trusting the people beside him to continue caring for him after you are gone."

Future Alias looked across the camp.

Rowan, asleep with his absurd tent pole.

Maris, pretending to sleep while one hand rested on the journal.

Corvin, awake in the dark with a map he did not need.

Eldric, sitting in the snow beside him despite the wound in his side.

The people who were frightened.

The people who were hurt.

The people who had not gone away.

"They might not forgive him," Future Alias said.

"They might not know how to forgive him immediately," Eldric corrected. "There is a difference."

"And if they are scared?"

"They are allowed to be. So is he. Fear is not the final shape of a person." Eldric glanced at the blankets. "Neither is one night."

Future Alias let out a slow breath.

Eldric reached forward, then paused.

"May I touch you?"

Future Alias looked at the hand.

He remembered people reaching without asking. Hands on his head, his shoulder, the back of his neck. Hands that meant comfort and hands that did not. Sometimes he had run before he knew which kind they were.

He lowered his head once.

Eldric's hand settled against the fur between his ears.

It was warm.

It did not hold him in place.

"Promise me something," Eldric said.

Future Alias looked up.

"What?"

"When Alias is frightened of himself, do not make him carry that fear in secret because it is easier for you. When he wants to run, do not only chase him. Give him a reason to come back. When he is ashamed, do not turn his shame into a lesson before he has had a chance to be heard."

Future Alias swallowed.

Eldric's hand remained still.

"And when you have to go," Eldric continued, "do not teach him that goodbye means he has been abandoned."

The words were careful. They were not a command to stay forever.

They were something harder.

A command to leave honestly.

Future Alias looked at Alias's sleeping hand beneath the blanket.

"I promise," he said.

Eldric waited.

Future Alias drew in a breath.

"I will tell him what I can. I will not make his choices for him because I am afraid of what he might become. I will remind him to come back. I will remind him that asking for help is not weakness." His voice shook once, but he continued. "And when I have to go, I will not make him think I am leaving because he failed me."

The old mage's eyes softened.

"Good," Eldric said.

"That is not all." Future Alias lowered his head. "I will keep him safe."

Eldric nodded.

"Not from becoming you."

Future Alias's eyes closed.

"From becoming alone," he finished.

For a while, neither of them spoke.

Then Eldric took his hand away and leaned back against the nearby log.

"You should rest too," he said.

Future Alias made a sound that was almost a laugh.

"I am a wolf. We do not rest."

"That explains why wolves look so tired all the time."

Future Alias opened one eye.

Eldric's mouth had become a small smile.

"You were awake when I arrived," Eldric said. "You have been counting his breaths."

Future Alias's ears angled away.

"He is breathing."

"He is."

"He could stop."

"So could you, if you do not sleep at all."

Future Alias did not answer.

Eldric looked toward the fire, then toward the dark trees.

"You are allowed to be afraid for him," he said. "You are also allowed to be tired. Those things do not cancel each other."

The wolf settled his chin across his paws.

Eldric stayed beside him a little longer.

The camp continued breathing around them.

At some point, Corvin shifted beneath his blanket and opened his eyes. He saw Eldric awake, saw Future Alias still curled beside Alias, and did not say anything. His gaze rested on the wolf for a moment.

Then he looked at Alias.

"His fever?" he whispered.

"Low," Eldric replied. "The wound is clean."

Corvin nodded.

He hesitated.

"I said things too sharply," he said.

Future Alias looked at him.

Corvin's jaw tightened as though apology was a language he understood but did not enjoy speaking.

"I was angry," he continued. "I still am. But that does not mean I wanted him gone."

The wolf's ears lifted a fraction.

Corvin looked down at the map on his lap.

"We will talk when he wakes," he said. "All of us. Properly."

Future Alias looked at Eldric.

Eldric only nodded.

No false promise.

No easy answer.

Just a door left open.

Corvin pulled his blanket back around his shoulders. Before closing his eyes, he reached out and placed a small cup of water within arm's reach of Alias's blankets.

Then he lay down again.

Future Alias watched the cup for a long moment.

Small things keep people here.

A fire.

A meal.

Water left for someone before they wake.

The first thin blue of morning began to show behind the trees.

Maris stirred. Rowan muttered something into his sleeve that sounded like an argument with a snowman. The attackers' horses shifted farther from camp, restless but quiet.

Alias did not wake.

Not yet.

Future Alias tightened his curl around the blankets, but not too close. He left space. He watched the sky grow lighter above the pines.

Tomorrow would be difficult.

They would talk about blood, secrets, fear, and trust.

They would say things that hurt because they were true.

But no one had left.

The road beyond the camp would still be waiting when morning fully came.

For now, Alias slept.

For now, Future Alias stayed.

PART III
THE WOLF WHO RAN

Chapter 14: Moonlight Rules

Fear does not vanish because it is named. But it can stop being the only thing in the room.

Morning did not arrive kindly.

It came pale and cold through the trees, showing every mark the night had left behind.

Smoke stained the snow around the broken edge of camp. One tent leaned crookedly against its repaired pole. Dark patches marked the places where blood had fallen and been covered as best as anyone could manage. The attackers' abandoned packs had been gathered near the stones. Their weapons were stacked farther away, where no one could reach them without being seen.

Alias woke because someone was saying his name.

Not loudly.

Not as though they were trying to pull him out of sleep by force.

Just once.

Then again.

"Alias."

He opened his eyes.

For a moment, he did not know where he was.

The sky above him was grey-blue. Pine branches crossed it in dark lines. The fire had burned down to red coals, and the air smelled like smoke, snow, and something metallic he did not want to name.

Then pain woke with him.

His shoulder hurt beneath the bandage. His ribs ached when he drew a breath. His hands felt strange, as though they belonged to someone who had been running for far too long.

He tried to sit up.

A large grey head lifted beside him.

Future Alias was still in wolf form.

For one sharp second, Alias only stared.

The wolf's eyes were tired. Not wild. Not angry. Tired.

Then the memory returned.

The clearing.

Rowan falling backward in the snow.

The sound of someone shouting.

His own body changing behind smoke and broken canvas.

Paws.

Teeth.

Blood.

Alias stopped breathing.

Future Alias made a low sound in his throat. Not a warning. Something softer.

Across the fire, Eldric was awake with a small pot over the coals. Maris sat beside him, knees pulled close to her chest, the shared journal in her lap. Corvin was a few steps away, checking the straps of a pack with slow, careful hands. Rowan stood near the edge of camp, facing outward. He did not seem to be watching for danger anymore.

He seemed to be trying not to look back.

Every person in the clearing turned when Alias woke.

Alias's stomach dropped.

"Do not," he said.

His voice came out thin.

Maris blinked. "Do not what?"

"Do not look at me like that."

No one answered immediately.

Future Alias shifted closer, then stopped before touching him.

Eldric poured hot water into a cup. "You are hurt," he said. "People tend to look at hurt things."

Alias looked down at the blanket over his lap.

"I am not a thing."

"No," Eldric said. "You are not."

The answer was too gentle. Alias hated that it made his throat tighten.

He pushed the blankets away.

Future Alias stood at once.

"I need to go," Alias said.

The words were already there before he knew where he meant to go.

The wolf did not block him.

Eldric did not reach for him.

Instead, Corvin set down the pack strap he had been fixing.

"You can," Corvin said. "But not alone."

Alias froze.

The sentence did not sound like an order. That made it worse.

"I do not need someone to follow me," he said.

"No," Corvin replied. "You need a shoulder bandage, food, and at least one person who knows where you are. Those are different things."

Alias looked away.

Rowan turned from the edge of camp at last. His face was pale, and there was dirt on one cheek where he had clearly rubbed at it too hard.

"You can sit down first," Rowan said. "That is allowed. Sitting down does not mean you are trapped."

Alias almost laughed.

It did not come out.

He sat back because his shoulder hurt too much to keep pretending it did not.

Future Alias lowered himself beside him again. After a moment, he shifted back into human form. He pulled on his coat slowly, as though even moving his arms was difficult.

Alias could not look at him.

"I remember," he said.

The words were quiet, but everyone heard them.

No one asked what he meant.

That was almost worse.

Alias pressed the heel of his hand against his eyes.

"I remember their faces."

The camp stayed still.

He saw one of the attackers again: not as a blur in smoke, not as a weapon raised toward Rowan, but as a person with a torn sleeve and a frightened expression. Someone who had shouted at someone else to get back. Someone who had tried to crawl away.

His stomach twisted.

"They were people," he said.

Future Alias looked down at his own hands.

"Yes," he said.

The simple agreement made Alias flinch.

No excuse.

No pretending it had been nothing.

Just yes.

"They were going to hurt you," Rowan said quickly. His hands were clenched around the tent pole. "They were going to hurt us."

"I know." Alias's voice cracked. "That does not make them not people."

"No," Eldric said. "It does not."

Alias looked at him, angry suddenly because no one was arguing.

"Then why is everyone acting like I am supposed to just-" He swallowed hard. "Like I am supposed to be grateful it worked?"

Maris leaned forward. Her eyes were red from lack of sleep, but her voice was steady.

"I do not think that is what anyone is saying."

"Then what are you saying?"

Maris looked at the snow between them.

"I am saying I was scared," she said. "I was scared of the people attacking us. I was scared when the wolf came out because I did not know what was happening. And I was scared when I realized it was you." She looked up. "All those things can be true."

Alias's chest hurt.

"Are you scared of me now?"

Maris did not answer quickly.

"A little," she said at last.

The word struck harder than it should have.

She held up one hand before he could turn away.

"Not because I think you are only that," she continued. "Not because I think you wanted it. I am scared because something happened that none of us knew how to handle. I am scared because you were scared, and nobody knew until it was already too late."

Alias stared at her.

Maris's fingers tightened around the journal.

"I do not want to be scared of you," she said. "I want to understand what happened. And I want you to be here while we do."

For a long time, Alias could not speak.

Corvin stood and walked to the coals. He added one small piece of wood to them, then watched until the flame caught.

"I was angry," he said.

Everyone looked at him.

Corvin did not look back.

"I still am. I am angry that we were attacked. I am angry that Future Alias knew enough to tell Alias to hide it and still let us walk into danger without knowing. I am angry that I had no plan for something like this." His jaw tightened. "I am angry because I was frightened."

Future Alias's head lowered.

Corvin turned toward him.

"But I am also alive because the wolf was there. So are Rowan and Maris."

Rowan gave a tiny, shaky nod.

Corvin looked at Alias.

"You saved us," he said. "That does not make the rest of it disappear. It does not make your fear disappear. But it is true."

Alias's eyes stung.

He looked at the fire before anyone could see.

"I did not know what I was doing," he whispered.

"I know," Future Alias said.

Alias snapped his head toward him.

There was no accusation in Future Alias's face. Only exhaustion and a kind of guilt that made Alias's own guilt feel suddenly less private.

"I know," Future Alias repeated. "And I should have told you more. I should have told everyone more. I thought hiding it would keep you safe." He swallowed. "I was wrong."

Alias looked down at his bandaged shoulder.

"Why did you know?"

Future Alias was quiet for several breaths.

"Because I saw the signs," he said. "Your hearing. The way you wake when nobody else hears anything. The way your body reacts before you have decided to be afraid." He looked past Alias, into the trees. "And because I know what it is like to feel something changing inside you and want no one to see it."

"You told me to keep it secret."

"Yes."

"You said it would be safer."

"I thought it would." Future Alias's voice was rough. "I was trying to protect you from people looking at you differently. But I was also trying to protect myself from having to watch you make the same choices I made."

The words sat between them.

Alias wanted to be angry. He was angry.

But Future Alias was not asking him to make the anger easier.

He was only telling the truth.

Eldric passed the cup of hot water to Alias.

"Drink," he said.

Alias looked at it.

"That is your answer?"

"At the moment, yes."

"We are talking about people dying."

"We are," Eldric said. "And your body still needs water. Big truths are difficult to hold when you are cold and half-conscious."

Alias took the cup because he did not have a better answer.

The warmth against his palms felt unfairly good.

He drank.

No one spoke until he had taken three small mouthfuls.

Then Eldric looked around the camp.

"We will need rules," he said.

Rowan blinked. "Rules?"

"Not punishments," Eldric said. "Not a list of reasons for someone to be ashamed. Rules for when fear becomes too large to carry alone."

Maris opened the journal.

Alias noticed the way she waited before writing.

"Can I?" she asked.

He knew what she meant.

Can I write this down?

Can I make it real?

Can I make it something we return to later?

Alias nodded once.

Maris placed the journal on her knee and waited.

Eldric spoke first.

"If you need to leave," he said, "tell someone."

Maris wrote it down.

Future Alias's expression changed. Only a little.

But Alias saw it.

Corvin added, "Not ask permission for every breath. Just tell someone where you are going and when you expect to return. If you need space, take space. Do not turn space into disappearance."

Maris wrote that too.

Rowan looked at Alias, then at Future Alias.

"If you need to hunt," he said slowly, "tell someone. Or whatever wolves do when they need to do wolf things."

Future Alias's mouth twitched despite himself.

"That is not a bad rule," he said.

"Good. I accidentally made a useful rule. Write it down before it escapes."

Maris did.

Alias stared into the cup.

"If you are afraid of what you might do," he said, "tell someone."

No one interrupted.

He kept his eyes on the water.

"Not because they can fix it. Maybe they cannot. But because if I had told someone before..." His voice failed for a moment. "Maybe I would have known I did not have to wait until I was already scared."

Maris wrote more slowly this time.

Eldric nodded.

"Nobody has to explain everything immediately," he said. "You may need time before you have words. You may be allowed to keep some things private. But silence cannot be the only plan."

Corvin looked at Future Alias.

Future Alias nodded once.

"And nobody disappears alone," Rowan said.

The sentence was simple.

It was the rule they had been trying to make since the night before.

Maris wrote it last.

Then she turned the journal so everyone could see.

The page read:

If you need to leave, tell someone.

If you need to hunt, tell someone.

If you are afraid of what you might do, tell someone.

Nobody has to explain everything immediately.

But nobody disappears alone.

Alias read the words once.

Then again.

They did not make the snow clean.

They did not bring anyone back.

They did not make his hands feel less like his own.

But they made a shape around something that had felt shapeless.

A way to return.

"What about the attackers?" he asked.

The question changed the air.

Corvin looked toward the far end of camp, where three wounded people lay beneath blankets with their hands tied loosely in front of them. The others had fled or fallen in the dark. The survivors had not spoken much since dawn.

"We cannot leave them to freeze," Corvin said.

"No," Eldric agreed.

"And we cannot take them with us like nothing happened," Rowan added.

"No," Eldric said again.

They talked quietly after that. Practical things. The nearest town was two days east, perhaps less if the weather stayed clear. There would be people there who could decide what happened next. The wounded attackers would get food and water. Their weapons would remain out of reach. No one in the group would be left alone near them.

Alias listened, but he did not say much.

When the decision was made, Corvin and Eldric went to speak with the prisoners. Rowan helped carry water. Maris folded the journal closed and set it beside Alias.

Future Alias remained where he was.

For a while, neither Alias spoke.

Then Alias said, "Did you kill people?"

Future Alias's eyes closed.

"Yes."

Alias waited.

"Not always in the same way," Future Alias continued. "Not always for the same reasons. Sometimes defending someone. Sometimes because I was hungry. Sometimes because I was frightened and could not tell the difference between danger and the memory of danger." He looked at Alias. "I am not proud of all of it."

Alias's throat tightened.

"How did you live with it?"

Future Alias looked toward the trees.

"Badly, at first. Alone."

The answer was so honest that Alias did not know how to fight it.

"And later?"

Future Alias glanced toward the others.

"I do not know yet," he said. "Maybe this is later."

Alias followed his gaze.

Maris was speaking to Rowan beside the prisoners. Corvin had one hand on Eldric's shoulder as they walked across the snow. Nobody looked calm. Nobody looked completely safe.

But they were there.

Future Alias looked back at Alias.

"You do not have to decide today what this means about you," he said. "You only have to decide whether you will let us sit beside you while you figure it out."

Alias wanted to say no.

The word sat at the back of his teeth.

Then he looked at the page of rules lying beside his blanket.

Nobody disappears alone.

"Okay," he said.

It was not a grand answer.

Future Alias seemed to understand that it was still an answer.

Later, when the sun had moved high enough to turn the snow bright, the camp began to feel less like a place frozen in one terrible moment.

The attackers had been given food. Their injuries had been checked. The group would leave for the eastern town tomorrow. Today, they would rest, repair what had broken, and learn how to stand in the same clearing without pretending nothing had changed.

Rowan approached Alias with both hands hidden behind his back.

Alias narrowed his eyes.

"That is never a good sign."

"It is a very good sign. I have been preparing."

"For what?"

Rowan looked at Future Alias.

Then back at Alias.

"For a question."

Future Alias sighed.

"Rowan."

"No, this is a respectful question. I have thought about it carefully for at least ten minutes."

He sat down in the snow, but not too close. "Can I see?"

Alias blinked.

"See what?"

"The wolf thing. Properly. Not in the middle of everyone nearly dying."

Silence returned, but it was a different kind this time.

Not the silence of fear.

The silence of waiting.

Rowan rushed on before anyone could speak.

"You can say no. That is fine. Very fine. I will not be offended. I will be deeply disappointed and perhaps become a tragic person, but I will not be offended."

Maris, who had come closer with her journal, gave him a look.

"You will not become tragic."

"I will become mildly tragic."

Alias looked at Future Alias.

Future Alias did not tell him what to do.

He only said, "It is your choice."

That mattered more than Alias expected.

Alias looked around the clearing.

Corvin stood with his arms crossed, watching carefully but not demanding anything. Eldric had a cup of tea in one hand. Maris held her journal closed against her chest. Rowan sat in the snow with the expression of someone trying very hard not to look excited enough to scare a wild animal away.

Alias thought of smoke.

He thought of claws.

He thought of blood.

Then he thought of Future Alias curled around him all night, leaving space instead of trapping him.

"Not here," he said. "A little farther away. Where there is room."

Rowan's face lit up.

"Yes. Good. Sensible. Room is excellent."

They walked to a wide stretch of snow beyond the camp, where the pines opened around a small frozen stream. The ground was clean there. The sky was clearer than it had been all morning.

Alias stood in the middle of the snow.

His heart began to race.

"I do not know how to do it on purpose," he admitted.

Future Alias stepped beside him.

"You do not have to force it," he said. "Think about what it feels like before you run. Not the fear. The part underneath it. The part that hears the snow fall. The part that knows where your feet are before you look."

Alias closed his eyes.

At first, nothing happened.

Then the world sharpened.

He heard Rowan shifting his boots behind him.

He heard Maris turn one page in her journal without realizing she had opened it.

He heard the water beneath the ice.

His body moved before he could decide whether to stop it.

The change was not painless.

But it was not only pain.

It was like stepping into a door that had always been inside him.

His hands became paws against the snow. The cold did not vanish, but it changed. His breath came quicker. Fur lifted along his back. When he opened his eyes again, the world was lower and wider and full of scent.

No one moved.

No one reached for him.

Alias stood in the snow as a grey wolf, smaller than Future Alias but built from the same shape.

Rowan made a noise that was half laugh and half gasp.

"Oh," he whispered.

Alias's ears tipped back.

Future Alias, still human, glanced at him.

"You can speak," he told Rowan. "Just do not rush him."

Rowan nodded so fast his scarf slipped sideways.

"Hello," he said carefully. "You are still you. You are just... significantly more fluffy."

Alias stared at him.

Rowan smiled.

After a moment, Alias's tail moved once.

Maris made a tiny sound and immediately covered her mouth.

"Sorry," she said. "That was not a note. That was just me."

She looked at Alias, then at Future Alias.

"May I write down what I see? Not about how you look. About what you say it feels like."

Alias looked at Future Alias.

Future Alias translated without words, simply lowering himself into the snow nearby.

Alias turned back to Maris and lowered his head once.

"Yes," Maris said quietly. "Only what you say is all right."

Corvin stepped closer, but he stopped several paces away.

"Practical question," he said. "Can you still understand us?"

Alias huffed.

Future Alias smiled slightly.

"That means yes."

"I assumed it might," Corvin said. "But assumptions are not plans. Can you speak?"

Alias tried.

A rough sound came out that was not a word.

Rowan's eyes went wide.
"He said something."
"He made a sound," Corvin corrected.
Future Alias's ears angled forward.
"He said, 'Probably not.'"
Alias stared at him.
Future Alias's expression became almost smug.
"You have an obvious face."
The wolf made another rough noise.
"That one was rude," Future Alias said.
Rowan laughed so suddenly that Alias startled backward.
Then, to everyone's surprise, the wolf gave what might have been the beginning of a playful growl.
It did not sound like the sound from the attack.
It sounded young.
Future Alias watched him carefully.
"Do you want me to shift too?" he asked.
Alias considered.
Then he lowered his head once.
Future Alias stepped away, took off his coat, and changed.
The larger wolf appeared in the snow with a low breath and a shake that sent white powder from his fur. He stood still for a moment, giving Alias space.
Then he lowered himself into a crouch.
Not a threat.
An invitation.
Alias looked at him.
The larger wolf flicked one ear.
Alias took one cautious step forward.
Then another.
Future Alias moved sideways through the snow, slow enough that Alias could stop at any moment.
Alias followed.
At first, it was only walking.
Two wolves crossing clean snow while five people watched from a respectful distance.
Then Future Alias suddenly darted around a pine tree.
Alias froze.

The larger wolf looked back from the other side, tail lifted.

Rowan whispered, "Is he challenging him?"

"He is inviting him to run," Eldric said.

Alias did not move for one long second.

Then he ran.

The world became speed.

Snow flew beneath his paws. The stream flashed silver beside him. Future Alias moved ahead, then beside him, then behind. They did not race to win. They ran because the ground was there and their bodies could do it.

Alias forgot the attack for three breaths.

Then five.

Then long enough to feel the wind in his fur and nothing else.

When they returned, both wolves were breathing hard. Alias's tongue hung out before he remembered that people were watching and tried to look serious again.

Rowan was failing very badly not to smile.

"May I?" he asked.

He held out one hand, palm open, and stayed where he was.

Alias looked at it.

The memory of hands made his muscles tighten.

Future Alias did not move closer. He did not tell him it would be fine.

He waited.

Alias took one step.

Then another.

He sniffed Rowan's hand.

It smelled like smoke, snow, wool, and the strange sweet roll Rowan had eaten for breakfast.

Rowan did not move.

After a moment, Alias pushed his head lightly against Rowan's palm.

Rowan's eyes went bright.

"Hello," he whispered.

His fingers moved once, slowly, behind Alias's ear.

Alias closed his eyes.

It was not magic.

It did not erase anything.

But it did not hurt.

Maris wrote something quickly, then stopped herself and looked at Alias.

"Sorry," she said. "That one can wait."

Corvin crouched down a little farther away.

"Question," he said. "If you need us to stop, how do you tell us?"

Future Alias looked at Alias.

Alias pulled one paw back from the snow and tapped it once against the ground.

Future Alias nodded.

"That works. One tap means stop. Two taps means give space. A low growl means do not come closer."

"Useful," Corvin said. "We should use clear signals."

Eldric lifted the cup in his hand.

"Would either of you like tea?"

Future Alias stared at him.

Alias stared at him.

Rowan made a strangled laugh.

"They are wolves," Corvin said.

"I am aware," Eldric replied. "It was polite to ask."

Future Alias made a sound that could only have been a wolfish version of, no.

Alias copied it.

Eldric nodded solemnly.

"More tea for me, then."

The moment loosened something in the group.

Rowan laughed openly this time. Even Corvin's mouth shifted at one corner. Maris looked down at the page in her journal and smiled before closing it.

Alias looked from one face to another.

They were still afraid.

He could smell it in small ways. Sweat beneath wool. Fast heartbeats that slowed only after a while. The sharpness of people who did not yet know every rule.

But fear was not the only thing there.

There was care.

There was caution.

There was room.

Future Alias stepped beside him, shoulder near Alias's shoulder but not touching.

The smaller wolf looked up at him.

Future Alias looked back.

Then, slowly, he bumped his shoulder against Alias's.

Alias did the same.

Behind them, the camp waited to be repaired. The road waited beyond the trees. The wounded people at the far side of the clearing still needed to be taken somewhere safe. Nothing had become easy.

But when the group walked back toward the fire, no one walked ahead alone. And when Alias crossed the snow, five sets of footsteps and two sets of pawprints moved beside him.

PART IV

THE THINGS PEOPLE LEAVE BEHIND

Chapter 15: The Page That Was Missing

Some things are lost. Some things are taken. Sometimes the difference matters more than anyone is ready to say.

The town did not know what to do with them.

That was fair.

By the time the group reached the eastern road town two days after the attack, the story had become difficult to carry in a single sentence.

There had been armed people in the snow. There had been a fight. Some people were wounded. Some had fled. Some had not survived. There were six travellers with strange coins, stranger keys, and weapons tied together in a bundle because no one trusted anyone to carry them carelessly.

There was also one grey wolf who had walked part of the road beside them, then changed back behind a screen of trees before they reached the first houses.

No single version of the truth would have been simple.

So they told the useful truth.

They had been attacked on the road. There were wounded people who needed care. There were survivors who needed to answer for what they had done. The group had defended themselves. They needed someone local to take over from there.

The town warden was a tired woman with a thick coat, a scar along one cheek, and the expression of someone who had already dealt with three impossible things before breakfast.

She listened without interrupting.

When Corvin finished, she looked at the rescued prisoners beneath the blankets in the back of the wagon. Then she looked at the bundle of weapons. Then she looked at the six travellers standing in the cold street.

"You brought them here instead of leaving them in the snow," she said.

"Yes," Eldric replied.

"You fed them?"

"Yes."

The warden studied him for a moment.

"Then you have done the part of my work that I prefer not to explain twice." She turned toward two guards near the gate. "Get the healer. And find rooms for these travellers before they fall down in the street."

Rowan blinked. "That was easier than I expected."

"Do not say that out loud," Corvin muttered.

The warden heard him.

"It was not easy," she said. "It was only the next thing that needed doing. There is a difference."

Corvin looked surprised.

Eldric's mouth softened at one corner.

The group stayed in the town for two nights.

The first day was full of practical things. Bandages were changed. Torn clothes were washed or mended. Corvin helped the warden make a clear list of what had happened because he could explain details without making them sound like a story people would rather not believe. Maris wrote down the route, the time, the number of people who had attacked, and every piece of information they could remember without turning the page into a courtroom.

Alias did not help with the list.

He sat near the inn's small back window with a blanket around his shoulders and watched snow melt from the roof across the lane.

Future Alias sat across from him, not saying much either.

That was different from before.

Before, silence between them had felt like a wall. One person on each side, both pretending they were not waiting for the other to leave.

Now it felt more like a bench.

Not comfortable exactly.

But shared.

At midday, Rowan brought them both bowls of stew.

He set one in front of Alias. Then one in front of Future Alias.

Then he stood there, holding the empty tray.

"What?" Alias asked.

"Nothing."

"You are doing the thing where you say nothing when you are very clearly doing something."

Rowan looked down at the tray. "I just wanted to make sure you ate."

Alias's first answer rose too quickly.

I can feed myself.

He stopped it before it reached his mouth.

Future Alias noticed. His eyes shifted toward Alias, then away again.

"Thank you," Alias said instead.

Rowan looked relieved enough to make Alias feel guilty for all the times he had made kindness into a difficult task.

"Good," Rowan said. "Because the cook made enough for everyone, and I have been warned that if I return two full bowls, she will assume I dropped them."

"Would that be so unbelievable?" Alias asked.

"Very rude. I only dropped one thing today."

"What was it?" Future Alias asked.

Rowan pointed at the tray. "A spoon. It was a dramatic accident."

Future Alias looked down at his own spoon.

Corvin, passing the table with a stack of folded maps under one arm, stopped walking.

"Do not," he said.

Future Alias looked up. "I did not say anything."

"You were thinking it."

"Can you see thoughts now?"

"Only yours. They are usually standing in the doorway holding a sign."

For a moment, Alias almost smiled.

Then he did.

It was small. It did not fix anything.

But it was there.

* * *

On the second evening, Future Alias asked to leave camp.

They had found a sheltered patch of trees beyond the town walls. The warden had offered them rooms again, but the group had chosen the edge of the woods instead. Not because the inn was unkind. Just because open sky and familiar bedrolls felt easier after too many nights indoors and too many people asking careful questions.

The fire had settled into a quiet orange circle. Maris was copying the day's route notes into the shared journal. Corvin had spread a map across his knees and was trying to decide whether the road west would be less muddy than the road south. Rowan was attempting to toast a piece of bread over the fire without burning it, which seemed to require more concentration than the snowball battle had.

Future Alias stood.

Everyone looked up.

He did not flinch from it.

That, too, was different.

"I need to run," he said.

The words were plain. No excuses hidden inside them. No forgotten object. No badly made lie.

Alias felt his chest tighten anyway.

Future Alias looked at him first.

"Not far," he added. "I will stay north of the stream. I will come back before the moon reaches the broken branch." He pointed to a dark tree beyond the fire. One branch split high above the others like a hand with two fingers raised.

Corvin checked the sky without looking up from the map. "That gives you about an hour."

"Yes."

"If you are late?" Corvin asked.

"Alias wakes you," Future Alias said.

Alias blinked.

Future Alias met his eyes.

"That is what we agreed."

The words should not have mattered so much.

But Alias remembered the old shelter. The way Future Alias had said I need to get something and expected everyone else to accept the space where the truth should have been.

Now there was a route. A time. Someone who would know.

Alias nodded.

"Do you want me to come?" he asked.

Future Alias thought about it.

Then he shook his head. "Not tonight. I think I need to do it alone. But I do not want to disappear."

"That is different," Alias said.

"I know."

Rowan lifted the burnt bread. "Do you want this for wolf food?"

Future Alias stared at it.

"No," he said.

"Fair. It is mostly charcoal now."

Future Alias's mouth twitched.

He stepped behind the nearest line of trees and changed where none of them could see. A moment later, the large grey wolf moved between the trunks, silent except for the soft press of paws into wet snow.

Alias listened until the sound faded.

Then he listened to the stream. To the wind. To the small movements of everyone around the fire.

Maris's pen scratched over paper.

Corvin folded one corner of the map back where it kept curling.

Rowan took one brave bite of the bread and made a face of deep regret.

No one said that it was easy.

No one acted like Future Alias's leaving did not matter.

But nobody followed him into the trees either.

They trusted the promise enough to let it be a promise.

When the moon reached the broken branch, Future Alias returned.

He emerged from the trees in wolf form, fur carrying the smell of cold water and pine needles. He shifted behind the same screen of branches and came back to the fire with his cloak pulled around his shoulders.

"You are back," Rowan said, as though he had only been waiting for someone to return from the market.

"I said I would be."

"Yes," Rowan replied. "That is why I said it normally."

Future Alias sat down.

After a moment, Alias passed him the cup of tea Eldric had poured earlier.

Future Alias looked at it with suspicion.

"It is still tea," Eldric said.

"I know."

"You have looked at it as though it may have changed sides."

Future Alias accepted the cup.

This time, he drank it.

* * *

They left the town the next morning under a sky the colour of unpolished silver.

The snow was thinner now. It clung to shaded ditches and the roots of trees, but the road itself had become a long stretch of mud and dark stone. The world smelled different as winter began to loosen its grip: wet earth, bark, smoke from distant chimneys, water moving beneath ice.

The group did not speak much at first.

They walked in a loose line. Corvin and Eldric checked the map together. Maris kept the shared journal tucked safely inside her coat. Rowan moved between everyone else, talking only when silence became too heavy.

After an hour, he pointed at a crow sitting on a fencepost.

"That bird looks judgmental."

"It is a crow," Corvin said.

"Exactly."

"That is not an explanation."

"It is the entire explanation."

The crow flew away.

Rowan watched it go. "See? It knew I was right."

"It knew you were loud," Maris said.

The others laughed.

Alias was surprised by how normal the sound felt.

Not perfect.

Not careless.

Normal.

By afternoon, the road passed a small cart stuck deep in the mud near a narrow bridge. An older woman stood beside it with both hands on her hips. Two crates of apples had tipped sideways in the back, and one wheel had sunk almost to the axle.

"It was fine five minutes ago," the woman announced before anyone had even offered help.

"Then the road decided it hated honest work."

"Roads do that," Eldric said.

The woman looked at him. "You sound like someone who has lost arguments with roads before."

"Many times."

They helped without making it important.

Corvin checked the wheel and found a stone wedged beneath the axle. Rowan gathered the fallen apples before they rolled into the stream. Maris held the mule's reins and spoke to it in a calm voice. Eldric found two sturdy branches that could work as levers.

Alias and Future Alias looked at the cart.

Then at each other.

"Together?" Alias asked.

Future Alias nodded.

They placed their shoulders beneath the back rail and pushed when Corvin counted.

The wheel lifted with a wet sucking sound.

The cart lurched free.

The older woman grabbed the side before the apples could escape again.

For one second, everyone stood very still.

Then Rowan raised both hands.

"We defeated mud," he said.

"Do not celebrate too loudly," Corvin told him. "It may return."

The woman laughed. She offered them apples as thanks, then stared at the six keys hanging beneath their coats when the wind shifted them into view.

"Travellers?" she asked.

"Something like that," Maris said.

The woman nodded as though that answer made complete sense.

"Then take the west road at the old split," she said. "The southern one has washed out near the mills. West is longer, but it is kinder to wheels."

Corvin thanked her.

They continued on with six apples between them.

Alias bit into one as they walked. It was crisp and sour enough to wake him completely.

Future Alias took his apple more slowly. He turned it once in his hand, studying the small bruise near the stem.

"What?" Alias asked.

"Nothing."

Alias waited.

Future Alias looked ahead.

"I used to think helping people like that was a waste of time," he said at last. "When I was alone."

The words were not proud. They were simply true.

"Because you needed to keep moving?" Alias asked.

"Because I thought stopping meant getting trapped." He took a bite from the apple. "And because it was easier to tell myself I had no responsibility for anyone I did not know."

Alias looked back at the bridge disappearing behind them.

"Did it feel better?"

Future Alias gave a short laugh without humour.

"No. It only felt faster."

They walked a little farther.

Then Alias said, "I liked helping."

Future Alias looked at him.

Alias shrugged. "The mud was terrible. But I liked helping."

"Good," Future Alias said.

There was something in his voice that made Alias glance away.

Not sadness.

Something closer to relief.

* * *

That evening, Maris discovered the missing page.

They had camped beside a stand of birches where the ground was soft enough for tent pegs and dry enough that Rowan did not complain every time he sat down. Corvin had made a small cooking fire behind a ring of stones. Eldric was cutting apples into a pot with oats and spices. The whole camp smelled warm and sharp.

Maris unpacked the shared journal after dinner.

She had made a habit of checking it before bed. Not because she thought someone would steal it. Because the journal had become the closest thing the group had to a map of themselves. Routes. Names. Rules. Stupid sketches of Rowan falling into snow. Important things written in margins before anyone could be brave enough to say them out loud twice.

She opened the leather cover.

Turned one page.

Then another.

Her hands stopped.

"That is strange," she said.

Corvin looked up from the fire. "What is?"

Maris checked the pockets inside the cover. Then the papers tucked beneath the back flap.

"I made a copy of the New Year page," she said. "The promise page. I wanted a loose version in case we needed to write it somewhere else later. It was here."

Rowan leaned over her shoulder. "Maybe it is inside the journal."

"I am looking inside the journal."

"Maybe it is hiding very well."

Maris gave him a look.

Alias felt something unpleasant twist in his stomach before anyone said a word.

The loose page.

A copied page.

A thing that had been there and was now gone.

He knew exactly what everyone remembered about him now.

The routehouse window.

The lock.

The word resourceful.

Corvin's spoon.

Rowan looked at Alias without meaning to. It happened for less than a second, but Alias saw it.

"I did not take it," Alias said.

Silence followed.

Rowan's face changed immediately. "I did not say you did."

"You looked at me."

"I looked at everyone."

"Not the same way."

Corvin set down the spoon he had been using to stir the oats.

"Alias," he began.

"No." Alias stood too quickly. "I know what this looks like. You all already know I can get into locked places. So a page disappears, and now everyone is wondering whether I thought it was useful."

Maris closed the journal carefully.

"I am not wondering that," she said.

Alias laughed once, sharp and empty. "You should be. It would make sense."

"That is not the same thing."

He looked at her.

Maris's expression did not change.

"A thing making sense is not proof," she said. "And I know you said you did not take it."

Alias's anger stumbled.

"You believe me?"

"Yes."

The answer came too fast to be careful.

That made it harder to ignore.

Corvin looked at the journal. "It may have blown loose when we packed this morning. We stopped near the bridge. We stopped at the town. It may be under one of the bedrolls. We should look before we decide it has been stolen at all."

Rowan nodded eagerly. "Yes. It could be in the oat bag. Things vanish into food bags all the time."

"That has never happened," Corvin said.

"It could happen for the first time tonight."

They searched.

They looked beneath blankets and inside packs. They checked the folds of Maris's coat, the map case, the empty apple bag, the space under the cooking pot, even the little pocket where Corvin kept spare string.

The page was not there.

Alias did not help at first.

He stood by the fire with his arms folded too tightly, watching everyone move around the camp.

Future Alias had not said anything.

Not one word.

He sat near the outer edge of the firelight with his hands around his cup. His face gave nothing away, but Alias could hear his heartbeat.

Too fast.

Not frightened exactly.

Guilty.

Alias looked at him.

Future Alias did not look back.

For one strange second, Alias knew.

Not with proof. Not with a clever clue.

Just with the feeling that came when someone else's silence took the shape of an answer.

Then Future Alias lifted his gaze.

Their eyes met.

Alias waited.

Future Alias said nothing.

It hurt more than it should have.

Not because of the page.

Because they had just made rules.

Because Future Alias had said he was trying to learn how not to disappear behind silence.

But Alias did not say anything either.

Maybe he was not ready to make the moment bigger. Maybe he did not want the others to turn toward Future Alias the way they had turned toward him.

Maybe he wanted to be sure.

Maris finally tied the journal shut again.

"It is only a copy," she said quietly. "The original is still here. The promise is still here."

"That does not mean it is fine," Rowan said.

"No," Maris replied. "It does not. But it means we do not need to make a trial out of a missing piece of paper tonight."

Eldric looked from Alias to Future Alias, then back to the dark trees.

"Things can be found," he said. "And truths can be spoken when the person holding them is ready. Neither becomes easier when we force it in the middle of the night."

Future Alias's fingers tightened around his cup.

Corvin looked as though he might object. Then he exhaled through his nose.

"We check again in the morning," he said. "And no one touches the shared journal without telling Maris. That is not an accusation. It is a new practical rule."

"Good," Maris said.

Alias sat down again.

The camp slowly returned to itself, but not completely.

Rowan burned the oats a little because he had forgotten to watch them. Corvin complained. Eldric said burnt oats built character. Maris wrote the new journal rule on a fresh page.

Future Alias stayed quiet.

Alias stayed quiet too.

The missing page sat between them without being there at all.

* * *

The coins changed direction before dawn.

Alias woke to the small sound of metal touching metal.

For a moment, he thought it was someone moving near the fire.

Then he saw pale light shining beneath the edge of his blanket.

His coin was warm against his chest.

Across the camp, the others were waking too.

The six coins had slipped from pockets, pouches, and cords during the night. They lay in the frost between the bedrolls, their faces turned in the same direction.

West.

No one spoke for a while.

Even Rowan seemed to understand that some moments were too strange to improve with a joke.

Corvin pulled the map closer and studied it by the weak blue light of morning.

"West is not the route we expected," he said.

"The coins have never cared what we expected," Maris replied.

Future Alias stood at the edge of camp, looking toward the dark line of hills beyond the trees.

Alias watched him.

"Do you know what is there?" he asked.

Future Alias did not answer at once.

The old road curved west through wet fields and low stone walls. Far away, barely visible through the morning mist, stood the shape of a gatehouse or an old boundary marker. Its roof had fallen in long ago. One side leaned crookedly toward the road.

Future Alias's face had gone pale.

"Not exactly," he said. "But I know the feeling of it."

Alias's hand found the coin at his throat.
The metal was warm.
Warm in a way that felt too much like recognition.
He looked at the broken marker in the distance.
A faded symbol had been carved into its stone. Most of it had been worn away by rain and years, but two lines remained: a small house shape beneath an open gate.
Something moved in Alias's memory.
Not a full picture.
A hand smoothing his hair when he was very small.
A voice saying, wait by the gate.
A road disappearing through rain.
He stopped breathing.
Future Alias looked at him.
"Alias?"
Alias did not take his eyes off the road west.
"I know that mark," he said.
No one asked how.
Eldric came to stand beside him, close enough to be there but not close enough to take away his choice.
"Then we go slowly," he said.
The coins lay in the frost between them, all six pointing toward the same old road.
And for the first time since they had left home, Alias wondered whether the path ahead was not leading them toward a mystery at all.
Maybe it was leading them toward a memory that had been waiting for them to return.

PART IV

THE THINGS PEOPLE LEAVE BEHIND

Chapter 16: A House Without Legends

Not every old house holds a secret. Some only hold the shape of the lives that happened inside them.

The road west did not become brighter because it was important.

It remained wet and cold and full of places where wheels had sunk deep enough to make everyone complain.

The broken gate marker vanished behind them by midday. The little house beneath the open gate had been carved there so long ago that most people travelling the road would never have noticed it. But Alias kept looking back until the mist and the hills swallowed it.

He had not told the others about the full memory.

There was not much to tell.

A hand in his hair.

Rain on stone.

A voice trying to be gentle and failing because it was frightened.

Wait by the gate.

That was all.

It was more than he had had before.

Future Alias walked beside him for most of the morning. Not close enough to crowd him. Not far enough to pretend he was not watching.

Eventually Alias said, "You can ask."

Future Alias looked over. "Ask what?"

"The thing you keep not asking."

For a few steps, Future Alias said nothing.

Then he breathed out through his nose. "Do you remember the house?"

Alias stared at the mud-dark road.

"Not really."

Future Alias nodded once, as if that answer had hurt him but was not unexpected.

"Do you?" Alias asked.

"Pieces."

"Are they useful pieces?"

"No."

Alias glanced at him.

Future Alias gave a small, tired smile. "That is not the same as saying they do not matter."

Ahead of them, Rowan was trying to walk on the low stone wall beside the road. Corvin kept telling him that this was dangerous, which only made Rowan look more committed to proving that it was not.

Maris walked with her journal tucked under one arm, keeping the coins in the other hand where she could watch their pale shine. Eldric was speaking softly to Corvin about the map, though neither of them sounded certain that the map knew more than the coins did.

For a while, the road was only a road.

Then it rose over a hill.

The town below had no walls.

It sat in a shallow valley beside a slow brown river, its roofs dark from rain and age. A narrow market square lay at its centre. Smoke climbed from chimneys in thin grey lines. Beyond the houses stood a row of bare fruit trees, their branches black against the pale afternoon sky.

Alias stopped walking.

The shape of the place reached into him before any clear memory did.

Not recognition exactly.

More like standing outside a room where someone had once called his name.

Future Alias had stopped too.

"Hollowmere," he said quietly.

Maris looked at him. "You know it?"

"I think so."

"That is a terrible answer," Rowan said from the stone wall.

"It is the honest one," Eldric replied.

The coins were warm in all their hands.

They pointed down the hill.

* * *

Hollowmere was not a place built for stories.

It had a baker, a blacksmith, a small market, two narrow streets of homes, and one inn that looked old enough to complain about being repaired. The river had flooded often enough that nearly every building along the lower street had a line of darker stone halfway up its walls.

There were no towers.

There were no guards in polished armour.

There were no strange lights in the windows or old songs waiting for the right traveller to arrive.

There were people carrying baskets, children running too quickly through puddles, and an old man on a ladder trying to fix a gutter before the next rain came.

Alias did not know whether that made him feel better or worse.

The coins led them past the market square and toward the older part of town.

The streets narrowed. The houses leaned closer together. Most had been repaired so many times that their walls were made from different colours of wood and stone. One house had a bright red door. Another had green shutters. A cat sat beneath a cart and watched the group with the serious expression of someone who owned the entire street.

Then the coins stopped pulling.

They did not go cold.

They simply settled.

In front of them stood a small house with boarded windows.

Its roof sagged in the middle. Moss covered the lower stones. A weathered wooden sign beside the door had once held a family name, but rain had scraped the letters almost completely away.

Alias could still see the first one.

A.

His chest tightened.

"Is this it?" Rowan asked.

No one answered.

Future Alias moved toward the door first. He lifted one hand, then stopped before touching it.

Alias walked past him.

The boards across the door had been nailed on years ago. One nail had rusted through. The old lock hung open but useless, as if someone had stopped believing it could keep anything out.

Alias pushed the door.

It did not move.

Corvin stepped closer. "It is swollen from rain. We could force it."

"No," Alias said too quickly.

Everyone went still.

He looked at the door.

"Not yet. I do not want to break it."

Corvin nodded. "Then we ask first."

That sounded so simple that Alias almost laughed.

Instead he nodded back.

They found out who to ask at the market square.

A woman selling onions told them the house had been empty for years. A man repairing boots said it belonged to the town now, though he was not certain. A girl with a basket of apples said she thought it was haunted, but admitted she had never seen a ghost and was mostly repeating what her brother told her.

Finally, the baker pointed them toward the records room above the old meeting hall.

"Ask Lysa," she said. "She knows every building in Hollowmere and half the arguments people had inside them."

The records room was smaller than Alias expected.

It sat above the meeting hall behind a crooked door marked TOWN PAPERS. Shelves covered two walls from floor to ceiling. Boxes were stacked beneath the windows. Loose papers lay in careful piles across a large desk, as if someone had begun sorting them years ago and was still working through the same afternoon.

Behind the desk sat a woman with silver hair tied back in a long braid. She wore a dark green coat and small round spectacles. When the six travellers entered, she looked at their muddy boots first.

Then at the coins.

Then at Alias.

"You are not here for taxes," she said.

"No," Corvin replied.

"Good. Taxes are dull, but at least people expect bad news from them." She folded the page in front of her and stood. "I am Lysa. What can I help you find?"

Alias looked toward the shelves.

The answer was too large to fit inside his mouth.

Future Alias spoke instead.

"A house on Willow Lane," he said. "Boarded windows. A damaged sign. We think it belonged to Alias's family."

Lysa looked from him to Alias. She did not ask why the two of them had the same name.

That was kind.

"How long ago?" she asked.

Alias swallowed. "I do not know."

"Do you remember any names?"

He shook his head.

Lysa did not make a face. She did not sigh. She only nodded once and walked toward the shelves.

"Then we begin with the house," she said.

For the next hour, they searched through old property records.

It was not exciting.

No hidden drawer opened when Alias touched the paper. No glowing mark appeared beside his childhood. The records smelled like dust, ink, and damp wood. Some pages had water stains along the edges. Some had been copied by three different hands because the originals had become too faint to read.

Lysa found the Willow Lane ledger first.

The house had belonged to a family for less than four years.

Before that, it had been a tailor's home. Before that, a storage place. Before that, a different family's home. There was no grand history in it. No old noble line. No secret room beneath the floorboards.

Just a record of people moving in and out, paying what they could, leaving when they could not.

Alias read the entry three times.

The name written beside the house was the same first letter he had seen on the sign.

A.

The rest had been blurred by water.

He pressed his thumb to the edge of the page without meaning to.

"Can it be read?" he asked.

Lysa bent closer.

"Not safely," she said. "I could guess. But guessing at a name is a poor kind of answer."

Future Alias stood very still beside him.

Maris had gone quiet too. Her journal remained closed in her hands.

Lysa opened another book.

This one held rent notes, repair requests, and small complaints the town had kept because someone once believed they might matter.

A roof leak over the back room.

A broken kitchen window.

A request for a lower payment after the river flooded the lower street.

A note from a local healer, asking the town not to remove the family from the house during a winter illness.

Alias stared at that line until the words stopped looking like words.

"Winter illness," Rowan said softly.

Lysa nodded. "There was a fever in the town that year. It took people. It left others weak for a long time."

"Who was ill?" Alias asked.

The paper did not say.

Lysa looked through the page again. "The healer only wrote that someone in the home needed rest and warmth."

Rest and warmth.

Things the group had given each other without thinking.

Things that could become impossible when there was no money, no stable work, and no one willing to help for long.

Alias hated how quickly his mind tried to build a story from that single line.

Maybe one parent had been sick.

Maybe both.

Maybe it had been nothing.

Maybe it had been everything.

"There are more entries," Lysa said.

There were.

A list of small debts at the baker's shop.

A note that one of the adults had taken road work outside town for several weeks.

A request for repairs that had never been completed because the town had no spare wood.

A line from the landlord: PAYMENT PROMISED AFTER NEXT JOURNEY.

Then another, six weeks later: PAYMENT NOT RECEIVED.

Corvin closed his eyes briefly.

Rowan looked angry at the page, as if it had personally chosen to be unfair.

Future Alias did not look at anything.

He was watching Alias.

Alias wished he would stop.

"They were not secret heroes," Alias said.

The room went quiet.

No one had said they were.

That almost made it worse.

"No," Lysa said carefully. "Most people are not."

Alias looked up at her.

She did not speak with pity. That helped a little.

"That does not mean they were nothing," she added. "It only means they were people."

People.

The word landed badly after the snow and the attack and the wolf and all the things Alias had not wanted to think about.

People could be afraid.

People could be hungry.

People could do harm while believing they had no other choice.

People could love someone and still fail them.

He was not ready to say any of that aloud.

Not yet.

* * *

Lysa gave them permission to enter the house before sunset.

"Do not pull apart the walls," she told Corvin.

"I was not going to," Corvin said.

Lysa looked at him over her spectacles.

"You were thinking about it."

Rowan made a small choking sound that might have been a laugh.

Corvin looked offended. "I was considering structural safety."

"Of course you were."

The front door opened after Eldric worked gently at the swollen frame with a flat piece of metal from his pack. He did not force it. He only persuaded the wood to move a little at a time.

When it finally gave way, a cold breath of dust came out.

Alias stood on the threshold.

The house was darker than it should have been. Boards covered the windows, leaving only thin bars of afternoon light across the floor. The air smelled of old rain, damp cloth, and stone.

There was one small room at the front with a fireplace. A kitchen stood behind it. A narrow stair climbed toward the second floor.

That was all.

Alias had imagined something bigger without knowing he had imagined it.

He had imagined rooms full of answers.

There were only rooms.

Rowan stayed near the door.

Maris walked carefully, not touching anything. Corvin checked the floorboards before allowing anyone up the stairs. Eldric opened the shutters one by one, letting grey light into the house.

Future Alias did not move at first.

Then he went to the fireplace.

"I remember this," he said.

Alias looked over.

Future Alias had crouched beside the cold stones. His fingers hovered above a small crack in the hearth.

"I used to put things in there," he said.

"What things?" Rowan asked.

Future Alias thought for a moment. "Buttons. A bent nail. A coin that was not worth anything.
Once, a dead beetle."

Rowan nodded solemnly. "Important treasures."

"At the time."

Alias walked to the fireplace and crouched beside him.

The crack was narrow. Nothing remained inside it except dust.

Still, he could see it.

A smaller hand pushing something precious into darkness because nobody else would
understand why it mattered.

He did not remember doing it.

But he believed it.

The kitchen held almost nothing.

A cracked bowl sat upside down in a cupboard. A rusted hook hung beside the hearth. There
was a shallow mark in the table where someone had cut bread too quickly or too often.

In the back room, Maris found a strip of cloth tied around an old chair leg.

It had once been blue.

Now it was grey with dust.

"Should we leave it?" she asked.

Alias looked at it.

His first thought was that it might have been his.

His second was that it might not.

He did not know which thought hurt more.

"Leave it," he said.

Maris nodded and let the cloth fall back into place.

Upstairs, there were two small rooms.

One had a collapsed corner where rain had entered through the roof. The other was barely
large enough for a bed, a chest, and a chair.

Future Alias stopped in the doorway.

Alias saw his face change.

Not much.

Enough.

"This was mine," Future Alias said.

Alias could not make himself enter.

The room was empty.

No toys. No blankets. No secret journal waiting beneath a floorboard. Only faded scratches near the window where someone had measured height against the wall, each line marked with a tiny crooked dash.

Future Alias moved close enough to see them.

His hand rose.

The highest mark was much lower than his shoulder now.

"I remember being angry because I did not grow fast enough," he said.

Rowan's voice was gentle. "That is a very normal thing to be angry about when you are small."

Future Alias smiled once.

Then the smile disappeared.

Alias walked inside.

The floor creaked beneath him. The window looked out over the bare fruit trees behind the house.

For one sharp second, a memory caught him.

A woman standing by the window with her back turned.

Her shoulders shaking.

A travel bag on the floor.

A voice saying, not today.

Then it was gone.

Alias reached for the wall to steady himself.

Future Alias did not ask what he had seen.

He only moved closer.

Their shoulders touched.

Alias let them.

* * *

They found the important thing by accident.

It was not hidden.

That was almost insulting.

Corvin had been checking the old chest in the small room to make sure it was empty before the floor gave out beneath it. The chest had no lock and no treasure. It held only a torn blanket, a mould-spotted coat, and a folded piece of thick paper stuck beneath the lining.

"There is something here," he said.

Everyone gathered near the doorway.

Alias did not move.

Corvin looked at him first.

"Do you want to see it?"

Alias forced himself to nod.

The paper was too damaged to read all at once. The fold had protected the middle, but the edges had gone soft from damp. It was not a letter. It was a receipt from the town office.

Lysa helped them read it back in the records room.

It listed a small deposit made at the western gatehouse.

One travel chest.

One sealed packet of papers.

One child's winter coat.

The date was only days before the property record stopped mentioning the house.

Below that, in a different hand, was a note:

RETURN EXPECTED. HOLD UNTIL FURTHER NOTICE.

No names survived clearly enough to read.

No explanation came with it.

But the gatehouse symbol at the bottom was the same one carved into the broken marker on the road.

A small house beneath an open gate.

Alias looked down at the page.

His hands had begun to shake.

"They left things there," Maris said quietly.

"Or they planned to," Corvin said. "A receipt does not tell us which."

"It tells us they thought there would be a later," Eldric said.

No one answered him.

Future Alias was staring at the note as if he wanted to climb inside the faded ink and force it to say more.

Alias understood.

A later.

It was not an answer.

It was not forgiveness.

It did not explain why a child had waited by a gate in the rain.

But it was something worse and softer than nothing.

It meant someone might have believed they were coming back.

Lysa closed the paper carefully.

"The western gatehouse still stands," she said. "Not well, but it stands. Old gate records were moved there after the river archive flooded. If the packet survived, that is where it would be listed. If anyone remembers the family, it may be someone who worked the gate back then."

Rowan looked at Alias. "Do we go?"

The question did not sound like a command.

It did not sound like a plan made for him.

It was only a question.

Alias looked through the meeting hall window.

Evening had begun to turn the river black. The bare trees behind the old house shook in the wind. Somewhere across town, a bell rang once for the closing market.

He thought of the house.

The cracked bowl.

The roof leak.

The scratches on the wall.

The line from the healer asking for warmth.

The receipt that said RETURN EXPECTED.

He did not know his parents.

Not really.

He knew a few pieces of two frightened people who had tried to keep going when they were already falling apart.

He knew that they might have loved him.

He knew that love had not been enough to keep him from standing alone.

He did not know what to do with either truth.

But the road had brought him this far.

And five people were waiting for his choice without taking it from him.

"Yes," Alias said.

Future Alias looked at him.

Alias folded his shaking hands together.

"We go to the gate."

Outside, the six coins rested warm against six different chests.

For once, none of them had to point the way.

PART IV

THE THINGS PEOPLE LEAVE BEHIND

Chapter 17: The Gate Where I Waited

Some answers arrive too late to heal the waiting. They are still answers.

The western gatehouse had not been built to welcome anyone.

It had been built to make people stop.

The road narrowed as it left Hollowmere and rose between low, rain-dark hills. On one side, the river followed them at a distance, brown and swollen from winter. On the other, bare trees crowded the slope, their branches scraping together whenever the wind moved through them.

No one spoke much.

Alias walked near the front, though he did not feel as if he had chosen that place. The gatehouse was somewhere ahead. Every time the road turned, part of him expected to see it.

Every time it did not appear, his stomach tightened again.

Future Alias stayed beside him.

Not close enough to touch.

Close enough that Alias could feel the choice in it.

Behind them, Rowan had been quiet for almost half an hour. That was long enough that Corvin finally looked over his shoulder.

"Are you ill?" Corvin asked.

"No," Rowan said.

"Then why are you not talking?"

"I am trying to be respectful."

Maris glanced up from the small map Lysa had copied for them. "You are allowed to speak quietly."

"That sounds dangerous. I might do it wrong."

Eldric gave a small smile. "Then you will learn."

Rowan thought about this with the seriousness of someone considering a difficult new skill.

Alias almost smiled.

The smile did not stay, but it had been there.

The gatehouse came into view near midday.

It stood where the old road passed between two stone pillars, one on either side of the track. The pillars had once held a wide wooden gate. Only the iron hinges remained now, black with rust and tilted toward empty air.

The house beside them was small and square, built from river stone. Its roof had been repaired so many times that no two rows of shingles matched. One shutter hung crooked. A faded lantern still swung above the door.

For a place that had been waiting in Alias's memory for years, it looked painfully ordinary.

A woman stood outside with a broom in one hand and a thick scarf wrapped around her neck. She had grey hair tucked under a knitted cap and the broad, tired shoulders of someone who had carried too many boxes in her life.

She looked at the six travellers as they approached.

Then she looked at Alias.

"Lysa said you might come," she said.

Her voice was not soft exactly. It was careful.

Eldric stepped forward. "You are the keeper here?"

"Keeper sounds grander than the job is." She rested both hands on the broom. "Mira Venn. I keep the old records dry, the roof mostly above us, and strangers from falling through the loose floorboards. Come in before the weather decides you look comfortable."

Rowan looked at the sky. "It does look angry."

"It is winter," Mira replied. "Winter has little else to do."

Inside, the gatehouse smelled of paper, smoke, and damp stone.

A small fire burned in the hearth. Shelves covered the walls from floor to ceiling, crowded with ledgers, bundles of letters, tin boxes, and rolled maps tied with string. A narrow desk stood beneath the window. On it sat a kettle, three chipped cups, and a stack of records so tall that it looked like it might be holding the ceiling up.

Mira set the broom beside the door.

"Lysa told me about the receipt," she said. "Travel chest. Sealed packet. Child's winter coat. Western gate deposit, many years ago."

Alias could not answer.

Future Alias did.

"Do you remember it?"

Mira looked at him for a moment. Her eyes moved from Future Alias to Alias and back again.

Like Lysa, she did not ask why they looked so alike.

"I remember parts," she said. "I was young then. I had been sent here to help my uncle for the season because he said I had neat handwriting and no sense of how cold a gatehouse could become."

Rowan leaned a little closer to Maris. "That is a strange job interview."

Maris did not look away from Mira. "Quietly."

Mira's mouth lifted at one corner.

Then she became serious again.

"I remember the rain," she said. "Everyone remembers the rain from that week. The river climbed the lower street in Hollowmere. Two bridges south of here were damaged. The road east became mud deep enough to lose a cart wheel."

Alias heard the words, but they did not settle.

Rain.

A road.

A hand in his hair.

Wait by the gate.

Mira walked to the shelves and pulled down a narrow ledger bound in peeling brown leather. She carried it to the table in the centre of the room and laid it down carefully.

"My uncle kept records because he believed every person on a road should leave some kind of mark," she said. "Not a grand mark. Just enough that someone could be found, if finding them became important."

Corvin pulled out a chair for Alias.

Alias did not sit at first.

Then his legs decided for him.

The chair creaked beneath his weight.

Future Alias took the seat beside him. The others stayed close, but not so close that the table felt crowded.

Mira opened the ledger.

The pages had been repaired with thin strips of cloth. Water had blurred some of the ink. Other entries remained sharp enough to read: wagon permits, food stores, names of travellers who had stayed one night because a storm had blocked the road.

She turned page after page.

Alias watched her finger move down lines written by people who had been dead for years.

Then Mira stopped.

The entry was small.

Too small.

Alias had expected something huge. A page full of explanation. A secret written only for him. Instead there were only a few lines in faded ink.

Mira read aloud slowly.

"Late evening. Two adults and one child arrived from the east road. Child feverish, underdressed, awake but exhausted. Parents requested warmth and watch until morning patrol. Deposit taken for coat, food, and packet storage. Parents stated they would return before second bell if the south crossing reopened."

No one moved.

Mira kept reading.

"Child left in the care of gatekeeper until return. Name recorded poorly due rain damage.

Family mark: open gate over small house."

There was a space below it.

Then one final line in different handwriting.

"Parents did not return before second bell. Child transferred safely with morning patrol after three days, per standing shelter rule. Packet and chest retained."

Alias stared at the page.

Three days.

The number filled the room.

Three days at a gatehouse he could barely remember.

Three days looking at the road.

Three days waiting for a shape to appear through rain.

His hands had become cold.

"What happened after that?" he asked.

His voice sounded too young.

Mira closed her eyes for a moment.

"I do not know," she said. "The south crossing never reopened that week. A landslide took part of the road. People were missing. Some came back days later. Some did not. The old reports are not kind enough to give clean answers."

Future Alias's chair scraped against the floor.

"They could have returned," he said.

Mira looked at him.

"They could have tried."

"That is not what I asked."

The sharpness in his voice made Rowan look down.

Mira did not flinch.

"No," she said. "It is not. And I cannot tell you they did. I can only tell you what was written and what I remember."

Future Alias looked away.

His jaw was tight.

Alias knew that feeling. It was the feeling of wanting an answer so badly that every incomplete thing felt like someone had chosen to hurt you.

Mira stood and crossed to a locked cupboard beside the hearth. She took a ring of keys from her belt, sorted through them, and opened the smallest drawer.

Inside was a flat wooden box.

The box had a black line painted across its lid, almost worn away by time.

"The packet was never collected," Mira said. "Neither was the chest. The chest did not survive the flood in the lower storage room. The packet did."

Alias could not breathe for a moment.

Mira brought the box to the table but did not open it.

"It belongs to you now," she said. "But you do not have to look today."

The words should have been comforting.

Instead they made the box feel heavier.

Alias stared at it.

"Did you see them?" he asked.

Mira's hand remained on the lid.

"Your parents?"

He nodded.

Mira's face changed. Not into pity. Something older than pity.

"Yes," she said. "For a few minutes."

Future Alias turned back toward her.

Mira looked down at the box as she spoke.

"They were soaked through. The woman held you. The man kept looking toward the south road. He had mud to his knees and blood on one hand. Not much. Enough that I noticed."

Alias gripped the edge of the table.

"Were they fighting?" he asked.

"No."

The answer came quickly.

Mira swallowed.

"They were frightened. There is a difference. They kept trying to speak at the same time. The woman asked if we had a blanket. The man asked whether the bridge could be crossed. Then she told him to stop asking questions nobody could answer. He told her he was trying. She said she knew."

Mira's voice became softer.

"They both looked at you every few seconds, even when they were speaking to someone else."

Alias did not know what to do with that.

It did not fix the road.

It did not bring them back.

It did not make three days of waiting disappear.

But it made the memory of the hand in his hair feel less like something he had invented because he wanted it to be true.

"Why did they leave me?" he asked.

No one answered at once.

Mira looked at the old ledger.

"I think they believed this was safer than taking you back into the storm," she said carefully. "They told my uncle they would return after they found a way through the south crossing. They left money for a coat and food. They left the packet. They asked him to keep the lamp lit near the window, because you were afraid of the dark."

Alias's throat closed.

The lamp.

There had been a light.

In the memory, he had always thought it was rain on glass. A pale, shaking thing near the window.

Now he could see it differently.

A lantern.

Someone keeping it lit.

"That was all I knew," Mira said. "Until today."

Future Alias's fingers had curled into a fist on the table.

"No," he said quietly. "That was not all."

Everyone looked at him.

His voice shook once before he forced it steady.

"They left. That is also true. They made a choice, and he waited for them. Whatever they thought would happen after, he still waited."

Mira nodded.

"Yes," she said. "That is also true."

The room stayed silent.

The storm outside pressed rain against the shutters.

Alias looked at the box.

For years, he had imagined a hundred versions of this moment.

In some, his parents had been monsters, because monsters at least made sense. In others, they had been heroes trapped by some grand secret, because heroes gave him someone to forgive without feeling foolish.

The truth was smaller.

Two frightened people had stood in this room. They had been cold. They had been desperate.

They had chosen a gatehouse with a warm fire and a keeper and a lamp.

Then they had walked away.

Maybe they meant to come back.

Maybe the road took that choice from them.
Maybe they made more choices afterward that no one would ever understand.
He was still the child who had waited.
Nothing inside the box could change that.
"Can I open it?" Alias asked.
Mira stepped back.
"Of course."
His fingers trembled against the lid.
Future Alias did not reach for him.
He only stayed beside him.
Alias lifted the box open.
Inside lay a folded packet wrapped in oilcloth, a small brass button, and a strip of blue fabric faded almost grey. The fabric had once been part of a child's coat. It was too small for him now.
Under it lay a single sheet of paper.
The ink was blurred at the edges, but the middle had survived.
Alias did not read it aloud.
He could not.
The note was not long.
It was written in a rushed hand.
Please keep him warm. We will return as soon as we can. Tell him we are finding the road home.
There was no name at the bottom that he could read.
There was only a smudged mark like an open gate above a small house.
Alias stared at the words until they stopped looking like words.
Tell him we are finding the road home.
A laugh tried to come out of him and became something else.
He put a hand over his mouth.
Maris looked away to give him privacy even while staying near enough to be there.
Rowan had tears in his eyes and was pretending very badly that he did not.
Corvin stood with both hands braced against the back of an empty chair. His face had gone hard, not at Alias, but at the unfairness of a world that could leave a child with a note and call it enough.
Eldric was watching Alias with the patient, sorrowful attention of someone who knew there was no correct thing to say.
Future Alias looked at the note once.
Then he stood so quickly that his chair fell backward.

"I need air," he said.

No one stopped him.

The door opened. Cold rain rushed in. Then it shut again.

Alias kept looking at the note.

The words did not comfort him.

They hurt too much to be comfort.

But they were not nothing.

That might have been the worst part.

* * *

Future Alias stood beneath the empty gate.

Rain darkened his hair and soaked the shoulders of his coat. He did not seem to notice.

The old iron hinges hung beside him, useless now. Beyond them, the road vanished south
through a curtain of grey.

Alias found him there after a while.

He did not bring the note.

He had folded it carefully and left it inside the box with the blue cloth and brass button. Mira
had offered to keep it safe until they decided what to do. Alias had not known whether he
wanted it near him or far away.

So he had said, "Not yet."

Mira had understood.

Future Alias did not turn when Alias came to stand beside him.

"You were right," Alias said.

Future Alias's laugh had no humour in it.

"That is not usually good news."

"They left."

"Yes."

"They were scared too."

Future Alias looked at the road.

"Yes."

Alias kicked lightly at a small stone near his boot.

"I wanted it to be simple."

"So did I."

The rain ticked against the old gatehouse roof.

After a moment, Future Alias said, "For years, I wanted proof they did not care. I thought that would make the rest of it easier. If they had been cruel, then I could hate them without feeling guilty. I could stop wondering whether I had been difficult to keep."

Alias said nothing.

Future Alias continued.

"Then sometimes I wanted proof they loved us. I thought that would fix something too."

"Did it?" Alias asked.

Future Alias looked at him then.

His eyes were tired.

"No."

The answer was simple.

It hurt because it was true.

Alias looked through the empty gate.

"Maybe they did love us," he said.

Future Alias nodded once.

"Maybe."

"And maybe they still failed us."

Future Alias's breath caught.

For a second, Alias thought he had said too much.

Then Future Alias looked down.

"Yes," he said. "Maybe both things are true."

Neither of them spoke after that.

They stood in the rain, side by side, looking down the road their parents had taken.

It was not a road that gave anything back.

It was only a road.

But Alias was not waiting beside it alone anymore.

When the cold finally became too sharp to ignore, Eldric opened the gatehouse door and called from inside.

"There is tea."

Rowan's voice followed him. "And dry bread. It is not very good, but that means it will match the mood."

Corvin said something that sounded like a complaint about bread being unable to match a mood.

Maris laughed quietly.

Alias looked at Future Alias.

"Come inside," he said.

Future Alias hesitated.

Then he nodded.

They walked back through the open gate together.

PART IV

THE THINGS PEOPLE LEAVE BEHIND

Chapter 18: What Love Could Not Fix

Truth does not always close a wound. Sometimes it only teaches you how to carry it honestly.

The rain stopped after midnight.

It did not become quiet.

Water still dripped from the gatehouse roof in slow, stubborn taps. Wind moved through the empty hinges outside and made them creak against the stone pillars. Somewhere down the road, the river kept carrying winter water south, brown and cold and too full to look at for long.

Alias lay awake beneath a borrowed blanket in the small room Mira had given him.

The room had one narrow bed, one chair, and a window with warped glass. The packet from the wooden box rested on the chair beside him. He had placed it there because he did not know where else to put it.

Too close, and it felt like it was watching him.

Too far, and he felt like he was abandoning it.

The note was folded inside the oilcloth again.

Please keep him warm. We will return as soon as we can. Tell him we are finding the road home.

He had read it enough times that the words no longer looked like handwriting. They looked like a door that had been opened only a finger-width.

Not enough to enter.

Not enough to close.

A soft knock came at the door.

Alias did not answer at first.

The knock did not come again.

Instead, Future Alias's voice said quietly from the other side, "I can go away."

Alias sat up.

For a moment, he almost said yes.

Not because he wanted Future Alias gone. Because saying yes would have been easier than admitting that he did not know what he wanted at all.

"Come in," he said.

The door opened carefully.

Future Alias stepped inside without bringing a lamp. Pale moonlight and the little fire from the hall gave him enough light to move by. His hair was still damp from the rain. He had changed out of his wet coat, but there was a dark patch at one shoulder where the water had soaked through anyway.

He stood near the door.

"You should sleep," Alias said.

"So should you."

"That was not an answer."

"Neither was yours."

Alias looked down at the packet.

Future Alias followed his eyes.

Neither of them spoke for a while.

Then Future Alias crossed the room and sat on the floor beside the chair. Not too close to the packet. Not far away from it either.

"I kept thinking the next thing would explain it," he said.

Alias frowned. "What next thing?"

"Anything." Future Alias rested his arms on his knees. "A note. A person who remembered. A house with some hidden room. I thought if we found the right piece, then all the other pieces would suddenly fit together. I thought I would know whether they cared. Whether they were cruel. Whether I had done something wrong."

Alias's throat tightened.

"Did you?" he asked.

Future Alias stared at the floorboards.

"No."

The word was quiet.

It still sounded heavy.

"We found something," Alias said.

"We did."

"They thought the gatehouse was safer."

"Yes."

"They wanted to come back."

"Maybe."

Alias's fingers curled in the blanket.

"You do not believe it."

Future Alias looked at him.

"I believe they wrote it," he said. "I believe they asked someone to keep us warm. I believe they left money for food and a coat. I believe Mira remembers them looking at us."

He paused.

"I do not know what happened after they walked out through that gate. And I do not know if knowing would change what it felt like to wait."

Alias looked at the warped window.

Outside, the moon had come out behind thin clouds. The gatehouse lantern hung near the empty road, turned low now but still burning.

"I remember the lamp," he said.

Future Alias did not speak.

"Not properly. Just... light. By the window. I thought it was rain." Alias swallowed. "It was someone keeping it lit because I was afraid of the dark."

"Yes," Future Alias said.

Alias laughed once, though there was no humour in it.

"That sounds like it should make me happy."

"It does not have to."

"It makes it worse."

Future Alias nodded.

"I know."

That was the strange thing about him. He did know.

Not everything. Not exactly. But he knew the shape of wanting a person to be either entirely good or entirely terrible because anything in between asked too much from your heart.

Alias picked up the packet.

The oilcloth was stiff with age. He did not open it.

"They can have loved us," he said slowly, "and still have failed us."

Future Alias went very still.

Alias had said the words earlier, under the gate. They had felt true then.

Saying them again made them feel real.

"They can have been frightened," he continued. "They can have tried. They can have meant to come back. And they still left us there."

"Yes," Future Alias whispered.

"Both things can be true."

Future Alias lowered his head.

For a while, Alias thought he might be crying. Then he saw that Future Alias was only breathing too carefully, as though grief was something with sharp edges that could cut him if he moved wrong.

"I did not know how to let both things be true," Future Alias said. "So I kept choosing one."

Alias waited.

"When I needed someone to blame, I made them monsters. When I needed a reason to forgive myself, I made them heroes. And every time I did that, I made them responsible for everything that happened after."

"They were not?"

Future Alias gave a tired, crooked smile.

"They were responsible for some of it. They were responsible for leaving a child at a gatehouse. They were responsible for not coming back, whether they could not or would not. But I used them as the answer to every road I took later."

His fingers pressed against the floor.

"I told myself I ran because they left. I stopped asking for help because they left. I stopped trusting people because they left. I thought it meant I had no choice but to become someone who did not need anyone."

Alias looked at him.

"But you did have choices."

"Yes."

The answer came without defence.

"Not easy choices," Future Alias added. "Not fair choices. But they were mine. Some were terrible. Some hurt people. Some hurt me. I cannot keep handing every one of them back to two people who might not even be alive to answer for them."

Alias held the packet tighter.

"That sounds like you are blaming yourself."

"I am trying not to." Future Alias looked down at his hands. "There is a difference between saying something was your choice and saying you deserved to be alone because of it. I am still learning that difference."

Alias did not know what to say to that.

So he said the truest thing he had.

"Me too."

Future Alias looked at him again.

For a moment, they were not past and future. Not warning and mistake. They were only two versions of someone sitting awake in a cold gatehouse, trying to understand why being loved did not always feel like being kept safe.

A floorboard creaked in the hall.

Then another.

The door opened a little, and Rowan's face appeared in the gap.

He looked from Alias to Future Alias to the packet.

"I had a feeling nobody was sleeping," he said.

"You had a feeling because you were not sleeping," Corvin said from somewhere behind him.

"That is still a feeling."

Maris stepped into view carrying a small tray with two cups and a third cup balanced in the middle. Eldric followed with a teapot in one hand and the expression of a man who had expected to find them awake.

"We can leave," Maris said at once. "We only thought you might want company."

Alias looked at the open door.

The others did not look afraid of the packet.

They did not look like they were waiting for him to become easier before they stayed.

"Stay," he said.

Rowan entered first and sat cross-legged at the end of the bed. Corvin took the chair only after moving the packet carefully onto the small table. Maris settled beside the window. Eldric poured tea into the cups.

Nobody tried to make the room cheerful.

That helped more than cheerful words would have.

Corvin gave Alias a cup.

"It is not an answer," he said.

Alias looked at him.

"The tea," Corvin clarified. "Eldric's tea is not an answer. Before anyone says it, I know that."

Rowan sniffed his own cup. "It is an answer to being cold, though."

"That is what I meant."

Eldric's mouth twitched.

Alias wrapped both hands around the cup. The warmth touched his fingers slowly.

Maris looked at the packet on the table.

"You do not have to decide what it means tonight," she said.

Alias stared at the oilcloth.

"What if I never know?"

The question came out smaller than he meant it to.

Maris did not rush to answer.

"Then you will not know," she said. "But not knowing is not the same as having nothing."

Alias thought about the note. The blue cloth. The brass button. Mira remembering his parents looking at him.

Nothing had been repaired.

But nothing was not the right word anymore either.

Rowan leaned his shoulder lightly against the bedframe.

"My father used to say people can love you and still be terrible at things," he said.

Corvin raised an eyebrow. "That is a surprisingly useful thing for your father to say."

"He also said never trust soup that has stopped steaming. So it was a mixed set of lessons."

A small laugh escaped Alias before he could stop it.

Rowan looked pleased but did not point it out.

"He meant," Rowan continued more quietly, "someone can care about you and still not know how to take care of you. It is not a good excuse. It just means people can fail in more than one direction."

Alias looked at the cup in his hands.

"I do not forgive them."

"You do not have to," Eldric said.

"I do not know if I hate them either."

"You do not have to decide that tonight," Eldric repeated.

Future Alias's eyes stayed on the packet.

"Or ever," he said.

Everyone looked at him.

He took a breath.

"We talk as though forgiveness is a door someone must walk through before they can leave a place behind. It is not. Sometimes you carry the place with you. Sometimes you build around it. Sometimes you come back years later and find the door has changed shape."

Eldric watched him for a long moment.

Then he nodded.

"That is well said."

Future Alias looked almost embarrassed.

"I have had too much time to think badly. A few useful thoughts were bound to happen by accident."

"A tragic waste of time," Rowan agreed.

This time even Future Alias smiled.

The smile did not last long.

It did not need to.

They stayed in the room until the fire in the hall burned low.

No one forced Alias to tell them more. No one asked to read the note again. They spoke about small things instead: whether the roof would survive another storm, whether Mira's records were organised by year or by who had the least tidy handwriting, whether the bread Rowan had criticised earlier had become worse because it had been reheated.

The ordinary conversation moved around the wound without pretending it was not there.

At some point, Alias leaned against the wall and felt his eyes close.
Before sleep took him, he heard Eldric say quietly to Future Alias, "You do not have to solve this for him."

Future Alias answered just as quietly.

"I know."

Then, after a pause:

"I am trying to learn how to stay anyway."

* * *

Morning came pale and clear.

The storm had passed east during the night. Frost silvered the grass beside the road. The empty gate stood black against a sky that had no rain left in it.

Mira made porridge for all of them and complained that the gatehouse stove had never respected a recipe in its life. Rowan offered to fix it. Corvin told him that repairing a stove and setting a stove on fire were different tasks.

"I know that," Rowan said.

"Do you?"

"I know it now."

Alias sat near the hearth with the wooden box beside him.

He had put the note, the button, and the strip of cloth back inside. He had not hidden them at the bottom of his pack. He had not left them in the gatehouse either.

He did not know what he would do with them.

For now, he would carry them.

Mira came over while the others gathered their things.

"The box has been waiting a long time," she said. "You do not owe it a perfect ending."

Alias looked up.

"I do not know if I can give it any ending."

Mira nodded.

"Then give it a place in the middle. Most things live there anyway."

It was not advice that solved anything.

It was only a way of making room for the unsolved thing.

Alias liked it more than he expected to.

"Thank you," he said.

Mira touched two fingers to the edge of the box.

"You were warm here," she said. "That is not enough. But it is true."

Alias looked toward the gate.

The lamp hung by the window, unlit in the morning.
He pictured a smaller version of himself sitting near it, waiting for people who did not come back.

For years, he had imagined that child alone because he had felt alone.
Now he knew there had been a keeper. A blanket. A coat. A lamp left burning. A morning patrol that took him somewhere safer when the waiting had gone on too long.

It did not undo the waiting.
But it meant the child had not been invisible.

Outside, the others were ready.
Corvin had checked the packs twice. Maris held the map under one arm. Rowan had managed to find a thin stick and was using it as a walking staff, despite everyone reminding him that there was no reason for it. Eldric stood near the road with the six keys hanging quietly beneath his coat.

Future Alias waited beside the gate.
He did not ask whether Alias was ready.
He only stood there.
Alias walked out to join him.
The coins in the small pouch at his belt shifted once.
Not pulling. Not demanding.
Just reminding him that roads still existed.

Future Alias looked toward the south road, then back toward the others.

"I thought coming here would make everything clearer," he said.

"Did it?" Alias asked.

Future Alias thought about it.

"A little," he said. "Not in the way I wanted."

Alias nodded.

"That seems to happen a lot."

"It does."

They stood beneath the empty gate for one last moment.
Then Alias adjusted the strap of his pack. The wooden box made a small, solid weight against his side.

"I do not forgive them," he said.

Future Alias did not flinch.

"You do not have to."

"I might never forgive them."

"You still do not have to."

Alias looked up at the pale sky.

"But I do not want to spend the rest of my life waiting for an answer they cannot give me."

Future Alias's face changed.

Not into happiness exactly.

Into recognition.

"That is enough for today," he said.

Alias nodded.

It was.

They left the gatehouse together.

Not healed.

Not finished.

Not carrying closure.

Only truth, grief, a small wooden box, and five people walking beside them.

For now, it was enough to keep going.

PART IV

THE THINGS PEOPLE LEAVE BEHIND

Chapter 19: A Day With Nothing to Solve

Not every good day changes your life. Some simply remind you that life is still there.

Morning came slowly to the gatehouse.

The rain had moved on in the night, leaving the road dark and shining beyond the empty arch. Water rested in the wagon ruts like strips of dull glass. The river had dropped a little, though it still sounded swollen somewhere below the slope.

For the first time since they arrived, Alias woke without reaching for an answer.

He reached for his coat instead.

The oilcloth packet lay folded inside the inner pocket where he had put it before sleeping. It was still too close. It was still not close enough. But he could carry it now without feeling as though it was the only thing in the room.

That was not peace.

It was only morning.

For now, that was enough.

Downstairs, the small gatehouse kitchen smelled of oats, smoke, and the sharp green scent of herbs Mira had thrown into a pot. Rowan had found the wooden spoon before anyone else and was attempting to stir everything at once with the seriousness of a captain steering a ship through a storm.

"It is breakfast," Corvin said from the table. "Not a siege."

"You have never cooked for a siege, then."

"Neither have you."

"That is why I am practising."

Maris sat beside the window with her journal open, copying the gatehouse record in smaller writing. She looked up when Alias entered.

"Did you sleep?" she asked.

"Some."

"That is more than none."

Alias nodded and sat down beside her.

Future Alias was already at the table. He had a mug between both hands and was staring into it as though tea might eventually tell him what to do next.

When he noticed Alias looking at him, he gave a small, questioning look.

Alias only shrugged.

He did not know what to say.

Neither of them seemed upset by that.

Mira came in from the back room with a cloth bundle under one arm. Her white hair had escaped its braid again. She set the bundle near Corvin's elbow and looked around the kitchen until her eyes found Alias.

"Road food," she said. "Bread, dried apples, cheese, and enough onion to make the whole pack complain."

"Rowan complains about onion even when there is no onion," Eldric said.

"That is because I have instincts," Rowan replied.

"Your instincts are frightened of vegetables."

"A sensible instinct."

Mira smiled, but it faded gently when she looked at Alias.

"You are leaving today?"

Alias glanced toward the others. The coins rested on the table beside Corvin's map. They had been quiet all morning. The compass pointed southeast with such stubborn certainty that even Corvin had stopped turning it around to check.

"I think so," Alias said. "We still have a road."

"Everyone does." Mira pulled out the chair across from him, though she did not sit. "Most people just do not notice until it starts asking things from them."

Rowan stopped stirring.

"That is the kind of sentence that should be written down," he announced.

Maris was already writing.

Mira laughed softly. Then she looked at Alias again.

"You do not owe this place forgiveness," she said. "And you do not owe your parents a story that makes their choices easier to carry."

Alias's fingers tightened around the edge of the table.

"But?" he asked.

"But you are allowed to remember that someone kept a lamp on for you." Her eyes moved toward the small window above the door. "That part was true too."

Alias swallowed.

"Thank you," he said.

Mira reached across the table and squeezed his hand once.

"Go carefully, then. And return only when you want to. Not because you think you are meant to."

* * *

They left just before midday.

The gatehouse stood behind them for a long time, small against the wet hill and the pale break in the clouds. Mira remained beneath the arch until the road bent south and hid her from view.

Alias looked back once.

Then he faced forward.

The day did not become dramatic because they had found a painful truth. The road was muddy. Rowan's left boot made a wet sucking sound every third step. Corvin told him to stop dragging it. Rowan told Corvin to stop listening to his boots.

Maris walked between them, writing when the ground was flat enough and tucking the journal away whenever she needed both hands.

Eldric hummed under his breath.

Future Alias walked near the rear of the group, where he could see all of them without making it obvious that he was doing so.

Alias noticed anyway.

He did not point it out.

By the time they reached the first dry rise, the rain had turned into a fine mist. The land around them was all low stone walls, bare hedges, and fields sleeping under winter grass. A few black birds lifted from a fence and argued loudly with one another before vanishing into the sky.

The compass needle stayed pointed southeast.

The coins did nothing at all.

"This is strange," Rowan said after a while.

"What is?" Maris asked.

"Nothing."

Corvin looked at him. "Nothing is strange?"

"No, I mean nothing is happening. The coins are not glowing. Paper has not insulted us in at least an hour. No one has found a cursed door or an old man who knows too much."

From inside Alias's satchel, Paper gave a faint rustle.

A sentence appeared across its pale surface.

****I AM RESTING. TRY IT.****

Rowan looked offended.

"See? Even the paper is being normal."

"It called you incapable of rest," Corvin said.

"Normal for it."

They stopped at a broken stone marker where the road divided in two. One path dipped through the fields toward a cluster of distant chimneys. The other climbed along a line of fir trees and disappeared into the grey slope above.

Corvin unfolded the map across a flat section of wall.

"The lower road goes through Pella," he said. "There will be a smith there if we need supplies. The upper road is shorter, but it turns rough after the ridge."

"What does the compass say?" Rowan asked.

Alias held it out.

The needle pointed between the roads.

Then it turned once, very slowly, and settled toward the lower path.

"Pella," Maris said.

"A town with a smith," Corvin added. "That sounds almost reasonable."

"Do not say it too loudly," Rowan warned. "The road will hear."

Future Alias had been looking up toward the fir ridge. The mist made the trees look farther away than they were.

Alias knew that look now.

It was not fear exactly.

It was the part of Future Alias that measured distance before he admitted he wanted it.

"I could run ahead," Future Alias said. "See whether the road is clear."

No one answered immediately.

It was not because they thought the offer was bad. It was because they all knew what it could mean.

Future Alias seemed to realise it too. His gaze dropped to the compass.

"Not because I need to leave," he said quickly. "I only meant it would be useful."

Alias stepped closer. "We do not need a scout today."

Future Alias waited.

"We can just walk," Alias said.

For a second, the older version of him looked almost embarrassed. Then he nodded.

"All right," he said.

They took the lower road together.

* * *

Pella turned out to be smaller than it looked from the hill.

It had one square, one bakery, a smithy with a crooked sign, and a narrow row of houses pressed against a shallow stream. Smoke rose from almost every chimney. Someone had tied coloured scraps of cloth to the bridge railing, though the winter wind had worn most of them into pale knots.

The first thing Rowan noticed was the bakery.

The second thing he noticed was a cart blocking the middle of the street.

One wheel had sunk deep into a rut beside the bridge. A woman in a blue wool coat stood beside it with both hands planted on her hips. A boy of about eight sat in the driver's seat looking very close to tears. The cart was loaded with sacks of grain, two crates of jars, and a cage containing three hens that seemed personally offended by the entire situation.

A thin mule stood in front of the cart and stared at the sky as if it had decided none of this was its fault.

"We should help," Eldric said.

"We should buy bread first," Rowan said.

Eldric looked at him.

"We should help, and then reward ourselves for our good deed with bread."

"Better."

The woman noticed them approaching and immediately raised a hand.

"Do not push from that side," she called. "The wheel is cracked. If it goes, the cart goes with it."

Corvin was already crouching near the rut.

"How long has it been stuck?" he asked.

"Since the first delivery cart came through this morning and chewed the road apart." The woman gestured toward the far end of the street. "My brother was meant to meet me, but his little one got sick. I have to get this to the mill before dark."

The boy looked guilty.

"I am not little," he muttered.

"Of course you are not," the woman said at once, softer.

Corvin examined the wheel. "The rim is split, but it can hold if we take the weight off first. We need boards. Rope. And people who can follow instructions."

Rowan raised his hand.

Corvin looked at him.

"People who can mostly follow instructions," he corrected.

The woman gave a tired laugh.

"There are boards behind the smithy," she said. "I am Lysa. This is my nephew, Tern."

"Rowan," Rowan said, pointing at himself. "That is Corvin, who is about to become very bossy. Maris writes everything down, Eldric makes tea somehow even when there is no tea, and those are Alias and Future Alias."

Tern looked between the two Aliases.

"Why do they have the same name?"

Rowan opened his mouth.

Maris gently put a hand over it.

"Long road," she said.

Tern accepted that answer more easily than most adults would have.

The next half hour became work.

Corvin directed everyone with increasing intensity. Alias and Future Alias carried boards from behind the smithy. Eldric found rope in a stable yard and spoke to the mule until it stopped leaning backward into the harness. Maris held the grain sacks steady while Lysa climbed into the cart to loosen the crate straps.

Rowan was sent to buy wedges from the smith.

He returned with wedges, a small hammer, two sweet rolls, and the face of someone who believed he had achieved efficiency.

"The rolls were essential," he said before anyone could speak.

"To the cart?" Corvin asked.

"To morale."

"That is almost true," Eldric said.

Future Alias slid beneath the raised edge of the cart to brace one of the boards. Mud streaked his coat and darkened his hair near his temple. Corvin told him to move two fingers to the left.

He did. Corvin told him to hold. He held.

It was all very ordinary.

That was what made Alias notice it.

Future Alias was not watching the nearest exit.

He was not counting the people in the square.

He was not measuring the road beyond the bridge.

He was looking at the cracked wheel and waiting for Corvin to tell him what came next.

"Ready," Corvin called.

Alias and Eldric pulled the rope. Lysa urged the mule forward. Rowan, Maris, and Tern pushed from the safe side of the cart, while Corvin shouted directions no one could fully hear over the protesting hens.

The wheel lifted once.

Slipped.

Then climbed free of the rut with a wet sucking sound.

The cart rolled forward half a length and stopped on solid stone.

For one quiet second, everyone stared at it.

Then Tern jumped down from the driver's seat and threw both arms into the air.

"We did it!"

The hens screamed as if they had been the ones doing the work.

Lysa laughed so hard she had to lean against the cart.

"You did," she said. Then she looked at the group, one by one. "You all did."

She tried to press coins into Corvin's hand.

He shook his head.

"We were going this way anyway."

"That is not a payment."

"No," Corvin agreed. "It is not."

Lysa looked as though she wanted to argue. Then she looked toward the bakery.

"At least let me buy you food."

Rowan became very still.

Eldric coughed into his hand to hide a smile.

"That would be rude to refuse," Rowan said.

"It would be extremely rude," Alias agreed.

So they ate warm bread, goat cheese, and apple cakes at the long table in the bakery's back room while Lysa told them which roads would flood first if the weather turned again. Tern showed Maris a picture he had drawn of the trapped cart, though in his version the hens were as large as horses and Corvin had a hammer the size of a tree.

"That is not accurate," Corvin said.

Tern looked offended.

Maris leaned over the drawing. "I think it is emotionally accurate."

Corvin looked at the huge hammer again.

"I do not know what that means."

"It means," Rowan said, already reaching for a second apple cake, "that you look very important."

Future Alias laughed.

It was not a careful smile. It was not the kind that appeared because someone else had made a joke and he knew he was supposed to react.

It surprised him so much that he stopped halfway through it.

Alias saw the moment he noticed himself.

He did not say anything.

He only smiled too.

* * *

They left Pella near sunset with their packs heavier by a loaf of bread and a small packet of salt Lysa had insisted they take.

The road beyond the town followed the stream for a while. The sky had cleared enough for a strip of gold to show beneath the clouds. Light caught in the ice along the bank and made it look as if the water had swallowed pieces of glass.

The coins stirred once in Alias's pocket.

Not a pull. Not a warning.

Only a small, warm tremble.

He took them out.

Their faces were still dull. But the compass needle had stopped pointing southeast. It now pointed along the stream toward a low hill where the dark shape of an old roadside shelter stood against the evening sky.

"There," Corvin said. "That will do for the night."

"No strange door?" Rowan asked.

"No strange door," Corvin said.

"No ancient tower?"

"No."

"No haunted spoon?"

"Why would there be a haunted spoon?"

Rowan looked offended by the question.

"You are the one who keeps losing spoons," Future Alias said.

Everyone looked at him.

Future Alias looked back.

Then, very slowly, he smiled.

"I have learned to return them," he added.

Rowan narrowed his eyes. "Have you?"

"Mostly."

The shelter had three walls, a roof that needed arguing with, and an old stone hearth full of ash. It was not comfortable, but it was dry enough after Eldric coaxed a small fire to life.

They made soup from oats, onion, the last of the herbs Mira had given them, and a handful of dried beans Corvin had forgotten were at the bottom of one pack.

Rowan cut bread.

Maris mended the tear in his glove while he kept moving his hand away to reach for food.

"Stop," she said for the fourth time.

"I am helping."

"You are being stitched. Those are different things."

Alias sat near the doorway with his coat around his shoulders, watching steam rise from the pot. The packet in his inner pocket was still there. He could feel it whenever he moved.

He did not need to take it out.

He did not need to decide what it meant tonight.

Across the fire, Future Alias had opened his personal journal.

He wrote for a while in the flickering light. His face was too thoughtful for someone simply recording the road.

Then he closed it.

Alias waited.

Future Alias looked toward the dark outside the shelter. Beyond the doorway, the fir trees on the hill stood black against the stars. The night was wide. It would have been easy to leave. Easy to say he needed to run, needed air, needed to listen to the woods.

His shoulders shifted once.

Then he pulled his blanket closer around himself and stayed where he was.

Alias did not make a big thing of it.

He only said, "What did you write?"

Future Alias looked down at the journal.

"Nothing important."

"That is never true when someone says it like that."

Future Alias's mouth turned upward a little.

"I wrote that we helped a woman named Lysa get a cart out of mud. Rowan bought two sweet rolls while supposed to be buying wedges. Corvin frightened a wheel into working."

"I did not frighten it," Corvin said from the other side of the fire.

"The wheel disagrees," Rowan said.

Future Alias looked at Alias again.

"And I wrote that I stayed."

The shelter grew quiet.

Not uncomfortable.

Just honest.

Alias nodded.

"I noticed," he said.

Future Alias waited for more.

Alias stirred the soup once with a wooden spoon.

"But I was not counting."

Something in Future Alias's expression changed.

It was small. Almost nothing.

Maybe that was why it mattered.

Eldric reached for the bowls.

"Good," he said. "Then we can eat before Rowan declares the soup a personal enemy."

"It smells suspiciously healthy," Rowan said.

"It has onion in it," Corvin told him.

"Then I was right to be suspicious."

They ate until the pot was empty.

They argued about whether the roadside shelter had once been a chapel, a toll stop, or a very badly designed house. Maris recorded the day in the shared journal. Corvin fixed the loose strap on Alias's pack. Eldric wrapped the remaining bread in cloth. Rowan fell asleep before he had finished insisting that he was not tired.

Paper lay beside the fire, its page blank for a long while.

At last, dark letters appeared.

****THIS WAS A PERFECTLY ACCEPTABLE DAY.****

Alias read them twice.

Then he lay down beneath his blanket and listened to the sounds of his friends settling around the dying fire.

No doors opened.

No riddles demanded answers.

No old road asked them to choose anything before morning.

Outside, the stream went on moving through the dark.

Inside, nobody disappeared.

PART V

THE PERSON BEHIND THE STAGE

Chapter 20: A Guide Written by M

A lantern cannot walk the road for you. It can only make the next step easier to see.

The coins woke before anyone else did.

Alias knew because Paper was tapping against the inside of his satchel.

Not loudly. Paper did not need to be loud when it wanted attention. A sharp little rustle against leather was enough to pull him out of sleep.

For a moment, he stayed beneath his blanket and listened to the roadside shelter around him.

Rain ticked softly from the broken edge of the roof. The fire had burned down to a dull bed of red ash. Rowan was snoring with the confidence of someone who had never once considered that other people might be trying to sleep. Corvin had fallen asleep sitting against the wall with his map rolled under one arm. Maris lay curled near the hearth, one hand still resting on the shared journal. Eldric was awake already, though his eyes were closed.

Future Alias was not in his blanket.

Alias sat up too quickly.

The space on the other side of the fire was empty. The blanket had been folded. Future Alias's personal journal was gone from beside it.

Paper tapped again.

Alias reached into his satchel. The pale page slid free before he had fully opened the flap.

Across it, in dark narrow letters, were three words.

HE IS OUTSIDE.

Alias exhaled slowly.

Of course he was.

He pulled on his boots, wrapped his coat around himself, and slipped through the doorway.

The morning was blue-grey and cold. Mist sat low over the stream. The hill beyond the shelter had disappeared behind it, leaving only the dark tops of fir trees showing through like marks made by a careless brush.

Future Alias stood beside the road with his hands in his pockets.

He had not gone far. He was close enough that Alias could still see the shelter behind him. Close enough that the others would find him immediately if they looked.

That mattered.

Alias walked up beside him.

"Could not sleep?" he asked.

Future Alias glanced over. "I slept. A little."

"That is not the same answer."

"No." He looked back toward the road. "I woke up before everyone. I wanted air."

Alias waited.

Future Alias did not say that he had told anyone. Because no one else was awake when he left. But he had stayed close. He had left his blanket folded, his journal gone, his tracks plain in the wet ground.

It was not perfect.

It was different.

The coins were in Alias's pocket, warm against his hand. He drew them out. Six dull pieces of metal rested in his palm. For the first time since Pella, all six had turned the same way.

Toward the misty slope.

Future Alias noticed.

"They are moving again," he said.

"Yes."

The compass had come out with the coins. Its needle shook once, then pointed toward the same hill.

Future Alias stared at it without touching it.

"Do you know this place?" Alias asked.

"Not exactly." He frowned. "I know the feeling of it. That is not useful."

"It can be useful later."

Future Alias gave him a brief look. "You have become very patient."

"No, I have become tired of people acting like knowing less than they want to know is a personal failure."

Future Alias's mouth moved like he wanted to smile but was not sure he had earned it.

Behind them, Rowan's voice rose from inside the shelter.

"Who stole the blanket?"

"No one stole your blanket," Corvin said.

"Then why is it on the floor?"

"Because you kicked it there."

"That sounds like something a blanket thief would say."

Future Alias looked at the road again.

Then he said, "I came outside. I should have told someone."

Alias nodded. "You are telling me now."

"That does not make it right."

"No. But it makes it easier to do better next time."

For a few seconds, neither of them spoke.

Then Future Alias reached into the pocket of his coat and pulled out a slim red thread. It was tied around one finger, faded slightly from weather and use.

The one from camp.

He looked at it for only a moment before tucking it away again.

"We should wake them," he said.

Alias watched him turn back toward the shelter.

He had not run.

Not this time.

* * *

Breakfast was oats, cold bread, and the last of the weak tea.

Rowan called it a crime against mornings. Corvin called it food. Eldric called it proof that they should all be grateful none of them had been asked to cook for the whole road alone.

Paper lay on the ground beside the fire, holding a small line of writing that had appeared while they packed.

UP THE HILL. DO NOT TAKE THE PRETTY PATH.

Rowan read it over Maris's shoulder.

"How does paper know which path is pretty?"

Paper answered before anyone else could.

I HAVE EYES.

"Where?" Rowan asked.

Paper remained blank.

"That was not helpful," Rowan said.

CORRECT.

The hill had two paths once they reached its base. The first curved through the fir trees, wide enough for an old wagon and covered in a clean layer of pale needles. It climbed gently and disappeared into a bright patch of mist where the morning sun had begun to break through.

The second was narrow, stony, and mostly hidden beneath wet grass. It cut sharply between two low walls of rock and looked like it had been abandoned by every sensible person in the world.

Rowan pointed at the first path.

"That is the pretty one," he said.

The coins pulled toward the second.

"Of course they do," he sighed.

Corvin checked the map twice. "There should be an old signal house above this ridge. It was marked as a shelter decades ago. Maybe before that it was a route station."

"A route station for what?" Maris asked.

"No idea. The map is too old."

Eldric adjusted the strap on his pack. "Then we will see whether the station is still there."

They climbed.

The ugly path did not become prettier as it rose. It narrowed until they had to walk in a line. Loose stones rolled under their boots. Wet branches caught at sleeves and hair. Rowan complained for the first ten minutes, then stopped only because he was too busy trying not to slide backward.

Corvin walked ahead with the map. Maris followed him, sometimes looking down at the old lines of ink and sometimes looking up at the real hill as if she expected them to agree eventually.

They did not.

At the first bend, the map showed a dry wall on the left. There was no wall.

At the second, it showed a fork leading west. The fork was there, but the western path ended after three steps at a drop into mist.

At the third, the path they were standing on was not on the map at all.

Corvin stopped.

"That is impossible," he said.

Rowan leaned past him. "Maybe the map is wrong."

"It is a map."

"Maps can be wrong."

"Not like this."

Future Alias had gone still at the back of the group.

Alias looked toward him. "What?"

Future Alias stared at the ground near their feet. "The stones were different a moment ago."

Rowan looked down. "They are stones."

"The cracked one was on the left," Future Alias said. "Now it is on the right."

Nobody answered immediately.

Then Maris crouched beside the path.

There was a small flat stone near her boot, split down the middle by a pale line. One side of it was worn smooth. The other was rough and dark.

"Was this the one?" she asked.

Future Alias nodded once.

Maris stood slowly. "Then the road is moving."

Rowan crossed his arms. "Roads should not move."

"They do if enough mud is involved," Corvin said.

"Not helpfully," Rowan said.

Paper slid from Alias's satchel and fluttered open in the wind. New writing appeared, larger than before.

THE ROAD IS NOT LOST.

Then, beneath it:

YOU ARE EXPECTING IT TO STAY STILL FOR YOU.

Eldric read the words.

"That sounds familiar," he said.

Future Alias looked at Paper sharply. "It does."

Alias turned to him. "From where?"

Future Alias was quiet for a moment.

"The Tower," he said. "Not those exact words. But... the way it says things. Like someone is trying to make a point while pretending they are not."

Rowan pointed at Paper. "It is very bad at pretending."

Paper wrote:

YOU ARE VERY BAD AT WALKING.

"I am walking up a mountain," Rowan said. "That is advanced walking."

Eldric smiled despite himself. Then his expression became thoughtful.

"A road that changes around people is not necessarily trying to trap them," he said. "Perhaps it is asking us to pay attention."

"It could ask with signs," Corvin muttered.

"It did," Maris said, tapping Paper lightly. "We ignored the first one because the path looked unpleasant."

"The path is unpleasant," Rowan said.

"That does not make it wrong."

The wind moved through the fir trees above them. Somewhere in the mist, water dripped steadily from a branch.

Alias took out the compass.

The needle did not point straight ahead. It pointed toward the edge of the path, where the grass gave way to a strip of black rock.

He walked there, careful of the drop beyond it.

At first, he saw nothing.

Then the mist shifted.

A narrow iron post stood half-hidden in the grass. It was no taller than his knee. Rust covered most of it, but someone had scratched a symbol into the top: a small lantern above a line that bent twice before continuing forward.

Below it were three letters.

M.

Maris breathed in.

"That is not a place name," she said.

"No," Future Alias said quietly.

He stepped closer but did not touch the post.

The six coins warmed at once.

A faint sound came from beneath the rock. Not a voice. Not quite. More like metal tapping against metal.

Alias knelt and ran his fingers along the edge of the stone.

There was a hollow below it.

"Rowan," he said.

"I am not climbing into a hole."

"I need you to move the rock."

Rowan brightened at once. "That I can do."

With Corvin directing where to place his hands and Eldric making certain nobody lost a foot over the slope, Rowan shifted the flat black stone aside.

Under it was a small iron box.

The lid had no lock.

Only a hand-painted sentence, faded almost white.

FOR THE TRAVELLER WHO FOUND THIS WITHOUT BREAKING IT.

Rowan looked at Future Alias.

"That feels aimed at you."

"It is not," Future Alias said.

"It feels aimed at both of you," Corvin added.

Alias opened the box before either of them could answer.

Inside lay a book wrapped in oiled cloth.

It was not old in the grand, magical way he had expected. It had no glowing cover. No hidden keyhole. No title written in gold.

The cover was brown leather, scuffed at the corners and repaired with rough black thread.

Someone had written on the first page in ordinary dark ink.

A SMALL GUIDE TO ROADS THAT DO NOT KEEP STILL

Below that, in smaller letters:

For anyone who has gotten a little lost.

And beneath the title was one name.

M.

For a long moment, nobody spoke.

Then Rowan said, "That is it?"

Maris took the book carefully from Alias's hands.

"It is a guide," she said.

"I know what it says. I expected something more..." Rowan moved his hands in the air.

"Mysterious."

Paper wrote across itself.

YOUR EXPECTATIONS ARE A HEAVY BAG. PUT THEM DOWN SOMETIMES.

"You are enjoying this," Rowan accused.

YES.

* * *

The signal house stood another quarter hour above the iron post.

It was little more than a square room of grey stone with one narrow window facing the valley. Moss covered half the roof. A broken lantern hook hung over the door. Yet the door opened when Eldric pushed it, and the inside was dry.

There was even an old table beneath the window.

"A perfect place to read a book that insults us," Rowan said.

"The book has not insulted you," Maris said.

"It is working with the paper."

Corvin lit the small stove in the corner while Maris set the guide on the table. The others gathered around it, shoulders nearly touching because the room was not large enough for distance.

The first pages were practical.

Maris read aloud.

"Before you begin: bring food, water, a spare needle, dry socks, and someone who is willing to tell you when you are being foolish."

Rowan looked around the room.

"We have several of those."

"Yes," Corvin said. "That is why we are alive."

Maris turned the page.

"Do not enter a strange road alone unless you have made a firm decision to make the road stranger."

Eldric nodded once. "Good advice."

Future Alias's eyes had not left the words.

Alias watched him. "You did, though."

Future Alias did not pretend not to understand.

"Yes," he said. "I did."

No one rushed to fill the silence.

Then Maris continued reading.

The guide was not written like a prophecy. It did not say what was waiting at the end of the road. It did not mention chosen people or hidden destiny. It spoke about wet boots, missed turns, broken bridges, and the way fear could make a traveller see an open door as a trap.

There were sketches in the margins: a lantern, a bridge, a fox with an arrow pointing away from it, a hand holding a cup of tea.

In one corner, M had written:

If you are tired, rest before you decide the whole road is hopeless.

In another:

A road can show you a choice. It cannot make it for you. Do not demand that it does.

Corvin leaned closer.

"That explains the map," he said.

"Does it?" Rowan asked.

"Not fully. But look." Corvin pointed to a paragraph near the middle. "'The roads that change are most difficult for travellers who need them to be predictable. They are not tests of intelligence. They are places where unfinished choices gather.'"

Maris read the next line silently, then said it aloud.

"'They become worse when a person enters them alone, refuses help, or asks the road to decide what only they can decide.'"

The room went still.

Future Alias stared at the table.

Alias understood why.

The Tower. The path. The impossible wish to go home. The years of walking alone because it seemed safer than asking anyone to stay.

Eldric rested one hand on the guide.

"M did not make the road," he said. "Not in the way we feared."

"How do you know?" Corvin asked.

"Because this is not a set of commands." Eldric turned one of the pages gently. "It is advice from someone who has been worried about travellers before. Someone who has seen what happens when they mistake being alone for being strong."

"That could still be someone powerful," Rowan said.

"Perhaps." Eldric smiled faintly. "But power does not make a person less ordinary. Look at this."

He pointed to a smudged line near the bottom of a page.

Never trust a bridge that has more birds than planks.

Rowan read it.

"That is excellent advice."

"It is also something a person writes after falling through a bridge," Eldric said.

For the first time, Future Alias smiled without looking away.

"M fell through a bridge," he said.

"Probably," Maris agreed.

Paper, who had been blank for several pages, wrote slowly.

M COMPLAINED ABOUT IT FOR THREE DAYS.

Everyone looked at Paper.

The page seemed to realise what it had written.

For a second, nothing happened.

Then the words blurred and vanished.

Rowan leaned close.

"Did it just remember?"

Paper wrote nothing.

Alias touched the edge of the page, not hard enough to bend it.

"You knew M?" he asked.

The paper stayed blank.

Future Alias spoke softly.

"Maybe it does not know how to answer yet."

Alias looked at him.

Future Alias's hand rested near his personal journal. His fingers were curled, not quite touching it.

He knew what it was like to have a truth pressing against the inside of you with no safe way to let it out.

Alias nodded and drew his hand back.

"All right," he said. "Not yet."

Paper's next words appeared much smaller.

THANK YOU.

* * *

They read until the light outside the narrow window turned pale gold.

Near the back of the guide, the writing changed. The ink was darker. Less rushed. There was a map folded into the binding, its corners cracked from being opened too many times.

It showed several small circles connected by uneven lines.

At the centre was a symbol they all recognised now: a lantern above a bent road.

Around it, six marks formed a rough ring.

Not keys.

Not exactly.

But six places.

Maris spread the map flat on the table.

"These are Structures," she said.

Corvin studied the shape of the lines. "Smaller ones. Look. This one is marked as a room. This one looks like a bridge. And this..."

He tapped a circle northwest of their current location.

"A house?"

Eldric read the note beside it.

"The House of Returning. Enter only if you are willing to leave it differently."

Rowan stared at the words.

"That is much more mysterious."

"You wanted a mysterious guide," Maris reminded him.

"I wanted it in the beginning. Now I have to care about it. That is different."

Alias looked down at the six coins in his palm.

They had grown warmer as the map opened.

The compass needle swung once, then settled northwest.

Toward the mark called the House of Returning.

Future Alias looked at it for a long time.

"I do not know what it is," he said.

"That is all right," Alias replied.

Future Alias looked up.

"It might be something from my path. Something I missed."

"Then we will not let you miss it alone."

The words came out simply. Alias had not planned them.

They filled the small room anyway.

Rowan looked at the map, then at the empty doorway. "How far?"

Corvin checked the scale. "Two days, if the roads behave."

Paper wrote:

THE ROADS WILL BEHAVE ACCORDING TO THEIR OWN DEFINITION OF BEHAVING.

"That means no," Rowan said.

"It means we should leave early," Corvin said.

Eldric closed the guide carefully and tied the oiled cloth around it again.

"Then tomorrow," he said, "we follow the next direction."

Maris looked at the book on the table.

"M was not waiting at the end of the road to judge us," she said. "M was leaving lamps behind."

No one made a joke for a moment.

Then Rowan pointed to the guide.

"We are taking it, right?"

"Of course," Corvin said.

"Good. I want to read the bridge part."

"Why?"

"To know how many birds are too many."

The others laughed.

Even Future Alias.

Outside, mist moved slowly across the ridge. The road below had changed at least three times that day. It would probably change again before morning.

But inside the old signal house, there was a guide on the table, a light in the stove, and six people close enough to hear one another breathe.

For now, that was direction enough.

PART V

THE PERSON BEHIND THE STAGE

Chapter 21: Rooms Made for Returning

A door can offer a choice. It cannot make it for you.

The House of Returning did not look like a house at first.

For most of the second day, it looked like nothing more than a grey shape between winter trees.

The road north of the signal house had been narrow, wet, and determined to make Corvin unhappy. It climbed through bare hills where old snow still held in the shadows, then dropped into a valley filled with thorn bushes and dark pine. The compass kept pointing ahead. The coins stayed warm in Alias's pocket, never hot enough to hurt, but never cool enough to forget.

By late afternoon, the sky had become the colour of unwashed wool.

"There," Maris said.

Everyone stopped.

At the far end of the valley stood a building with a steep roof and one crooked chimney. It leaned slightly to the left, as though a strong wind had tried to move it years ago and failed.

There was no fence. No smoke. No path that Alias could see.

Just the house.

Rowan stared at it for a long moment.

"That is much less impressive than I expected," he said.

"You expected a castle?" Corvin asked.

"Maybe a tower. Towers at least know how to look mysterious. That looks like it needs repairs."

Eldric watched the building quietly.

"Some things look ordinary until you are close enough to notice they are not," he said.

Future Alias had gone very still.

Alias looked at him. "Do you recognise it?"

"No," Future Alias said after a moment. "Not exactly."

That was not the same as no.

Nobody said so.

They crossed the valley together.

The nearer they came, the more Alias noticed small details that did not fit. The windows were dark, but they reflected a bright blue sky instead of the clouds above them. The chimney

had no smoke, yet the air around it smelled faintly of woodsmoke and tea. A line of wet footprints led from the road to the front door.

They were not their footprints.

They stopped at the bottom step.

Then the footprints ended.

Rowan leaned forward. "Did someone walk inside?"

Corvin crouched beside the prints. "Possibly. But they are old. And new."

Rowan blinked. "That is not how footprints work."

"I know."

The front door was painted a faded dark green. There was no lock. Above the handle, someone had carved a small lantern into the wood.

Eldric reached for it, then paused.

"We enter together," he said.

Future Alias's fingers brushed his journal.

Alias took one of the coins from his pocket. The little disc warmed at once, as though it had been waiting to be seen.

"Together," he agreed.

Eldric opened the door.

* * *

The first room was a kitchen.

It was a small kitchen, with a narrow table, a cold iron stove, three cupboards, and a window looking out over a garden buried under snow.

Alias stepped inside first.

The air was warm.

Not fire-warm. Not summer-warm. It felt like the warmth of a room someone had left only minutes ago. The kind of warmth that held the memory of people.

Rowan looked around carefully.

"I hate that it is normal," he said.

"You hate everything when it is normal," Corvin said.

"No. I hate things when they are pretending to be normal."

Maris moved to the table. Six bowls sat there in a neat row.

They were empty.

One had a chip near the rim. One was painted with a blue line. One had a small crack repaired with dark thread. The others were plain.

There were six chairs too.

But when Alias counted them again, there were seven.
The seventh chair stood in the corner, slightly turned away from the table.
He looked at it for too long.

Future Alias noticed.

"Do not sit there," he said quietly.

Alias turned. "Why?"

Future Alias did not answer at once. His eyes stayed on the empty chair.

"I do not know," he admitted. "It feels like someone is supposed to come back to it."

The Paper slid out of Alias's coat pocket by itself.

It landed on the table with a soft slap.

Letters appeared.

THE HOUSE DOES NOT LIKE BEING RUSHED.

Rowan leaned in. "That is somehow the least helpful thing it could have said."

More letters appeared.

YOU ARE WELCOME.

Maris placed one finger near the edge of the Paper, not touching the words. "Does it know this place?"

The Paper remained blank for several breaths.

Then:

I KNOW OF IT.

"That is a very careful answer," Corvin said.

YES.

Eldric stood by the doorway, studying the room without moving farther inside.

"This is a Structure," he said.

No one argued.

They had seen enough strange roads and impossible buildings to recognise the feeling of a place holding more than its walls should be able to hold.

But this did not feel like the Tower.

The Tower had been large, cold, and full of questions that seemed to wait in the dark.

The House of Returning felt smaller than it should have been. Quieter too. It felt as if it had learned to make itself ordinary on purpose.

Maris opened her journal. "M's guide said Structures gather around unfinished choices."

"It said many things gather around unfinished choices," Corvin corrected. "Not that the Structures make them."

"Right." Maris looked at the room again. "So this house did not create someone leaving an empty chair. It found that feeling. Or... made a place for it."

Future Alias looked toward the seventh chair.

"A place for someone who keeps waiting," he said.

The room went quiet.

Alias thought of the gatehouse. Three days beneath a lamp. A bed that had been made for him. A chair he had not been allowed to use because he was too small to reach it.

He swallowed and looked away.

Eldric spoke gently. "We do not have to solve every room we find."

"Then why are we here?" Rowan asked.

Eldric considered that.

"Perhaps to understand that they exist."

The front door shut behind them.

Not loudly.

Just enough for everyone to hear it.

Rowan jumped anyway.

"I understand it exists," he said. "Can we understand it from outside now?"

The Paper wrote:

NO.

"Rude," Rowan said.

* * *

The kitchen had two doors besides the one they entered through.

The left door opened onto a narrow hallway lined with framed pictures. The right door opened onto a sitting room with a faded red rug and a fire already burning in the grate.

Corvin stared at the fire.

"There was no wood in the stove," he said.

"There is wood there," Rowan replied, pointing at the grate.

"That is not the point."

"It is a very fire-shaped point."

Eldric raised one hand. "Slowly."

They chose the hallway first.

The pictures were all landscapes.

A bridge at dawn. A field in summer. A street beneath falling snow. A road disappearing between trees. None showed people. Yet each image felt as though someone had just stepped outside the frame.

At the end of the hall was a small room with one desk and a single sealed letter resting in the centre.

The letter had no name on it.

No address.

No mark at all.

Only a blank envelope waiting beneath a brass paperweight.

Maris stopped in the doorway.

"Oh," she whispered.

Alias looked at her. "What?"

"It is for things you never said."

No one touched the envelope.

It was not theirs.

Or perhaps it was everyone's.

Future Alias stepped closer, then stopped before his boots crossed the threshold.

The Paper slipped from the pocket again.

DO NOT WRITE THINGS HERE JUST TO MAKE THEM DISAPPEAR.

Future Alias's jaw tightened.

Alias saw it.

"What happens if someone does?" he asked.

THE HOUSE KEEPS THE LETTER. THE PERSON DOES NOT LOSE THE FEELING.

Maris nodded slowly.

"So it is not a place to get rid of grief," she said.

NO.

"Then what is it for?" Rowan asked.

The Paper stayed blank.

Rowan crossed his arms. "You know, refusing to answer is still an answer."

After a long pause, new words appeared.

IT IS FOR SEEING WHAT YOU HAVE BEEN CARRYING.

No one made a joke.

Alias looked at the unmarked envelope again.

He wondered what he would write if he could write anything at all.

He wondered who it would be for.

Then he thought of his parents. He thought of the gatehouse records. He thought of the unfinished phrase inside the damaged letter: We will...

His throat tightened.

He stepped back from the room.

Future Alias did the same.

Neither asked the other why.

* * *

The next room was stranger.

They found it behind a door that should have led to the back garden.

Instead, it opened onto a platform high above a dark river.

A narrow wooden bridge crossed the water. It vanished into mist on the other side. The rails were old but solid. Lanterns hung from posts along the way, though none of them were lit.

There was no wall behind them now.

When Alias looked back, the house was gone.

Only the doorway remained, hanging in empty air above the river.

Rowan took one careful step backward.

"That is not a garden."

"No," Corvin said. His voice had become very quiet. "It is not."

The wind below smelled of rain and stone.

At the beginning of the bridge stood a wooden sign.

On it, in worn white letters, were the words:

YOU MAY CROSS. YOU MAY TURN BACK. YOU MAY REST HERE.

Nothing else.

Maris read it twice.

"It does not say what is across," she said.

"That is because it depends on who crosses," Eldric said.

"You are guessing," Rowan said.

"Yes."

"Good. Just checking."

Future Alias stood at the edge of the platform, staring at the bridge as if he had walked it before.

Alias went beside him.

"Do you remember?"

Future Alias shook his head.

"Not this bridge. But..." He stopped. "I remember wanting to cross something once because I thought the other side would have the answer. I remember being sure I could not come back if I did."

Alias did not ask what had been on the other side.

The bridge creaked softly in the wind.

The coins in his pocket warmed, but they did not pull him forward.

That mattered.

He could feel it.

The Structure was not dragging them. It was not demanding that someone walk over the river. It was not even trying to make the choice for them.

It had only put the choice where they could see it.

Eldric noticed Alias looking at the sign.

"Sometimes seeing that you may turn back is enough," he said.

Future Alias let out a breath.

"I did not think I could," he said.

Eldric's expression softened. "I know."

For a while, none of them moved.

Then Rowan sat down on the wooden platform beside the doorway.

"I choose resting here," he announced. "That is one of the options."

Corvin stared at him.

"You are making a serious moment difficult."

"I am making it survivable. There is a difference."

Maris smiled despite herself and sat beside him.

After a moment, Corvin did too.

Eldric sat last, leaning his back against the doorframe.

Alias looked at Future Alias.

Future Alias looked at the bridge one more time.

Then he sat down beside Alias.

Not on the other side.

Not running away.

Just beside him.

The lanterns along the bridge lit one by one.

No one had touched them.

The light was gentle and gold.

It reached only a little way into the mist.

Enough for the next step.

Not enough to show where the bridge ended.

* * *

When they stepped back through the doorway, they were in the sitting room.

The fire crackled in the grate. Outside the windows, snow fell over the buried garden.

The small house looked ordinary again.

Almost.

The seven chairs around the kitchen table had become six.

The empty chair in the corner was gone.

Alias did not know whether that was comforting or sad.

The Paper was lying on the red rug near the fire.

Letters appeared before anyone could ask.

STRUCTURES DO NOT MAKE PEOPLE SAD.

Corvin sat forward. "We know that."

SOME PEOPLE DO NOT.

The next line came slower.

THEY DO NOT CREATE EVERY LOSS. THEY DO NOT CAUSE EVERY ROAD TO BREAK.

THEY DO NOT KEEP PEOPLE FROM LEAVING.

Maris copied every word into her journal.

THEY GATHER WHERE PEOPLE HAVE STOPPED MOVING.

Alias thought of the letter room. The bridge. The empty chair.

"Because they are hurt?" he asked.

**BECAUSE THEY ARE HURT. BECAUSE THEY ARE AFRAID. BECAUSE THEY ARE WAITING
FOR A PERSON WHO WILL NOT COME. BECAUSE THEY WANT TO GO BACK. BECAUSE THEY
WANT TO STAY. BECAUSE THEY THINK ONE PERFECT ANSWER WILL MAKE EVERYTHING
STOP.**

Future Alias lowered his head.

The Paper continued.

THE STRUCTURE SHOWS THEM A DOOR.

"And then?" Rowan asked.

THEN THEY CHOOSE.

Corvin looked around the warm room. "And if they choose badly?"

The Paper remained still.

Eldric answered before it could.

"Then the road continues. And perhaps another door waits somewhere later."

"That is not very reassuring," Rowan said.

"No," Eldric agreed. "It is only true."

Maris closed her journal. "M did not build these to control people."

"Maybe M did not build them at all," Corvin said. "Maybe M found them. Learned what they were. Left maps for them."

The Paper wrote:

CLOSER.

Everyone turned toward it.

Alias knelt beside the rug. "Then what was M trying to do?"

For the first time since they entered the House, the Paper did not answer.

The fire popped.

Snow tapped softly against the window.

Future Alias's fingers had tightened around the red thread tied inside his coat pocket. Alias could see the smallest edge of it where the fabric had shifted.

He had not meant to look.

He looked away anyway.

At last, the Paper wrote:

M TRIED TO LEAVE THE DOORS OPEN.

The words were not grand.

That was why Alias believed them.

* * *

They stayed the night in the house.

The House of Returning did not ask them to do anything else.

It gave them rooms when they needed sleep. It gave them blankets that smelled faintly of lavender and dust. It gave Rowan a pantry with three jars of biscuits, which he declared proof that the Structure had finally made one correct decision.

It did not explain where the biscuits came from.

Corvin refused to eat one until Eldric took the first bite.

Eldric ate half a biscuit, waited a full minute, and declared himself alive.

Rowan ate four.

Maris sat by the fire until late, writing notes about the letter room and the bridge. Every few minutes she crossed something out and started again.

"It will not fit properly in words," she admitted.

"Most things do not," Eldric said.

"That is unhelpful."

"I know."

Alias lay awake in the room he had been given, staring at a ceiling with one long crack running through it.

He thought about the bridge sign.

You may cross.

You may turn back.

You may rest here.

He had spent so long believing choices only mattered if they were permanent. If he chose wrong, the road would close. If he trusted wrong, he would be left. If he stepped forward, he could not return.

But the bridge had not said that.

It had only said he could choose.

A soft knock came at the door.

Alias sat up. "Come in."

Future Alias stepped inside.

He had not brought his journal. His hands were empty until the door shut behind him. Then, slowly, he pulled something from inside his coat.

The red thread.

It was looped once around his fingers.

"Could not sleep?" Alias asked.

Future Alias gave a small smile. "You too?"

"Apparently this house makes people think."

"Rude house."

Alias shifted over on the edge of the bed. Future Alias did not sit beside him. He leaned against the wall near the door instead.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Future Alias said, "The bridge was not a command."

"No."

"I keep waiting for things to become commands." His voice was quiet. "A road. A place. A mistake. I keep thinking that if I do one thing wrong enough, there will be only one direction left."

Alias looked down at his hands.

"I do that too," he said.

Future Alias nodded.

"I know."

The words did not hurt the way Alias expected.

They just felt true.

Future Alias looked at the red thread around his fingers.

"When something is good, I start trying to hold it still," he said. "Like if I keep enough of it close, it cannot become something I lost."

Alias watched him carefully.

"Does it work?"

Future Alias gave a small, tired laugh.

"No."

The answer sat between them.

Not an answer that fixed anything.

Just an honest one.

Alias thought of the empty chair in the kitchen. The unmarked letter. The bridge that offered a way forward, backward, or nowhere at all.

"Maybe holding on is not the same as keeping it," he said.

Future Alias looked up.

"Maybe," he repeated.

For a while, the snow made the only sound outside the window.

Then Alias said, "You do not have to tell me everything tonight."

Future Alias's shoulders loosened a little.

"I know."

"But you also do not have to turn every important thing into a secret."

"I am trying," Future Alias said.

Alias believed him enough to let the silence remain gentle.

Future Alias tied the red thread carefully around his wrist, then covered it with his sleeve.

"Goodnight," he said.

"Goodnight."

At the door, Future Alias paused.

"Alias?"

"Yes?"

"Thank you for making asking possible."

Then he left.

The room became quiet again.

Alias lay back down and watched the cracked ceiling.

Outside, snow kept falling.

Somewhere in the house, a floorboard creaked as though a person had walked across it.

Maybe no one had.

Maybe the house was only remembering.

Either way, Alias closed his eyes.

For once, the road did not feel like a thing waiting to take something from him.

It felt like a door left open.

PART V

THE PERSON BEHIND THE STAGE

Chapter 22: What M Could Not Fix

A lantern is not an answer. It is proof that someone hoped you would find your way.

Morning came slowly to the House of Returning.

It did not arrive with sunlight.

The windows still showed snow resting over the buried garden, and the sky beyond them was the same soft grey it had been the night before. But the house changed in small ways when everyone woke. The fire in the sitting room had gone out. The warm smell of lavender had faded.

The seventh chair had not returned to the kitchen.

Alias noticed all of this before he noticed that Future Alias was already awake.

He was sitting at the narrow kitchen table with both hands around a cup that did not steam. His personal journal rested beside him. The red thread was hidden under his sleeve again, but Alias had begun to recognise the way Future Alias held his wrist when he was thinking too much.

"Did you sleep at all?" Alias asked.

Future Alias looked up. "Some."

"That was not the question."

A small smile appeared and disappeared. "No. Not much."

Alias pulled out the chair beside him. For a moment he considered saying something useful.

He had no idea what useful would be. So he sat down instead.

The others came in one by one.

Rowan arrived first, still wrapped in his blanket like a very offended ghost.

"I have decided," he announced, "that mysterious houses should provide breakfast if they expect people to wake up inside them."

The Paper, which had spent the night folded beside the cold stove, slid across the table.

CHECK THE CUPBOARD.

Rowan blinked at it.

"You could have said that before I made a serious complaint."

YOU WERE MAKING A COMPLAINING NOISE.

"That is different."

Corvin entered behind him, hair still flattened on one side from sleep. He watched Rowan open the cupboard and remove a loaf of bread, a crock of butter, dried apples, and a jar of honey.

"We should not eat food that appears in an impossible house," Corvin said.

Rowan held up the bread. "It is bread-shaped."

"That does not make it safe."

Eldric came in last. He looked at the food, looked at the Paper, and sighed with the patience of someone who had expected this exact argument.

"I will taste it first," he said.

Rowan immediately handed him the bread.

"You make it sound as though I am a poison tester."

"You are the wisest person here," Rowan said. "That must be useful for something."

Eldric took a bite, chewed slowly, and waited.

Everyone watched him.

After a full minute, Eldric nodded. "Bread."

Rowan took the loaf back. "Excellent. A Structure has made one responsible choice."

The kitchen became louder after that. Butter was passed. Corvin found a small pan and warmed the dried apples over the coals left in the stove. Maris wrote something in her journal before eating, then crossed out half of it when Rowan asked whether the house would be offended if they used too much honey.

For a few minutes, it felt almost ordinary.

That was when Alias noticed the new door.

It stood between the cupboard and the cold stove.

He was sure it had not been there the night before.

It was narrow, painted the same faded green as the front door, with a small brass handle. There was no carving above it. No lantern. No sign. Just a door in a wall that had been empty.

Alias stopped chewing.

"Was that there before?"

Everyone looked.

Rowan put down the honey jar. "No."

Corvin stood. "I would have noticed a door."

"You did not notice the seventh chair until Alias counted it," Rowan said.

"That was because there were six chairs when I looked."

"And seven when he looked."

"Yes. That was the alarming part."

The Paper slid closer to the door. Its edges curled once, as though caught by a wind that did not reach anyone else.

Letters appeared.

THE HOUSE REMEMBERS WHAT YOU ASKED.

Maris frowned. "What did we ask?"

No one answered immediately.

Then Future Alias looked at the Paper.

"What M was trying to do," he said.

The words stayed in the kitchen after he spoke them.

Alias remembered the night before. The Paper had said only that M tried to leave doors open. It had not explained why. It had not said who M had been before maps and Towers and impossible rooms.

The brass handle clicked.

Rowan took one step back.

"I would like it clearly recorded that I did not touch it."

"Recorded," Maris said, already writing.

Eldric looked around the table. "Together?"

Alias felt the coin in his pocket warm.

"Together," he said.

* * *

The room behind the new door was not large.

At first, Alias thought it was an old storage room. Shelves rose along three walls, crowded with boxes, rolled maps, bundles of tied paper, jars of ink that had dried years ago, and stacks of notebooks in every size. A narrow desk sat under a window. Unlike the other windows in the house, this one looked out over a road.

Not the snowy garden.

A road.

It bent between two hills beneath a bright afternoon sky. A traveller in a blue coat walked along it with a pack over one shoulder. By the time Alias stepped closer, the traveller had reached the bend and disappeared.

The desk held a lamp with a cracked glass shade.

It was unlit.

Above it, someone had written on the wall in dark brown ink.

FOR THE NEXT PERSON WHO NEEDS A WAY THROUGH.

Maris let out a breath.

"M," she said.

The Paper moved onto the desk.

It stayed blank.

Future Alias did not enter at first. He stood in the doorway, one hand on the frame, staring at the shelves with an expression Alias knew too well.

It was the look of someone standing near a memory that belonged to another version of himself.

"You have seen this before," Alias said quietly.

Future Alias shook his head. "Not this room. But I have seen writing like that. In the Tower. On an old table, near the first-floor windows." He swallowed. "I thought it was another note. I did not know there were so many."

Eldric stepped inside, careful not to touch anything yet. "Then perhaps this is not a library."

Corvin looked at the shelves. "It has books."

"A library keeps things because they are important," Eldric said. "This feels like a place that keeps things because someone may need them."

Rowan peered at a label tied to one of the boxes. "That is still a library, but with more guilt."

Maris smiled a little, then moved closer to the desk.

There were dozens of notebooks piled beneath it. Some were leather-bound. Some were made from folded paper and string. Some had stains from rain, tea, mud, or something darker that Alias did not want to identify.

Each had a simple label on its cover.

North Road, rain season.

The town with no bridge. Ask before crossing.

Three places to sleep near the old quarry.

For people who think they cannot go back.

Alias read that one twice.

Future Alias noticed.

Neither reached for it.

Maris picked up a thin notebook from the top of the nearest stack. The cover was blue-grey and worn soft at the corners. A faint M had been written near the bottom in black ink.

"Can we read these?" she asked.

The Paper remained still.

Then it wrote:

THEY WERE LEFT TO BE FOUND.

"That sounds like yes," Rowan said.

"It sounds like the closest thing we will get to yes," Corvin corrected.

Maris opened the notebook.

The first page was not a secret map or a prophecy.

It was a list.

The handwriting was uneven, sloping downhill across the page as though the writer had been tired or writing on a moving cart.

If you are travelling south after hard rain:

- 1. Do not trust the lower bridge.**
- 2. The inn with the blue shutters is kinder than it looks.**
- 3. Ask for Sera if you need a meal and have no coin. Pay her back when you can.**
- 4. Do not sleep beside the field of white flowers. They are beautiful, and they bite.**

Rowan read the last line over Maris's shoulder.

"That is very useful information."

"It is also very specific," Corvin said.

Eldric took the notebook gently when Maris offered it. He turned several pages.

There were maps drawn with simple arrows. Names of towns. Warnings about unstable roads. Notes about which people could be trusted to help a stranger and which people should not be given the location of anything valuable.

Between the practical notes were smaller lines.

Left an extra blanket at the old signal post. Someone will need it before winter ends.
Told the boy at the river he was allowed to turn back. I do not know whether he heard me.

The woman in the red scarf asked for an answer. I had only directions. She took them anyway.

The room became quiet.

Alias looked at the shelves again.

He had expected M's records to be important in a distant way. Ancient. Perfect. Written by someone who always knew what would happen next.

But the notebook felt like it belonged to a tired traveller with mud on his boots. Someone who had been worried about bridges, hungry people, blankets, and whether another person had listened.

"M was just... walking around," Rowan said.

The Paper wrote:

M WAS VERY GOOD AT WALKING AROUND.

Rowan nodded seriously. "That is fair."

Future Alias stepped closer to the desk. He touched the edge of one notebook but did not lift it.

"Was M ever a Pathstrider?" he asked.

The Paper did not answer at once.

It wrote one word.

YES.

Maris looked up. "Like us?"

NOT LIKE YOU.

"That is less clear than you think it is," Corvin said.

The Paper added:

THE ROADS CHANGE WITH THE PEOPLE WHO WALK THEM. M DID NOT HAVE YOUR KEYS. M DID NOT HAVE YOUR GROUP. M DID NOT HAVE YOUR QUESTIONS.

Alias rested a hand over the coin in his pocket.

"What did M have?"

For several breaths, the Paper gave no answer.

Then new letters appeared slowly.

A BAG. BAD BOOTS. TOO MUCH HOPE. NOT ENOUGH SENSE.

Eldric made a quiet sound that might have been a laugh.

Rowan looked delighted. "Finally. A legendary person with normal problems."

"Bad boots can become a serious problem," Corvin said.

"I know. That is why it is legendary."

The Paper wrote one more line.

M LEARNED. EVENTUALLY.

* * *

They spent most of the morning reading.

Not every notebook held something important to their road. Some were nothing more than weather notes, food lists, or directions to wells. One contained four pages about the best way to repair torn boots. Rowan declared it the most useful book in the room.

But as they read, a picture of M began to form.

M had not begun by building Towers.

M had begun by getting lost.

In a thin journal tied with blue string, Maris found an older entry. The first pages had been written in larger, less careful letters. There were ink blots where rain had hit the paper.

She read it aloud.

"I thought every road wanted to take me somewhere important. It turns out some roads are just roads, and some are dangerous because I do not know where I am. These are not the same thing."

Rowan folded his arms. "That is actually good."

"Do not sound so surprised," Maris said.

"I was expecting instructions about biting flowers."

Eldric turned more pages. "Here."

His voice changed slightly when he read the next entry.

"Met a family beside the broken wall at Harn. They had been waiting for a road to return the person they lost. I could not make it return anyone. I could only tell them where the next town was and walk with them until the rain stopped."

No one spoke.

Alias thought of the gatehouse. Three days of waiting for footsteps that never came.

Future Alias was looking at the floor.

Maris continued, more quietly this time.

"I keep thinking there must be a better answer. There must be something clever enough to repair all the places people break. But every time I arrive late, the road is still broken. Every time I arrive early, someone is still hurt. I am beginning to suspect that knowing a door exists is not the same as having the right to push someone through it."

The Paper's corner lifted, then settled.

Alias looked at it. "You remember this."

YES.

"Were you there?"

The Paper did not write.

Future Alias looked at it too. "You said you knew M."

For a long time, nothing happened.

Then the Paper wrote:

I WAS A PAGE BEFORE I WAS PAPER.

Rowan stared at it. "That somehow made it worse."

Corvin rubbed a hand over his face. "It made it more confusing. There is a difference."

"I disagree."

Maris leaned closer, careful not to touch it. "What does that mean?"

The Paper wrote:

IT MEANS I DO NOT REMEMBER EVERYTHING IN THE RIGHT ORDER.

The letters faded slightly at the edges.

**IT MEANS I CANNOT ALWAYS TELL YOU WHAT I KNOW WITHOUT TELLING YOU
WHAT YOU NEED TO FIND YOURSELVES.**

Alias felt something in his chest tighten.

"That is not fair," he said.

The Paper stayed blank.

He was not angry at it exactly. He was angry at every answer that came with another question. At roads that knew how to lead but not how to explain. At old notes that made him feel less alone and more confused at the same time.

Eldric rested a hand lightly on the back of Alias's chair.

"No," he said. "It is not fair. But it may still be true."

Alias looked down.

Future Alias spoke before anyone else could.

"It is not hiding things to hurt us," he said.

No one had accused it of that.

Still, the words mattered.

The Paper wrote:

I HIDE THINGS BADLY.

Rowan snorted.

That broke the tightness in the room just enough for everyone to breathe again.

* * *

Near midday, Corvin found the record that changed the conversation.

It was not a journal. It was a sheet of folded paper tucked inside a book of maps, held closed with a strip of dark green cloth. The top had been labelled in M's writing:

Things I Could Not Fix

Corvin did not open it right away.

He looked at Eldric. "This feels private."

The Paper wrote:

IT WAS COPIED.

"By whom?" Maris asked.

M.

Rowan frowned. "M copied a private letter for strangers?"

M THOUGHT STRANGERS SOMETIMES NEEDED HONEST THINGS.

That sounded enough like permission.

Corvin unfolded the paper.

The handwriting was different from the travel notes. Slower. Straighter. There were places where the pen had pressed too hard and almost torn through the page.

He read silently at first.

Then he gave the page to Eldric.

"You read it," he said.

Eldric did.

His voice was low.

"I could not fix the old man who wanted to speak to his son after twenty years. I could not fix the girl who believed the road would make her brave if she walked far enough. I could not fix

the friends who chose different directions and called it betrayal because grief made every
goodbye sound cruel."

The room seemed smaller.

"I could not fix the parents who were too frightened to be good parents. I could not fix the
children who grew up carrying that fear. I could not fix the people who thought they had become
monsters because they survived something badly."

Alias stopped breathing for half a second.

Future Alias's fingers closed around the edge of the desk.

Eldric continued.

"I could not fix the dead. I could not fix what people had done to one another. I could not
take one person backwards without asking another person to pay for it."

The last sentence made Future Alias flinch.

Alias saw it.

Eldric lowered the paper.

No one asked him to continue.

The Paper moved across the desk until it rested beside the folded page.

New letters appeared.

M HATED THIS LIST.

Rowan's voice was very quiet. "Why keep it?"

BECAUSE M FORGOT SOMETIMES.

"Forgot what?" Maris asked.

THAT NOT FIXING A THING IS NOT THE SAME AS NOT CARING ABOUT IT.

Eldric looked at the words for a long time.

Then he said, "That is a hard lesson."

"Did M learn it?" Alias asked.

The Paper wrote:

SOME DAYS.

It was such a small answer.

It felt more honest than a perfect one would have.

Corvin sat down heavily in the chair near the desk. "So M did not make the Structures to save
everyone."

"No," Maris said. She was looking at the shelves, the notebooks, the worn maps. "M made
records. Or found places where records could be kept. M pointed people toward doors."

"And left blankets," Rowan added.

Eldric smiled. "And left blankets."

Alias thought about M walking with a family until the rain stopped. Not solving their loss. Not changing what had already happened. Just refusing to let them stand alone beside a broken wall.

A lantern, he thought.

Not a hand pulling someone down the road.

A light, only bright enough for the next step.

"M was not behind the stage," Alias said.

The others looked at him.

He tried again. "Not the way we thought. Not someone pulling strings. M was..."

"The person who put the lantern there," Future Alias said.

Alias nodded.

"And hoped someone would see it."

The Paper wrote:

CLOSER.

* * *

They found the final note just before they left.

It had been tucked into the back of a plain brown notebook. The notebook was almost empty. Only the first page held writing.

Future Alias found it.

Alias knew because he went still in the middle of reaching for another map.

The note was short.

It did not have a title.

Future Alias read it once without speaking. Then once more.

"What is it?" Maris asked.

He looked up.

For a moment, Alias thought he would put it away. He could see the old habit in the movement of his hand, the way his fingers folded around the page as if keeping it close might keep it safe.

But he did not put it away.

He passed it to Maris.

She read it aloud.

"Do not tell a person what their story means before they are ready to speak it. Do not take their page because you believe you can write it better. Leave a light. Leave a place. When they are ready, let them write."

No one spoke.

The words did not feel directed at one person.

That was why they reached everyone.

Alias thought of the way Future Alias had watched him at the gatehouse. The way he had kept quiet when Alias needed silence. The way he had said nothing in the House's letter room, even though there were clearly things he wanted to tell.

Future Alias looked at the brown notebook in his hands.

Then he looked at his own journal on the desk beside him.

It was worn from years of being carried. The cover had scratches along one edge. A loose thread hung from its spine. Alias had seen him hold it like a shield, like a map, like something that could not be touched without making the rest of him fall apart.

"I have pages," Future Alias said.

His voice was unsteady, but he did not stop.

"Not all of them. Some are... mine. I do not think I can make them anything else yet."

"You do not have to," Eldric said.

Future Alias nodded.

"But there are pages you should read. If you still want to." He looked at Alias. "Pages about my road. About why I used the name Varux. About what happened before I reached the Tower."

Alias did not answer quickly.

He could feel how much the offer cost.

"Only if you want us to," he said.

Future Alias's mouth pulled into a small, tired smile.

"I think I do."

The Paper wrote one line beside the empty brown notebook.

GOOD.

Rowan tilted his head. "That was almost kind."

DO NOT MAKE THIS A HABIT.

Rowan grinned.

The room softened around them.

They did not read the journal there.

Not in M's record room. Not surrounded by someone else's maps and lessons. Future Alias closed his journal carefully and placed it inside his coat.

"Tonight," he said. "At camp."

Eldric nodded once. "Tonight."

* * *

When they opened the door back to the kitchen, the House of Returning was already beginning to feel less solid.

The shelves in the record room blurred at the edges. The window no longer showed the sunny road. It showed only snow. The lamp on the desk stayed unlit.

Alias looked back once more.

For the next person who needs a way through.

He wondered how many people had stood in that room before them. How many had taken a map. How many had left a letter. How many had found a door and chosen not to use it yet.

The house did not answer.

It did not need to.

Outside, the valley waited beneath a pale winter sky. Their tracks from the day before had nearly vanished under fresh snow. The road ahead was still there, thin and uncertain between the trees.

Corvin checked their packs. Rowan argued that a mysterious house should have let him take more biscuits. Maris tied her journal closed with new care. Eldric stood at the front step until everyone had come outside.

Future Alias was the last to leave.

He paused with one hand against the green door.

Alias waited beside him.

"Do you think M knew us?" Future Alias asked.

Alias looked at the small lantern carved above the handle.

"Not us exactly," he said. "Maybe M knew there would be people like us. People who got lost."

Future Alias looked down at the red thread hidden beneath his sleeve.

"That is a lot of people."

"Yeah," Alias said. "Maybe that was the point."

Future Alias nodded.

Then he took his hand away from the door. They walked down the valley together. Behind them, the House of Returning kept its door open until the snow covered it, neither calling them back nor sending them forward.

PART V

THE PERSON BEHIND THE STAGE

Chapter 23: The Journal of Varux

A journal is not a wall. It is a door with a handle on both sides.

The road away from the House of Returning was quiet in the way that came after a difficult truth.

Not empty. Not uncomfortable. Just careful.

Snow lay in the low places between the trees, blue where the evening light touched it and grey where the branches had thrown shadows across it. Their boots made soft, regular sounds as they walked. Rowan complained about snow going into his boots. Corvin said snow was not choosing him personally. Rowan said that was exactly what snow wanted Corvin to think.

Normally, Maris would have written both lines down.

Tonight, her journal stayed closed in her pack.

Future Alias walked near the back of the group with one hand resting against the inside of his coat. Alias knew what was there. The old journal. The one Future Alias had offered to share.

Nobody mentioned it while they walked.

That made Alias more nervous, somehow.

The six keys were warm through the cloth of his bag. The compass no longer pulled with its old restless feeling. It only pointed ahead, patient and quiet. Paper had not written a single sarcastic sentence since they left the green house.

Rowan noticed first.

"Paper is being strange," he said.

Paper remained blank.

"That is strange," Corvin agreed.

Eldric glanced at the folded sheet resting in the outer pocket of Alias's bag. "Perhaps it knows when silence is useful."

Rowan looked offended. "I know when silence is useful."

Maris raised one eyebrow.

"I do," Rowan said. "I just do not use it very often."

The path narrowed as the sun slipped behind the trees. Eldric chose a small rise beneath a stand of pines for camp. It was sheltered from the wind, with a shallow creek half-hidden beneath ice a short walk away.

They set up without needing many words.

Corvin made the fire. Rowan gathered wood and came back carrying twice as much as anyone had asked for, most of it badly chosen and one piece clearly too damp to burn. Maris sorted supplies. Eldric checked every knot in every tent, not because he doubted the others but because he had always checked things that mattered twice.

Alias helped Future Alias lay down the bedrolls.

Their hands reached for the same blanket at the same time.

Future Alias pulled his hand back first.

"Sorry," he said.

"You do not have to apologize for touching a blanket," Alias said.

"I know."

But he still sounded as though he was apologizing for something much larger.

Alias did not press him.

When the fire was going, everyone sat close enough to see one another properly. The cold gathered beyond the circle of light. Snow fell from a pine branch with a soft rush and landed behind Rowan's tent.

Future Alias took out his journal.

It was not a dramatic movement. He did not place it in the middle of the ground like a challenge. He simply held it in both hands, looking at its worn cover for a long moment.

Then he set it on the flat stone between them.

"I said there were pages you could read," he began.

Rowan stopped moving.

Future Alias looked around the fire. At Eldric. At Corvin. At Maris. At Rowan. Finally, at Alias.

"There are also pages you cannot," he said. "Not because I do not trust you. Not because I want to make you guess. I just... some things are still only mine."

"That is allowed," Maris said immediately.

Future Alias nodded once, but he looked relieved anyway.

"The pages I chose are not the whole story," he continued. "They are not every reason. They are not an excuse. I do not want them to become one."

Eldric leaned forward slightly. "Then we will read them as you intend. As part of your road."

Future Alias gave a short, uneven laugh. "You make that sound simple."

"No," Eldric said. "I make it sound possible."

For a moment, Future Alias did not move.

Then he opened the journal.

The first page he turned to was marked with a small folded corner. His handwriting filled it in narrow, dark lines. At the top, there was no date. Only one word.

Leaving.

"I wrote this after I had already left," Future Alias said. "I was not good at writing things while they were happening. I thought writing them later made them less real."

"Did it?" Alias asked.

Future Alias looked down at the page.

"No."

He read.

"I left before dawn because it was easier than looking at anyone. I told myself I only needed one day. Then one week. Then a road that did not know my name. I thought leaving first meant I could not be left behind. It only meant I was the one who made the empty space."

The fire cracked.

Nobody rushed to fill the silence after it.

Future Alias turned the page.

"This one is about the name."

Alias's attention sharpened.

Future Alias had explained Varux before, in pieces. Never enough for the name to stop feeling like a closed door.

The next page had a torn edge. Someone had pressed hard enough with a pen that the writing showed faintly through the paper beneath.

"I started using Varux because Alias felt like a name that belonged to a person who had people beside him," Future Alias said. "I thought I had failed that person. I thought I did not have the right to keep using his name."

Rowan frowned. "Names do not work like rewards."

Future Alias looked at him, surprised.

"No," Rowan said, quieter now. "They do not. You do not lose your name because you did something wrong. Or because things went wrong around you."

"I know that now," Future Alias said.

"Did you know it then?"

"No."

He looked back at the journal.

"Varux sounded like a person who could keep moving. Someone harder to hurt. Someone who did not have to answer when people called for him."

Corvin rested his elbows on his knees. "Did it work?"

Future Alias gave a humorless smile.

"For a while, I thought it did."

He read again.

"Varux is not afraid. Varux does not wait at gates. Varux does not ask whether he should go back. Varux keeps walking until there is no one left to disappoint."

The words stayed between them.

Alias looked at the future version of himself across the fire. He thought of the western gate. Of a child waiting for three days, learning the shape of the road before he understood why nobody returned.

"That sounds exhausting," he said.

Future Alias blinked.

Then, unexpectedly, he laughed. It was quiet, but real.

"Yes," he said. "It was."

The next page was marked by a strip of old cloth. Not red thread. Grey, frayed cloth from something that might once have been a sleeve.

Future Alias did not read at once.

Alias knew why before he said anything.

"This is about the wolf," Future Alias said.

No one shifted away from him.

Not even slightly.

That seemed to cost Future Alias a breath.

"After I left, being a wolf was easier sometimes. Not better. Easier." He rubbed his thumb over the page. "A wolf is hungry, tired, afraid, or safe. Those things are simple. A wolf can run until the noise becomes wind. A wolf does not have to explain why a room feels too full."

Maris watched him carefully. "Did you stay like that for long?"

"Longer than I should have." He swallowed. "At first, only a night. Then two. Then I began choosing forests over towns even when I needed food. I began thinking people were only a problem I could avoid if I was quick enough."

He read.

"The wolf did not ask what I should have done differently. The wolf did not remember every face. It only knew the next scent, the next shelter, the next thing that might hurt it. I called that peace because I did not have another word for being numb."

The silence around the fire changed.

Not into fear.

Into understanding that did not know how to be easy.

Eldric was the first to speak.

"You survived with the tools you had," he said. "That does not mean those tools were all you deserved."

Future Alias pressed his lips together.

"I thought surviving alone was the same thing as living," he said.

Alias heard the sentence as if it had been waiting in the cold for years.

"And now?" he asked.

Future Alias looked at him.

The firelight made his face look older than it had that morning.

"Now I think I knew it was not," he said. "I just did not know how to come back after I had spent so long proving I could stay gone."

Paper moved inside Alias's bag.

Everyone looked at it.

Alias pulled it out and set it beside the journal.

For a moment, nothing happened.

Then letters appeared.

COMING BACK IS NOT THE SAME AS PRETENDING YOU NEVER LEFT.

No one made a joke.

Future Alias looked at the sentence until it stopped changing.

"That is annoyingly useful," Rowan said finally.

Paper wrote beneath it.

MY FINEST QUALITY.

The small laugh that went through the group did not fix anything.

It did make room to breathe.

Future Alias turned several pages at once. The papers made a soft, dry sound.

"There are parts about all of you," he said. "Not enough to explain everything. Chapter twenty-four will not be tonight." He caught himself, then frowned. "That sounded strange."

"It did," Rowan said. "But I respect the confidence."

Future Alias looked horrified for half a second. Then Maris laughed, and the tension loosened again.

"I mean," Future Alias said, trying again, "there are parts I cannot read yet. Parts about what I lost. I can tell you more later. I want to. But not tonight."

"Then not tonight," Corvin said.

Future Alias nodded.

He found one last page and held it open with both hands.

"This one is not about a single day," he said. "It is about the years after."

The writing was smaller here. More crowded. As though the person who wrote it had been afraid the page would run out before he could get everything down.

"I missed invitations because I thought they were pity. I did not answer letters because I thought people would be better if I stayed a memory. I left places before anyone could ask me to remain. Every time someone was kind, I looked for the moment they would regret it. When they did not, I made the moment myself by leaving."

Future Alias stopped reading.

His hands had begun to shake.

Alias did not reach for the journal. He did not take it away. He only placed his hand on the ground between them, palm upward.

Future Alias looked at it.

After a moment, he set the journal down and placed his own hand in Alias's.

His fingers were cold.

"I am sorry," Future Alias said.

Alias's throat tightened.

"For what?"

"For acting like you would be safer if you became me later. For holding things back. For teaching you to hide, even when I thought I was warning you." His voice became smaller. "For thinking I had to save you from every version of my mistakes."

Alias looked at their hands.

He knew he could say it was fine.

It would be easier. It would make the fire feel warmer for a little while.

But it would not be true.

"I am angry sometimes," Alias said.

Future Alias's fingers tightened once.

"I know."

"And I am scared of becoming alone like you were."

"I know."

"But I do not want you to be alone now either."

Future Alias went still.

The fire leaned in the wind. Snow slid from a branch somewhere beyond the tents.

"I do not know how to accept that," Future Alias whispered.

Alias looked at him.

"You do not have to know all at once. You only have to stop running every time someone gives you the chance."

For a while, Future Alias could not answer.

Then he nodded.

Not like someone making a promise he could not keep. Like someone deciding to try. Maris opened her own journal, but she did not write. She laid it closed across her knees.

"Can I ask one question?" she said.

Future Alias looked uncertain, then nodded again.

"When you wrote these pages, did you want someone to find them?"

The question seemed to reach him more deeply than any of the others.

He thought about it for a long time.

"Yes," he said at last. "I think I did."

His eyes stayed on the journal.

"I just wanted them to find it without finding me."

Eldric's expression was sad, but not surprised.

"That is a lonely kind of hope," he said.

"Yes."

"You do not need it anymore."

Future Alias looked up.

Eldric did not say more. He did not need to.

They were here. All six of them. The fire was small but warm. The road ahead was still unknown. The road behind was full of things none of them could undo.

But the journal was open between them.

Rowan leaned back against a log and folded his arms. "For the record," he said, "I never thought Varux sounded scary. I thought it sounded like the name of someone who would refuse soup because soup was too emotionally honest."

Future Alias stared at him.

"What does that even mean?" Corvin asked.

"It means he looks like a person who has been rude to a stew."

"I have not been rude to a stew," Future Alias said.

"Not yet."

Future Alias gave him a flat look.

Then, very slowly, his mouth curved.

It was not a large smile.

It was enough.

Later, when the fire had burned down and their tents were ready, Future Alias did not carry his journal away from the group.

He put it inside his coat again. Not hidden under his bedroll. Not pressed beneath a stone.

Just inside his coat, where he could reach it if he needed to.

Alias saw the red thread still looped around his wrist when Future Alias pulled his sleeve down.

"Goodnight," Future Alias said.

"Goodnight," Maris answered.

"Do not let the stew get you," Rowan added.

"I will leave you outside in the snow," Future Alias said.

"That is friendship."

Eldric smiled into his tea.

When Alias lay down, he could hear Future Alias settle into his bedroll on the other side of the fire. He could hear Corvin turn once in his sleep. He could hear Rowan whisper something sleepy and useless about soup.

The sounds were ordinary.

They were proof.

Before Alias closed his eyes, Paper wrote one final line across the dark page beside him.

A JOURNAL IS NOT A WALL.

Then, after a pause:

IT IS A DOOR WITH A HANDLE ON BOTH SIDES.

Alias read the words twice.

Across the dying fire, Future Alias was still awake.

He had read them too.

Neither of them spoke.

They did not need to.

For one night, the door stayed open.

PART V

THE PERSON BEHIND THE STAGE

Chapter 24: Before the Grey Cloak

The past did not become smaller because he had learned a different name for himself.

The next evening, Future Alias asked them to stop before the sun went down.

It was not because the road had become dangerous. The path ahead was clear enough, winding through black pines and low ridges where old snow had frozen hard beneath a thin new layer. They could have walked another hour before camp.

Instead, Future Alias stopped beside a narrow stream and looked at the flat place beneath the trees.

"Here," he said.

Rowan stared at him. "Here? It is barely afternoon."

"It will be dark soon," Corvin said.

"That is not the same thing as now," Rowan answered.

Future Alias did not smile. He stood with both hands hidden inside the grey cloak he wore over his travel clothes. The cloak had always seemed ordinary to Alias. Warm, worn at the edges, useful for rain and wind. Now Alias noticed how often Future Alias pulled it close when the others came too near.

Eldric looked at him for a moment, then nodded.

"Here is good," he said.

No one argued after that.

They made camp early. Corvin chose a sheltered place between two large stones. Maris collected dry branches from beneath the pines. Rowan complained that stopping early meant he had more time to think about being cold, which was apparently a serious problem. Alias helped Eldric fill the kettle from the stream, breaking thin ice with the heel of his boot.

Future Alias built the fire.

He did it carefully. Too carefully.

Every stick was placed with the exactness of someone making a small machine. The flames caught after only one attempt. He watched them rise until they were stable, then sat down on the far side of the fire without taking off his cloak.

Paper stayed folded beside Alias's bag.

It had been quieter since the House of Returning. Alias was beginning to think it understood the difference between silence that helped and silence that hid.

The sky darkened. The trees became black shapes around the little circle of firelight. Someone passed around bread. Eldric poured tea into the chipped metal cups they carried. Rowan burned his tongue because he drank too early and acted as though the tea had personally betrayed him.

For a while, they were only six people at a camp.

Then Future Alias spoke.

"There is more I did not put in the journal."

The words were quiet, but everyone heard them.

Maris placed her cup down. Corvin stopped adjusting the strap on his pack. Rowan looked at Future Alias, then at Alias, as if asking whether this was something they were supposed to be ready for.

Alias was not ready.

He nodded anyway.

Future Alias looked at the fire.

"The journal had pages about leaving. About Varux. About the wolf," he said. "But it did not have enough about you four. Not really."

He glanced toward Rowan, Maris, Corvin, and Eldric.

The four of them did not move.

"You do not owe us that," Eldric said.

Future Alias's mouth tightened slightly.

"I know," he answered. "That is why I want to say it." He drew a breath. "I spent too long making all of you into a story I could not touch. I think I did that because memories are easier to keep when they cannot disagree with you."

Maris's expression softened, but she did not interrupt.

Future Alias stared down at the grey cloth across his knees.

"Before this cloak," he said, "before Varux, before I started pretending I had chosen being alone, there was a long time when we were simply... us."

Rowan blinked.

"That is strange to hear," he said.

"It was strange to remember," Future Alias replied.

For the first time, something almost like a smile reached him.

"You complained about wet boots then too," he told Rowan.

"Good," Rowan said firmly. "At least some things remain true across all possible horrible futures."

A small laugh passed through the camp. It did not last long, but it made the next silence easier to enter.

Future Alias leaned forward and held his hands toward the fire.

"I need you to understand something first," he said. "I did not lose all of you in one terrible day. That would almost be easier to explain. There was no single battle where everything ended.

No one moment I can point to and say, there, that is where my life broke."

The wood shifted in the fire with a soft crack.

"It happened over years," Future Alias continued. "There were roads. Towns. Work we took because someone needed help. Arguments that felt small until they were not. Times we said we would meet again soon. Times we believed there would always be another season."

He looked at Rowan first.

"You were the first person I lost from the road."

Rowan's face changed.

Not fear exactly. Not yet. Something quieter.

"Not the first person who died," Future Alias said quickly. "The first person who stopped travelling with me."

Rowan let out a breath he had been holding.

"That is still not a very pleasant sentence," he said.

"No," Future Alias admitted.

He looked at the dark beyond the fire.

"There was a valley called Harrowbend. The river flooded after spring thaw and took half the lower streets with it. We had only planned to pass through. You found a group trying to pull people out of a collapsed storage house, and you went in before anyone could explain why it was dangerous."

Rowan's eyebrows rose. "That does sound like me."

"It did," Future Alias said.

"You stayed for three days. Then a week. Then you said they needed people who knew how to make a bad day less frightening. I said we could all stay. You said the rest of us had a road to follow too."

He stopped for a moment.

"You promised you would catch up by summer."

The firelight reflected in Future Alias's eyes, but he kept looking at the flames.

"I told you to take your time. I thought I was being kind. I thought people who care about each other do not have to hold on so tightly."

"That sounds reasonable," Rowan said, quieter now.

"It was," Future Alias said. "Until I started using reasonable things as excuses not to return."

No one spoke.

"You wrote twice," Future Alias continued. "The first letter said the roofs were almost finished. The second said you had taught three children how to cheat at cards and one old woman how to argue with Corvin without being scared of him."

Corvin looked offended. "I am not frightening."

"You are when you start explaining bridge supports," Rowan said.

Even Corvin gave a small huff of laughter.

Future Alias's smile faded again.

"I wrote back too late. By then, there had been a winter fever. You were gone before my letter reached Harrowbend."

Rowan lowered his eyes.

Future Alias did not add details. He did not need to.

"I told myself I would have reached you if I had left sooner," he said. "Maybe I would have. Maybe I would only have arrived in time to say goodbye. I never learned which answer was worse."

Eldric's hand rested briefly on Rowan's shoulder.

Rowan did not pull away.

Future Alias looked at Maris next.

"You travelled with me longest after that."

Maris sat very still, her hands wrapped around her cup.

"You wrote everything down," he said. "Not because you thought it made you important. Because you were afraid we would forget ordinary days if we did not. You were always right about that."

Maris's mouth pressed into a small, sad line.

"After Harrowbend, you began asking me what I was doing when I went quiet. You did not accuse me. You just asked. I hated that." Future Alias glanced at her. "Not because you were wrong. Because you kept finding the places where I was hiding."

"That also sounds like me," Maris said.

"It was."

Future Alias looked down.

"We had an argument outside a town called Merrow. It was not even a good argument. You wanted to stay two days because you had found records about an old route. I wanted to keep moving because I was certain something important was waiting ahead. You said I was treating every pause like a trap."

Alias watched Future Alias's hands tighten on the cloak.

"I said some cruel things," Future Alias went on. "I told you that writing about roads was not the same as walking them. I told you that I could not spend every day waiting for you to finish a page."

Maris's eyes shone, but she did not look away.

"You told me I was already leaving before my feet moved."

The fire cracked again.

"You were right," Future Alias said.

His voice had become rough.

"You stayed in Merrow. You found work copying records for the town archive. You kept sending me notes. Not angry ones. That would have been easier. You sent me little pieces of information. A bridge repaired. A strange bird near the southern road. A recipe you thought Eldric would hate."

Eldric raised his brows. "I rarely hate recipes."

"It had too much salt," Future Alias said.

"Then she knew me well."

Maris laughed once through the sadness, and wiped quickly beneath one eye.

"The last note came years later," Future Alias said. "It was only three lines. You said the archive roof leaked. You said the town finally bought a proper kettle. You said you hoped I had learned how to stay somewhere long enough to be missed."

He stopped.

"I never answered that one."

No one asked why.

"The archive burned during a dry summer," he said. "It was an accident. A lamp knocked over after midnight. The people who found it said you had been trying to carry records outside."

Maris's breath shook.

Future Alias bowed his head.

"I thought of all the pages you had saved and how many I had refused to read because I was afraid they would tell me I was wrong."

Maris looked toward the journal tucked inside her pack. After a long moment, she said, "I would have written you again."

Future Alias looked up at her.

"I know," he whispered.

For a few moments, nobody said anything.

The darkness beyond the trees did not move closer, but it felt as though it was listening.

Future Alias turned his gaze to Corvin.

"You were the one who kept trying to make the road practical."

Corvin nodded once. His face was unreadable.

"Maps. Supplies. Repairs. You said grief did not make a broken wheel less broken. I used to think that meant you did not understand. I know now that it meant you were trying to keep us alive long enough to understand anything at all."

Corvin stared into his cup.

"You stayed after Maris died," Future Alias said. "You said someone had to make sure I ate, which was rude but correct. We travelled together after that. Not easily. We argued more. I stopped listening more."

"That also sounds correct," Corvin said, but there was no humor in it.

Future Alias nodded.

"We reached an old pass in the mountains. There was a group trapped on the far side after a landslide. You wanted to take the safer route around and bring help. I wanted to cross immediately. I said there was no time. You said there would be no time for anyone if the bridge went under us."

Alias knew where this was going before Future Alias said it. He wished, suddenly and uselessly, that he could stop the story.

"I crossed first," Future Alias said. "Because I could. Because I was fast. Because I thought being able to do something meant I should do it alone."

His fingers curled into the grey fabric.

"The bridge held for me. It did not hold for you."

Corvin closed his eyes.

Future Alias did not describe the fall.

"I found you below," he said. "You were still alive long enough to tell me the people on the far side still needed help. You were angry that I was crying instead of moving."

Corvin opened his eyes again.

"I would be," he said quietly.

"I know."

Future Alias's voice broke on the last word.

"I helped them. Then I came back. I built a marker because I did not know what else to do. I stood there until it got dark. I told myself I would return with something better than a pile of stones."

"Did you?" Alias asked.

Future Alias looked at him.

"No," he said. "Not for a long time."

The answer sat heavily among them.

Eldric had been silent throughout all of it.

Future Alias looked at him last.

The old tea kettle gave a faint sound as it settled beside the fire.

"You lived the longest," Future Alias said.

Eldric's expression did not change much. But Alias saw the sadness in his eyes.

"You kept finding me," Future Alias continued. "Even after I stopped answering letters. Even after I started calling myself Varux everywhere. You would appear in a village I thought nobody knew about with tea, new boots, and some reason you had invented for being there."

Eldric's mouth curved faintly. "I have always been good at reasons."

"You told me you did not need me to become the person I had been. You only wanted me to become a person who came back when someone knocked." Future Alias looked down. "I did not know how to do that."

The silence was different now.

Not empty. Not waiting.

"You became ill in the end," Future Alias said. "There was no enemy. No falling bridge. No curse. You got tired. You had lived a long life and I kept acting as though that was something I could argue with."

Eldric breathed in slowly.

"You asked me to sit with you at the end," Future Alias said. "I did. That was the first thing I did right for a long time."

No one moved.

"You told me that losing people did not prove I had failed them. You told me I was confusing grief with a punishment. Then you fell asleep and did not wake up."

Future Alias stared at the fire until his eyes were bright.

"After that, I did not know who I was supposed to be."

Rowan shifted closer, though he did not touch him. Maris held her cup against her chest. Corvin rubbed one hand over his face. Eldric sat with both hands resting calmly in his lap, alive and warm on the other side of the fire.

Alias could not stop looking at him.

Future Alias noticed.

"I know," he said softly. "It is a terrible thing to tell someone who is sitting right in front of you."

Eldric nodded.

"It is," he said. "But it is not a terrible thing to tell the truth."

Future Alias looked as though he did not know how to answer that.

So Eldric continued.

"The person I was on your road had a life. A full one, from what you have said. He made choices, drank tea, worried about you, and reached his ending. That is sad. It is not a reason for you to stop living yours."

Future Alias closed his eyes.

"I stopped anyway," he said.

"For a while," Eldric corrected. "You are here now."

The words were simple. They did not undo anything.

They did not have to.

Future Alias wiped one hand quickly over his face, then gave a breath that was almost a laugh.

"After you were gone, I put on the grey cloak," he said. "I stopped wearing anything bright. I stopped using Alias. I stopped staying where people might remember me. I thought if I looked like a shadow, I could walk through a life without anyone asking me to be part of it."

Alias looked at the cloak again.

It did not look like armor. It looked tired.

"I became Varux properly then," Future Alias said. "Not all at once. I was still me under it. That was the worst part. I thought changing my name could make the old choices belong to someone else, but they followed me. Every road did."

Paper unfolded slightly beside Alias's bag.

A sentence appeared.

A NEW NAME IS NOT A NEW PAST.

Future Alias gave Paper a weak look.

"You could have waited ten minutes," he said.

Paper wrote beneath it.

I COULD HAVE.

Rowan made a sound halfway between a laugh and a sob.

Future Alias looked toward the dark road beyond camp.

"Eventually, I heard stories about a Tower," he said. "Not from M's records. Not at first. From people who had found strange roads and come back with no clear idea of how. A library at the center. A place that held maps nobody could read until they needed them. A place that sometimes gave people exactly the thing they should not have asked for."

Alias felt the compass, tucked in his coat, turn warm against his chest.

"I had nowhere left to go that felt different from any other road," Future Alias continued. "So I went looking for it."

"The Tower," Maris said.

Future Alias nodded.

"I spent months finding the first door. Then longer finding the next. I was exhausted by the time I reached it. Angry. Hungry. I had not slept properly in days."

He looked at Alias.

"And I wanted one impossible thing."

Alias already knew the answer.

He did not want to say it.

"You wanted to go home," he said.

Future Alias's eyes held his.
"I wanted to go back," he said. "I thought that was the same thing."
The fire burned lower between them.
Future Alias pulled the grey cloak close around himself one more time.
"Tomorrow," he said, "I will tell you what happened in the library."
No one pushed him for more.
They sat together until the tea went cold.
And when the fire finally became only red coals, nobody left Future Alias alone with the
dark.

PART V

THE PERSON BEHIND THE STAGE

Chapter 25: The Book That Hit Me

He had asked a library for an impossible answer. It answered with a very large book.

The next morning, the road looked ordinary.

That was the first thing Alias noticed when he woke.

The snow had melted from the lowest branches during the night. Water fell from the black pines one drop at a time, each sound too small to matter and impossible to ignore once he heard it. The stream beside camp moved beneath a skin of ice. The fire had become a grey circle of ash, though Eldric was already awake and crouched beside it, giving the coals a careful breath.

For a few moments, Alias did not remember why everyone was quiet.

Then he saw Future Alias sitting on the far side of the dead fire, grey cloak pulled around his shoulders, Paper folded in front of him.

The memories of the night before returned in pieces.

Harrowbend. Merrow. The bridge. Eldric falling asleep and not waking again.

The Tower.

Alias pushed himself upright inside his blanket.

Future Alias looked up at the movement. His face had the tired, distant look of someone who had slept only because his body had forced him to.

"You do not have to tell us today," Alias said.

Future Alias looked down at Paper.

"I said tomorrow," he answered. "I have spent enough years deciding that later was safer."

Eldric set the kettle above the small returning flame.

"Then we will listen," he said.

The others woke slowly. Rowan complained that grief had not improved the ground beneath him, which was unfair because grief was not in charge of the ground. Corvin checked the pack straps twice without saying anything. Maris sat beside the fire with her journal closed in her lap.

No one rushed Future Alias.

When the tea was warm enough to hold, he began.

"The Tower did not look like a place that could change anything," he said.

Rowan glanced toward him. "That feels like a bad start."

"It was," Future Alias replied.

His fingers rested on the edge of the grey cloak.

"I had been looking for it for months. People described it differently. A library above the clouds. A door beneath a lake. A tower with no top. A room where every book knew your name. None of the stories agreed, except for one thing. People said that if you found the first door, the rest of the road would know you were coming."

Paper remained still.

"I found the first door in a quarry," Future Alias continued. "It was standing upright in the middle of a wall of stone. No building around it. No path leading to it. Just an old blue door with a brass handle and rain running down its panels."

"That is already more dramatic than I wanted," Corvin said.

"I was too tired to appreciate it."

Future Alias gave a small, humorless smile.

"I opened it. On the other side was a stairwell. It went down farther than the quarry should have allowed. Then there was another door. Then another. Some opened into halls. Some opened into places I had seen before. One opened onto a beach in the middle of winter. One opened into a kitchen where someone had left bread on a table. I did not eat it."

"You should have eaten it," Eldric said.

"I know that now."

"That has been your answer to many things," Rowan said quietly.

Future Alias nodded as though he had expected it.

"By the time I reached the Tower, I was hungry enough to be angry at furniture," he said. "I had slept badly for days. I had not spoken to another person in longer than that. I had started thinking the road was testing me."

"Was it?" Maris asked.

Future Alias looked at Paper.

Paper stayed blank.

"I do not know," he said. "That is one of the answers I still do not have."

He stared into the fire while the flame grew steadier.

"The Tower itself was not shining. It did not have guards or banners. It stood on a hill under a sky the colour of old iron. The front door was open. Inside, there were shelves. That was all. Shelves, stairs, dust, lamps, and so many books that I could not understand how the building held them."

Alias pictured it against his will: Future Alias alone beneath the high ceiling, wearing the cloak that had become an attempt to disappear.

"I thought I had finally found something important," Future Alias said. "Then I walked into the first-floor reading room and found a table, one chair, and a book lying in the middle of it."

"Just one book?" Rowan asked.

"One book that wanted to be noticed."

Paper unfolded by a corner.

Future Alias glanced at it.

"It was not much larger than this journal," he said. "Dark blue cover. No lock. No dust. The title said, "A Guide for Those Who Ask the Road to Decide for Them.""

Rowan sat up straighter.

"That is an extremely rude title."

"Yes," Future Alias said. "That was why I opened it."

A small laugh moved around the fire. It was quiet, but it was there.

Future Alias went on.

"The first page was not a prophecy. It did not tell me why I was there. It said, "If you have reached this table, sit down. Drink water. Put your bag down. You will make worse choices while hungry.""

Eldric nodded with approval.

"M," he said.

"I did not know that name then," Future Alias replied. "I thought the book was speaking directly to me. That made me angry. I had walked through doors that did not belong in the world. I had lost people. I had spent years trying to understand what I had done wrong. And the first advice this impossible library gave me was to drink water."

"Still good advice," Eldric said.

"It was. I hated it."

He looked toward Alias.

"I had begun to hate anything that was simple enough to be true."

The words stayed with Alias.

Future Alias leaned forward.

"I read the guide. It explained roads that changed. It explained that some places gathered around things people had not finished choosing. It explained that a road could show you a door, but it could not walk through the door for you. It explained that going backward was not the same as going home."

His jaw tightened.

"I stopped reading there."

No one spoke.

"I threw the book across the room," Future Alias said.

Rowan blinked. "You threw the special Tower guide?"

"Yes."

"Did it survive?"

"It was a book, Rowan."

"That has not answered my question."

Future Alias almost smiled.

"It survived. It landed on another table. Then a loose page slid out from under it."

Paper lifted itself a little higher.

"You?" Alias asked.

Paper wrote one word.

YES.

Future Alias looked at it as if he still found the answer strange.

"It was folded then," he said. "Blank at first. I thought it was part of the book. Then it wrote,

"THAT WAS UNNECESSARY."

Rowan covered his mouth, trying and failing not to laugh.

"You had the exact same voice?" he asked Paper.

Paper considered this.

I HAVE IMPROVED.

"I disagree," Future Alias said.

Paper wrote beneath it.

YOU ARE ALIVE TO DISAGREE.

No one knew what to say to that.

The fire gave a small pop.

Future Alias watched the sparks rise and vanish.

"I argued with Paper for a long time," he said. "Or I argued with a piece of paper, which is probably more accurate. I said the guide was useless. I said the Tower was cruel. I said that if there was any person behind the roads, then they had no right to leave doors open and call that help."

Maris's hand tightened around the edge of her journal.

"What did Paper say?" she asked.

Future Alias looked at it.

Paper wrote slowly.

I SAID YOU WERE TIRED.

"It did," Future Alias said. "I hated that too."

The faintest smile reached Maris's face.

"Eventually, I stopped shouting," Future Alias continued. "Not because I became reasonable. I simply ran out of strength. I sat on the floor beside the table. I could see the guide where I had thrown it. I could see rows and rows of books above me. More answers than any person could hold. And none of them could give me the one thing I wanted."

He paused.

"I wanted the road to take me back before the letters I answered too late. Before I walked away from Maris. Before I crossed the bridge without Corvin. Before Eldric had to forgive me for being afraid."

The present Maris lowered her eyes. Corvin stared at the steam rising from his cup. Eldric listened without interrupting.

"I did not ask for it like a spell," Future Alias said. "There were no right words. I did not know any. I just said it."

His voice grew quieter.

"I said, 'Please. Take me home.'"

The morning seemed to hold its breath with the group.

"Paper wrote that it could not promise that," Future Alias said. "I told it I did not care about promises. I said I had nowhere left that felt like home anyway. I said I would take a memory. A dream. A lie. Anything."

Alias felt the cold beneath his blanket, despite the fire.

"Then I said the truth," Future Alias continued. "I said I did not want a new road. I did not want to choose again. I wanted to go back and be someone who had not lost everyone yet."

No one moved.

Future Alias gave one small, tired laugh.

"The room went quiet. Even Paper stopped writing. The lamps dimmed. I thought perhaps that was the Tower deciding I had failed some kind of test."

Paper wrote:

THERE WAS NO TEST.

"I know that now," Future Alias said. "I did not know it then."

His fingers pressed into the grey cloth over his knees.

"The guide book slid off the table by itself. It opened on the floor. The pages turned very fast. The air changed. It felt like the room was inhaling."

Rowan's eyes had widened.

"That is the point where you should have left," he said.

"I was sitting under a library that had just begun breathing, Rowan. I do not think walking calmly away was an option."

"Fair."

"Then something fell."

Future Alias stopped.

For a second, even he looked embarrassed.

Alias knew what was coming. He had heard the short version before. The full story somehow made the strange moment feel more real, not less.

"It was a book," Future Alias said.

Rowan waited.

"A very large book."

Rowan's mouth opened.

"From where?" Corvin asked.

"A shelf above me. I still do not know which shelf. I looked up because Paper wrote "DUCK," but it wrote it too late."

Paper wrote immediately:

I WROTE IT AS FAST AS I COULD.

"The book hit me on the head," Future Alias said.

There was one heartbeat of silence.

Then Rowan made a broken sound and started laughing.

He tried to stop. He looked at Future Alias's face and tried again. It did not work.

"I am sorry," Rowan said, not sounding sorry at all. "You crossed impossible doors. You found the centre of every strange road. You argued with a haunted page. You asked the universe to take you home." He took a breath. "And then a book fell on you."

Future Alias looked toward the fire.

"Yes."

"How big was it?" Rowan asked.

"Big enough."

"That is not a measurement."

"It was larger than my head, Rowan."

That made Rowan laugh harder. Even Corvin's mouth moved as though he was losing a fight with a smile. Maris pressed her knuckles against her lips. Eldric lowered his gaze, and Alias could tell by the movement of his shoulders that he was laughing too.

Future Alias waited through it.

Then, unexpectedly, he laughed once as well.

It was not a happy sound exactly.

But it was not the sound of someone alone.

When the laughter faded, Paper wrote:

THE BOOK WAS POORLY SHELVED.

"You are making that up," Future Alias told it.

PROVE IT.

Rowan pointed at Paper. "I like this version of history."

"Of course you do," Corvin said.

The warmth in the group did not erase what came next. It only made it possible to hear.

Future Alias's expression settled again.

"I remember falling backward," he said. "I remember the floor. I remember Paper sliding under the table. Then nothing."

He looked across the fire at Alias.

"When I woke, I was not in the Tower."

Alias held his gaze.

"I was on a road," Future Alias said. "A real road. Mud, grass, rain in the ditch. I could smell horses. I could hear a cart wheel complaining somewhere nearby. My head hurt so badly I thought the library had simply dropped me outside."

"Had it?" Rowan asked.

"No."

Future Alias's eyes remained on Alias.

"The road was familiar. Not just familiar like a place you have passed through. Familiar like a scar. I had walked it long ago, before the grey cloak, before Varux. I knew where the bend would be before I saw it. I knew that there would be a broken milestone half buried in the grass."

Alias's hand closed around his cup.

"Then I saw you," Future Alias said.

No one looked away.

"Not all of you at first. Just Alias. Younger. Standing at the side of the road with that expression you get when you are pretending you understand what is happening."

Alias felt his face warm.

"I do not always do that," he said.

"You do," Future Alias answered gently.

For a breath, the old familiar teasing lived between them.

Then Future Alias continued.

"I thought I was dreaming. I thought I had hit my head so hard that my own memories had become a punishment. I followed from a distance for two days because I was afraid that if I spoke, everything would vanish."

"You followed me?" Alias asked.

"Yes."

"That is creepy."

"I know."

"You are telling me this now?"

"I have become slightly better at timing."

Paper wrote:

DEBATABLE.

Alias tried to look angry. It did not work very well.

Future Alias's expression softened.

"I did not know if any of you were truly there. I did not know if I was there. I thought perhaps the Tower had given me one last dream and I would wake up in the library with a bruise on my head and nothing changed."

"But you did not," Maris said.

"No."

"How did you know?" she asked.

Future Alias was quiet for a long time.

"I do not know that I ever knew completely," he said. "Not at first. Maybe not even now."

The answer made the air feel strangely open.

"But I knew that it hurt," he went on. "I knew I could make mistakes. I knew you surprised me. Dreams usually did not surprise me. And Paper was still rude."

Paper wrote:

STRONG EVIDENCE.

"It is not strong evidence," Corvin said.

IT IS ADEQUATE.

Future Alias looked down at his hands.

"More than that, I knew I had been given something I had not earned. A chance to see you again. A chance to see where I had started leaving before I even understood I was leaving."

Alias watched him closely.

"You could have tried to change everything," he said.

"I did try," Future Alias said. "At first. I wanted to stop every hard moment before it happened. I wanted to tell you all what roads to avoid. I wanted to make choices for you because I was afraid of what choosing had cost me."

He looked at Eldric.

"Eldric stopped me. More than once."

Eldric's expression was calm.

"That sounds likely," he said.

"He told me that knowing a storm was coming did not give me the right to lock everyone inside forever. He said a warning was not the same as a command."

Eldric nodded once.

"A good rule," he said.

"It was."

Future Alias turned back to Alias.

"You were not a second version of me for me to control. You were yourself. You had to choose the roads you walked. You had to make mistakes that belonged to you, not me."

The words landed more gently than Alias expected. They did not make the future feel less frightening. They made it feel less trapped.

"So what did the Tower do?" Maris asked. "Really?"

Future Alias looked toward the pale sky between the branches.

"It gave me a chance," he said. "That is the closest answer I have. Not a chance to erase the past. Not a chance to bring everyone back because I demanded it. A chance to see what I had become. A chance to stop teaching myself that being alone was safer."

Paper unfolded fully.

A new line appeared.

A ROAD CAN RETURN YOU TO A CHOICE. IT CANNOT CHOOSE FOR YOU.

They read it together.

Alias remembered the House of Returning. The doors they had seen. The guide M had written. The lanterns left for people who might arrive hurt, angry, or frightened.

"And when you woke here," Alias said slowly, "you decided to stay."

Future Alias looked at him.

"At first, I decided to be afraid," he said. "Then I decided to stay anyway."

No one laughed at that.

Eldric poured more tea into Future Alias's cup before he could refuse it.

"That is often the first useful decision," Eldric said.

Future Alias wrapped both hands around the cup.

"I still do not know whether the Tower sent me through time," he said. "Or whether it found a road between things that had always been connected. I do not know whether this is another path, a memory with consequences, or something none of us have words for."

Corvin frowned thoughtfully. "You are saying the answer may not fit into a map."

"I hate that," Future Alias said.

"I know," Corvin replied.

For the first time that morning, the smile Future Alias gave him reached his eyes.

Alias looked at the grey cloak around Future Alias's shoulders.

"Do you think it will send you back?" he asked.

The question changed the room around the fire.

Future Alias did not lie.

"Yes," he said. "I think one day it will."

Alias's chest tightened.

"Do you want it to?"

Future Alias looked toward the road beyond the pines. Then back at the five people around the fire.

"I do not know," he said. "There are days when I want to stay because I am afraid of what waits for me. There are days when I want to go because I am afraid this is only borrowed."

He took a breath.

"But I am trying not to let fear make the whole decision anymore."

Eldric's eyes softened.

"Good," he said.

Future Alias looked at Alias once more.

"The Tower did not send me here to make you into me," he said. "I believe it sent me here to learn that you did not have to become me at all."

Alias did not know what to say.

So he reached across the small distance between them and put his hand over Future Alias's, where it rested around the warm cup.

Future Alias went very still.

Then he turned his hand and held on.

Paper watched them for a while.

Finally, it wrote:

FOR THE RECORD, THE BOOK WAS NOT A METAPHOR.

Rowan laughed first.

This time, Future Alias did too.

PART VI

SIX KEYS, ONE ROAD

Chapter 26: The Last Direction

The last direction did not tell them where to go. It asked whether they wanted to go at all.

The morning after the story of the Tower was too bright.

Alias woke before the sun had fully climbed above the pine trees. Frost still covered the edges of the camp, turning the grass silver. The fire had become a low bed of red coals beneath its ash. Someone had covered Future Alias with an extra blanket in the night. Alias could not tell who. Future Alias was awake already, sitting with his back against a fallen log and watching the eastern sky as though it might change its mind about being there.

For a few minutes, nothing strange happened.

Rowan snored with one arm over his face. Corvin slept with his boots beside his bedroll in a straight, unreasonable line. Maris had somehow kept her journal tucked beneath one hand even while sleeping. Eldric sat near the coals, quietly warming water for tea.

It was ordinary.

Alias had learned that ordinary did not mean unimportant.

Then the coins began to move.

They did not jump or spin wildly. That would have been easier to understand. The six old coins, kept in a small pouch near the center of camp, made one soft sound against each other.

Click.

Alias looked over.

The pouch was closed.

Click.

Future Alias heard it too. His head turned at the same time.

Eldric lifted the pouch before it could make the sound a third time. He loosened the drawstring and tipped the coins into his palm.

For months, they had never rested for long. They had pointed toward roads, shifted when nobody watched, pulled the group through places that only made sense after they had already walked them.

Now they lay flat against Eldric's hand.

All six faces pointed east.

No trembling. No turning. No faint restless scrape.

Just east.

Rowan woke when Corvin stepped on the end of his blanket.

"Ow," Rowan said into the ground. Then he lifted his head. "Are we being attacked?"

"No," Corvin said. "The coins stopped moving."

Rowan sat up faster than anyone expected. "That is somehow worse."

Maris was awake next. She pushed loose hair from her face, opened her journal, and then stared at the coins instead of writing.

"They have never done that," she said.

"No," Future Alias answered.

His voice was careful.

Alias looked down at the compass tucked inside his coat. It had been warm since the night before. Not hot. Not painful. Just present, like a hand resting lightly against his chest.

He pulled it out.

The brass casing was dull from travel and scratched near the clasp. When he opened it, the needle did not wobble. It slid once around the face, then settled in the same direction as the coins.

East.

The group fell quiet.

Even Rowan did not have a joke immediately.

Paper lay folded beside Maris's bag. Its corner lifted. Ink appeared in large, sharp letters.

AT LAST.

Rowan leaned toward it. "That sounds like you knew this was going to happen."

Paper waited.

Then it wrote:

I KNEW IT WAS POSSIBLE.

"That is not the same thing," Corvin said.

IT USUALLY IS TO PEOPLE WHO HAVE NEVER HAD TO EXPLAIN A MAGIC LIBRARY.

Corvin's expression suggested that Paper had, somehow, lost an argument it had not been invited into.

Eldric held the coins carefully. "Does anyone know what this means?"

Future Alias looked east again.

"I think," he said slowly, "we have reached the last direction."

The words did not sound grand when he said them. They sounded tired. Afraid. Honest.

Alias sat up straighter.

"The Tower?" he asked.

"Maybe the Tower. Maybe the place before it." Future Alias rubbed his thumb against the edge of the grey cloak. "The final place was never clear in my memories. I remember the library because I arrived there alone. I remember the book because it hit me. But the roads before it..." He breathed out. "They felt like a question I could not read yet."

"And now we can?" Maris asked.

"Maybe now we are meant to try."

Paper wrote:

THE ROAD DOES NOT RESPOND WELL TO "MEANT TO."

Then, after a pause:

TRYING IS ACCEPTABLE.

Rowan pointed at it. "You are becoming nicer."

NO.

"I heard it. Everyone heard it."

NO ONE HEARD ANYTHING.

The coins remained still in Eldric's hand.

For a moment, Alias thought that might be enough. A direction. A compass. Another strange place on the map. They had followed stranger things before.

Then the six keys began to warm.

His was beneath his shirt, where he kept it on a cord. The metal against his skin was suddenly hot enough to make him inhale sharply. Across the camp, the others reacted at the same time.

Maris pressed a hand to the key at her belt.

Corvin caught his inside his coat.

Rowan swore softly and pulled his out by the ring.

Eldric's key shone faintly against his palm beside the coins.

Future Alias held his in both hands as though it had become something fragile.

The keys did not burn them. The heat faded before anyone had to let go.

But when they placed them on the flat stone by the fire, something changed.

Six keys. Six different shapes. Six old pieces of metal gathered around an empty center.

A faint line of light ran through each one.

It did not form a map.

It did not show a door.

It did not give them a voice from the sky telling them exactly what to do.

The light simply reached outward, one thin line from each key, and met in the middle.

For a breath, the center of the stone looked like a little circle of morning sun.

Then words appeared across the surface.

Not carved. Not written in ink. They seemed to rise from within the stone itself.

WILLINGLY.

That was all.

Rowan stared at it.

"That is rude," he said.

Maris looked at him. "How is it rude?"

"Because it is one word. We crossed half the world for one word. It could at least be a sentence."

Corvin crouched beside the stone. "It is clear."

"It is suspiciously clear."

Future Alias had gone very still.

Alias knew that stillness now. It was not calm. It was the moment before Future Alias decided whether to step toward something or away from it.

"Willingly," Future Alias repeated.

Eldric nodded once.

"The keys are not asking whether we can continue," he said. "They are asking whether we choose to."

No one answered.

The answer should have been easy. They had come this far. They had faced roads that bent wrong, a winter town, old grief, old homes, old names, and a book large enough to make a person question the nature of libraries.

But that was not the same as choosing the last road.

Alias looked at the line of light stretching from his key toward the center.

He thought about the gatehouse.

He thought about three days of waiting, a child trying to believe the road would bring someone back. He thought about the House of Returning, where each door had stayed closed until someone chose it. He thought about the wolf in the forest and the way he had run because he had believed being afraid made him dangerous.

He did not want a road to decide who he was.

He also did not want to turn away just because the road was frightening.

The realization was small. It did not feel like a grand answer. It felt more like choosing where to put his next foot.

Alias reached for his key.

The metal was warm, but no longer hot.

"I want to go," he said.

Everyone looked at him.

His voice almost disappeared. He made it stay.

"Not because I think the final place will fix anything. It probably will not. It did not fix the gate. It did not fix what happened in the forest. It did not fix... any of it." He swallowed. "But I do not want to stop at the edge of something because I am scared of what I might find. I want to know where this road ends. I want it to be my choice."

The line from his key brightened once.

Then it became steady.

No thunder answered. No hidden door opened in the trees.

The quiet made the choice feel more real.

Rowan looked down at his own key.

"Fine," he said.

Corvin raised an eyebrow. "That sounds very convincing."

"I am thinking." Rowan leaned back on his hands. For once, he did not fill the space immediately. "I want to go because all of you are going. That sounds like a bad reason when I say it like that."

"Not necessarily," Eldric said.

Rowan looked at him.

"I mean, I know I make jokes. I know I complain when the road is wet and when Corvin tells me not to eat unknown berries, which is most of the time." He glanced toward Corvin. "But I do not want to be the person who leaves when things get serious. I do not want you to look back one day and realize I was only around for the easy parts."

His fingers closed around the key.

"Also," he added, "I need to see whether the final place has snacks. That is an important responsibility."

Maris laughed softly. The sound was small, but it loosened something in the camp.

Rowan's line of light brightened.

"There," he said. "See? The keys understand responsibility."

"The keys have made no statement," Corvin said.

"They glow. That is a statement."

Maris held her key against the open page of her journal. The pages had become fuller since she first began writing. Not only with strange roads and dangers. There were notes about inns, recipes, snowball rules, how Rowan cheated at dice, and the exact color of the morning when Future Alias had finally smiled without looking like he expected someone to take it away.

"I want to go," she said. "At first, I would have said it was because I want to understand. And I do. I want to know what M left behind. I want to know why the keys are six and why the roads found us."

She traced the edge of her key with one finger.

"But I do not only want to understand the story. I want to be here for it. Not as someone watching from the outside. Not as someone who writes down what everyone else decided."

She looked around the fire.

"I want to choose the road with you. And I want to write the truth about it after. Even when the truth is not neat."

Her line of light joined the others, calm and gold.

Corvin had not moved.

Alias expected him to say something practical. Corvin always had a practical reason ready: food, weather, tools, routes, how many days until the next town.

Instead, Corvin looked at the stones beneath the fire and seemed annoyed that the answer was not becoming simpler.

"I want to go because there are still questions," he said at last.

Rowan gave him an exaggerated look. "That is extremely Corvin of you."

"I am not finished." Corvin's tone stayed patient, which somehow made Rowan sit up straighter. "I do want answers. I want to understand how the roads work, where the coins came from, and why

M's places find people who are already carrying too much. But I know now that understanding something is not the same as controlling it."

Future Alias glanced at him.

Corvin continued.

"I spent a long time believing that if I made a good enough plan, I could keep everyone safe. Then people got hurt anyway. The plan mattered. It helped. But it was never the whole thing." He looked toward the others. "I want to go because I am tired of standing at the edge of unknown things and pretending I am only there to measure them. I am here because you are here. I want to see this through with all of you."

His key brightened.

Rowan nudged him with one shoulder. "That was almost emotional."

"Do not make it worse," Corvin said.

Eldric's smile was quiet.

When he reached for his key, the others watched him without meaning to.

Eldric had always seemed like someone who knew when the road would turn. Not because he could see the future, but because he did not panic when the map ended. He had been the one to make tea beside ruins, to ask the question nobody wanted to answer, to remind them that they could sit down before making the next decision.

"I want to go," he said. "Because I am still here."

The words were so simple that nobody interrupted.

"A road is not owed my company," Eldric continued. "Neither are any of you. But I have been given this morning, this fire, these friends, and a direction. I do not know how many mornings any of us will have. I do know that I would rather spend this one walking beside people I care about than sitting safely at the beginning and wondering who reached the end."

His key shone softly.

"And," he added, looking at Rowan, "someone must ensure that the final place does not give you access to its kitchen unsupervised."

Rowan opened his mouth.

"I accept the duty," Eldric said before he could speak.

That made everyone laugh, even Corvin.

Only Future Alias had not spoken.

His key lay in his hands. The light from it was faint but alive, pulsing with the same slow rhythm as a heartbeat.

The others did not rush him.

Alias watched the grey cloak move in the morning wind. He remembered the words beside the fire: I am trying not to let fear make the whole decision anymore.

Future Alias looked at the eastern sky for so long that Alias thought he might not answer at all.

Then he said, "I want to go because I am afraid to."

The camp became very quiet.

Future Alias let out a breath that shook once.

"I do not want to return to the Tower only because it may send me home. I do not want to reach the end and discover that I have been waiting for it to take something away from me." His fingers tightened around the key. "I am afraid that when I go back, the people I lost will still be gone. I am afraid the sky will look grey again. I am afraid I will find myself standing in the same library and remember how easy it was to ask a building to make my choices for me."

Alias's chest hurt.

"But I do not want fear to be the only honest thing about me anymore," Future Alias continued. "I want to finish this road with you. Not because I think I deserve an answer. Not because I can control what waits at the end. I want to stand there and know I did not run before I arrived."

His key flared bright enough to paint gold against his hands.

Future Alias blinked at it.

Then he laughed once, surprised and breathless.

Paper wrote across its page:

ADEQUATE.

Future Alias looked at it. "That is all I get?"

YOU RECEIVED A GLOWING KEY.

"I meant emotionally."

THE KEY HAS NO EMOTIONS.

"That is not what I meant."

Paper did not reply.

All five lines of light were steady now.

Alias looked down at the sixth.

Future Alias had spoken. The key had answered. The circle in the middle of the stone had become brighter, warm enough that the frost around it melted into tiny drops of water.

But there was one last thing.

The line from Future Alias's key did not complete the circle by itself.

It stretched toward Alias's, then stopped just short.

Alias understood before anyone said it.

"It is not just asking us separately," he said.

Maris leaned closer. "What do you mean?"

Alias looked at Future Alias.

"The road was never only his. And it is not only mine."

Future Alias went still.

Alias remembered the first days after they had met. He remembered Future Alias watching him like a warning made into a person. He remembered learning things about the future that made his own hands feel borrowed. He remembered being afraid that every step was leading toward the grey cloak.

Now he looked at the person inside it.

"I do not want to walk this final road as your second chance," Alias said.

Future Alias's face changed. Not hurt exactly. More like he had expected the words and still had not prepared for them.

"You are not," he said.

"I know," Alias answered. "I need you to know it too."

The wind moved softly through the trees.

Alias held his key over the stone.

"I am not you. You are not only what I might become. We can both choose what comes next."

For a moment, Future Alias could not speak.

Then he put his key beside Alias's.

The two lines touched.

Light moved through all six keys at once.

The bright center on the stone widened into a thin ring. Not a door. Not yet. Just a circle of light, holding them together for one breath before sinking into the rock.

The words changed.

WILLINGLY became:

TOGETHER.

Nobody said anything right away.

There was nothing to add.

The coins in Eldric's hand gave one final soft click.

Then they lifted, one by one, and settled in a line along the eastern edge of the stone. The compass needle turned so sharply that Alias heard it tap the inside of its glass.

East.

Beyond the trees, there was no shining tower waiting for them. No visible doorway. Only a narrow old path, half-covered by frost and pine needles, slipping between two dark hills.

It had probably been there all along.

Rowan stood first. He fastened his coat, picked up his pack, and looked down the path.

"Well," he said. "That looks suspiciously like a road."

"It is," Corvin said.

"Thank you, Corvin. I would have been lost without you."

Maris closed her journal, then put it away. She did not write the moment down yet.

Eldric gathered the coins and placed one in each of their hands, as though returning something that had always belonged there.

When Future Alias received his, he closed his fingers around it. He did not put it away immediately.

Alias watched him look toward the eastern path.

"Ready?" Alias asked.

Future Alias looked at him.

For years, he had answered questions like that by pretending he did not need them. By walking ahead. By leaving before anyone noticed he had gone.

This time, he did not look away.

"No," he said.

Then, after a small breath, "But I am here."

Alias nodded.

"Good enough."

They packed the camp together.

Nothing dramatic happened. Rowan argued with his bedroll. Corvin fixed the knot Rowan had made worse. Maris made sure the fire was fully out. Eldric passed around the last of the warm tea. Future Alias folded his blanket carefully, then accepted the extra one without pretending he had not needed it.

Paper folded itself and slid into Maris's bag.

Before its page disappeared, it wrote one final sentence.

THE LAST DIRECTION IS STILL A ROAD.

Alias read it while the others began to walk.

He thought of all the roads behind them. The one that had led him to the group. The one that had taken Future Alias away. The one that had brought him back in a way nobody fully understood. The roads that had ended at gates, fires, snow towns, watchtowers, old homes, and doors made for returning.

A road could lead someone to a choice.

It could not take the step for them.

Alias adjusted the key against his chest and followed the others east.

For the first time, the coins did not need to pull him forward.

He went because he chose to.

Chapter 27: The Doors We Chose

At the end of the road, they found no treasure. Only a door that asked them to choose it together.

The eastern path did not look like the last road in the world.

It was narrow, uneven, and mostly hidden beneath frost. Pine roots pushed through the earth in crooked lines. Old needles softened the sound of their boots. The hills on either side rose slowly, dark with trees, and the morning light came late between them.

Rowan had expected something more dramatic.

He said so after the first hour.

"I am only saying," he began, stepping over a root, "that when a magical compass finally gives one clear direction after months of being mysterious, the road should at least glow a little. Or have black birds. Or a sign saying **FINAL ROAD THIS WAY.**"

"That sign would make it easier for everyone else," Corvin said.

"Exactly. It is thoughtful design."

"It is also the sort of sign bandits would use."

"Then the bandits would have excellent handwriting."

Maris smiled without looking up from the small notebook she had taken from her pack. She had been writing while she walked, stopping only when the path became too rough for her hand to keep the words straight.

"What did you write?" Alias asked.

"That the final road is disappointingly normal."

Rowan looked pleased. "Thank you."

"That was not praise."

"It can still be used as praise."

Ahead of them, Eldric walked with the coins resting in one hand. They did not pull at him anymore. They did not tremble or slide against one another. They lay still in his palm, warm enough that a little steam gathered in the cold air around his fingers.

Future Alias watched them often.

Not every few minutes, like before. Not with the tightness of someone afraid they would vanish if he looked away. He only checked them when the path bent, or when the trees grew close enough to hide the sky.

Alias noticed because he still noticed.

Future Alias noticed exits. He noticed sounds. He noticed where the ground could turn to mud, where the roots might catch someone's foot, and how far they were from the last place they could have made camp. It had become easier to see the habits now that the group knew why he had them.

But he was trying.

When Rowan slipped on a patch of wet stone and caught himself with an offended noise, Future Alias did not move ahead to inspect the ground first. He only reached out, waited until Rowan took his hand, and helped him balance again.

"I had it," Rowan said.

"You did," Future Alias answered.

"I would have had it more impressively if the stone had not cheated."

"I will speak to the stone," Eldric said from ahead.

Rowan brightened. "Could you?"

"No."

The path continued east.

It did not twist when they looked away. It did not open into a shadowed door or ask anyone to leave the others behind. It was only a road through cold hills, and that almost made Alias more nervous than something openly strange would have.

A road that looked ordinary could still be leading somewhere impossible.

He knew that now.

* * *

They stopped near noon beside a shallow stream. The water moved beneath a skin of thin ice, clear enough to show stones below it. Corvin checked the banks before they unpacked anything. Maris filled her water flask. Rowan tried to break the ice with a stick until Eldric took the stick away from him.

"You are making more work for Corvin," Eldric said.

"I am testing the stream."

"For what?"

"Hidden fish."

Corvin looked at the water. "There are no hidden fish."

"That is exactly what hidden fish want you to believe."

Alias sat near a flat stone and pulled bread from his pack. It was not warm anymore, but it was still bread. After the road they had already walked, that felt like enough.

Future Alias sat beside him, close enough that their shoulders almost touched but did not quite. He held his portion of bread in both hands and stared at the steam rising from the stream.

For a while, neither of them spoke.

Then Future Alias said, "Do you think it will really be empty?"

Alias looked at him. "The final place?"

Future Alias nodded.

"Why would it be?"

"Because the guide said the road does not make choices for people." He gave a small, humourless laugh. "An empty room would be very good at that."

Alias thought about the House of Returning. The doors that had shown what people could choose without choosing for them. The Tower library. Paper's messages. M's notes about lanterns and roads and the limits of helping someone who did not want help yet.

"Maybe empty does not mean nothing," Alias said.

Future Alias glanced at him.

"Maybe it means there is room."

Future Alias looked back at the stream.

"Room for what?"

"Us, probably."

That did not make him smile immediately. But after a moment, he leaned his shoulder lightly against Alias's.

"That sounds too simple."

"Most important things are annoying like that."

"Is that what Paper told you?"

"No. Paper would have made it insulting."

At the mention of its name, Paper unfolded itself from Maris's bag. It slipped through the air with all the dignity of something that had not been carried upside down beside a pencil case and a dried apple.

A sentence appeared across it.

I CAN STILL MAKE IT INSULTING.

Rowan looked over from where he was trying to convince Corvin that a wet boot was a personal tragedy.

"I knew it could hear us."

YOU SAY EVERYTHING LOUDLY.

"That is not an answer."

IT IS THE MOST ACCURATE ANSWER AVAILABLE.

Even Future Alias laughed at that, quietly enough that the sound could almost have been missed.

Alias did not miss it.

* * *

The road changed in the afternoon.

Not suddenly. There was no line across the ground and no flash of light. The trees simply began to stand farther apart. Their trunks grew taller, pale and smooth, with branches so high that the wind moved through them long before it reached the travellers below.

The frost vanished from the path.

Not melted. Gone.

One step, the earth was grey-white beneath their boots. The next, it was dark and bare, soft with old leaves.

Corvin stopped first.

"Everyone stay where you are."

Rowan froze halfway through a step. "Did I do something?"

"No."

"Good. I am asking because you said it in the voice people use before there is a monster."

"There is no monster," Eldric said.

"That does not make the voice better."

Corvin crouched and touched the ground. He pressed two fingers against the bare earth, then held them out. No mud clung to them. No cold showed on his glove.

"It is warmer here," he said.

Maris moved closer, careful not to cross the line he had noticed. "Is it a Structure?"

Eldric looked past the trees. His expression had become quiet in the way it did when he was listening to something the others could not hear.

"The edge of one," he said. "Or the edge of a place made by one."

Future Alias's hand went to the pocket where he had kept his coin. Alias saw it, then saw him stop himself from gripping it too hard.

"The compass?" Eldric asked.

Future Alias took it out.

The needle pointed east.

It did not spin. It did not hesitate.

"Still east," he said.

"That is comforting," Rowan said. "Except for the part where the ground is deciding whether it wants winter."

Maris looked at the pale trees. "Maybe it is not deciding. Maybe the winter ended here a long time ago."

"That is worse," Rowan said.

Nobody argued with him.

Eldric nodded once toward the bare ground.

"We entered together," he said. "We continue together."

No one had to repeat the rule. They crossed the strange line one at a time, but close enough that each person could see the others. Alias stepped beside Future Alias. Rowan stayed between Maris and Corvin. Eldric came last, coins warm in his palm.

Nothing attacked them.

Nothing whispered.

The forest only became still.

Alias could hear his own breathing. He could hear Rowan's coat brush against the branches. He could hear the soft scrape of Corvin's boot when he shifted his weight. Beneath it all, there was a low sound that was not quite wind and not quite music.

A waiting sound.

The path led them between the pale trunks until the trees stopped all at once.

Beyond them stood a wall of dark stone.

It rose from the hill as if it had always been part of it. No tower stood above it. No windows looked down from it. There were no flags, no carvings of old rulers, no great animal statues guarding the entrance.

There was only a door.

It was taller than any of them by three times over and wide enough for a cart, though there was no road broad enough to bring one here. The stone around it was smooth. Six narrow keyholes had been cut into the door in a circle around its centre.

They were not identical.

Each had a slightly different shape: one long and straight, one curved at the end, one with a small split in its side. None of them looked like a name. None of them had a symbol beside it.

The keys in their packs became warm.

Rowan exhaled through his nose. "All right. This is more like it."

"You wanted a sign," Corvin said.

"I wanted a sign. I did not ask for a wall."

Maris walked closer but did not touch the stone. "There is no writing."

Alias looked for it too. There were no words at eye level, no warning on the ground, no message hiding in the shadows. The door did not tell them what it wanted.

It only waited.

Future Alias stood very still.

Alias could see the tension in his shoulders. It was different from fear of an attack. There was no exit to watch here. No sound to track. No easy way to prepare for a door that might lead him home, or away from it, or somewhere that neither of those words could reach.

"You all right?" Alias asked quietly.

Future Alias did not answer right away.

Then he said, "I thought I would feel more certain when we got here."

Alias looked at the door.

"Maybe certainty is not part of it."

"That is not comforting."

"I know."

Eldric came to stand beside them. He held the coins in both hands now, and the metal lay quiet against his skin.

"M did not make places that forced people to prove themselves," he said. "That would not have been a guide. It would have been a trap."

"And this is not a trap?" Rowan asked.

Eldric considered the door.

"I do not know," he said honestly. "But it has not asked any of us to leave someone behind. That is a good beginning."

Paper lifted itself from Maris's shoulder and drifted toward the door. It hovered near the centre, where the six keyholes formed a circle.

For a long time, it remained blank.

Then the words appeared.

YOU HAVE KEYS.

Rowan stared at it.

"That is the whole message?"

YES.

"That is not very helpful."

YOU HAVE ALL HAD A LONG TIME TO PRACTISE.

Corvin sighed. "It is right."

"I hate when it is right."

"You hate when anyone is right except you," Maris said.

"That is not true."

Everyone looked at him.

Rowan thought about it.

"Fine. It is mostly true."

* * *

They took out the keys.

Alias's key was cold at first. He had carried it close to his chest for so long that he had almost forgotten its shape. In his palm, it looked older than the door and younger than anything old should be, as if it had only just been made and had somehow already gathered years around it.

One by one, the others stepped forward.

No one assigned places.

The keys did it themselves.

When Alias approached the circle, one keyhole gave off a faint line of silver light. When Rowan moved beside him, a different keyhole answered. Then Maris. Corvin. Eldric. Future Alias.

Each key found the place where it belonged.

They looked at one another.

"Do we put them in at the same time?" Maris asked.

"Probably," Corvin said.

"What happens if we do it wrong?" Rowan asked.

"Probably nothing good," Corvin answered.

"That is not comforting either."

Eldric smiled a little.

"The door has waited for all six of us," he said. "It can wait one more breath."

He did not give an order. He only held his key near the slot and looked around the circle.

"Are you here because you choose to be?"

The question settled over them more heavily than a command could have.

Alias looked down at his key.

He thought of Book 1. Of walking into a road because he did not know where else to go. Of not understanding why the coins, the Structures, and the people around him seemed to keep asking him to stay.

He thought of the gatehouse. Of the wolf in the forest. Of the way Future Alias had looked at the road in front of him and said he was not ready, but he was here.

Alias lifted his eyes.

"Yes," he said.

Rowan was next.

He swallowed, then shrugged as if he had not just been asked something important by a door in a forest.

"Yes," he said. "Also, I would like to know why there are six keyholes and no snack table."

"Rowan," Maris said.

"I am being emotionally honest."

Maris's mouth twitched.

"Yes," she said. "I choose it. Even if I do not understand it yet."

Corvin looked at the door as though it was a difficult problem he could solve if he stared at it long enough. Then his shoulders eased.

"Yes," he said. "I want to see the end of the road. And what comes after it."

Eldric held his key in front of him.

"Yes," he said. "Not because anyone needs me to decide for them. Because I want to walk beside them while they decide for themselves."

For a second, Future Alias did not move.

Alias waited.

No one rushed him.

At last, Future Alias looked from face to face: Rowan trying not to look too serious, Maris holding her journal against her chest, Corvin standing steady with both feet planted, Eldric calm beside the door, and Alias nearest of all.

Future Alias's eyes stopped on Alias.

"Yes," he said.

His voice shook once.

Then it steadied.

"I choose to be here."

Six keys entered six locks.

The sound was small.

Not thunder. Not a choir. Not a great magical bell travelling across the hills.

Just six soft clicks, close together.

For one breath, nothing happened.

Then the keys grew warm beneath their hands.

The silver lines around each keyhole joined. They spread through the stone in a circle, thin as threads and bright as moonlight. The door did not open at once. Instead, it seemed to breathe inward, as if the hill itself had taken a long quiet breath and decided to let them pass.

The stone moved without grinding.

A narrow line of darkness appeared down the centre.

Then the door opened.

* * *

The room beyond was not dark for long.

Soft white light came from nowhere Alias could see. It filled the space evenly, without casting sharp shadows. The room was round, built from pale stone. Its ceiling curved high above them, smooth and plain.

There were no shelves full of lost books.

No piles of treasure.

No throne.

No sleeping monster.

No enormous machine waiting to explain the universe.

In the centre stood a plain wooden table.

That was all.

The table was round and wide enough for all six of them. It had scratches along one edge, as though someone had once used it for writing or drawing maps. There were no chairs around it. No objects rested on it. No symbols had been carved into its surface.

The room was empty.

Rowan stepped in first, slowly, then turned in a circle.

"That is it?"

Nobody answered.

He checked beneath the table.

"Not even a biscuit."

"Why would there be a biscuit?" Corvin asked.

"Because it is the final place. People should be prepared."

Maris walked around the room with her journal open, but she did not write anything. Her eyes moved from the high ceiling to the blank walls, then to the open door behind them.

"It is not empty," she said.

Rowan looked under the table again. "I promise you it is."

"Not like that." Maris rested one hand on the table. "It has space. It is meant to have space."

Alias felt it too.

The room did not feel abandoned. It did not feel like someone had forgotten to place the important part inside.

It felt like someone had cleared everything away on purpose.

Like a table before a difficult conversation.

Like the pause after someone asked a question and before anyone was brave enough to answer.

Future Alias stepped into the room last.

The door stayed open behind him. The six keys remained in the stone, each one glowing faintly.

He stared at the table.

"I expected a judgement," he said.

His words sounded too loud in the quiet room.

Alias stood beside him.

"From who?"

Future Alias looked toward the ceiling.

"From M. From the Tower. From whatever made all of this." He made a small motion toward the empty room. "I thought there would be someone here to tell me whether I did enough. Whether I ruined too much. Whether I should have come back at all."

Eldric moved closer to the table.

"And would you have believed them?" he asked.

Future Alias did not answer.

Eldric nodded as if that was answer enough.

"There are questions no stranger can finish for you," he said. "Not even a wise stranger. Not even one who built a road through impossible places."

"That is cruel," Future Alias said.

"Sometimes," Eldric replied. "But it is also freedom."

Rowan stopped searching for biscuits.

He looked at Future Alias, then at the table.

"So we came all this way to sit around a table?"

Paper floated in from the doorway. It landed flat on the wood.

HUMANS HAVE SOLVED WORSE PROBLEMS AROUND TABLES.

Rowan leaned over it.

"Have they solved snack problems?"

NO.

"That seems like a flaw in humanity."

ONE OF MANY.

Maris finally wrote something in her journal.

Alias did not ask what.

He walked to the table and placed one hand on its edge. The wood was warm. Not magically hot.

Warm the way a table became warm after sunlight had rested on it for a long time.

He looked around at the others.

They had come here expecting a final answer. A prize. A door home. A way to prove that every frightening road, every choice, every loss, had meant something clear.

Instead, they had been given a room.

A table.

Enough space for all of them.

It should have felt disappointing.

Maybe a part of him did feel disappointed. He was still someone who wanted answers. He still wanted the strange roads to explain why they had chosen him, why they had brought Future Alias back, why the past had to hurt so much before it could become something they could carry.

But another part of him understood.

A room could be empty because nothing was there.

Or it could be empty because everyone had finally been given room to speak.

"We should sit," Alias said.

There were no chairs.

Rowan blinked. "On what?"

Alias looked around.

Then he sat on the floor beside the table.

For a moment, Rowan looked offended by this solution.

Then he sat too.

"This is not how I imagined the end of a magical road," he said.

"You imagined biscuits," Maris reminded him.

"I imagined a magical road with biscuits. That was only one part of it."

Maris sat across from Alias. Corvin lowered himself beside her, setting his pack within reach. Eldric sat near the door but not in front of it. He left space beside him without saying anything.

Future Alias stood alone for one breath longer.

Then he came forward and sat in the space Eldric had left.

No one made a speech about it.

No one pretended not to notice.

Paper lay blank on the table.

The door behind them began to close.

It made no sound. The bright line around the keyholes dimmed slowly, and the wall became whole again. The keys did not fall. They remained where they were, six small shapes of light in dark stone.

The room was quiet.

Nothing happened.

Not yet.

But nobody stood up to leave.

Chapter 28: The Note Still Being Written

The final message did not offer an answer. It offered a reason to keep walking.

The room waited with them.

At first, it did nothing at all.

The six keys remained in the wall behind them, each one glowing with the same low, steady light. The table was still warm beneath Alias's palm. Paper lay flat in the middle of it, blank as though it had used up every rude opinion it had ever possessed.

Rowan lasted perhaps twelve seconds.

"So," he said, looking around the quiet circular room, "is this the part where the walls explain everything?"

Nothing answered.

He waited.

"Or the part where a hidden drawer opens and gives us biscuits?"

Still nothing.

"I feel this room is not respecting the mood I have carefully built."

Corvin leaned back against the wall. "Your mood has never once been carefully built."

"That is unfair. I build it every morning."

"With what?"

"Hope. And breakfast."

Maris smiled despite herself, then looked down at the blank Paper. "Maybe it needs time."

"For what?" Rowan asked.

"To decide whether it wants to answer us."

Paper remained still.

Alias looked toward Future Alias.

He had not moved much since sitting down beside Eldric. His grey cloak pooled around him on the floor, darker than the stone. His hands were folded in his lap. He was watching the keys with the kind of attention someone gave a sleeping animal: not wanting to wake it, but not trusting it to remain quiet forever.

"What do you think happens now?" Alias asked.

Future Alias gave a short breath that was almost a laugh.

"I have spent a long time being wrong about that question."

No one rushed to fill the silence after that.

The room did not feel dangerous. Not exactly. It did not feel safe in the easy way a familiar inn did either. It felt awake.

Then a dark line appeared on Paper.

Maris leaned forward first.

The line became a word.

Then another.

Ink moved across the page without a pen. It did not rush. The letters arrived slowly, carefully, like someone writing at a table far away and pausing between thoughts.

CONGRATULATIONS.

Rowan blinked.

"That is either very good or very alarming."

The ink continued.

YOU FOUND THE END OF THIS ROAD.

A second line formed beneath it.

PLEASE DO NOT MISTAKE THAT FOR THE END OF YOUR WALKING.

For a moment, nobody spoke.

The words were neat, but not too neat. The letters leaned slightly to the left in places. There was a small unevenness in the line beneath PLEASE, as though the writer had pressed too hard or written after too little sleep.

Alias had seen M's handwriting in old records and travel notes. This looked like it.

Not copied.

Not carved into stone long ago.

Written now.

Maris lifted one hand over the page without touching it. "M?"

The ink paused.

Then it wrote:

HELLO, MARIS.

Rowan sat up straighter. "Oh. It knows names. I do not like that."

Paper snapped upright, folded itself once, and wrote over the new words in large, sharp letters.

YOU HAVE BEEN AWARE OF THIS FOR SEVERAL BOOKS.

Rowan pointed at it. "I have been aware in a general way. This is more specific."

A new line appeared beneath Paper's message. The two sets of ink did not mix.

I AM SORRY IF THAT WAS UNSETTLING.

Paper added beneath it:

IT WAS.

Corvin covered his mouth with one hand. Alias could not tell whether he was hiding a smile or a sigh.

Eldric looked at the page with patient interest. "Are you truly M?"

The ink took longer this time.

I AM A RECORD LEFT BY M.

Another line followed.

**I HAVE LEARNED THAT A RECORD CAN BECOME A LITTLE MORE THAN A RECORD WHEN
ENOUGH PEOPLE KEEP ANSWERING IT.**

Rowan stared.

"That does not answer the question."

**NO, Paper wrote. BUT IT IS A BETTER ANSWER THAN PRETENDING IT HAS ONE SIMPLE
VERSION.**

Future Alias's gaze stayed on the page.

"You are writing now," he said quietly.

The page was still for a moment.

I AM WRITING NOW.

The sentence should have made the room colder.

Instead, Alias felt something loosen in his chest. M had become such a large mystery over the years of strange roads, Towers, old notes, and impossible doors that it had been easy to imagine a god behind all of it. Someone watching from far above. Someone who had planned every loss before it happened.

But the letters on the page were imperfect. They paused. They leaned.

They felt like a person trying to choose the right words.

Alias drew a breath. "Then why did you bring us here?"

The room seemed to listen.

M's answer formed beneath his question.

I DID NOT BRING YOU HERE.

Alias frowned.

The next line appeared.

I LEFT A WAY FOR PEOPLE WHO ARRIVED TOGETHER TO FIND A DOOR.

Then:

THE ROAD BROUGHT YOU AS FAR AS A ROAD COULD. YOU CHOSE THE REST.

Corvin looked over his shoulder toward the six keys in the wall. "And those?"

The ink made a small mark before continuing, as though M had considered how to begin.

THE KEYS ARE NOT A TEST OF WORTH.

THEY ARE NOT A REWARD FOR BEING GOOD.

THEY ARE NOT PROOF THAT ANY OF YOU WERE CHOSEN ABOVE SOMEONE ELSE.

Rowan exhaled. "Good. Because I have made several choices that would have made that system very unfair."

"Several?" Corvin asked.

"Today? Or generally?"

M wrote on.

A KEY IS A WAY OF ASKING WHETHER SOMEONE WISHES TO CONTINUE.

SIX OF YOU ARRIVED. SIX OF YOU CHOSE. SO THERE WERE SIX KEYS.

ANOTHER GROUP WOULD HAVE FOUND A DIFFERENT DOOR.

ANOTHER GROUP MIGHT HAVE FOUND A DIFFERENT NUMBER.

Maris looked at the wall. "So the number was never the important part."

NO.

The next line appeared more slowly.

THE IMPORTANT PART WAS THAT NONE OF YOU HAD TO TURN A KEY ALONE.

The sentence settled over them.

Alias thought of the gatehouse. The watchtower. The old shelter. Future Alias sitting by a fire and pretending that leaving first was the same as being strong. He thought of how many doors he had almost opened by himself. How often he had believed that needing someone nearby would make him smaller.

Beside him, Future Alias looked down at his hands.

Eldric did not speak.

He did not need to.

Maris touched the edge of Paper carefully. "What are the Structures, then? Really?"

M's answer came in lines that appeared one after another.

THEY ARE ROOMS BUILT AROUND QUESTIONS PEOPLE COULD NOT STOP ASKING.

HOW DO I RETURN?

HOW DO I LEAVE?

HOW DO I SAY GOODBYE?

HOW DO I KEEP GOING WHEN I CANNOT FIX WHAT HAPPENED?

The room felt larger after that.

Not because its walls moved. They did not.

But because Alias could see the road inside those questions. The road that had led Future Alias away. The road that had led him back. The road that had brought them to old homes, old friends, old grief, and choices that did not become easier just because they had answers.

A STRUCTURE CANNOT HEAL A WOUND FOR SOMEONE, M wrote.

IT CAN OFFER A QUIET PLACE TO LOOK AT IT.

IT CAN OFFER A DOOR.

IT CANNOT WALK THROUGH THAT DOOR FOR YOU.

Paper added, in smaller letters:

IT ALSO CANNOT MAKE YOU LESS STUBBORN. THIS HAS BEEN TESTED.

Rowan nodded gravely. "I appreciate the research."

"You are the research," Corvin said.

"I knew it. I have always been important."

That made Maris laugh, a real laugh this time. The sound did not break the room's seriousness. It made it easier to breathe inside it.

Future Alias looked at the page again. "Then why did the Tower send me back?"

Everything in the room seemed to grow still.

Alias turned toward him.

He knew the answer mattered. Not only because Future Alias had spent so long fearing it, but because no answer could give him permission to believe that all of this had been arranged for him.

No answer could make the group into pieces of a story built to repair him.

M's ink did not move for a long time.

At last, it wrote:

YOU ASKED TO GO HOME.

Future Alias's shoulders tightened.

**THE TOWER DID NOT KNOW WHETHER YOU MEANT A PLACE, A TIME, A PERSON, OR A
VERSION OF YOURSELF THAT NO LONGER EXISTED.**

No one interrupted.

SO IT GAVE YOU A ROAD.

NOT TO ERASE WHAT YOU HAD DONE.

NOT TO RETURN WHAT YOU HAD LOST.

NOT TO MAKE YOUR FRIENDS RESPONSIBLE FOR SAVING YOU.

The words were not cruel.

That made them harder to hear.

Future Alias closed his eyes.

M continued.

IT GAVE YOU THE CHANCE TO SEE THE ROAD YOU HAD LEFT.

AND THE CHANCE TO CHOOSE DIFFERENTLY WHILE WALKING IT.

Alias felt Future Alias's hand shake once against the floor between them.

Without thinking too much about it, he placed his own hand beside it. Not touching. Just close enough that the choice stayed visible.

Future Alias looked at their hands for a moment.

Then he moved his fingers until the side of his little finger rested against Alias's.

It was barely a touch.

It was enough.

"So it was not a second chance," Future Alias said.

M's answer appeared almost immediately.

IT WAS A CHANCE.

THERE IS A DIFFERENCE.

Future Alias let out a breath that shook on the way out.

Rowan looked down at the keys, then back to the page. "And this is it?"
He looked embarrassed the moment he said it, as though he worried it sounded disappointed.

M did not seem offended.

THIS IS THE END OF THIS ROAD.

THE ROAD WAS NEVER A PRIZE.

THE ANSWER WAS NEVER A TREASURE WAITING AT THE LAST DOOR.

A final group of words appeared, darker than the rest.

YOU DID NOT FIND ENLIGHTENMENT.

YOU FOUND EACH OTHER.

THIS IS USUALLY MORE USEFUL.

For several seconds, no one said anything.

Then Paper wrote beneath it:

AND FAR MORE INCONVENIENT.

Rowan made an offended noise. "We are not inconvenient."

Paper considered this.

I WILL NOT DEBATE A DOCUMENTED FACT.

Even Future Alias smiled.

It was small. It did not solve the sadness in his face. It did not make all the years behind him
harmless.

But he smiled.

Alias looked at the people around the table. Rowan with snow still somehow caught in the fold of
one boot. Maris's journal held against her knee. Corvin watching everyone while pretending he was
only watching the page. Eldric calm and tired and present. Future Alias beside him, no longer sitting
apart from the group even when he thought he was.

No treasure could have done what this had done.

No final answer could have made it less frightening to keep walking.

But the room had not asked them to stop.

It had asked them to remember they did not need to walk alone.

The six keys in the wall brightened.

A low sound moved through the stone beneath them. Not a warning. Not quite a bell. The room
hummed as if a faraway road had begun to sing under the floor.

Future Alias went still.

His hand pulled away from Alias's.

"What is it?" Maris asked.

He looked down at his chest.

The old coin there was moving beneath his shirt.

Not spinning restlessly like it had before.

Pulling.

He drew it out.

The coin lay in his palm, warm and bright. The faint line of its engraved road pointed not toward the door behind them, nor toward the six keys.

It pointed into the centre of the table.

A thin ring of light appeared there.

Eldric stood slowly, but he did not reach for a weapon.

"Future Alias?"

Future Alias swallowed.

"I think," he said, and had to stop for a breath, "I think it is trying to send me back."

The room became very quiet again.

No one looked pleased.

No one said that was what they had wanted all along.

Alias stared at the coin. The word back felt too small for what it meant. Back to a world where the people in this room had lived and died. Back to Gerhardt. Back to old graves. Back to a Tower library and a version of himself that had believed he could survive by becoming a shadow.

"Home?" Alias asked.

Future Alias looked at him.

Fear was there. So was something else.

Not the old hunger to flee.

Not the helpless wish that someone else would decide for him.

A choice.

"I do not know," Future Alias said honestly. "But I think it is my road."

The light at the centre of the table widened by the smallest amount.

M wrote one last line beneath all the others.

NOT EVERYONE LEAVES A ROOM BY THE SAME DOOR.

Future Alias read it twice.

Then he nodded.

Not because he was ready.

Because he understood that readiness was not the only thing a road could ask for.

Alias looked at the circle of light, then at the person who had once arrived as a frightening stranger in a grey cloak. The person who had become a thief, a wolf, a warning, a friend, and something neither of them had known how to name.

The room had not ended their road.

It had simply opened one more door.

Chapter 29: The Farewell That Was Not a Flight

Leaving was different when you were not trying to escape.

The ring of light at the centre of the table did not pull.

That was the first thing Alias noticed.

It did not reach for Future Alias. It did not grow brighter when he moved or dim when he stood still. It simply waited, a thin circle of gold set into the wood, warm enough to turn the edge of every hand around it pale.

For years, Future Alias had been afraid of doors.

Alias knew that now. Not only the impossible kind. Not only the doors inside Towers or Structures. He had been afraid of ordinary ones too: an inn room after someone had invited him in, a campfire with an empty place beside it, a gate that might close behind him before he had decided whether he was allowed to return.

This door did not close.

It waited.

Future Alias stood beside it with his coin in one hand and his other hand pressed flat against the leather strap around his journal. His grey cloak hung heavily from his shoulders. He looked at the light as if he expected it to turn cruel when he trusted it.

"Does it hurt?" Maris asked.

Future Alias blinked, as though he had forgotten anyone else was there.

"No," he said. "It is only warm."

Rowan leaned forward a little. "Warm is usually a good sign. Unless it is soup that has been left out too long."

Corvin looked at him. "You have a very narrow understanding of danger."

"No, I have a broad understanding. It includes soup."

A small laugh moved around the table. It did not make the room less sad. It made it possible to remain inside the sadness without being swallowed by it.

Future Alias looked from one of them to another.

He had looked at them like that before. Alias had seen him do it at breakfast, at camp, before sleeping. Like he was trying to remember every detail in case there came a time when memory was all he had left.

This time, Alias did not let him look away.

"You do not have to go immediately," he said.

The words were simple. They still seemed to change something in Future Alias's face.

"I know," he said after a moment.

Paper wrote, in its sharp little letters:

THIS IS NOT A TRAIN. THERE IS NO WHISTLE.

Rowan looked relieved. "Good. I never know what to do when things have whistles."

"You wave," Maris said.

"At a magical door?"

"At a train."

"That seems too ordinary."

Future Alias looked down, but Alias saw the corner of his mouth move.

The ring of light stayed open.

Eldric rose from his place at the table first. He did not go to the light. He went to the small pile of supplies they had carried into the room: blankets, water, the shared journal, the things they had refused to leave behind even when the final road had promised an end.

He picked up the little cloth bundle of tea leaves from his pack.

"There is not much left," he said. "But there is enough for one cup."

Rowan made a sound of surprise. "You brought tea into the final mysterious room?"

Eldric looked at him. "Of course I did."

"I think I love you a little," Rowan said.

"That has been obvious for years."

Eldric found a small travel kettle and the last of their water. There was no fire in the circular room. He set the kettle down beside the ring of light anyway.

For a moment, nothing happened.

Then the bottom of the kettle began to glow with the same low gold warmth as the door. Not hot enough to burn the table. Hot enough to make the water tremble.

Paper wrote:

THIS ROOM HAS MADE A QUESTIONABLE CHOICE.

"It made tea," Eldric said.

THAT IS NOT WHAT I MEANT.

The sound of water beginning to warm felt impossibly ordinary.

They sat around the table while it happened.

No one said it was a goodbye at first.

Perhaps that was because saying it would make it real. Perhaps it was because all of them had learned that some words were too heavy to throw into the middle of a room without first making sure everyone had somewhere safe to stand.

Alias watched steam begin to rise from the kettle.

Future Alias stood beside the light, silent, holding his coin as though it might tell him what to say.

"Sit down," Eldric told him.

Future Alias looked at the circle of light.

"It will wait," Eldric said.

Future Alias stared at him for a long moment.

Then he sat.

Not at the edge of the group.

Between Alias and Eldric.

Eldric poured six uneven cups of tea once the water had cooled enough to be kind. There was not enough for full cups. It did not matter. Each one was warm between their hands.

Rowan took one careful sip and made a face. "This is very grown-up tea."

"It is mint," Eldric said.

"Mint has never forgiven me for something."

Corvin took Rowan's cup before he could spill it. "Drink it anyway."

Future Alias lifted his own cup but did not drink.

Eldric's pale green tea-leaf charm was tied to the cord around his wrist. Alias noticed it only because he had been looking for small things. The little wooden leaf was worn smooth from being touched.

"You kept it," Eldric said quietly.

Future Alias looked at the charm.

"I kept all of them," he said.

The sentence landed softly.

He did not explain. Nobody asked him to.

Rowan reached inside his coat and pulled out the little pale wooden lantern he had carved in Wrenfall. Its yellow paper centre had become a little bent at one corner, but it was still a lantern.

"This is yours," Rowan said. "You do not have to give it back. I just wanted to say..."

He stopped. For once, no joke arrived to save him.

Future Alias waited.

Rowan rubbed his thumb against the lantern's uneven side. "You did not have to become someone else just because things got hard. I know that now. I mean, I knew it in a general way. But I did not know it like this."

Future Alias's eyes lowered.

"You were still you when you came back to breakfast," Rowan continued. "You were still you when you stole my spoon. You were still you when you were frightened. You are still you now. So... do not go back and decide you have to become the grey cloak again."

For a moment, Future Alias could not answer.

Then he reached across the table and took the little lantern from Rowan's hand. He held it carefully, as though it were made from glass instead of poor carving and stubborn kindness.

"I will try," he said.

Rowan shook his head. "No. That is too weak. Say you will annoy Paper with us from a different road."

Paper immediately wrote:

PLEASE DO NOT MAKE THIS A PROMISE.

Future Alias's laugh was quiet, but it was real.

"I will try to annoy Paper," he said.

"Good enough," Rowan replied, wiping one eye with the back of his wrist as though he had simply gotten tea there.

Corvin had been looking down at the table. Now he took the compass-marked cord from where it rested around his own wrist.

The bead was dark from rain and use. The little carved arrow was barely visible under the wear of his thumb.

"I thought about giving you this," he said. "Then I thought you already have yours."

Future Alias touched the cord tied to his journal, where the small compass bead rested against the leather strap.

"I do," he said.

"Good." Corvin nodded once. "Keep it somewhere you can see it. Not because you owe anyone a return. Not because you have to come back exactly the same. Just because you should know where you are trying to go."

Future Alias looked at him.

Corvin's voice became firmer, almost practical enough to hide the feeling beneath it. "And because a return marker is allowed to mean more than one place. It can mean a tavern. A grave. A fire. A person you have not spoken to in too long. Do not decide you have nowhere to return to before you check."

Future Alias's fingers closed around the cord on his journal.

"I will not," he said.

Corvin nodded again. Then, after a second, he added, "And do not use the cord to tie anything dangerous. It is not as strong as it looks."

"That is your final advice?" Rowan asked.

"It is useful advice."

"It is very you."

"I know."

Maris had been holding her folded New Year note in both hands. It had been inside the shared journal since Wrenfall. The edges were softened from being opened and closed.

She gave it to Future Alias without speaking.

He took it, then looked confused.

"You still have yours," she said.

"I do."

"I know. This is mine."

He looked at the folded paper again.

"I wanted you to have it," Maris said. "Not because it says anything important. It just has something I noticed about you. I want you to have proof that I noticed."

Future Alias unfolded it slowly.

Alias could not read it from where he sat. He watched Future Alias's face instead.

Whatever was written there made his breathing change.

"What does it say?" Rowan asked.

Maris looked at him. "It is not for you."

"I am part of the group."

"That is exactly why you should know better."

Future Alias folded the paper along its old lines. His thumb stayed over one word, protecting it from the room.

"Thank you," he said.

Maris nodded.

"I will remember," he added.

"You do not have to remember every word," she said. "Just remember that it happened. You were here. We were here."

Future Alias swallowed.

"I will remember that," he said.

Alias knew Maris's note to him by heart now.

You never walk at the front for long. You keep moving back to make sure everyone is still there.

He wondered what Maris had written for the person who had spent so long convinced nobody was looking back for him.

Eldric did not offer a speech right away.

He finished his tea. He placed his empty cup down. Then he looked at Future Alias with the same calm attention he had used at the fire outside the watchtower.

"There is something I want to tell you," Eldric said.

Future Alias waited.

"You will feel tempted to make this moment into a judgement. You will think of everyone you lost. You will count what you should have done differently. You will stand in familiar places and decide you have arrived too late to deserve them."

Future Alias's face tightened.

Eldric continued before he could argue.

"Some of that grief is yours to carry. You do not need to pretend otherwise. But you are not required to carry it as a punishment."

The steam above the kettle had faded. The room felt quieter without it.

"When you speak to the people you left behind," Eldric said, "speak honestly. When you stand before the dead, tell them the truth. When you stand before the living, let them answer you. Do not decide their answers for them before you have given them the chance."

Future Alias looked down at his hands.

"I am afraid," he said.

"Of course you are," Eldric replied. "Fear is not a sign you have chosen wrongly. Sometimes it is only proof that the choice matters."

Future Alias closed his eyes.

Eldric leaned forward and placed his hand over the younger man's fist, not trapping it. Just touching it.

"Go home," he said.

Two small words.

They were gentler than a command.

Future Alias opened his eyes.

"I do not know if I still have one," he whispered.

Eldric's hand remained where it was.

"Then go and find out."

Alias had been quiet too long.

He had known there would be something he wanted to say. He had tried to prepare it in his head, arranging the sentences like supplies before a difficult journey.

Now that the moment was there, every prepared sentence felt false.

Future Alias turned to him.

Alias saw the person in the grey cloak. The wolf by the fire. The thief who knew where to step. The frightened older self who had spent years trying to turn grief into a map back to someone he could no longer be.

He also saw the person who had stayed at breakfast.

"You still have time," Alias said.

Future Alias's face broke a little at that.

Alias did not look away.

"You told me that," he said. "When I did not know what I was going to become. You said I was not already you. That I could choose."

Future Alias gave the smallest nod.

"You can choose too," Alias said. "You still have time."

For a while, Future Alias could not speak.

Then he looked at Alias as though he was seeing him through a doorway that had been locked for years.

"So do you," he said.

Alias smiled, though his throat hurt.

"I know," he said. "I think I am starting to."

Their hands found each other on the table.

Not like a promise that neither of them would ever be afraid again.

Not like a way to hold someone still.

Only a hand beside a hand.

Future Alias's coin warmed between them.

The light at the centre of the table widened.

The room did not rush him.

It simply made space.

Future Alias stood slowly.

Rowan stood too, then Maris, Corvin, Eldric, and Alias. The six keys remained behind them in the wall. For a moment, their soft glow reflected in the wetness at the corners of several eyes.

Nobody pretended not to notice.

Future Alias took his journal from beneath his cloak. The leather strap Alias had made still held it closed. The compass cord still hung from its spine. He tucked something small beneath the strap - Alias caught a glimpse of red, then the corner of folded paper - but the movement was too quick to understand.

Future Alias placed one hand over the journal.

Then he looked at the group.

"I do not know what happens after I step through," he said.

"Neither do we," Corvin replied.

"That is normal for roads," Rowan added. "Very rude, but normal."

Future Alias smiled.

"I am sorry," he began.

Eldric lifted one hand.

"You may be sorry," he said. "But do not make this only an apology."

Future Alias looked at him.

"You are not leaving to escape a room full of people you hurt," Eldric continued. "You are leaving because your road is asking for you. There is a difference."

The words settled into him.

Future Alias nodded.

"Then," he said, trying again, "thank you."

Rowan stepped forward and pulled him into a fierce, sudden hug.

Future Alias froze.

Then, slowly, he hugged Rowan back.

"Do not crush him," Corvin said. "We have only just taught him not to disappear."

"I am giving him structural support," Rowan said into Future Alias's cloak.

Maris hugged him next. She said something too soft for Alias to hear. Future Alias bent his head and listened as though the words were precious enough to break.

Corvin held out his hand. Future Alias took it. Then Corvin pulled him into a brief, awkward embrace that lasted exactly two seconds longer than either of them expected.

"Return marker," Corvin said when they stepped apart.

Future Alias touched his journal. "Return marker."

Eldric embraced him last before Alias.

It was not dramatic. It was not a farewell that tried to make itself important by becoming difficult to bear. Eldric held him with the steady warmth of someone making room at a fire.

"Go home," he said again.

Future Alias closed his eyes.

"I will try," he whispered.

"No," Rowan said. "We already fixed that one."

Future Alias laughed through the tears in his voice.

"I will go home," he said.

Then he faced Alias.

For one second, neither of them moved.

Alias did not know whether to hug him. Future Alias had never seemed like someone who knew what to do with hugs until five minutes ago.

So Alias opened his arms.

Future Alias stepped into them.

The hug was awkward at first because they were too similar in the ways they held themselves tight. Then Future Alias let out a breath and rested his forehead briefly against Alias's shoulder.

"You do not have to become the version of me that I was," he said quietly.

"I know."

"Do not let fear teach you that being alone is the same as being safe."

Alias held on a little tighter.

"I will not," he said. "And you do not have to become Varux again."

Future Alias drew back enough to look at him.

"I do not know who I will be," he admitted.

Alias thought of the first morning at home. Future Alias standing in a warm room and looking as though happiness was something he had to memorize before it vanished.

"That is all right," Alias said. "You can find out."

Future Alias nodded.

The ring of light shone around their feet.

He stepped to its edge.

He did not look like someone being sent away.

He looked like someone standing at the start of a road he was finally willing to take.

Alias's hand found the red thread tied beneath his own sleeve. He had not noticed he was touching it until then.

Future Alias's eyes followed the movement.

For a moment, something passed between them. A quiet recognition. A secret that did not need explaining yet.

Then Future Alias looked at all of them one more time.

"Go home," Alias said.

The others joined him, not perfectly together.

"Go home."

Future Alias closed his eyes.

When he opened them, he was crying.

But he was smiling too.

"Go home," he answered.

Then he stepped into the light.

The gold rose around him without sound. It took the outline of his cloak first, then his hands, then the small journal held tight against his chest. For one heartbeat, Alias could still see him through it: older and tired and frightened and alive.

The light did not pull him away. It opened. Future Alias walked forward, and the room let him go.

Chapter 30: The Library Again

Some proof is small enough to fit in one hand.

The first thing Future Alias knew was pain.

The second was dust.

It was in his mouth, on his cheek, in the back of his throat where he had made a noise that might have been a groan or a cough. The floor beneath him was hard stone. A smell of paper, old wood, rain that had dried somewhere long ago, and the faint burnt scent of a fireplace that had not been used in months pressed around him.

He did not move at first.

For one wild moment, he thought he had only dreamed the road.

The breakfast table. Snow falling over Wrenfall. Rowan shouting because someone had thrown a snowball down the back of his coat. Maris writing by firelight. Corvin folding maps into impossible neat squares. Eldric holding a cup of tea beside a sleeping wolf. Alias standing in the circular room and telling him that he still had time.

Dreams were cruel like that. They learned the shape of what you wanted and wore it until you woke.

Future Alias opened his eyes.

Bookshelves rose around him.

They were taller than he remembered, though perhaps that was only because he was lying on the floor. Dark shelves climbed toward the shadowed ceiling in narrow walls of wood. Hundreds of books leaned against one another above him, their spines faded, their corners worn pale. The windows at the far side of the library were high and narrow. Rain drew thin lines down the glass.

The first-floor table stood a few steps away.

And beside it lay the book.

Future Alias stared at it.

It was too large to have fallen by accident. It was thick, square, and ugly in the familiar way of something that had changed your life and refused to look impressive while doing it. The cover was dark leather. One corner had been repaired with thread. There was a faint mark in the dust where it had struck the floor.

His forehead hurt.

He lifted a hand to it.

There was a tender lump above his brow.

For a moment, he simply sat there with his fingers against it.
Then Paper slid off the edge of the table and landed against his shoulder.

Future Alias flinched.

Paper wrote:

YOU ARE AWAKE. THIS IS PROMISING.

His breath stopped.

The letters were untidy. They were dry. They were real.

"Paper," he said.

Paper paused before answering.

UNFORTUNATELY.

The sound that came out of him was not a laugh at first. It hurt too much for that. It was a broken breath that turned into something smaller and stranger, a laugh with no happiness in it yet but the beginning of room for happiness to return.

He pressed the heel of his hand to his eyes.

When he lowered it, Paper had written again.

DO NOT CRY ON ME. I AM PAPER.

"You are very bad at this," Future Alias said.

I AM EXCELLENT AT THIS. YOU ARE SIMPLY DIFFICULT TO ASSIST.

He almost said Alias would have liked that.

The thought caught in his chest.

Alias would have laughed. Rowan would have said that Paper had finally admitted being helpful. Maris would have written down the exact wording. Corvin would have looked offended that anybody had asked Paper to assist without making a plan first. Eldric would have poured tea for an object that could not drink it, just to see whether the room would allow it.

No one answered him.

The library was quiet.

Not the warm kind of quiet that came after everyone else in camp had fallen asleep. This was the quiet of a place that had been empty before he entered it and would remain empty if he left.

Future Alias pushed himself upright.

His joints protested. The grey cloak still hung from his shoulders. It was damp at one hem, dusty at the other. The same cloak. The same worn boots. The same hands.

But his hands were not empty.

Something was caught against his palm.

He opened his fingers slowly.

A thin red thread lay curled there.

It was not long. It was frayed at one end and knotted once near the middle. It looked ridiculous against the hard lines of his hand. It should have been nothing. A thread dropped near a campfire. A small thing nobody had noticed missing until much later.

It was Rowan.

Future Alias swallowed.

Beneath the thread was a folded piece of paper. He knew the handwriting before he opened it. Maris's small, careful letters ran across the page.

No one walks into the next year alone.

The copied promise page.

There was a little map square too, marked with Corvin's precise dark line and a return symbol in the corner. Beside it rested a tea charm made from cloth and string, small enough to fit in a pocket.

The faint scent of dried leaves remained inside it.

And tucked beneath all of them was the wooden token Alias had carved for him after the snowball fight.

Future Alias stared at the little wolf carved into the wood.

He had seen it in Alias's hand.

He had held it once at the farewell.

He had told himself he would return it.

Now it was here.

The objects did not glow. They did not tell him why they had crossed a road that should not have let anything cross. They were only objects.

That was what made them unbearable.

He placed them one by one on the table beside the great book.

The red thread.

The promise page.

The map square.

The tea charm.

The carved wolf.

Then his coin rolled from the inside pocket of his coat and struck the wood with a small, clear sound.

Future Alias watched it spin.

It settled with the same face upward that it had worn in the circular room: a road bending forward beneath a small mark like a lantern.

He had not remembered putting it away.

"It happened," he whispered.

Paper wrote:

YES.

He looked at the words.

"How?"

Paper remained still for so long that he thought it might not answer.

Then it wrote:

YOU WERE THERE.

"That is not an answer."

IT IS THE ONLY ONE I HAVE.

Future Alias sat down in the chair beside the table.

The chair was older than it had any right to be. One arm had been repaired with a strip of dark wood. He remembered doing it himself during a storm, years ago, because the broken arm had kept catching his sleeve. He remembered being angry with it. He remembered believing that no one would notice if it stayed broken.

He had noticed.

The library around him looked exactly as it had when he had left.

That thought was wrong. He had not left it. He had fallen asleep here, or been thrown, or been given another road. He did not know which word was true.

But the shelves were the same. The windows were the same. His old bag lay beneath the table where he had abandoned it. A stack of empty cups stood on the sideboard, grey with dust. A cracked blue bowl rested beside the cold fireplace.

Nothing had changed.

Everything had changed.

Future Alias leaned forward and opened his personal journal.

The pages were swollen from old rain and travel. Some were filled with cramped writing. Some had only a line or two, written on mornings when he had needed to prove he was still capable of making words. Some were crossed out so hard the paper had nearly torn.

Near the middle, he found the page where he had written before entering the Tower.

If this does not work, I do not know what I will do next.

The sentence looked smaller now.

Not less true. Just smaller.

He turned the page.

A new line had appeared beneath it in ink he did not remember using.

Then do the next thing.

Future Alias stared at the words.

He knew the writing was not his.

It was not Maris's either. Her letters were more careful. This handwriting leaned forward, almost impatiently, as though whoever had written it wanted the reader to stop staring and stand up.

M.

Perhaps.

Or perhaps the Tower had learned a trick from Paper.

Future Alias put his fingertips against the ink but did not smudge it.

"The next thing," he said.

Paper wrote:

A REVOLUTIONARY CONCEPT.

He ignored it.

Outside, rain tapped the windows. It was not the snow of Wrenfall. It was not the soft rain that had followed the group through Nettlebridge. This was older rain, harder rain, the kind that made the road outside a Tower shine black between stones.

He rose and crossed the library.

At the tallest window, he looked down.

The hill below the Tower dropped into dark pines and a narrow road. Beyond the trees, far enough that he could only see pieces of it, lay the small valley town where he had once bought stale bread and avoided people who knew his name.

A little farther down that road was Gerhardt's tavern.

Future Alias knew the way without needing a map.

That made his stomach twist.

He had passed it so many times without stopping. He had seen the sign above its door, the warm windows, the smoke from its chimney, and told himself there was no point going in. Gerhardt would be older. Gerhardt would ask questions. Gerhardt would look at him and see all the years Future Alias had wasted.

So he had kept walking.

He looked back at the objects on the table.

The tea charm sat beside the coin.

The red thread curved like a small road.

No one walks into the next year alone.

The words were meant for a town in snow. They were meant for the people who had said them together. They were not supposed to travel across impossible roads and wait in an empty Tower for someone who had spent too long believing he had already missed every chance to return.

But they were here.

Future Alias picked up the wooden wolf.

Its shape was clumsy. One ear was slightly larger than the other. The paws were uneven. Alias had tried to make it look fierce and had accidentally made it look stubborn instead.

Future Alias held it in his fist.

"I am back," he said.

The library did not answer.

He had expected that. He still felt disappointed.

Paper wrote:

YES. THAT WAS THE ENTIRE POINT OF THE DOOR.

Future Alias looked at it.

"I know."

GOOD. KNOWING THINGS IS USEFUL. DOING SOMETHING WITH THEM IS BETTER.

He almost laughed again.

Then he looked at the road below the Tower.

The thought of opening the door made his hands cold.

It was only a door. Old wood. Iron latch. Rain beyond it. A road leading toward a tavern he could reach before dark if he did not walk too slowly.

It was only a door.

He had faced rooms that rearranged themselves around grief. He had crossed snowfields. He had watched a younger version of himself become a wolf and choose to return to his friends. He had stood in a final room and been told, with irritating gentleness, that the road had never wanted him to be alone.

And still an ordinary door frightened him.

That did not make the fear less real.

It only made the next thing clear.

Future Alias gathered the objects from the table.

He did not hide them in the bottom of his bag. He did not tuck them away where he could pretend they were only proof for himself. He placed the red thread around the tea charm, folded the promise page carefully, slid the map square against the inside cover of his journal, and put the wooden wolf in the small pocket closest to his heart.

The coin went beside it.

Then he lifted his bag from beneath the table.

It was lighter than he remembered.

Maybe because he had carried so much alone for so long.

At the library door, he stopped.

The great book still lay on the floor behind him. Paper rested on top of it, its small white pages almost bright against the dark cover.

"Are you coming?" Future Alias asked.

Paper wrote:

I HAVE BEEN HERE THE WHOLE TIME.

"That was not what I asked."

Paper considered this.

Then it folded itself once, awkwardly, and slid into the outer pocket of his bag.

DO NOT MAKE THIS SENTIMENTAL.

Future Alias's hand rested on the iron latch.

For years, he had left doors without saying goodbye.

This time, he looked back at the library.

At the table. At the chair he had repaired. At the old shelves. At the book that had hit him hard enough to knock him into another life.

"Thank you," he said.

No answer came.

The rain continued to tap the windows.

Future Alias opened the door.

Cold air entered first. It smelled of wet earth, pine needles, and smoke from somewhere below the hill. The rain touched his face. It was real rain. It made his hair stick to his forehead and darkened the shoulders of his cloak.

He stepped outside.

The Tower stood behind him, silent and ordinary-looking from this side.

The road curved down through the pines.

Somewhere beyond them, a tavern door waited.

Future Alias did not know what Gerhardt would say.

He did not know whether he would be forgiven for leaving, or welcomed without questions, or told exactly how terrible he looked.

He did not know if he deserved any of those things.

But there was someone alive down that road.

Someone he had chosen not to see because grief had made every return feel impossible.

Future Alias adjusted the strap of his bag.

The wooden wolf rested against his chest.

The coin was warm beside it.

He began to walk downhill.

Not quickly.

Not because he was being forced.

And not because he was running away.

Chapter 31: Gerhardt's Door

Some doors have been waiting longer than you know.

Rain had turned the road to black glass by the time Future Alias saw the tavern sign through the trees.

It hung crooked above the door, carved from dark wood and painted so many times that the old letters had become soft at their edges. A lantern burned beneath it. Not a magical lantern. Just a square of yellow light behind cloudy glass, swinging slightly whenever the wind moved down the road.

Future Alias stopped beneath the awning across the street.

The tavern looked smaller than he remembered.

That was impossible. The building had not changed because he had spent too many years refusing to look at it properly. Its roof still leaned a little over the front windows. The stone step outside its door still dipped in the centre from boots and rain and generations of people arriving tired. Smoke still rose from the chimney in a dark, steady line.

But he had made it enormous in his mind.

He had made the door into something that could judge him.

Rain slid from his hair onto the collar of his cloak. The boxy shape of Paper shifted inside the outer pocket of his bag.

YOU HAVE STOPPED WALKING, Paper wrote.

"I noticed."

THIS IS A DOOR. YOU HAVE RECENT EXPERIENCE WITH DOORS.

"Those doors did not know me."

Paper was quiet for a moment.

Then it wrote:

THIS ONE DOES. THAT IS WHY YOU CAME.

Future Alias looked across the road again.

The lantern above the tavern entrance swung once in the wind.

He remembered walking past it with his hood raised. He remembered seeing the same warm square of light and deciding that Gerhardt would not want him inside. Or worse, that Gerhardt would let him inside and ask nothing, which would leave Future Alias alone with every question he had brought.

He remembered thinking that staying away was kinder.

It had been easier.

That did not make it kinder.

Eldric's voice returned to him with painful clarity.

Do not decide answers for people before you have given them the chance.

Future Alias drew one breath, then another.

He crossed the road.

The door was heavy but ordinary under his hand. The iron latch was cold. When he pushed it open, a little bell somewhere above him gave a tired chime.

Warmth met him first.

Wood smoke. Wet wool. Onion stew. Yeast from fresh bread. The sharp, sweet smell of cider. The sound of people speaking over one another, of mugs touching tabletops, of someone laughing too loudly at a joke that was not especially good.

For a second, Future Alias stood still in the doorway with rainwater darkening the floor beneath his boots.

A few people looked up.

Some looked away again, because he was only a wet traveller in a grey cloak.

One older woman at a table near the fire looked at him twice. Her face changed as if she had recognized a ghost and decided not to make a scene about it.

Behind the bar, Gerhardt was drying a cup with a cloth.

He had changed.

Of course he had.

His hair had gone almost fully silver, though the thick shape of it remained stubbornly the same. His shoulders were still broad beneath his brown shirt, but one hand moved more slowly around the cup. A narrow scar marked his chin. Future Alias did not remember it being there. Or perhaps it had been there all along, and he had not looked closely enough.

Gerhardt set the cup down.

For a long moment, neither of them spoke.

Then Gerhardt looked him over from soaked boots to grey cloak to the bruised spot above his brow.

"You look terrible," he said.

Future Alias swallowed.

"I know."

Gerhardt gave one short nod.

"Good," he said. "Means you are still listening."

The words should not have made Future Alias's throat close.

They did anyway.

Gerhardt looked toward the hook beside the door. "Take off the cloak before it drips a lake into my floor. Then sit down. You can make whatever speech you have prepared after you eat something."

Future Alias stared at him.

"I did not prepare a speech."

"Then you have disappointed me twice already. Sit."

A laugh escaped him before he could stop it. It was thin and tired, but it was a laugh.

Gerhardt pointed at an empty table near the far wall. Not the furthest table. Not the darkest corner. A place beside the stove, where the light reached easily.

Future Alias removed the grey cloak.

His hands trembled slightly as he hung it on the hook.

Paper slipped from his bag pocket and landed against the inside of the cloak, then wrote one line across its blank face.

NO DRAMATIC ESCAPES THROUGH WINDOWS.

Future Alias folded Paper once and put it into his shirt pocket.

"Was that a message?" Gerhardt asked.

"Something like that."

"Is it rude?"

"Usually."

"Then it will fit in here."

Future Alias crossed the tavern and sat at the table.

He had sat there before. That thought came to him slowly. Not in this exact chair, perhaps, but near enough. He remembered Rowan sprawling across the bench and stealing crusts from Corvin's plate. He remembered Maris keeping a journal open beside her bowl because she claimed soup made people say things worth writing down. He remembered Eldric asking Gerhardt whether the tea had mint in it, and Gerhardt replying that it had tea in it, which should be enough for anyone.

The memories did not arrive as a wall this time.

They came like footsteps through another room.

Gerhardt set a bowl in front of him. Steam curled from it. Thick stew, bread torn into pieces, carrots, beans, something green he could not identify. Beside it, he placed a mug of water.

"Eat," Gerhardt said.

Future Alias looked at the bowl.

"I should explain."

"You can explain between bites. That way I know you are not about to fall over."

"I am not going to fall over."

Gerhardt glanced at him.

Future Alias picked up the spoon.

The first mouthful was too hot. The second was better. By the third, he realized how hungry he was.

Gerhardt remained standing on the other side of the table, arms folded loosely. He did not stare.

He did not leave.

Future Alias kept his eyes on the bowl.

"I am sorry," he said.

Gerhardt's expression did not soften exactly. It became more careful.

"For what part?"

Future Alias stopped with the spoon halfway to his mouth.

"All of it."

"That is a large amount of apology. Be more specific."

"For leaving. For not writing. For walking past this place and pretending I did not know it. For making you wonder whether I was alive."

The tavern continued around them. Someone at the bar dropped a spoon. Someone else complained about cards. A dog barked once outside and was shushed by a person who did not sound convinced it would listen.

Gerhardt pulled out the chair opposite him and sat down.

"You did make me wonder," he said. "For a while."

Future Alias lowered his spoon.

"I know."

"No," Gerhardt said. "You know the words. That is different."

Future Alias waited.

Gerhardt rubbed his thumb over the edge of the table, where the wood had been scratched by cups and knives and too many restless hands.

"The first year, I thought you needed time. The second, I thought you needed someone to drag you down from that Tower by the collar. I went up there twice. You did not answer. I left food. Once you left the bowl outside the door, clean as if that was meant to count as a conversation."

Future Alias winced.

"It was," Gerhardt said. "A bad one. But it was something."

"Why did you stop coming?"

Gerhardt looked at him for a long time.

"I did not stop. I stopped forcing the door. Those are different things."

Future Alias's fingers tightened around his spoon.

"I thought you had given up."

"I was angry," Gerhardt said plainly. "I was worried. I was tired of being shouted at by a closed door. But I did not give up."

He leaned back slightly.

"There is a difference between keeping a place for someone and trying to live their life for them. Took me years to learn it. You do not drag a person home by breaking every door they close. You make sure there is still a lamp on when they decide to come back."

Future Alias thought of M's lantern. Eldric's fire. The lights in Wrenfall. The ridiculous little wooden lantern Rowan had pressed into his hand in the final room.

His eyes burned.

"I did not deserve that," he said.

Gerhardt sighed through his nose.

"There it is. The sentence you have been carrying around like it pays rent."

Future Alias looked up.

"You do not have to earn a bowl of stew," Gerhardt continued. "You do not have to earn a chair. You do not have to earn the right to say you are sorry. There are things you need to repair. There are people you hurt by disappearing. That is true. But do not turn repair into a punishment you can never finish. That is just another way of staying gone."

Future Alias could not answer.

Gerhardt did not demand one.

He stood, walked behind the bar, and began polishing the same cup again even though it was already clean.

Future Alias ate another spoonful of stew.

It tasted like beans, rain, and the unbearable proof that he had once belonged somewhere ordinary.

After a while, Gerhardt returned carrying a wooden box.

It was not large. Dark cedar, worn pale at the corners. A strip of old blue cloth tied the lid shut. The kind of box that had spent a long time waiting in a place where no one wanted to disturb it.

Gerhardt set it on the table between them.

Future Alias stared at it.

"What is that?"

Gerhardt rested one hand on top of the lid.

"Things."

"That does not answer the question."

"I am getting old. I am allowed to be vague."

Future Alias looked at the box again.

Something inside shifted softly when Gerhardt moved it. Paper, from his shirt pocket, creased itself once.

Gerhardt's eyes lowered to the blue cloth around the box.

"Some were left here for you," he said. "Some were brought back by people who said they did not know where you were but thought I might. Some were kept because I could not bring myself to throw them away."

Future Alias went still.

"From them?"

Gerhardt nodded.

He did not say their names.

He did not need to.

Future Alias's hands drew back from the table.

"I cannot."

"Not tonight," Gerhardt said. "You do not have to open it tonight."

"I mean, I cannot take it."

Gerhardt's face became very tired for a moment.

"You can," he said. "You do not have to know what to do with it yet. You do not have to forgive anyone. You do not have to turn it into an answer. You only have to take it upstairs when you are ready."

Future Alias stared at the blue cloth.

He remembered the little gifts in the final room. Rowan's crooked lantern. Maris's note. Corvin's compass cord. Eldric's tea charm.

He remembered trying to accept them without believing they could possibly belong to him.

"Did they know I would come back?" he asked.

Gerhardt did not answer quickly.

"They hoped," he said at last. "They were angry sometimes. They were afraid for you. They did not always know what to do with you. But they hoped."

Future Alias felt the sentence enter him slowly, like warmth reaching hands that had been cold too long.

They hoped.

Not a promise.

Not a perfect ending.

Only a place held open.

Gerhardt untied the blue cloth and laid it beside the box.

He did not lift the lid.

"The room above the kitchen is empty," he said. "You can use it tonight. I changed the blanket this morning. Not because I had a feeling. I just run a decent tavern."

Future Alias looked toward the narrow staircase at the back of the room.

"You would let me stay?"

Gerhardt gave him a look of such deep annoyance that Future Alias almost smiled.

"It is a tavern," he said. "We have rooms."

"But after all this time..."

"Especially after all this time."

Paper wrote from his pocket:

THE MAN HAS INVENTORY.

Future Alias covered his mouth with one hand.

Gerhardt noticed the movement. "Your rude paper again?"

"It says you have inventory."

Gerhardt considered that. "It is not wrong."

The laugh that came from Future Alias this time was not thin.

It startled him.

It startled Gerhardt too, though he hid it by standing and taking Future Alias's empty bowl before the last bite had quite left it.

"Finish the bread," Gerhardt said. "Then take the box upstairs. Sleep. We can talk tomorrow, when you are less likely to apologize to the chairs."

"I was not going to apologize to the chairs."

"Good. They have suffered enough."

Future Alias finished the bread.

He did not rush.

That was new enough to feel strange.

When he stood, he lifted the cedar box with both hands. It was heavier than it looked. Not because of what was inside. Because of everything he had spent years believing it might contain.

He paused beside the table.

"Gerhardt."

The older man looked up from behind the bar.

Future Alias did not know how to say thank you without making it too small.

So he tried the truth instead.

"I came back," he said.

Gerhardt's face softened at last.

"Yes," he said. "You did."

Future Alias carried the box upstairs.

The room above the kitchen was small and clean. A narrow bed stood against one wall. Rain tapped at the window. A folded blanket lay at the foot of the mattress, thick and dark green. On the table beside the bed was a candle, a chipped cup, and a little bowl with two wrapped pieces of mint tucked inside it.

He set the box down carefully.

For a while, he only stood there.

The blue cloth rested beside the lid. The cedar smelled faintly of dust and old wood and something sweeter he could not name.

He could open it.

He could pull every old memory into the room and force himself to look at it all at once.

He could decide tonight was the night he would finally prove he could survive it.

But that was not what Eldric had taught him.

That was not what the others had asked.

No one had asked him to do everything at once.

Future Alias took the wooden wolf from the pocket closest to his heart and placed it beside the box.

Then he placed the red thread beside it.

A small road of red against dark cedar.

He sat on the edge of the bed.

Below him, the tavern murmured. Someone laughed. A chair scraped. Gerhardt told somebody to stop putting their feet on the table. The sound came through the floorboards, ordinary and alive.

Future Alias looked at the unopened box.

"Tomorrow," he said.

Paper wrote, from the pillow where it had somehow placed itself:

A SENSIBLE PLAN. I DISLIKE IT.

Future Alias lay down without taking off his clothes.

He was tired enough that the bed seemed to tilt beneath him. But before sleep came, he listened to the people below.

He did not have to imagine them.

He did not have to remember them through a closed door.

There was someone alive downstairs.

There was a room above the kitchen.

There was a box waiting for tomorrow.

And for the first time in years, Future Alias fell asleep without planning where he would run next.

Chapter 32: I Received Your Gifts

Some gifts wait until you are ready to receive them.

Morning reached the room above the kitchen carefully.

At first it was only a pale line under the curtain. Then it moved across the floorboards, climbed the leg of the chair, and warmed the edge of the cedar box where it sat on the little table beside the bed.

Future Alias woke before he understood where he was.

For one sharp second, he expected stone walls. A locked Tower door. The cold, familiar weight of another day he would have to survive alone.

Then he heard somebody downstairs drop a tray.

A voice that was probably Gerhardt said, "If you break another cup, you are buying it."

Another voice said something too quiet to hear.

A dog barked outside.

Rain had stopped in the night. Sunlight pressed weakly through the cloudy window. The room smelled of old wood, damp wool drying near a stove, and bread.

Future Alias lay still beneath the blanket.

The box waited on the table.

Paper was folded beside his pillow in a shape that made it look almost asleep.

When Future Alias sat up, it unfolded one corner and wrote:

MORNING. NO DRAMATIC ESCAPES HAVE BEEN RECORDED.

"It is early," he said.

YOU HAVE HAD MANY YEARS.

Future Alias looked at the cedar box.

The blue cloth lay beside it, neatly folded now. He remembered Gerhardt untying it. He remembered saying tomorrow as though tomorrow were a safe distance away.

Tomorrow had arrived anyway.

His hand went to the journal beneath his shirt. The leather strap was warm from sleep. Beneath it, he could feel the little things he had carried back from the other road: the corner of Maris's folded note, the thin red thread, the small wooden lantern Rowan had pressed into his hand. Nothing there had asked him to explain himself. Nothing had demanded that he become better in one night.

They had simply come with him.

A knock sounded on the door.

Future Alias froze.

"Breakfast," Gerhardt called through the wood. "And before you say you are not hungry, I have seen you eat. Do not lie to me this early."

Future Alias looked at Paper.

Paper wrote:

A FORMIDABLE OPPONENT.

"Come in," Future Alias said.

Gerhardt opened the door with one hand and carried a tray in the other. Bread, eggs, a small dish of jam, and tea in the chipped blue cup from the table. He set it down on the narrow desk beneath the window without asking permission, because he had always treated permission and practical care as things that could live in the same room.

Then he saw the box.

His face did not change much. It only became quieter.

"You do not have to open it while I am here," he said.

"I know."

"You do not have to open it today either."

Future Alias looked at him.

Gerhardt crossed his arms. "I am trying a new thing where I say useful sentences before breakfast. Do not make it a habit."

Despite himself, Future Alias smiled.

Gerhardt noticed. He did not point it out.

"I think I want to," Future Alias said. "Open it."

Gerhardt nodded once.

"All right."

"Will you..." Future Alias stopped.

The question felt younger than he was. It felt like standing at a gate and not knowing whether somebody would wait if he asked.

Gerhardt waited anyway.

"Will you stay?" Future Alias asked.

Gerhardt's expression softened, though only around the eyes.

"Yes," he said. "I can stay."

He did not sit beside the box. He pulled the chair near the window back a little and took the edge of it, leaving Future Alias the table and the choice. It was a small thing. Future Alias noticed it.

Paper climbed somehow from the bed to the desk, folded itself into a square, and wrote:

I WILL PROVIDE EMOTIONAL SUPPORT BY REMAINING RUDE.

Gerhardt glanced at it. "That is a strange-looking journal."

"It is not a journal."

"Good. It has terrible handwriting."

Paper went blank for a full three seconds.

Future Alias let out a startled laugh.

The sound did not fix anything.

It made the room easier to stay in.

He pulled the box closer.

The cedar made a soft scrape across the wood. The lid had no lock. It never had. That almost hurt more than if it had.

Future Alias placed both hands on it.

His fingers shook.

He thought of the Tower. Of all the doors he had refused to open because he had decided they would contain something unbearable. He thought of the final room, where every door had waited instead of pulling him through.

This was only a box.

Only a box.

And still, his breath caught when he lifted the lid.

The smell rose first.

Cedar. Paper. Dust. Dried mint.

Then the things inside became clear.

They were not arranged like relics.

That was the first surprise.

They were arranged like people had expected them to be used.

A small cloth pouch rested near the top. A folded map lay under it, its edges softened by years. A bundle of dried tea leaves sat in a tin that had once held buttons. There was a square envelope with his name written across the front in dark, uneven ink. And beside it, tied in a loose knot, was a length of red thread.

Future Alias stopped breathing for a moment.

The thread was not the same one he had brought from the other road. That thread waited under the strap of his journal, bright and newer, given to him by a Rowan who was still alive.

This thread was faded at the edges.

It had been wound around a small wooden token shaped like a wolf.

Not a careful carving. The ears were too large. One front paw was shorter than the other. Its face had the serious expression of something that had no idea it was supposed to be frightening.

Future Alias touched it with one finger.

A scrap of paper was tied beneath the thread.

He knew the handwriting before he read it.

FOR WHEN YOU START LOOKING TOO GREY AGAIN.

Below that, in smaller letters:

RED MEANS PEOPLE CAN FIND YOU. THIS IS IMPORTANT. - ROWAN

Future Alias's mouth opened.

No sound came out.

He could see Rowan leaning over a table somewhere, tongue caught between his teeth while he carved the little wolf. He could hear the complaint that the ears were meant to be that big. He could imagine him tying the red thread around it with fingers that never stayed still for long.

He had not known.

Or perhaps he had known, once, and had been too frightened to understand what knowing meant.

"He left that here?" Future Alias asked.

Gerhardt looked toward the token.

"Rowan came by before one of the longer routes," he said. "Said you were being difficult in a distant and dramatic way. Said I should give it to you when you stopped being impossible."

Future Alias stared at the red thread.

"Did he think I would come back?"

Gerhardt did not pretend the answer was simple.

"He hoped you would," he said. "He also said that if you did not, I was to keep it somewhere safe until you did."

Future Alias's thumb brushed the knot.

Red means people can find you.

On the other road, Rowan had given him a tiny lantern and told him not to become the grey cloak again.

Here, years before, he had left a red thread because he wanted Future Alias to be visible.

The thought made his eyes burn.

Future Alias set the little wolf carefully on the table beside the box.

Then he picked up the folded map.

It was smaller than he expected. A map of the roads around the tavern, drawn in precise dark lines. Corvin's handwriting marked distances, water sources, old bridges, and two places where a traveller could find shelter if the weather turned. Near the lower edge, a thin arrow pointed toward the tavern.

Beside it, Corvin had written:

RETURN MARKER.

On the back, in even smaller letters:

A return marker is not a promise you will arrive unchanged. It is proof that there is a place worth finding again.

Future Alias sat very still.

He remembered Corvin in the final room, holding the compass-marked cord between his fingers.

Do not decide you have nowhere to return to before you check.

The same idea. Different road. The same person, somehow, still trying to make survival practical enough that it could be believed.

"He made this for me," Future Alias whispered.

Gerhardt nodded.

"He left it the winter after you stopped answering letters. He was annoyed about it."

"That sounds like Corvin."

"It does. He said, 'Someone should make the path clear in case he has forgotten what roads are for.' Then he pretended it was only a travel map."

Future Alias pressed the heel of his hand against his eyes.

Gerhardt looked away, giving him the privacy of not being watched while he cried.

Paper wrote, very small:

ROADS ARE FOR RETURNING TOO.

Future Alias folded the map along its old creases. He did not put it away yet.

The small button tin was next.

Its lid was dented. A faded picture of blue flowers circled the side. When he opened it, the smell of mint rose more strongly.

Inside was a paper packet of tea leaves, dry but carefully sealed, and a pale green wooden charm shaped like a tea leaf. A string looped through the top so it could be tied to a bag, a wrist, a compass, or anything else that might need reminding.

A note rested beneath it.

Eldric's handwriting was straight and gentle.

For one cup at a time.

Nothing else.

Future Alias stared at the words until they blurred.

For one cup at a time.

Not solve everything at once.

Not forgive everything at once.

Not carry every loss until it became a punishment.

One cup at a time.

He remembered the last cup of tea in the circular room, warm between his hands while Eldric told him fear did not mean he had chosen wrongly.

He picked up the little charm.

It was smooth with age. He wondered whether Eldric had made it himself. Of course he had. Eldric would have made it without telling anyone, then acted surprised if somebody noticed the effort.

Future Alias closed his fist around it.

"I did not receive this," he said.

Gerhardt did not correct him.

"Not then," Future Alias continued. "I saw things. I heard people. But I did not let them reach me. I think I thought that if I took anything from them, I would have to admit I still needed them."

Gerhardt rested one hand on the back of his chair.

"Needing people is not a debt," he said.

Future Alias looked down at the charm.

"It can feel like one."

"Yes," Gerhardt said. "That does not make it one."

The envelope waited beside the tin.

Future Alias did not want to touch it.

Then he did.

His name was written across the front.

Not Varux.

Not a title. Not a warning. Not an old version of himself he had worn because it made distance easier.

Alias.

The handwriting belonged to Maris.

He knew because every letter looked like it had been given time.

His fingers found the edge of the envelope and stopped.

"You do not need to read it aloud," Gerhardt said.

Future Alias nodded.

He opened it.

Inside was a page torn carefully from a journal, but it was not a story page. There were no dates, no route notes, no descriptions of weather or strangers or dangerous roads.

Only a few lines.

Alias,

I know you think becoming quiet makes you easier to carry. It does not. It only makes it harder for people who love you to know where to stand.

You do not have to tell us every thought. You do not have to be cheerful when you are not. But please do not make yourself smaller and call it kindness.

We have room.

- Maris

Future Alias read it once.

Then again.

We have room.

The phrase seemed to come from everywhere at once: the empty circle of chairs in the final room; Gerhardt leaving a place beside the stove; Eldric making room at a fire; six people saying no one walks into the next year alone.

His vision blurred.

He folded the page too quickly, then stopped and carefully unfolded it again.

Maris would have hated that. She would have said paper was not fragile just because the words mattered.

A laugh and a sob collided in his chest.

Gerhardt reached for the tea cup on the desk and moved it closer. He did not tell Future Alias to drink. He only made it easier to reach.

The last thing in the box was wrapped in brown cloth.

Future Alias recognized his own habit in the knot. Careful. Double-tied. The kind of knot somebody made when they did not want a gift to open in a bag by accident.

He untied it slowly.

Inside was a small brass coin case, just large enough for a single old road coin. The lid was plain except for six tiny marks around the edge, each one shaped like a different arrow.

Inside, on a narrow strip of paper, was one sentence in handwriting he did not recognize.

FOR WHEN ALL OF YOU COME BACK TOGETHER.

Future Alias's breath left him.

"Who wrote this?" he asked.

Gerhardt came closer, though he still did not touch the box.

"All of them, I think," he said. "They bought it together. They were planning to give it to you after a route that went badly. They said you had all made it back and should probably have a better way to carry the coin than stuffing it in your pocket."

Future Alias looked at the little case.

All of you.

Not only him.

Not only the person who had left.

They had made a place in the future for all of them returning together.

The future had not happened the way they expected.

That did not make the hope foolish.

He held the brass case in both hands.

For years, he had thought the things left behind were proof of everything he had failed to save.

Now, sitting in a small room above a tavern with bread cooling on a tray and Gerhardt pretending not to watch him cry, he saw something else inside them.

They were proof that people had tried to reach him.

They were proof that he had been loved by people who did not always know how to fix him.

They were proof that love had existed before he was ready to accept it.

Future Alias laid the coin case beside the red thread, the map, the tea charm, and Maris's letter.

Then he placed both hands flat on the table.

His fingers stopped shaking.

"I received your gifts," he said.

The words sounded too small at first.

So he said them again.

"I received your gifts."

Not as an apology.

Not as a way to pretend that nothing had been lost.

As a truth.

Rowan had tried to make him visible.

Corvin had left a way back.

Eldric had told him to take one cup at a time.

Maris had written that there was room.

They had reached toward him.

He had reached back too late to change the past.

But not too late to receive what they had given.

Gerhardt nodded slowly.

"Good," he said, his voice rougher than before. "They would have liked to hear that."

Future Alias swallowed.

"I wish I could tell them."

"You can," Gerhardt said.

Future Alias looked up.

Gerhardt nodded toward the window, beyond the tavern roof, beyond the wet road and the trees and the hills he had spent years refusing to cross.

"The hill path is still there," he said. "The stones are still there. And they are still people worth speaking to, even if they cannot answer you in the old way."

Future Alias looked back down at the gifts.

He knew what Gerhardt meant.

The graves.

For a moment, fear returned. Not the sharp fear of attack or hunger or a wolf scent in the dark. The quieter kind. The fear of standing before names and not knowing whether he had the right to speak.

Then his fingers touched the bright red thread from the other road beneath his journal strap.

Red means people can find you.

He thought of Alias saying, You still have time.

He thought of Eldric saying, Go home.

He thought of Maris's words: We have room.

"I will go," he said.

Gerhardt looked toward the breakfast tray. "After you eat. Grief can wait twenty minutes. Eggs cannot."

Future Alias gave a breathless laugh.

"That is not true."

"It is true enough for breakfast."

Paper wrote:

THE WISEST THING SAID THIS MORNING.

Gerhardt pointed at it. "I am starting to like the rude paper."

"Do not encourage it," Future Alias said.

Too late. Paper had already written:

I HAVE BEEN ENCOURAGED FOR CENTURIES.

Future Alias put the gifts back into the cedar box one at a time.

Not hidden.

Not sealed away like evidence of pain he could not face.

Kept.

The red thread went around the little wooden wolf. The map rested flat beneath it. The tea charm lay on top of the button tin. Maris's letter went into the brass coin case, protected by the plain lid and six small arrows.

He did not close the box immediately.

For a while, he simply looked at what had been waiting for him.

Then he closed the lid.

He tied the blue cloth around it, not because he was sending it away, but because he was taking it with him.

Outside, the morning had become clear enough to show a strip of blue between the clouds.

Future Alias stood by the window and watched the light touch the wet road.

There were graves ahead.

There were words he had not said.

There was still grief.

But there was also a tavern below him, a box he had opened, a map pointing home, and a road waiting for his next step.

For once, that was enough to make him move.

Chapter 33: Four Stones Under Moonlight

Grief does not end. But neither does the road.

The moon was already high when Future Alias left Gerhardt's tavern.

He did not leave through the back door.

That detail mattered to him more than it should have.

The back door opened into the narrow lane behind the kitchens, away from the road and away from the windows. It was the door he had used in earlier years when the tavern felt too warm, when Gerhardt's questions were too quiet, when a friendly voice made him want to disappear before it could ask him to stay.

Tonight, he used the front door.

Gerhardt stood behind the counter, wiping the same cup for far longer than the cup required. He did not ask where Future Alias was going. He only looked at the small satchel over his shoulder and the folded bundle held carefully against his chest.

"You coming back?" Gerhardt asked.

Future Alias paused with his hand on the latch.

The old answer rose easily. I do not know. Maybe. Do not wait up.

He looked at the warm room instead. At the empty table near the wall. At the blue cup that had been left on the counter because Gerhardt knew he would be back before dawn or after it or whenever the road stopped feeling too loud.

"Yes," Future Alias said. "I am coming back."

Gerhardt nodded as though that was all he had needed.

"Good," he said. "Breakfast is at a reasonable hour. Try not to turn it into a tragedy."

Paper poked one corner out of Future Alias's satchel and wrote:

HE WILL TRY. NO PROMISES.

Gerhardt squinted at it. "You are still a terrible journal."

Paper folded itself flatter.

Future Alias smiled, pulled open the door, and stepped into the night.

* * *

The cemetery lay beyond the last houses, past a field where low stone walls divided sleeping sheep from sleeping grass.

Future Alias remembered the path even though he had not walked it in years.

That was the cruel thing about some roads. A person could forget whole seasons and still remember every place that had hurt them. The slope where the mud always gathered after rain. The bent ash tree at the turn. The cracked milestone with no number left on it. His body remembered before he allowed his mind to.

The air was cold and clean. The rain from the previous day had left silver water in the hollows of the road. Moonlight touched each puddle and made it look deeper than it was.

Paper remained quiet for almost the whole walk.

At last, it wrote:

YOU MAY TURN AROUND.

Future Alias looked down at the page. "I know."

YOU MAY ALSO CONTINUE.

"I know that too."

Paper gave a small, untidy crease that might have been approval.

He kept walking.

The cemetery gate appeared between two old yew trees. It was not impressive. A simple iron gate, worn dark by weather, with one hinge that complained whenever it moved. The gate had complained when they had carried Rowan in. It had complained when Maris was buried beside him.

It had complained for Corvin. For Eldric.

It complained again now.

Future Alias stopped just inside.

Four stones waited beneath the moon.

They stood in a row near the far wall, not far from a small bench that someone had repaired badly but honestly. Moss crept along the lower edges. Wild grass had grown around them, though Gerhardt had clearly come by often enough to keep the names visible.

For years, Future Alias had imagined this place as an ending.

A line in the world past which he had no right to continue.

Now it looked smaller than his memory. Sadder, perhaps. But smaller.

The dead had not built a wall around him.

He had done that himself.

He walked to the first stone.

ROWAN

The name looked strange without a loud voice attached to it.

Future Alias opened his satchel. Before leaving the tavern, he had placed the old gifts from Gerhardt's cedar box safely beneath the folded blanket in his room: Rowan's crooked wooden wolf, Corvin's old route map, Eldric's first tea charm, and Maris's letter. Those were gifts he had finally received. They belonged to the life they had lived together.

The things in his satchel had come from another road.

They were not replacements.

They were proof that something had changed.

He took out the thin red thread.

It was brighter than the faded thread wrapped around Rowan's wooden wolf. This one had been dropped near a campfire by a Rowan who was still laughing, still alive, still capable of tying knots that

never quite stayed tied. Future Alias had carried it across a road he could never fully explain because it had felt too small to matter.

Now it looked like exactly what it was.

A way to be found.

He knelt beside the stone.

"You would hate this," he said softly.

The words sounded too loud in the quiet cemetery.

"Not the moonlight part. You liked moonlight when it made you look dramatic. You would hate that I am trying to say something serious without you interrupting."

His fingers tightened around the thread.

"I thought I had to become less visible to survive. Grey cloak. Quiet roads. No letters. No place anyone could find me." He swallowed. "You tried to tell me that was stupid before I understood what you meant. You were right. I hated that."

The wind moved through the yew branches.

Future Alias tied the red thread around the top of Rowan's stone. It looked almost impossible against the pale weathered surface. A tiny line of colour. A small refusal to disappear into grey.

"There is another you," he whispered. "He is still loud. Still impossible. He gave me a lantern and told me not to become the cloak again. I think you would have liked him. I think you would have annoyed each other immediately."

Paper wrote:

LIKELY WITHIN THREE MINUTES.

Future Alias let out a breath that almost became a laugh.

"I know," he said.

He stood and touched the red thread once before moving on.

* * *

Maris's stone stood beside Rowan's.

MARIS

There were more words carved below her name than on the others. A small line from one of her own notebooks, chosen by Gerhardt after the rest of them had spent an hour arguing about what she would hate least.

WRITE IT DOWN. SOMEONE MAY NEED TO REMEMBER.

Future Alias had hated the line when he first saw it.

It had felt unfair. As if writing something down could make it stay. As if a page could be enough when the person who filled it was gone.

Now he understood that the line had never promised enough.

It had only asked for honesty.

He took the folded page from his satchel.

The copied promise page had gone missing from the shared journal on the other road. For a while, they had thought Alias had taken it. Future Alias had stayed silent because he had taken it himself. Not to hurt anyone. Not because he wanted to steal something beautiful away from them.

He had wanted proof.

Proof that the words had existed. Proof that they had said them while standing together in a room full of snow light and ordinary happiness.

No one walks into the next year alone.

He had carried the page home.

He unfolded it now.

The handwriting was small and careful. Maris's copying hand had made every word clear, but there were other marks too: a smudge where Rowan had leaned over it, Corvin's neat correction to a date in the corner, the faint ring left by Eldric's cup, and Alias's name written once in the margin because he had been bored while Maris worked.

Future Alias ran his thumb over the page.

"You would tell me not to leave this out in the weather," he said.

Paper wrote:

SHE WOULD BE RIGHT.

"I know."

He had brought a small glass frame from Gerhardt's storeroom. It was plain, with a wooden back and a thin iron clip. He slid the page inside it carefully and set it at the foot of Maris's stone, partly beneath the shelter of the low yew branches.

It would not last forever there. Nothing did.

But it would last long enough to be seen.

"I kept one of your pages," he told the stone. "A page from someone who is still here. I kept it because I was afraid that if I did not have proof, I would wake up and find the whole road had been a dream."

His voice shook on the last word.

"Maybe it was strange to take it. Maybe it was selfish. But I brought it here because I think you would understand the part that matters. I did not want to forget them. I did not want to forget you either."

He looked at the words in the frame.

"I am writing this down now," he added. "Not in my journal yet. But I will."

For a while, he stood between the stones of Rowan and Maris with the moonlight on both names.

Then he moved to Corvin.

* * *

CORVIN

Corvin's stone was the plainest of the four. He would probably have approved. The name. The dates. A small carved arrow beneath them, pointing toward the road.

Nothing else.

Future Alias crouched in front of it.

"You made it practical," he said.

The words were not enough, so he tried again.

"You made everything practical. Fear. Hunger. Rain. Broken wheels. The fact that I did not know how to return when I had been gone too long. You made lists for things that most people only panic about."

He opened his satchel and removed the compass cord from the other road.

It was a simple piece of dark cord threaded through a small metal ring, the kind Corvin would have chosen because it could be repaired with ordinary tools. The ring held a tiny engraved mark: an arrow bent back toward itself.

RETURN.

Future Alias remembered the other Corvin standing in the final room, placing it in his hand and saying, Do not decide you have nowhere to return to before you check.

The words had sounded like Corvin because they had been both kind and annoying enough to be useful.

"There is another you too," Future Alias said. "He still makes plans when nobody asks him to. He still looks offended when people ignore those plans. He still believes a good map can save a person from at least half their own mistakes."

Paper wrote:

AN OPTIMISTIC ESTIMATE.

Future Alias smiled weakly.

"He gave me this. I think you would have approved of the knot. It is very ugly, but it works." He looped the compass cord around the stone's carved arrow. The metal ring rested just below the name, catching the moonlight.

"I am learning what you meant," Future Alias said. "Returning is not going backward. It is not pretending I did not leave. It is checking whether a road still has room for me on it."

His hand settled over the carved arrow.

"Gerhardt left a lamp on. I went through the front door. I told him I would come back. That felt impossible once."

The wind moved across the grass.

"You would have made a checklist about it," he said.

In his mind, Corvin answered immediately: Of course I would. You are not finished simply because you are uncomfortable.

Future Alias lowered his head.

"I know," he whispered.

* * *

Eldric's stone stood at the end of the row.

It was the only one with a small stone cup carved near the base. Gerhardt had commissioned it after Eldric died, because nobody could think of a better sign than tea. The cup had filled with rainwater during the night. Moonlight rested in it like a pale drink.

Future Alias stopped a few steps away.

He had carried this part of the night with him since he left the tavern.

He took the tea charm from the satchel.

It was not the first charm Eldric had made. That one lay safely in Gerhardt's room, wrapped in cloth beside the other gifts from the old life. This charm had crossed the other road with him. It was small, green, and smooth under his fingers. It had hung from the cup Eldric had given him in the final room, as though he had known Future Alias might need a reminder that some things could be taken one cup at a time.

Future Alias knelt in the wet grass.

For a long time, he could not speak.

Eldric had been the hardest person to miss because he had made absence feel less final. He had always been good at that. A quiet chair nearby. A cup poured before someone asked. A sentence that did not push, but did not let a person disappear either.

Future Alias remembered the fire on the other road. Alias asleep under blankets. Future Alias in wolf form, too afraid to move away. Eldric's voice in the dark.

Not from becoming you.

From becoming alone.

He pressed the tea charm against the stone.

"I kept your promise," he said.

The cemetery did not answer.

Still, he continued.

"Not perfectly. Not quickly. But he was not alone."

His breath broke.

"I tried to keep him safe at first. I thought that was the same thing. I thought I could stop him from hurting if I hid the worst parts of myself, if I took every danger before it reached him, if I taught him which doors not to open."

Tears slipped down his face. He let them.

"But he needed people. He needed the truth. He needed to be allowed to be frightened and angry and still come back. He needed to know that strength was not just surviving something by himself."

The tea charm shook in his hand.

"I needed that too."

Paper did not write anything.

Future Alias tied the charm to the carved stone cup. It swung once in the wind, a small green shape against grey stone.

"I came back," he told Eldric. "I went to Gerhardt. I opened the door. I let him make tea. I am standing here instead of running from it. I do not know what happens next."

He leaned forward until his forehead rested against the cold stone.

"But I think I am going to find out."

* * *

He stayed there until the moon began to lower.

Not kneeling. Not crying every moment. Just sitting on the damp grass between the four stones with Paper open beside him and the quiet of the cemetery around them.

Eventually, Paper wrote:

YOU HAVE BEEN HERE FOR A LONG TIME.

"I know."

THE DEAD ARE NOT GOING TO COMPLAIN. GERHARDT MAY.

Future Alias looked toward the dark shape of the tavern far beyond the field.

"He said breakfast was at a reasonable hour."

A TERRIFYING THREAT.

Future Alias smiled.

Then the smile faded into something softer.

He looked at all four stones one more time.

Rowan's red thread moved in the light wind.

Maris's page waited in its little frame beneath the yew branches.

Corvin's return marker caught one thin line of moonlight.

Eldric's tea charm rested against the carved cup.

Nothing had been fixed.

Rowan was still gone. Maris was still gone. Corvin was still gone. Eldric was still gone.

The stones did not become doors. The road did not open and give him back the years he had missed.

But the dead had not asked him to stop living beside them.

They had left him gifts. Maps. Threads. Tea. Pages. A lantern in the dark.

They had left him, in every way they knew how, a way to return.

Future Alias rose.

He brushed wet grass from his knees and did not apologize for the tears on his face.

"Goodnight," he said.

Then, after a moment, "I will come back."

He turned toward the gate.

Behind him, the four small objects remained beneath the moon.

Ahead of him, a thin grey light had begun to gather at the edge of the sky.

Chapter 34: The Sky Was Always Bright

The world does not become brighter all at once. Sometimes you simply look up.

Dawn did not arrive all at once.

At first it was only a thinning of darkness beyond the cemetery wall. The black between the trees softened. The far hills stopped being a single shape and became slopes, hedges, stone fences, and sleeping fields.

Future Alias stood by the gate with one hand resting on the cold iron.

Behind him, the four stones remained quiet beneath the moon.

He had said what he could say.

Not everything. There would never be a final sentence large enough for Rowan, Maris, Corvin, and Eldric. There would never be a set of words that made a grave feel fair.

But he had said their names.

He had stayed.

And when he had told them that he would come back, the promise had not felt like a lie.

That was new.

Paper rested open beneath his arm. It had been silent since they left the stones, which was either an act of kindness or proof that it had run out of rude things to say. Future Alias did not ask which.

He pushed the gate open.

It complained on its old hinge.

For years, that sound had made his chest close. It had been the sound of endings. The sound of a place he did not deserve to leave because other people had not been able to.

This morning, it was only an old hinge.

Still sad.

Still familiar.

But only a hinge.

He stepped onto the road.

* * *

The path down from the cemetery curved around a low hill before it returned to the village.

Future Alias did not take it immediately.

Instead, he climbed the hill.

The grass was wet enough to soak the edges of his boots. Small drops of water clung to every blade and caught the first light. The cold reached through the soles of his boots, but he kept walking until the cemetery was below him and the village roofs spread beyond it.

Gerhardt's tavern was there among the other buildings. Its chimney was already breathing a thin trail of smoke into the morning air.

A lamp still glowed in one upstairs window.

Future Alias stared at it for a long moment.

He had expected the world to look empty when he returned.

Not because it was empty. He knew better than that. People still lived here. Roads still filled with carts and rain and arguments about bread. Gerhardt had continued pouring tea. The sun had continued rising.

He had expected it to look empty because he had trained himself to see only what was gone.

The grey cloak had helped with that.

Grey was easy. Grey did not ask him to notice the red of Rowan's thread, or the green of an old tea charm, or the blue of a cup waiting on a tavern counter. Grey turned every road into the same road. It made leaving feel less like a choice.

Future Alias looked down at his hands.

One still held the folded edge of Paper. The other rested on the strap of his satchel. He could feel the small things inside it: the journal, the coin, the proof of another road. Objects that had crossed impossible distance with him.

He could also feel the cold morning air moving around his fingers.

He lifted his head.

The world was not grey.

The sky above the eastern hills was deep blue, darker near the top and becoming pale near the horizon. The moon had not disappeared yet; it hung low and silver above the trees. The fields were dark green where the frost had not touched them. Brown earth showed through the turned rows. A crow crossed the sky with black wings edged by early gold.

And behind him, at the cemetery wall, Rowan's red thread was still visible.

It was only a thin line from this far away.

It should have been too small to see.

But it was there.

Future Alias breathed in.

The air smelled of wet grass, chimney smoke, and the cold clean scent that came before a clear day.

"Was the sky always this bright?" he asked.

Paper moved beneath his hand.

YES.

Future Alias gave a short laugh, though it caught strangely in his throat.

"I did not see it."

Paper waited a moment.

Then it wrote:

YOU WERE LOOKING DOWN.

He stared at the words.

There were many things Paper could have said. It could have told him he had been foolish. It could have told him he had wasted years. It could have made some sharp little joke about cloaks and self-pity and dramatic wolves.

Instead, it told the truth in six words.

You were looking down.

Future Alias looked at the red thread again.

At the moon.

At the tavern window with its lamp still burning.

He had spent so long believing that moving forward meant leaving people behind. He had spent so long mistaking every memory for an anchor.

But Rowan's thread did not pull him backward.

Maris's page did not trap him in the past.

Corvin's return marker did not demand that he undo the road.

Eldric's charm did not ask him to become perfect before he could be loved.

They were not chains.

They were directions.

* * *

The thought made him sit down in the wet grass.

Paper slid from beneath his arm and opened across his knees. It wrote nothing.

Future Alias was grateful for that.

He watched the sunrise begin slowly, as if the world was taking its time remembering how to be seen.

A cart rolled along the road in the distance. The driver was too far away to make out, but Future Alias heard the steady clop of the horse and the creak of the wheels. A dog barked from one of the cottages. Somewhere below, someone opened shutters with a wooden knock.

Ordinary sounds.

He had crossed Structures, followed coins through impossible roads, watched doors open where walls should have been, and walked beside a younger version of himself.

Yet the sound of a village waking felt harder to face than any of it.

Because it was real.

Because he could not hide inside a mystery here.

He would have to decide what happened after breakfast. He would have to let Gerhardt ask whether he had slept. He would have to write the first page in his journal without pretending it was a report about someone else. He might have to meet people who remembered Varux as a person who vanished, or Alias as a person they had once known.

He would not know how to answer every question.

He would make mistakes.

He might still want to run.

The thought did not feel like a failure anymore.

Wanting to run was not the same as running.

And even running did not have to mean leaving forever.

Paper finally wrote:

YOU ARE THINKING TOO LOUDLY.

Future Alias looked down. "You cannot hear thoughts."

I HAVE HAD PRACTICE.

"That is not an answer."

IT IS A BETTER ONE THAN YOU DESERVE BEFORE BREAKFAST.

Future Alias smiled.

The smile stayed this time.

He reached into his satchel and took out his personal journal. Its cover was worn. The corners had been softened by weather and by hands that had held it too tightly. On its first pages, he had once written as Varux because he could not bear to use the name Alias.

He opened it to a blank page near the end.

For a while, he only held the pencil above the paper.

Then he wrote:

I am back.

He stopped.

The words looked too small.

So he wrote beneath them:

I am home.

The letters were uneven. His hand shook once while he made the last line. He did not cross anything out.

Paper leaned toward the journal as though inspecting the page.

ACCEPTABLE.

"That is your highest praise, is it?"

DO NOT GET USED TO IT.

Future Alias closed the journal and held it against his chest.

He was back.

He was home.

Not because the world had returned to what it used to be.

It had not.

Not because everyone he loved had returned with him.

They had not.

Home was not a reward for surviving correctly. It was not a place that stayed untouched until a person was brave enough to come back.

It was a road that still had room for him.
And this morning, he was choosing to walk it.

* * *

A sudden urge rose through him then, quick and bright.

Not the old urge.

The old urge had been sharp with fear. It had told him to vanish before anyone could ask him to stay. It had turned every open field into an escape route and every forest into a place where nobody would find him.

This was different.

It was the need to move because the morning was too wide to stand still inside it.
Future Alias set his journal carefully back in the satchel. He tucked Paper beneath the strap.

Paper immediately wrote:

WHAT ARE YOU DOING?

"Going for a run."

YOU SAY THAT AS IF IT HAS NEVER GONE BADLY BEFORE.

"I told Gerhardt I was coming back."

Paper paused.

Future Alias looked toward the tavern and raised his voice just enough to carry across the hill, though Gerhardt could not possibly hear him from there.

"I am coming back!"

The village did not answer.

The lamp in the tavern window stayed lit.

But saying it aloud changed something in him.

Paper wrote:

GOOD. NOW TRY NOT TO DESTROY ANYTHING.

"No promises."

THAT IS NOT COMFORTING.

Future Alias laughed, and the sound carried over the wet grass.

Then he stepped away from the path.

He took off the grey cloak first.

He folded it once, then again, and set it on a flat stone beside the hill. Not thrown away. Not burned. The cloak had been part of him for too long to pretend it meant nothing.

But it did not have to be the only thing he wore.

The first change was always a breath.

His hands pressed into the grass. His body folded and lengthened with familiar aching motion. Fur moved across his skin like a remembered storm. His senses opened: the sharp green of crushed grass, the small warm trails of mice under the hedge, the distant smoke from Gerhard's chimney, the quiet water in the ditch below.

Then the large grey wolf stood where Future Alias had been.

For a few heartbeats, he did nothing.

The wolf had once been the only shape that felt honest. No explanations. No name that hurt. No face for someone to recognize.

Now it was still him.

Not less human.

Not a hiding place.

A part of him that could run beneath an open sky.

He lifted his muzzle toward the pale morning moon.

The howl began low.

It carried sorrow in it. It carried the names of four friends sleeping beneath stone. It carried every road he had walked alone because he believed there was no other way.

But it carried something else too.

A promise made at a tavern door.

A red thread moving in the wind.

A younger self who had looked at him and said, *You still have time.*

The howl rose clear across the fields.

When it ended, the hill was quiet again.

Paper, crooked beneath the satchel strap, wrote:

DRAMATIC.

The wolf's mouth opened in what was almost a grin.

He shifted back just long enough to retrieve the grey cloak and tie it securely to his satchel.

Then he looked east, where the sun was climbing.

"I think it is time for my next page," Future Alias said.

Paper answered at once.

ABOUT TIME.

Future Alias became the wolf again.

Then he ran.

Not away from the graves.

Not away from the tavern.

Not away from the name he had once been afraid to carry.

He ran through the brightening grass and down toward the old forest road, fast enough to feel the cold air pull tears from his eyes. He ran because he was alive. He ran because the world had

colour. He ran because there were still pages he had not written, people he might meet, mistakes he might make, meals he might share, and doors he might choose to walk through.

Behind him, the cemetery remained beneath the morning sky.

Ahead of him, the road opened.

And for the first time in years, Future Alias was not running from his life.

He was running toward it.

Chapter 35: The Dream of Those Who Stayed

Some goodbyes do not end the road. They show you what it was worth walking.

The first thing Future Alias noticed was the smell of tea.

Not Gerhardt's tea.

Gerhardt used whatever leaves he could afford and boiled them until they became brown, bitter, and strong enough to wake a person who had made poor decisions. This tea smelled of mint, smoke, and something warm that had no name.

The second thing he noticed was a fire.

He opened his eyes.

For one clear, impossible second, he did not understand where he was.

The ceiling above him was not the small room at Gerhardt's tavern. There was no cracked white plaster, no crooked beam, no faded curtain moving against the window. Above him were branches, black and broad against a sky crowded with stars.

He was lying on a bedroll near a familiar fire.

The fire snapped.

Someone groaned loudly from the other side of it.

"If anyone touches my blanket again," Rowan announced, "I will become a much worse person."

Future Alias stopped breathing.

Rowan was sitting with his back against a fallen log, red scarf loose around his neck and hair in the same impossible direction it always found after sleeping outdoors. He was holding a blanket with both hands as though it had personally betrayed him.

Across from him, Maris was writing by firelight.

Her pen scratched steadily over a notebook balanced on one knee. She did not look up when she said, "You said that last time. Then you forgave Corvin because he made breakfast."

"Breakfast is very powerful," Rowan said.

Corvin sat beside the supplies, kneeling over a map that had been folded and opened too many times. His hair was tied back badly, which meant someone had interrupted him before he finished. He traced a line down the page with one finger.

"The blanket was on the ground," he said. "I moved it so it would not become wet."

"You moved it onto me."

"A more efficient storage location."

Eldric laughed softly from near the kettle.

Future Alias looked at him.

Eldric sat in the exact place Future Alias had expected him to be. Close enough to the fire to tend it. Far enough from the smoke that he would not complain later. His grey hair caught the orange light. His hands moved with the patient certainty of someone who had made tea in rain, in caves, on mountains, and on roads where nobody had packed enough cups.

He looked up.
For a moment, nothing changed on his face.
Then he smiled.
"There you are," Eldric said.
Future Alias could not move.
The fire warmed his hands. The earth pressed steadily beneath his back. The smell of tea drifted through the cold air. Every detail was too clear.
He pushed himself upright slowly.
His hands were older than he remembered them being on this road. There were scars across his knuckles that had not existed the last time he had sat here. The grey sleeve of his cloak covered one wrist.
Rowan noticed first.
He stared.
"You look terrible," Rowan said.
Future Alias gave a broken laugh before he could stop it.
"Gerhardt said the same thing."
Corvin's head snapped up from the map. "Gerhardt?"
The name landed between them.
Maris finally stopped writing.
Eldric poured tea into a chipped cup and held it out.
"Come closer," he said. "The fire is better for questions than the cold."
Future Alias looked from face to face.
They were here.
Not shadows. Not memories that blurred when he tried to look at them. Rowan's scarf had a burn mark near one end from the time he had tried to dry it too close to a fire. Maris's left thumb had a streak of ink along the side. Corvin had a small tear in one glove where the stitching had failed.
Eldric's cup had a blue chip at the rim.
Things Future Alias had forgotten he remembered.
He stood too quickly and nearly stumbled.
Eldric set the cup down before it could spill.
"Easy," he said.
Future Alias did not go to the fire.
Instead, he walked around it.
Rowan watched him approach with open suspicion. "Why are you looking at me like that?"
Future Alias reached out.
His hand stopped just before Rowan's shoulder.
Rowan's expression changed.

Not much. Just enough.

"Oh," he said quietly.

Future Alias's fingers closed around the cloth of Rowan's scarf.

It was real beneath his hand. Rough wool. Warm from Rowan's body. Rowan himself was warm too, when Future Alias pulled him into an embrace before he could decide not to.

Rowan went stiff for half a heartbeat.

Then his arms came around Future Alias's back.

"All right," he muttered. "That is enough dramatic hugging. People will think I am nice."

Future Alias laughed into his shoulder.

The sound broke halfway through and became something else.

Rowan held on tighter.

"Hey," he said, no longer joking. "Hey. I have you."

Future Alias closed his eyes.

For years, he had imagined this moment as the only thing that could possibly make the rest bearable.

A road backward.

A fire before the losses.

A chance to hold someone before the world took them.

But standing there, with Rowan alive beneath his hands, did not erase anything. It did not make the cemetery disappear. It did not change the four stones beneath the moon. It did not make him younger, or wiser, or less afraid.

It only made him miss them with his whole body.

When he finally let go, Rowan looked at him as if he had been given a puzzle without any sensible answer.

"You are definitely terrible," he said. "But you are also upsettingly sad. Did Corvin make you read one of his maps?"

"Maps are not upsetting," Corvin said.

"That is because you are wrong about maps."

Maris closed her notebook.

"Sit down," she told Future Alias.

It was not a question.

He sat.

Eldric placed the cup in his hands. The tea was warm enough to sting his fingers through the clay.

Nobody asked him to explain immediately.

For a while, they let the fire make noise for them.

* * *

The camp lay in a hollow between low hills, sheltered from the wind by a line of ash trees. Future Alias knew this place.

Not by name. He did not think it had ever had one.

It had been one of the many small camps between larger places. A night of rain that had not arrived. A shared supper. A bad song Rowan had sung until everyone threw things at him. Nothing important had happened here.

That was why it hurt.

His life with them had not been made only of endings.

It had been made of this.

Corvin worrying at a map. Maris writing down something that might matter later. Eldric measuring tea leaves without measuring them at all. Rowan complaining because complaining was easier than admitting he was cold.

The ordinary parts had been real too.

"You are staring again," Maris said.

Future Alias looked down at his cup. "Sorry."

"Do not apologize for looking." She opened her notebook again. "Just do not forget to blink."

Rowan leaned across the fire. "So. Gerhardt. Is he all right?"

Future Alias's chest tightened.

The question was too simple.

He could answer it.

"He is older," he said.

The four of them went still in different ways.

Corvin's hand stopped on the map. Maris's pen hovered above the page. Rowan looked toward the dark trees rather than at Future Alias. Eldric only watched him.

Future Alias understood then that they already knew something was wrong with this road.

Maybe they had known from the moment he woke.

Maybe the dream had known before he did.

"But he is alive," Future Alias continued. "He still makes terrible tea. He still leaves lamps on when he thinks someone might need one."

Eldric nodded once.

"Good," he said.

Rowan swallowed. "And the tavern?"

"Still there. The blue cup is still on the counter." Future Alias stared into the tea. "I used the front door."

For a moment, Rowan looked confused.

Then he smiled, small and fierce.

"That is very brave of you," he said.

"It was a door."

"Doors can be difficult." Maris's voice was gentle. "Especially the ones that lead back to people."

Future Alias looked at her.

"You wrote that?"

Maris shrugged. "Probably. It sounds like me."

He wanted to ask how she knew. He wanted to ask whether they were all ghosts, or memories, or pieces of a road the Tower had opened because it did not know how else to say goodbye.

Instead he said, "I came back."

No one answered immediately.

The words sat by the fire with them.

Then Eldric reached across and placed one hand over Future Alias's wrist.

"I know," he said.

The gentleness of it hurt more than any question could have.

Future Alias looked away quickly.

A red thread was tied around Rowan's wrist.

It was not the same thread he had left at the grave. This one was brighter, newer, looped clumsily beneath Rowan's glove. Future Alias had seen it a hundred times and somehow had not remembered its exact colour until now.

"You took it," Future Alias said.

Rowan lifted his wrist. "Took what?"

"The thread."

Rowan grinned. "I found it. There is a difference."

"You found it in Maris's pack."

"Then it was waiting to be found."

Maris did not look up from her notebook. "It was not."

"Details."

Future Alias touched the red thread with one finger.

His throat closed.

He had carried a version of this colour through another world because he had needed proof that the campfire had been real.

But now the proof was sitting in front of him, laughing at rules he had broken years ago.

"I kept it," Future Alias whispered.

Rowan's smile faded.

"Of course you did," he said.

Future Alias frowned. "How did you know?"

Rowan looked toward the fire. "You keep little things when you do not know how to keep people."

The words were not accusing.

That made them worse.

Future Alias pulled his hand away from the thread.

"I thought I was protecting myself."

"You were trying," Rowan said. "That is not always the same thing."

Corvin folded the map with careful, exact movements.

"What happens next?" he asked.

Future Alias looked at him.

"I do not know."

"Then we should plan for more than one possibility."

The answer was so Corvin that Future Alias nearly laughed again.

Corvin held up the map. "If you return to the tavern, you can remain there for a few days. Speak to Gerhardt. Eat. Sleep. Then choose the next road. There is no requirement to decide the entire year before breakfast."

"I told him that," Eldric said.

"You told me I think too far ahead."

"That is also true."

Maris closed her notebook and looked directly at Future Alias.

"Do you have your journal?"

Future Alias reached automatically for the pocket inside his cloak.

It was there.

The worn cover. The softened corner. His real journal, not the younger book he had carried on this road.

He took it out.

The first page he had written after returning was still open inside it.

I am back.

I am home.

Maris read the words without touching the page.

She smiled.

"Good beginning," she said.

Future Alias stared at her.

"It is not enough."

"No," Maris agreed. "A beginning is not enough. That is why it is a beginning."

* * *

They spent the rest of the dream as though the road had given them a day.

Future Alias did not know whether time passed in a normal way. The sky slowly changed from night-blue to the pale colour before sunrise, but the fire never seemed to run low. Their breakfast was too good for camp food and too ordinary to be magic: bread warmed near the coals, cheese,

apples, tea, and one egg Rowan claimed he had saved from a travelling merchant who had "clearly wished to donate it."

"You stole an egg," Corvin said.

"Borrowed it."

"From a person who did not know you were borrowing it."

"That is the fastest kind of borrowing."

Future Alias looked at Rowan and laughed.

Rowan pointed at him with the egg. "There. I got a laugh. Someone write that down."

Maris had already started.

"I will not write that," she said. "It would make the journal unreliable."

They packed together after breakfast.

Corvin checked the straps twice. Maris wrapped her notebook in oilcloth. Rowan tried to put his blanket into Eldric's pack and was caught immediately. Eldric pretended to be surprised for the sake of the argument.

Future Alias watched them move around each other without needing to ask where anything belonged.

This was not the road he had wanted to return to.

He had wanted a road before mistakes. Before grief. Before any choice could become permanent.

But this road had always included choices. It had always included fear. They had just carried those things together.

Eldric handed him a small cup of the last tea.

"What are you thinking?" he asked.

Future Alias did not try to lie.

"That I was wrong."

Eldric took that in without triumph.

"About what?"

"I thought going back would fix it. I thought if I could stand here again, then I would know what to do."

"And do you?"

Future Alias looked at the road waiting beyond the ash trees.

"Not all of it."

Eldric smiled. "That is usually enough."

"It is?"

"For the next step." Eldric nodded toward the open path. "The next step is the only one that ever truly asks for your foot."

Future Alias held the cup with both hands.

He had said something like that to Alias once. Not those words. He had not been wise enough for those words then. But he had tried to tell his younger self that a person could still walk forward without knowing how the whole road ended.

It had taken a long time to believe it himself.

"I went to the graves," he said.

The others became quiet.

"I left things there. Things from another road. Rowan, I left a red thread. Maris, a copied page. Corvin, a return marker. Eldric, a tea charm."

Rowan's mouth wavered into a smile.

"A tea charm? That is painfully correct."

Eldric gave him a look. "You should try it sometime."

"I have. It is hot leaf water."

Maris set her notebook down.

"And what did you say?" she asked.

Future Alias's hand tightened on the cup.

"I said I received your gifts."

No one moved.

He looked at them one by one.

"I should have said it sooner. I should have believed you sooner. I should have come back sooner." His voice shook. "I am sorry."

Rowan shook his head at once. "No."

Future Alias blinked.

"No?"

"No making the apology bigger than the people you are apologizing to." Rowan looked irritated, which was how he looked when he was trying not to cry. "You came back. You said it. You are doing the next thing. That matters."

Corvin nodded. "A late answer is still an answer."

Maris added quietly, "And being sorry is not the same as being sentenced forever."

Future Alias could not look at Eldric.

When he finally did, Eldric was smiling with tears in his eyes.

"Not perfectly," Eldric said.

Future Alias breathed in sharply.

"Not quickly," Eldric continued. "But you came back."

The words opened something in him that had been closed for years.

He cried then.

Not silently. Not well. He covered his face with one hand and bent forward, but the tears came anyway, hot and helpless and honest.

No one told him to stop.

Rowan sat beside him and leaned his shoulder against Future Alias's.

Maris rested her hand between his shoulder blades.

Corvin put the map down and stayed close enough that his knee touched Future Alias's boot.

Eldric waited until Future Alias could lower his hand, then gave him the cup again.

The tea had gone cold.

It was still good.

* * *

When the sun finally rose in the dream, it did not rise from the east.

It appeared between the ash trees where there should have been only the road.

Future Alias noticed because the light touched Rowan's red thread first.

The colour became too bright.

Not painful. Not frightening. Just impossible.

Maris was the first to look toward it.

"It is time," she said.

Future Alias's hands went cold.

"No," he whispered.

Rowan sighed. "You always were bad at endings."

"I just got you back."

The words came out smaller than he meant them to.

Eldric stepped closer.

"You did not get us back," he said gently.

Future Alias flinched.

Eldric put one hand on his shoulder.

"But you did come back to us. There is a difference."

The light between the trees grew warmer.

Future Alias looked from one face to another.

He wanted to memorize everything. The line of Maris's smile. Corvin's worn gloves. Rowan's scarf. Eldric's hands. He wanted to lock the moment away where no road could take it from him.

Then he remembered the red thread at the cemetery.

He remembered that a thing did not have to be locked away to remain real.

"Was this a dream?" he asked.

Rowan groaned. "That is a very boring question."

"It matters."

"Does it?" Maris asked.

Future Alias looked at her.

She picked up her notebook and tucked it under one arm.

"You remember us," she said. "You loved us. You are going to keep walking. That is enough truth for one morning."

Corvin folded the map.

"Technically," he said, "it may be a memory, a dream, an unusual Structure effect, or some combination. There is insufficient information to decide."

"Thank you, Corvin," Rowan said. "That made it much worse."

"You are welcome."

Eldric smiled at Future Alias.

"You do not need to name every kindness before you accept it."

Future Alias looked toward the light again.

His chest hurt.

But it did not feel like a door closing.

It felt like a hand opening.

Rowan slung his pack over one shoulder. Maris tucked her pencil behind her ear. Corvin took the lead because he always did when a map was involved. Eldric picked up the kettle and somehow made it look important.

They stood together on the edge of the road.

For one second, nobody moved.

Then Rowan looked back at Future Alias.

"Well?"

Future Alias could barely speak. "Well what?"

Rowan smiled.

"Our adventure awaits."

Maris smiled too.

Corvin lifted the map slightly.

Eldric gave him the smallest nod.

Future Alias took one step toward them.

The light rose.

The fire disappeared.

The road became morning.

* * *

Future Alias woke with tears already on his face.

For a while, he did not move.

The tavern room was grey with early dawn. The cracked ceiling beam was above him. Rain tapped softly against the window. His blanket had twisted around his legs. Paper lay open on the small table beside the bed.

No fire.

No campsite.
No familiar voices arguing beyond the wall.
Only the slow, ordinary sound of Gerhardt moving downstairs.
Future Alias pressed the heel of one hand against his mouth.
The grief came back.
So did the warmth.
They arrived together now.
That was the strange part.
He had thought accepting one would mean losing the other. He had thought he could either remember his friends and drown, or forget enough to survive.
But the dream had not asked him to choose.
It had only let him sit beside them one more time.
Paper shifted on the table.
Future Alias looked at it.
For several seconds, nothing appeared.
Then Paper wrote:
YOU ARE CRYING ON THE PILLOW.
Future Alias let out a wet, embarrassed laugh.
"I noticed."
Paper waited.
Then another line appeared.
DID YOU GET LOST?
Future Alias looked toward the window.
Beyond the glass, the first real colour of morning was beginning to touch the street.
He thought of a red thread around a stone. A cup of tea held in two hands. A road that did not demand every answer at once.
"No," he said.
He sat up slowly and reached for his journal.
The page where he had written *I am back. I am home* waited near the end.
Below those words, he wrote one more line.
I remember you. I will keep walking.
He did not know whether the camp had been a dream, a memory, another possible road, or a kindness left by the Tower.
He did not know whether he would ever be given that answer.
For once, he did not need it.
He closed the journal.

Downstairs, a cup knocked against a saucer. Gerhardt muttered something at the kettle. The tavern door opened and shut as someone stepped in from the rain.

Life was already happening.

Future Alias wiped his face, stood, and went to meet it.

* * *

Far away, on a road that belonged to another version of the world, Alias woke beneath a different roof.

For a moment, he did not know why his face was wet.

The room around him was quiet. The final place had opened a simple door after Future Alias left, and that door had led the group to a small traveller's shelter on the edge of the eastern road. There had been no magic left in it by morning. Only wooden walls, blankets, a stove gone cold, and the soft sleeping sounds of people who had walked too far in one day.

Rowan slept near the window with one arm hanging off the bedroll.

Maris had fallen asleep with her notebook open against her chest.

Corvin was curled beneath two blankets because he claimed he was "efficiently conserving warmth."

Eldric was awake.

Of course he was.

He sat beside the small stove with a cup of tea between both hands, watching the first light move across the floorboards.

He looked up when Alias moved.

"Bad dream?" Eldric asked quietly.

Alias opened his mouth.

At first, no words came.

He could still smell the dream-fire. He could still hear Rowan's voice saying *Our adventure awaits.* He could still feel the ache of someone walking away without leaving anyone behind.

Maris stirred awake. "Alias?"

Corvin lifted his head from the blankets, immediately alert despite the sleep in his eyes.

Rowan mumbled something that sounded like, "Is breakfast attacking?"

Alias looked at them.

His living friends.

All here.

No grave stones. No empty campfire. No name written only on paper.

The ache in his chest did not vanish.

It settled.

Like something that had finally found the place where it belonged.

He wiped his face with the heel of his hand.

"I think he got home," Alias said.

No one asked how he knew.

Eldric only nodded.

Maris reached across the space between their bedrolls and touched Alias's hand.

Rowan sat up, hair worse than usual, and looked toward the pale window.

"Good," he said.

Corvin pulled the blankets closer around his shoulders.

"Then we should let him have breakfast," he said.

Alias laughed softly.

The sound stayed.

Chapter 36: Recorded by M

Some stories end when the road disappears. This one ends when someone chooses to keep walking.

Morning arrived without magic.

That was how Alias knew it was real.

The traveller's shelter was still only a shelter: crooked wooden walls, a cold iron stove, six bedrolls that had been rolled too many times, and one small window looking out across a pale road. The strange door from the final room had vanished during the night. There was no ring of light in the floorboards. No keyholes. No writing in the air.

Only the ordinary work of waking up.

Eldric was already crouched near the stove, coaxing a little flame from dry twigs. Corvin was pretending to be asleep while listening to every sound in the room. Maris had her notebook open beside her blanket, though the page was still empty. Rowan had managed to wrap himself in most of his own bedroll and half of Corvin's.

Alias lay still for a moment and listened to them breathe.

He could still see the dream when he closed his eyes.

A different campfire. Four people who had been gone for years in another life. Future Alias standing in the first colour of morning, crying and laughing at the same time. Rowan's voice saying,
Our adventure awaits.

The dream did not feel like a message that needed solving.

It felt like a hand placed gently between his shoulders.

Alias sat up.

Maris looked over from her notebook. "You are awake."

"I noticed," Alias said.

Rowan made a tired noise from beneath the blankets. "Could everyone notice more quietly?"

"You have Corvin's blanket," Corvin said without opening his eyes.

"I am keeping it safe."

"From what?"

"The cold."

"The cold was using it."

Rowan pulled the blanket closer around his shoulders. "Then I rescued it."

Eldric hid a smile as he set the kettle over the small flame. "A noble act."

For a few minutes, nobody spoke about the dream.

They did not have to.

The silence was not empty. It was full of the fact that Alias was here, that Future Alias had gone somewhere he had chosen to go, and that the road outside the shelter did not ask anyone to explain every feeling before breakfast.

Maris reached for the shared journal when she began to pack.

Her hand stopped.

"That is odd," she said.

Alias looked over.

The shared journal lay where she had left it beside her bedroll, its leather cover bent at one corner. Maris turned it once in her hands, then opened it slowly.

The page where she had copied the New Year promise was gone.

Not torn badly. Not ripped out in panic.

The thread at the spine had been lifted with careful fingers. The page had been removed so neatly that it took a second look to see the empty space between the remaining sheets.

Maris touched the gap.

"It was already missing," Alias said. "Since the road after the attack."

"I know." Her voice was quiet. "But I thought it might have come back."

Rowan finally pulled himself upright. He rubbed one eye, then reached toward the pocket inside his coat.

His hand stayed there.

"No," he said.

Corvin opened his eyes. "What?"

Rowan searched the other pocket. Then the small pouch on his belt. Then, with increasing annoyance, the folds of his scarf.

"My red thread," he said. "The one from my wrist."

Alias looked at the knot near Rowan's glove. It was gone. Only a faint impression remained in the wool where the thread had rested.

Rowan frowned at it.

"I tied that again last night," he said. "I remember tying it."

Corvin sat up and reached for his map case.

He opened it with the careful speed of someone who already suspected what he would find. Inside were their route maps, the old notes from M's guide, and the folded page where he had kept the little return-marked square from the final road.

The square was missing.

Eldric's hand went to the cord around his travel kettle.

The pale green tea charm was gone too.

For a moment, the shelter became very quiet.

Then Rowan turned toward Alias.

Not accusingly.

Not exactly.

But everyone remembered the routehouse. The locks. The spoons. The way Alias had slipped through places without seeming to touch the air.

Alias lifted both hands.

"It was not me."

"I know," Rowan said immediately.

The speed of it made Alias blink.

Rowan looked down at the place where the red thread had been.

"I mean, I did think it for half a second," he admitted. "But only because you are the obvious suspect."

"Thank you," Alias said dryly.

"You are welcome."

Corvin looked between the empty place in his map case and the empty gap in the journal. "The removals are deliberate. They are all things connected to the journey."

Maris closed the shared journal carefully.

"And things connected to us."

Alias's hand moved to the inside pocket of his coat.

The little wooden wolf was gone.

He had carried it since the snowball fight. It had been a silly carving, uneven at the ears and too stubborn-looking to be fierce. Future Alias had held it during the farewell. Alias remembered him giving it back.

Or thought he did.

His fingers found only the soft lining of the pocket.

The missing things settled between them all at once.

The red thread Future Alias had picked up near the beginning of the road.

The coloured ribbons he had watched too long in Wrenfall.

The copied promise page that vanished after the wolf arc.

The way he had sometimes looked at a small thing in somebody's hand as if it mattered more than it should.

The way he had looked at all of them, every morning, as if he was trying to remember how to breathe in a room full of people.

Eldric sat back beside the stove.

"He took them," he said.

Alias swallowed. "He took them home."

No one moved.

Outside, wind stirred the frozen grass beside the shelter. Somewhere farther down the road, a bird called once and then fell silent again.

Rowan stared at the empty knot around his wrist.

"He could have asked," he said.

"He could have," Maris agreed.

Rowan's mouth twisted. "I would have said yes."

"I think he knew that," she said.

The answer did not make it less sad.

It made it understandable.

Future Alias had not taken the objects because he thought they belonged to him. He had taken them because he needed something solid in his hands. Something that could survive the door, the Tower, the years, and the terrible possibility that he might wake up alone and decide he had imagined every good thing.

Proof.

Not of a prophecy.

Not of a victory.

Proof that there had been a morning full of bad tea. A town buried in snow. A fight that ended in laughter. A page copied by careful hands. A wolf who came back. A group who had said, together, that no one would walk into the next year alone.

Maris looked toward the pale window.

"He was afraid the road would become a dream," she said. "So he carried pieces of it with him."

Corvin nodded slowly. "A bad method. But understandable."

"That is very kind of you," Rowan said.

"I did not say it was correct."

Eldric poured hot water into the six cups he had lined up on the floorboards. The tea was weak. It smelled faintly of leaves and smoke.

He handed one to Alias first.

"Small things can carry a great deal," Eldric said. "That does not mean they are gone from us."

Alias wrapped both hands around the cup.

He thought of Future Alias waking in the Tower, perhaps opening his hand and finding the red thread there. He imagined the other version of himself seeing the carved wolf in his pocket and knowing that the people he had lost had not been only a dream, and neither had the people he had found.

For the first time since waking, Alias felt the ache in his chest loosen.

Not disappear.

Loosen.

"He needed proof," Alias said.

Maris nodded. "Then he has it."

Rowan looked out the window. "Good."

Corvin lifted his cup. "He should still write a letter someday."

"That would be difficult across different roads," Maris said.

"Then he should find a way."

Eldric's smile was small. "That sounds like a future problem."

Corvin considered this. "I accept that."

Alias looked down at the steam rising from his tea.

For a long time, he had thought going home meant returning to the exact place where nothing had gone wrong yet. A door backward. A different choice. A version of the world where nobody had been left behind.

But Future Alias had gone home to a world that still had graves in it.

He had gone home anyway.

Maybe that was what made it real.

* * *

They left the shelter after breakfast.

The road beyond it was narrow and pale beneath the early sun. It curled through fields glazed with frost, then disappeared between two low hills. There were no coins leading them now. No compass pulling at a hand. The six keys lay quiet in their packs, cool and ordinary.

For the first time in a long while, nobody knew exactly where the road was supposed to go.

Rowan stopped at the fork just beyond the shelter and looked in both directions.

"Well," he said. "That feels illegal."

"What does?" Maris asked.

"Choosing without a strange object making a noise at us first."

Corvin unfolded a map. It was a new map, one of the plain ones bought in Wrenfall before any of them had expected to find a final room or a door between worlds.

He pointed left.

"The western road returns toward the larger towns. We could reach Nettlebridge in three days, perhaps four in bad weather."

Rowan pointed right. "And that way?"

"A small village called Brightwater. There is a bridge there."

"That is not a description of a village."

"It is the most relevant feature on the map."

Maris leaned over the page. "There is a note beside it."

Corvin narrowed his eyes. "Where?"

She tapped the faded writing at the edge.

Old footbridge damaged after the winter storm. Travellers advised to use the southern crossing.

Eldric read it over her shoulder.

"That note could be old," he said.

"Or it could be current," Corvin replied.

Rowan's expression brightened. "A broken bridge."

Alias looked at him. "You sound pleased."

"I am not pleased it is broken. I am pleased we have something normal to do." Rowan spread his hands. "We can help. Carry wood. Hold ropes. Let Corvin tell us we are holding ropes wrong."

"You would be holding them wrong," Corvin said.

"Exactly. It will be familiar."

Maris looked down the right-hand road.

"Brightwater," she said. "It sounds nice."

Alias listened to them decide.

No keys glowed.

No Structure opened.

No voice appeared in the air to tell them which choice was right.

There was only a broken bridge in a village they had never seen, a road with frost shining on it, and five people beside him who were waiting to hear what he thought.

It should have felt smaller than the final room.

Instead, it felt enormous.

Alias smiled.

"Brightwater," he said.

Rowan lifted both arms. "A new quest!"

"It is not a quest," Corvin said. "It is a bridge repair."

"Every bridge repair is a quest if you care enough."

Eldric started down the road. "Then we should care enough to arrive before dark."

They followed him.

Alias walked near the middle of the group.

Not at the front, where he could pretend he was responsible for every danger. Not at the very back, where he could make sure nobody saw if he started to disappear.

Near the middle.

Where he could hear Rowan complaining about the cold, Maris writing down the village name, Corvin explaining ropes before anyone had asked, and Eldric quietly reminding them all to drink water.

Above them, the sky was bright enough to hurt his eyes.

Alias looked up anyway.

* * *

Much later.

Or perhaps at exactly the same moment, in a room where roads were kept as carefully as books.

A hand turned the final page.

The room was not grand.

It had no throne, no great machine, no walls made from stars. It was a small room built from dark wood and old stone, warmed by a lamp on a desk. Shelves covered two walls. Some held maps rolled

with ribbon. Some held journals swollen with rain. Some held books so thin they might contain one person's afternoon, and books so thick they might contain a century of roads.

A kettle sat near the lamp.

Its tea had gone cold.

At the desk sat M.

The name was written in the corner of many maps and at the bottom of many notes. Sometimes it appeared in ink so faded that readers mistook it for a mark left by rain. Sometimes it was scratched into stone near a door nobody was meant to find alone.

M wore no crown.

M had no reason to.

A road did not need a ruler. It needed someone willing to leave a lantern where darkness had become too convincing.

On the desk lay three books.

The first was worn at the corners from being opened too often.

THE FLIP SIDE OF KNOWLEDGE

The second had a dark stain along one edge, as if it had once been carried too close to a fire.

BURNED MEMORIES AND MADE-UP APOLOGIES

The third was newer.

Its cover was still marked by the pressure of hands that had not yet learned how much a book could remember.

FOOL'S STAGE | GO HOME...

M rested a hand on the final cover.

For a while, the lamp made the only sound in the room.

Then M opened the book one last time.

The last pages held a road in frost, six figures moving toward a village with a broken bridge, and the bright open sky above them. They were very small on the page.

They did not need to be larger.

M had once thought that a recorded journey had to contain every answer. Every turning point. Every hidden door. Every moment where a person might have chosen differently.

Years had taught a quieter truth.

A record did not have to hold a life still.

It only had to hold the light on long enough for someone else to see that the road had been real.

M took up a pen.

At the bottom of the final page, beneath the road to Brightwater, new words appeared.

They were not saved by a Tower.

M paused.

Then wrote beneath it:

They were not saved by knowing everything.

The pen moved once more.

They were saved, again and again, by returning when it was difficult. By speaking when silence was easier. By refusing to let one another vanish alone.

The lamp's light trembled slightly as M set the pen down.

Outside the small window, there was no single world to see. There were only roads: some straight, some broken, some leading toward homes that no longer looked exactly as they had in memory.

M looked at them for a long time.

Then, gently, M closed the book.

The sound was small.

It was not the sound of a prison closing.

It was not the sound of a story being taken away.

It was the sound of a record being kept.

A lantern being left beside a road.

A door remaining open for whoever might need it next.

M placed the book beside the other two.

Three journeys.

Three roads.

And beyond them, the ordinary, difficult, beautiful work of continuing.

* * *

Reader.

You have read far enough.

What will you do with your next page?